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**HUMAN NATURE BEYOND NATURALISM.
PHENOMENOLOGICAL, ANTHROPOLOGICAL AND PSYCHOANALYTICAL
PERSPECTIVES**

Guest Editors: *Jagna Brudzińska* and *Stanisław Czerniak*

Dieter Lohmar — Human Freedom—a Husserlian Perspective

Mariannina Failla — Disturbances of Temporality and the Potentialities of Phenomenological Perception

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All editorial correspondence and submissions should be addressed to:

e-mail: dialogueanduniversalism@ifispan.waw.pl,

or to: Institute of Philosophy and Sociology of the Polish Academy of Sciences,
ul. Nowy Świat 72, 00–330 Warszawa, Poland

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Editorial

This *Dialogue and Universalism* issue includes two thematic selections. The first one entitled *Human Nature beyond Naturalism. Phenomenological, Anthropological and Psychoanalytical Perspectives* is a collection of papers founded on the idea of non-reducibility of human being to natural phenomena. The authors investigate human being from three antinaturalistic standpoints, significant in contemporary philosophy. The standpoints grounding their considerations are weak antinaturalisms since they regard human being an ontically complex entity—with natural as well as supernatural (in a modern, not religious sense of the term) aspects. This type of antinaturalism prevails in those contemporary philosophical conceptions of man which oppose naturalistic apprehensions currently much more widespread. The presuppositions of the selection of the papers and its contents are presented in detail in the *Introduction* authored by its editors, Jagna Brudzińska and Stanisław Czerniak.

The second collection of papers in this *Dialogue and Universalism* issue entitled *In Memoriam Marek Siemek* is a continuation and at the same time a complement of the previous one (2/2016) which has been devoted entirely to an outstanding Polish philosopher Marek Siemek. The previous *Dialogue and Universalism* issue has been thematically concentrated on forgotten as well as over-estimated problems in social philosophy whereas this issue includes the papers thematically diversified but joined together by the common feature: they are intellectual gifts of their authors to Marek Siemek's memory in the fifth anniversary of his death, an amazing evidence that *non omnis moriar*. We would like to express our gratitude to all the contributors of this collection. First and foremost, the editorial board of *Dialogue and Universalism* warmly thanks Professor Wolfram Hogrebe—a great authority for Marek Siemek and a person of exceptional importance in his life.

Małgorzata Czarnocka
Dialogue and Universalism Editor-in-Chief

INTRODUCTION

HUMAN NATURE BEYOND NATURALISM. PHENOMENOLOGICAL, ANTHROPOLOGICAL AND PSYCHOANALYTICAL PERSPECTIVES

Studies of the human being and the structure of human experience are nowadays carried out mainly in the naturalistic paradigm. This concerns the empirical sciences as well as the cognitively oriented philosophy supported by the positivistic and linguistic pragmatic epistemologies. The human subject is treated here essentially as a particular natural fact, while nature itself is understood as a complexity of cause-determined phenomena which can be observed from outside. Thereby, neurosciences play a leading role, significantly affecting the perception of ourselves and of the world around us. In their view, subjectivity is reduced to the ways of functioning of the brain. This is understood as a causally determined system directed to information processing. Despite such a deterministic thesis, naturalism also assumes that the brain should be able to interact. Furthermore, it is considered able to generate random processes. These interruptions of the natural causal chain are labelled as *autopoiesis* and are considered as an evolutionary factor.

Thus, our shared world appears as a construct of the neuronal structure miraculously converting the matter into spirit. Modern medicine, contemporary neurological brain research as well as other neurosciences strive to identify the biological, chemical or physical conditions of the human organism and its cerebral activities as that which determines our experience, either in the practical or theoretical, aesthetical or axiological realm.

The present collection of essays consciously distances itself from these trends, maintaining that research conducted in the reductive-naturalistic approach does not give the answer to the question about the meaning and sense of human activity as actions of personal subjects in the lifeworld. What is more, the authors emphasize that this kind of research neglects the immanent teleology of human subjects as persons motivated in their actions, therefore persons who are free and able to make free decisions. All the here presented articles refer, explicitly or implicitly, to the phenomenological tradition and emphasise the significance of the lifeworld as the intuitive fundament of every cognition. They seek to formulate a positive alternative to the interpretation of human nature comprehending it on the one hand as a bodily specified structure of experi-

ence, on the other hand as an intentional and therefore sense-performing developmental structure.

In this context it is mainly the classical (even if currently somewhat marginalized) phenomenology of Edmund Husserl that shows its up-to-date face. After all, it is he who, in the footsteps of Wilhelm Dilthey, argued in the first half of the twentieth century that the naturalistic position was nothing else than a logical consequence of a particular idealizing cognitive attitude formed in the modern era and grounded in the development and expansion of the natural sciences. According to Husserl, this attitude is burdened with fateful assumptions regarding the concepts of nature and the laws governing it, first of all the assumption of the universal law of causality. However, human consciousness, even if we recognize its bodily determination, cannot be explained by reference to the facts of physical nature and the laws governing them.

Husserl shows that the universal law of causality is no less but also no more than an effective hypothesis about the subjects of physics. By no means it is adequate for interpreting human nature, either in its individual and bodily dimension, or in its social dimension. Husserl requires us to critically reflect on the assumptions which impose experience. His own reflection results among others in descriptions of alternative attitudes, especially of the so-called personalistic attitude, which reveals experience to us before it becomes naturalistically deformed. Within the personalistic attitude experience is not burdened with these assumptions. If we observe it exactly, if we let it speak, it turns out that even the oppositions of body and spirit, of interior and exterior, lose their legitimacy. Within the personalistic attitude experience is experience in the lifeworld, in our shared world, which is defined by affective and volitional reference, by intersubjective and evaluative relations, in a world which is guided by understandable motivation, and not by blind but necessary causality. The body—the Trojan horse of naturalism—represents here not just a fact of nature, not only animated matter as an object in time and space defined by a succession of physiological processes. In the personalistic attitude corporeality signifies a dynamic sphere of subjectivity as the sphere which defines our *here and now*. However, at the same time it generates the original sense of experience. These issues are mentioned and further developed by the post-Husserlian phenomenology in existential as well as in ethical or aesthetical reflection and by philosophical anthropology. In this way phenomenology reveals its closeness to psychology and, last but not least, to psychoanalytical thought.

The authors of the presented collection deal with these threads and motives, both in terms of systematic as well as historical research. The cycle starts with systematic analyses of selected issues concerning human nature—like freedom, drives and memory, conflict or bodily perception—which cannot be adequately grasped from the naturalistic point of view. Consequently, discussed are some historical positions in philosophical anthropology (Max Scheler, Johann Gottfried Herder, Arnold Gehlen, Gernot Böhme) as well as in aesthetics (Vasily

Sesemann). These are considered bearers of a still unexhausted antinaturalistic potential with regard to the interpretation of human nature and its achievements.

Dieter Lohmar deals with the topic of human freedom. The author discusses the different meanings of our daily claim that we are free in our actions and decisions on the grounds of phenomenology. He rejects deterministic theories in the naturalistic approach using Husserl's argument that the subsumption of human decisions under the causal paradigm is simply an unjustified extension of methodical idealization in the framework of naturalization. Then, he argues for Husserl's understanding that humans are generally subjects under manifold effective influences but they are nevertheless free. In the end some aspects of our freedom are delineated. Mariannina Failla dedicates her contribution to the phenomenological conception of bodily perception (*leibliche Wahrnehmung*) as a possible therapeutic model for treating melancholic depression. Starting with a few key concepts of Freudian psychoanalysis (instinct (*Trieb*), memory, perception, narcissism and melancholia), she develops a comparison of the Freudian theory of melancholia and the studies of phenomenological psychopathology (Otto Binswanger). The article finally focuses on the question of the extent to which the structure of perception and its constitutive openness towards the future represent a theoretical model for therapeutic practices designed to treat melancholic depression. Jagna Brudzińska goes further on the path of connecting phenomenological research with the psychoanalytical approach, focusing on the issue of conflict as the crucial dimension of human nature and its developing dynamics. On this basis, it becomes clear that human nature cannot be explained through a strict causal schema. She stresses that conflict is not a mere additional and accidental characteristic of experience that can be somehow eliminated. Conflict rather affects the fundamental structure of personal experience and should be therefore understood as a constitutive moment of human nature. Thereby, her radical claim is that both self-experience and the development of community can only be understood in the light of motivational conflicts.

The following cluster of essays examines some particular philosophical–anthropological positions which from our point of view still deserve deeper consideration. Stanisław Czerniak discusses Böhme's approach, pointing out that Böhme's philosophical anthropology emphasises the differences between the “historical models of man” and its author can be considered a follower of descriptive historicism, although his doctrinal ties to critical theory also make him open to normative positions. Böhme seeks the normative standards for his social critique in his axiological “sovereign man” project. Czerniak investigates this two types of philosophical narrative and concludes that there are categorial and argumentative inconsistencies at their meeting-point which could have prompted Böhme to partial withdrawal from the sovereign man idea in favour of another “reference to history,” though no longer in the descriptive but in the “relief” (*Entlastung*) mode. Here the German philosopher takes the same path as thinkers like Jürgen Habermas, who referred to the “relief” category in their

critical polemic with supporters of eugenic genetic engineering. Rafał Michalski analyses Gehlen's anthropological approach, which he confronts with Herder's. His essay is an attempt to present Gehlen's concept of language in the context of his self-expounded "elementary anthropology." Emphasis is put on the role of language in the formation of motoric and sensory imagination, the crystallization of human drives and, finally, the development of cognitive competencies. Michalski shows that Gehlen refers in his project directly to the thoughts of Herder. The related anthropological position of Helmuth Plessner is displayed by Alice Pugliese. She discusses criticism against naturalism based on the irreducibility of first-person-perspective facts. This critique considers naturalism as insufficient, since it proposes the view of reality as a centreless dimension. Against this view, she refers to Plessner's notions of positionality and aspectivity as characteristics of all natural forms of life, thus suggesting the possibility of a more encompassing critique to naturalism on the basis of the philosophical-anthropological research. From a psychological standpoint, Flávio Vieira Curvello explores Franz Brentano's approach in the lectures *Descriptive Psychology* and how it leads to a new way of introducing and reframing his fundamental psychological theses. Even though many problems of the *Descriptive Psychology*, as well as their solutions, are already to be found in the *Psychology from an Empirical Standpoint*, the argumentative turn is clear. And it contributes to set the purely descriptive overtones of the latter aside and emphasizes the relevance of the development of descriptive psychology as an ontology of the soul. Finally, Saulius Geniusas takes into consideration the rather forgotten approach to aesthetics of the Lithuanian Vasily Sesemann, and shows its great potential for the modern debate, also by confronting it with the renowned position of Merleau-Ponty. He thus offers an account of the overall structures of perceptual acts and contends that the distinctive nature of aesthetic perception lies in the unique disposition of the aesthetic attitude.

The last three essays shed light on the problem of the body as a crucial issue in the debate on naturalism and antinaturalism. With reference to the phenomenological understanding of the living body, Andrzej Gniazdowski analyses the antinaturalistic theory of race developed by Ludwig Ferdinand Clauss. The critical conclusion of the article is that in spite of the claim to work out a clear, rigorous and "presuppositionless" theory of race, Ludwig Ferdinand Clauss' race psychology remains a form of racism that contradicts the solidarity of mankind and the principles of tolerance. From the transcendental phenomenological point of view, also Mansooreh Khalilizand underscores the question of the body and contrasts the naturalistic meaning of instincts with the transcendental phenomenological one. In her analysis she strives to explicate Husserl's specific description of instinctive processes and the experienced teleology of instincts and to reconstruct the body- and nature-relatedness within the instinctual structures. Finally, Karel Novotný addresses the question of the subjective and embodied character of appearance, and shows that it can play its central role

for human experience only by means of its connection with subjectivity of the body. Through its corporeality, experience is given immediately; it is self-given in a non-intentional way, in the immediate auto-affection of experience.

This compilation certainly does not exhaust the question of human nature. We only hope to formulate some arguments for an adequate and differentiate understanding of the human and its experience as well as to contribute to further discussion.

Jagna Brudzińska, Stanisław Czerniak

Dieter Lohmar

HUMAN FREEDOM—A HUSSERLIAN PERSPECTIVE

ABSTRACT

I would like to discuss—on the basis of a phenomenological argumentation—the different meanings of our everyday claim that we are free in our actions and decisions. First, I reject deterministic theories in the naturalistic approach by using Husserl's argument that the subsumption of human decisions under the causal paradigm is simply an unjustified extension of a methodical idealization in the framework of naturalization. Then I argue for Husserl's understanding that humans are generally subjects under a manifold of effective influences but they are nevertheless free. In the end some aspects of our freedom are delineated.

Keywords: Freedom, determinism, everyday causality, naturalistic and personalistic attitude.

At the very beginning of my analysis I will not pose the question whether or not we are free. Nevertheless, this is a central theme in modern and contemporary philosophy. While I do not consider this question to be unimportant, I think that it is secondary to the question in what way do we experience that we are free. Therefore, I wrote this essay under the working title of "How are we free?," and you can surmise from this indirect formulation which questions I will pose and which I think to be of secondary interest.

Using the framework of Husserl's phenomenological methods, we must ask the question of our freedom completely from within the perspective of our own experiences. Nevertheless, I accept the everyday self-understood belief that we are responsible for our deeds and must therefore be free. This freedom is not to be understood as an absolute freedom, because we know from our own experience that we decide under many different influences; yet, we believe that we are not determined by any one of these influences or even by the sum of them.

Our own personal experience indicates that we are free. We register the fact of our freedom by recognizing the space of our decisions, for example when choosing between alternatives. We are moved by different motives to different

sides of a decision; we waver between them, but we are not completely determined by one of the intuitively felt motives. But this everyday conviction can only be taken as a claim for insight into our freedom, a claim that has to be verified (confirmed) by a phenomenological analysis of our willing, deciding and acting. To do this we must concentrate on the specific ways of experiencing freedom in our conscious life, and only after this examination we might—now with the right of intuition—say that we are free.

Therefore, we have to start with an analysis of our willing and deciding. We have to know what we can do in principle and what motives are working on us that can influence our decisions. In doing this I will work in the methodical framework of Edmund Husserl's phenomenology and make use of some of his analysis of the will in *Ideas II* and *Studien zur Struktur des Bewusstseins*.

There are some popular prevalent determinist theses that claim that humans are not free due to factors found in human nature. I will neither ignore these theses nor take them too seriously; however, in order to justify such an attitude, I must consider them at the outset.

The first deterministic thesis stems from theology and rests on the idea that we are created by an omnipotent and omniscient God. If we are created by such a God, then it seems very likely that all of our actions and decisions are predetermined in advance. Obviously there are alternatives to this conception in theological thinking that try to base human freedom on theological arguments. For example, there is the Christian idea that we have an immortal soul, which is punished or rewarded in the Last Judgement. The immortal soul, incorporated into the mortal human, is the subject that is held responsible for his deeds and decisions in front of God. Therefore, this immortal soul must be absolutely free in its decisions, while the human body is always influenced by inclinations. If the soul might not be absolutely free, it would be unfair to regard it responsible for its deeds.

Concerning theological thinking, we could argue that it is somehow old fashioned and we should not have to discuss it in philosophy. But this attitude ignores that the heritage of theology is still at work under a philosophical disguise. We might see this already in Kant's ethics when he insists that our decisions and actions cannot be influenced by inclination but must be motivated by pure reason alone in order to claim to be free. It appears to me to be the fiction of a completely non-inclined reasonable subject, for there cannot be even the smallest part of inclination in our motives. This immediately would be a heteronomy and thus we would not be responsible for this decision. In Husserl's texts we will see that he thinks of a free subject even though it is at the same time subject to many effective inclinations.

There are more influential determinist theories that belong to the broad stream of influence of the natural sciences, first of all the idea of universal causality in nature. The unlimited generalization of this concept is a part of the idealizations in modern physics. This idealizing presupposition is problematic—which Husserl points out from the *Ideas II* until the *Crisis*—especially when we

understand ourselves as a subject of decisions in this paradigm. If we do this, we conceive ourselves only as a part of the mechanism of nature determined causally in every move. Then, freedom is nothing but a consolidating illusion, like responsibility, love or guilt. At minimum this is a bizarre misinterpretation of our self; but also an incorrect generalization of an idealizing presupposition of natural science about us as subjects—the subjects conceiving science, nature, culture and the world as a whole. In my opinion: If today there is still a struggle against bad metaphysics it has to be directed against this hasty transference of a fruitful methodical concept of physics onto human subjects.

This critique of the idea of universal causality does not affect our everyday concept of causality that belongs to our experience of the world.¹ In the everyday attitude we know about numerous regularities of events following other events, and being experiencing human subjects we constantly take into account these regularities in our plans.

I will take a distanced attitude to these deterministic positions. In fact, I believe that we will not have to take determinist positions into consideration in the discussion of human freedom at all. This attitude is grounded in Husserl's starting point in vivid (sensual) intuition, the general personalistic attitude of phenomenology and Husserl's critique of the idealizing presupposed in natural science as found in his *Crisis*. In my view, Husserl's phenomenology also contains an attempt of a phenomenological dialectics that identifies illegitimate crossings of boundaries.² Thus, this dialectic has a similar function as Kant's transcendental dialectic in his *Critique of Pure Reason*, but it is directed differently and grounded in other insights.

What might Husserl have said in the *Crisis* about the naturalizing theory of universal causality in nature expanding to entail human subjects and their decisions? His answer results from his discussion on the formation of modern science: The idea of universal causality is an important idealizing presupposition of modern natural sciences. It is an extremely *fruitful* methodical presupposition of physics and all other natural sciences. It allows for the forecasting of causal effects of events, which in the technical use turns out to be very *useful* for our everyday life.³

But scientific fruitfulness and usefulness in our everyday life is not yet truth, and in judging theories these two aspects are not our only criteria, because

¹ As one of the inspirations for discussing the theme of freedom, I would like to refer to a lecture by László Tengelyi: 2014. *Freiheit als partielle Kausalität*. Wuppertal. Cf. also Rinofner-Kreidl, S. 2007. "On Naturalizing Free Will." In: *Rediscovering Phenomenology*. Boi, L., P. Kerszberg, F. Patras (Eds.). Springer, 125–164. I would like to express my gratitude to Paul Zipfel for his engaged efforts to improve my English text.

² By this I will not allude to the analyses of Karl Schuhmann under the same title. Cf. Schuhmann, K. 1973. *Die Dialektik der Phänomenologie*, 2 volumes. Nijhoff: Den Haag.

³ Today we have learned to be more sceptical: The unlimited exploitation of the resources of our planet through technique and with the aim of maximizing the benefit for single persons or groups will soon find its limits. Further, technical mastering and complete control of human life can become an obstacle of a rational and good life.

there are absurd consequences of human self-interpretation following this pattern: The human subject can interpret himself only as a small part of the causal mechanism and not as responsible subject.

In view of this strong contrast in interpreting the world as a whole, we may ask: What is the true world? Is it our personalistic everyday world, where we have friends and enemies, or is it the “world in the background” (*Hinterwelt*) of atoms, electrons, quarks and bosons? Today for many humans this second idea of a bare physical world seems to be the real, true world. However, in this regard Husserl in his *Crisis* is very clear: All conceptions of such non-intuitive worlds staying “behind” the experienced world (and causing it) can only gain their sense and the limits of their sense from the experienced everyday world that is completely within our reach. In this concern it makes no difference whether it is a religious, a philosophical-metaphysical or an idealized-scientific picture of the “world in the background.” All these ideas of the true background world are sense productions of communities engaged in common activities like believing, valuing and doing research—but not more. In no case can they be the decisive, true world because there is only one world: the one we live in, where we have personal connections, etc., i.e. the lifeworld.⁴

Husserl writes that all problems concerning the truth and the being of those worlds in the background, all methods, hypotheses, results, etc., for any kind of world can only find their last solution and clearness in going back to the lifeworld where we live in personal relations.⁵ Thus, there is also in Husserl the function of a dialectic that determines the limits of epistemic claims by going back to intuition—be these mythical, religious or scientific claims.

A central methodical problem in Husserl’s project of a critique of scientific idealizations is the fact that all contents of these convictions regarding the “true world” behind the everyday world have already somehow flowed into the everyday world (*Einströmen*).⁶ The everyday concept of the world is not autonomous in regard to the contents of science because the view of the world is a constitutive product of a community that acts, believes and does research. In fact our view of the world in which we live has a lot of elements stemming from the idealizations of physics—in the same way as religious ideas are an important element of our understanding of the world and ourselves today or were in the past.

⁴ Cf. Husserl, E. 1976. *Die Krisis der europäischen Wissenschaften und die transzendente Phänomenologie*. Den Haag: Nijhoff, § 34 f.

⁵ He writes that “alle Wahrheits- und Seinsprobleme, alle für sie erdenklichen Methoden, Hypothesen, Ergebnisse—ob für Erfahrungswelten oder metaphysische Hinterwelten—ihre letzte Klarheit, ihren evidenten Sinn oder die Evidenz des Widersinns [...]” find in the life-world cf. Husserl, E. 1976, op. cit., 136. You will realize that in this context Husserl does not distinguish between the background-worlds of natural sciences, myths and theology.

⁶ Cf. Husserl, E. 1976, op. cit., § 34 e. The phenomenon of the “seeping-in” of ideas related to the respective background-worlds is not only registered in our present lifeworld so closely related to idealizing natural sciences. We may detect this interweaving of motives also in a lifeworld related closely to religious thought.

Therefore, it is relatively difficult to loosen the influence of these commonly accepted elements of our understanding of the world—in the case of religion as well as in the case of scientific idealizations. In this concern Husserl sees an important application of his transcendental reduction (besides its application in the project of a radical foundation of knowledge): Transcendental reduction can free us from the boundaries of our tradition and commonly accepted beliefs by holding back (bracketing) the performance of commonly accepted beliefs, thereby opening our eyes for the real intuitive fulfilment of our intentions of individual objects.⁷ All other objects and also the cultural senses of value, property, proper use, etc., belong to the realm of beliefs initiated by the community we live in—and all of them include ideas about something attached to everyday objects that does not fall within our intuition, something that we cannot perceive but which we nevertheless believe.

We should not forget that the most important enemy of the critical phenomenological dialectic is the naturalization of the human subject and the thesis of universal causality. Further, in this case—despite our high estimation of science as a whole—we must insist on systematic grounds that science and all its idealizations are also to be regarded as a part of the common beliefs, i.e. as a cultural formation.

We might also ask whether we are not already so-called “compatibilists” when we interpret the idea of universal causality as a methodical idealization. This might be understood as one of the ways of binding without contradiction universal causality and the fact of our freedom in decision and action. I do not want to go into the details of compatibilist conceptions, but I think that we must reject this reading of the phenomenological attitude. We simply cannot be compatibilists because we do not accept the belief in universal causality ruling all

⁷ Cf. Lohmar, D. 2002. “Die Idee der Reduktion. Husserls Reduktionen und ihr gemeinsamer methodischer Sinn.” In: *Die erscheinende Welt. Festschrift für K. Held*. Hüni, H., P. Trawny (Eds.). Berlin, 751–771 and idem. 2006. “Ich ... enthalte mich aller Tradition.” *Freiheit und Epoché in Husserls späten Schriften*. In: *Tradition und Traditionsbruch*. v. Bickmann, C. et al. (Eds.). Amsterdam, 193–207.

We might ask why Husserl did not discuss the classical topics of theological metaphysics like existence and properties of God, the existence and immortality of the soul, the beginning and end of the world, etc. On the one hand—due to Kant and the Enlightenment—these themes generally have lost a lot of their relevance, and, on the other hand, Husserl’s access to such products of an intersubjective constitution of cultural senses is quite different from the contemporaries of Kant. Husserl takes all of these topics for justified themes of our thought, but the related questions are posed in an important modification completely alien to Kant and his contemporaries: All of these metaphysical topics are part of the specific realm of “cultural senses,” and these senses are constituted by each culture in a different way. For example the questions concerning the existence and properties of God are no longer regarded as questions referring to a real object, i.e. as epistemological or ontological questions, but more like the specific questions of human sciences (*Geisteswissenschaften*). The related questions are (in some parallelism to the questions he poses in regard of the offspring and the initiation of modern sciences in the *Crisis*): Which conception of creation and God can we find here? In which cultural formations they show up and how is the filiation and modification of these ideas.

events in nature, including the human subjects' thinking and deciding. It is possible to view ourselves as a part of the causal mechanism of nature, as in the case of neurology. Currently, it is common to conceptualize thinking as an activity of the brain. This is not yet an incorrect idea, but if we understand this point of view as absolute truth and as a special case of universal causality, then it might appear to us as a clear consequence that our brain is thinking us. For example, Thomas Metzinger claims that it is our brain that construes a fictive entity that we call "Ego."⁸ As a consequence, all of our experienced motives and propensities, as well as our experience of wavering in the situation of making a decision, that causes us to believe that we are free, all of these are only epiphenomena without function.

But this is in fact a peculiar upside-down picture of the situation. We can only avoid this kind of misinterpretation if we reject the wrong transfer of idealizing presuppositions in natural science onto ourselves as persons. In this concern the strict personalism of the *Ideas II* and the critique of science in the *Crisis* still have the important function of reminding us of what we have forgotten: the idealizing presuppositions of science.

While the first historical Enlightenment opposes political paternalism and dogmatic religious thinking, today a renewal of the idea of rational self-determination must oppose naturalization in the philosophical understanding of humans. Today wrong metaphysics is the naturalization of subjects, i.e. the transfer of physicalistic idealizations onto humans.

Up to now we have mostly eliminated obstacles to an objective understanding of our freedom. For example, we do not have to share the opinion of the naturalizing "new metaphysics" that human subjects are only a small part of mechanics, and thus with decisions resulting only from mechanical influences. We also do not inherit from the old metaphysics the view that the subject of our decisions is an immortal reasonable soul departed from the body and uninfluenced by passions. In opposition to both the views we are subjects of decisions subordinating to many effective influences, but in spite of them we still are free in deciding. These effective influences on our decisions are registered by us; they have noticeable influence and thus are intuitively given to us. In Husserl's view humans are free-subjects-under-heavy-influences.

In Husserl's *Studien zur Struktur des Bewusstseins*, approximately one third of the analyses is dedicated to the will. He investigates how humans experience their real possibilities to act in intuitive ways.⁹ Husserl describes the margins of our possibilities and the aspects of our freedom in the framework of depend-

⁸ Cf. Metzinger, Th. 2009. *Der Ego-Tunnel*. Berlin.

⁹ Cf. Ms. A VI 12 I / Bl. 189a, cf. on the topic of freedom also the hints in Note No. 12. The special characteristic of real possibility is—like in every reality—that they are empirically dependent upon the circumstances: "Denn Reales ist, was es ist, überhaupt nur in Bezug auf 'Umstände' seines Verhaltens." I thank Prof. Dr. Ullrich Melle, the director of the Husserl-Archive Leuven for the permission to cite unpublished Husserl's manuscripts.

encies. Thus, in the first view, the space of freedom seems to be strongly limited.

One of the very provoking theses concerning our acting is:

“I find myself empirically dependent on the ‘outer’ world of things, in a special way dependant on my lived body, which is the go-between of outer effects on me, dependant on my subterranean knowledge (*seelischer Untergrund*), my memory, my factual associations, etc.; but then also on other people, positive law, the church, etc.”¹⁰

The most alarming of this list of dependencies is the “etc.” that indicates that this list is neither finished nor may be finished.

If a subject is in the focus of so many effective dependencies, an expert on the human psyche might guess quite reliably how the course of the decisions of a person will develop in special situations. But even this relative reliability of the decisions of persons does not imply that they are not free in their deciding.¹¹ Think of someone who habitually orders Wiener Schnitzel—even this person might surprise us by taking salad or a vegetarian dish.

One might object that I have a quite trivial idea of freedom coming from everyday experiences and that my theses are easy to reject by scientific naturalizing hypotheses. But we should remember that there are sciences of humans and animals not bound by a simplifying causal scheme. I am thinking of evolution theory which faces a mixture of physiological, behaviour, specific psychic facilities and culturally acquired institutions in a species that all together master the challenge of selection in a changing surrounding. In this special view, the freedom of choice is nothing more than a broad spread variant of behavioural strategy (in the sense of arbitrariness or incalculability of reaction in the flight of animals). Thus, freedom is no longer a special gift of God to its preferred creatures necessarily combined with reason and self-consciousness. A species whose reaction to the challenge of a predator is easy to foresee will not survive. Nevertheless, there are differences in the species’ lifestyles that matter here: the species that produces a hundred thousand or a million offspring at one time might get along well with a stereotypical strategy in flight behaviour, but the species that has only few offspring to raise with a great deal of energy cannot afford such luxury—and humans are not the only species to meet this characterization. Opposed to this, a predator may follow a more simple strategy.

¹⁰ The German wording is: “Ich finde mich empirisch abhängig von der ‘äußeren’ Dingwelt, in besonderer Weise von meinem Leib, dem Vermittler äußerer Einwirkungen, von meinem seelischen Untergrund, meinem Gedächtnis, meinen faktisch gewordenen Assoziationen usw.; dann aber auch von anderen Menschen, von dem geltenden Recht, von der Kirche usw.” Ms. A VI 12 I / Bl. 189a.

¹¹ In this point we do not have to agree with Husserl cf. Hume, D. 1967. *Eine Untersuchung über den menschlichen Verstand*. Stuttgart: Reclam, chap. 8.

To understand correctly this argument for freedom from evolution we have to become clear about the special character of the functional explanations of evolution theory, because there are no prescribed causal ways to solve problems: everything what is successful goes. This means that everything that allows a species to survive is a possible way to survive and in this regard functional. The only condition of a proper, a “fitting” combination of physiology, behaviour and common institutions, is a factual success, the survival of the species. In this regard there are no necessary, but only sufficient conditions of this success. And usually there are different ways to ensure the survival of species, including self-made common institutions and their tradition in a community. For example, it may be altruism or some other strategy analogous to a kind of morals that leads a species to survival (like in the case of humans), and then this solution functions, but if egoism and recklessness is a way of success this will also function. Therefore, in higher cerebralized species the way to survive does not consist only in learning from experience. There also must be a certain degree of unpredictability in their reaction, and thus the fact of the survival of this species shows its freedom.

We might tend to follow the broadly spread prejudice concerning science, namely claiming that all natural sciences are based on the causal paradigm, but this does not align with evolution theory. It would be a misunderstanding of the character of the explanations of evolution theory, even if it is based on paleontology, archaeology, biology, medicine, physics, neurology, etc. Even if evolution theory has to make use of all of these natural sciences (in the strict sense), each of them based on the causal paradigm, it itself does not depend in its explanations exclusively on this paradigm.

But now let us come back to the phenomenological access to freedom.

Freedom is not a central theme in Husserl's phenomenology, but this is also true about many other more anthropological themes. He considers aspects of freedom in his different lectures on ethics but usually only *en passant*; as in the *Ideas II*, the articles in the Japanese-German journal *Kaizo*, and the *Studien zur Struktur des Bewusstseins*.¹² The theme of freedom is relevant because it is a central element of human self-conception and an essential presupposition of every ethics.

¹² Husserl touches the theme of freedom usually in his analyses concerning will, cf. for example his lectures on ethics from 1914 (cf.: Husserl, E. 1988. *Vorlesungen über Ethik und Wertlehre 1908–1914*. Dordrecht: Kluwer, §§ 13–21), and the lecture on ethics from 1920 (see: idem. 2004. *Einleitung in die Ethik. Vorlesungen Sommersemester 1920 und 1924*. Dordrecht: Kluwer, §§ 44–49), cf. also his *Erneuerung als individualethisches Problem* (in: Hua XXVII, 20–42). From the *Studien zur Struktur des Bewusstseins*, forthcoming in 4 volumes, I would like to mention the manuscript entitled “Ich kann” (A VI 12 II/155–156 and A VI 12 I/Bl. 189–190) and also a manuscript that was part of „Ich kann“ (Ms. F IV 3, 82–83 and Ms. F IV 3 / Bl. 76–81, from 1918). The most important secondary source of Husserl's phenomenology of the will is still: Melle, U. 1992. “Husserls Phänomenologie des Willens.” *Tijdschrift voor Filosofie*, 54, 280–304.

Therefore, it is astonishing that there are only a few analyses dedicated to freedom. An exceptionally good presentation is found in Phillippe Merz's *Werterfahrung und Wahrheit*.¹³ I have the impression that I can not exceed this discussion, so I will concentrate on three of the central forms of our experience of freedom in an individual subject: freedom in my bodily abilities, freedom in my intentional performances, and freedom in my personal decisions.

One of the most prominent fields of experience of our freedom is our knowledge about our bodily abilities. My body is the only element in the world that I can move immediately, while I can move other objects only with the help of my limbs. In moving objects I feel the weight and inertia of these bodies and even that of my own body. Thus, I also have an experience of everyday causality in these kinds of actions: The suitcase is nearly too heavy, so I can barely carry it, or my arm moves the cue and this moves the billiard ball, passing its momentum on to the next ball, etc.

My body is not only the organ of all of my actions previously conceived in my will, it is also a movable organ of different perceptions: visual, tactual, acoustic, olfactory and taste. My body can move my sense organs to new places of interest, and this free mobility is interwoven in the performance of constitution in most forms of perception. I see something circular in my visual field. It may be a sphere with a spatial extension, perhaps a ball, and I assure myself that it is a sphere by a slight lateral movement of my head. The sense element of spatiality in this object motivates me further to touch the object and to experience its extension as well as the spherical shape. We can transfer this analogically to all of my sense organs. The free movability of my body is directly motivated, intended practically and performed in the same moment that I have a direct kinaesthetic feedback. Moreover my body is a carrier of the involuntary and voluntary expressions that others can see and interpret.

I have a lot of experiences with my body and I know about its abilities, which are also my abilities; I know what I can and cannot do with my body. Husserl's analyses of the "I can" and our experience of bodily freedom (in the *Studien* and *Ideas II*) start with single and quite low-level forms of this "I can." The lowest levels of bodily action are terminologically referred to by Husserl as "mere doing." He establishes a terminological difference between the intentional "actions" on the base of a decision of the conscious ego, the "I" and the mere doing that is not yet intending a clear aim.¹⁴ I know "what I can do" in a special mode, and I do not have to remember my former bodily actions to know about the scope of my doing. The knowledge about my scope of bodily doing is built

¹³ Cf. Merz, Ph. 2015. *Werterfahrung und Wahrheit. Phänomenologische Ethikbegründung nach Husserl*. Paderborn.

¹⁴ In regard to this "mere doing" we might object that I am only able to speak of this doing in sentences that use the phrase "I do ..." and that therefore my "I", the ego, must be involved also in this kind of activity. This is true, but only in regard to the conventions of language that—in this case—leads us to an error concerning the facts. Rules of speaking of something are not always rules of facts.

of my former doings that I perform without special attention to them, i.e. my involuntary bodily doing (*unwillkürliche Tätigkeiten*). My involuntary bodily doings interweave and somehow organize and synthesize themselves in a system of “possible bodily deeds.” In this concern we should not interpret the idea of system at a level too high. What is meant in this context by the system is the possibility of combining elements of my involuntary doing, like taking hold of something, pulling it to me, turning it, etc., into a new bodily doing. Therefore, I also can anticipate movements as possible for me that I had not performed previously. This forms a kind of unlimited system of possible combinations, but on the other side this system is not completely open, for there are also limits of my bodily movements of which I am well aware. I cannot bend my arm in every angle. This system of possible bodily movements is well motivated and also limited in my own experiences of involuntary doing.¹⁵

Now let us step over to the level of intentional performances. On this level we have a scope of freedom that is also present to us in our own experiences. This scope of freedom is to be registered on lower as well as on higher levels of constitution. I start with quite a high-level example: In the formation of my values and practical attitudes towards objects and possible actions, there is always a personal go-between in play: parents, relatives, grandparents, neighbours, etc. The character of the person who mediates values always plays an important role in the formation of my own character. Think about the possible scenario that my father might be a choleric with a violent temper and he has gotten along well in his life with this social strategy. Even then I am not forced to accept and adopt his temper, for I can like and adopt this strategy or dislike and reject it. Thus, in this situation the individual valuation of his violent temper plays a decisive role. There is a strong influence of his example on my character, but it is me who decide whether I like or dislike it: I am deciding with my non-predictable apperception and valuation whether the influence is positive or negative.

The same may be found on all deeper levels of my intentional life. For example, all our instinctive drives that we experience with our body are not yet motives that move me to act. Husserl calls these drives “*Anmutungen*,” i.e. something like an impression with a tendency to follow the drive—but not yet a motive that really moves me. Thus, all of these bodily-experienced instinctive tendencies are not yet motives to act because they have to be accepted as such motives by an intentional attention and by something like deciding to accept this felt tendency as a motive for my action. However, in this act of positively

¹⁵ From a methodological point of view in this analysis we find the same proceeding as in Husserl's analyses of the constitution of time and space. They do not start with abstract ideas or concepts but with concrete experiences with single spatial objects tactually given and with specific objects of time like events or melodies. Husserl starts from the concrete experienced single object to analyze and understand the constitution of the big space and the big time—not the other way around, as for example in Kant's view.

taking up a tendency and making it a motive, these instinctively raised tendencies are *moderated*—i.e. tendencies do not simply causally move us to actions and this work of causal influence works in every case in the same way. Opposed to this simple model we are only motivated to become attentive to these tendencies and react with acceptance of varying degrees or with rejection, and the outcome of this process of moderation might be a positive action trying to live in the tendency but not necessarily. All this is dependent on active, conscious and free intentional performances that we might perform or not. It is within our deciding that we either accept the instinctive tendencies as motives for our deeds or do not, and it is up to us to what extent we accept them.

For the important role of intentional performances we also can find quite good examples on a very low level of constitution: a loud visual or acoustic impression, as well as hunger, a dull toothache, etc., is affecting us with its tendency. This impression has a kind of drive that Husserl describes as a draw that attracts our attention, but it does not force us to attend to it, because maybe some interesting lecture allows us to forget about our toothache or hunger—at least for a time. What is missing here is an intentional performance that turns our attention to the object “my hunger” or “my toothache,” and even if I turn my intentional attention to these objects, there is still missing the acceptance in different modes (or a rejection) that gives the tendency an influence on my actions; these are the performances that make tendencies into motives. On all levels of constitution up to personal and conscious decisions, the human subjects have the ability to moderate the effect of instinctive tendencies on actions.¹⁶

In extreme cases even very strong instinctive tendencies can remain without effecting our actions because they undergo a moderation on the intentional level. If we think about high-level personal motives, we see that these motives can have an effect on our drives, for example can move political motives to a hunger strike.

Further, the level of conscious personal decisions is bound to necessary intentional performances, one of the most important performances in this concern is to become (and stay) conscious of myself in different ways. A very characteristic mode of self-conception is to conceive of myself as being a person in a community. This intentional performance opens up a new realm of personal factors to us that we experience also in the form of impressional given tendencies (*Anmutung*).

Jean Paul Sartre describes a person watching other persons through a keyhole—this example and the dynamics in it allow us to well understand in which way we can reach the personalistic level of self-conception in “regarding

¹⁶ Husserl wrote that human subjects on all levels of constitution had the possibility: “sein passives Tun [...] und die es passiv motivierenden Voraussetzungen (Neigungen, Meinungen) in ihrer Auswirkung zu ‘hemmen,’ sie in Frage zu stellen,” cf. Hua XXVII, 24.

myself as a person in a community” (*Sich-als-Person-in-der-Gemeinschaft-Betrachten*).¹⁷ The voyeur at the key hole is a human subject completely entangled in his doing, and he may also be fascinated by the spectacle that is offered him. But suddenly he performs the intention on the others and the community as a whole—and this might happen without his really being trapped by someone else.

Suddenly, he feels ashamed because he becomes aware of the picture he might give for others. This new intention includes that he conceives himself as a person that is in the look of others (*Sich-als-Person-in-dem-Blick-Anderer-Begreifen*). And this self-conception raises immediately a learned valuation of his peeping, a valuation he is factually sharing as a member of his community. But only in the light of this newly acquired status of self-conception he criticizes himself: You should not do this. One should not do this! And this new valuative attitude reveals that he was not conscious of himself in this important personal regard, while in fact he was conscious of himself in other regards, for example, in bodily regard as being bent in an uncomfortable posture.

We realize that if we localize ourselves as persons in a community, there are new personal and communal impressions working on us, like sympathy and shame. We feel exposed to these new demands and personal mediated influences, influences that did not affect us while we were conscious of ourselves but not in the mode of being persons in our community, such as the valuations of our community, the individual demands of single persons (or groups) to which we have a personal relation.

But also at this level of affections in the mode of being a person in our community these affections (in the form of social feelings) have to be taken up in intentional performances to become effective motives of my actions. As on the lower level of instinctive affections, this intentional performance works in a well differentiated way, for I have to be and I can be selective in giving or rejecting this influence in my moderating of the intentional activity. Located here are spaces for my decision to take up (and to what extent) an affection as motive for me. As long as I conceive of myself as a person in our community, I have to decide about this question. Only in this personal self-determination I can reach the level of full personal freedom.¹⁸

In the process of deciding on a personal level, I have to posit an aim as the state of affairs to which I am striving, and I have to hold on to this aim during

¹⁷ Cf. Sartre, J. P. 1984 (1943). *Being and Nothingness*. Barnes, H. E. (Trans.). New York: Washington Square Press, part 3, chap. 1, IV.

¹⁸ Beside this there are also other differences concerning the way we are conscious of ourselves. For example, a big part of our everyday affairs and actions are organized only on a habitual level. We lock the door, we switch of the coffee-machine, etc., and this is done in an habitual way. We do not perform these actions with an “awake consciousness” (*wachen Bewusstsein*), and we do not have to judge consciously on each phase of our actions.

the whole action. Beside this, to start with the concrete action I have to initiate an impulse to start the action: Now I will start doing it—and I start doing it! During the process of realizing the aim, I have to hold on to this aim and my will to realize it. I have to keep on this will to realize this aim.¹⁹

Every now and then I will find myself in a situation in which I have to decide about an action that tends to bind myself as a person and for the future. In such situations I am in a conscious relation to my own future, and I have to make up my mind who I would like to be in the future, which kind of human person I would like to be.

Also this figure of a conscious self-obligation is only to be found on the constitutional level of the person in her community. And only here we can also find the element of an explicit, public discussion on the aims of our self-determination (which is an agreement in which ideally all members of the community take part). This communal agreement can—but must not—be oriented to low-level values like the common benefit.²⁰ It might also be a conscious striving towards a theoretical and practical ideal of the self-determination of our community. For Husserl the highest ideal of reasonable life for individual persons as well as for communities is rational self-determination in theory and practice. In his late lectures and writings he often calls this ideal the aim of rational self-determination “Europa.”²¹

ABOUT THE AUTHOR — Professor for Philosophy at the University of Cologne, Husserl-Archive, Albertus-Magnus-Platz, D-50923 Cologne, Germany (affiliation). Beside many articles in the fields of phenomenology, transcendental philosophy and empiricism, he wrote: 1989. *Phänomenologie der Mathematik*. Dordrecht: Kluwer; 1998. *Erfahrung und kategoriales Denken*. Dordrecht–Boston–London: Kluwer; 2000.

¹⁹ On Husserl’s theory of action and will, cf. Melle, U. 1992. “Husserls Phänomenologie des Willens.” *Tijdschrift voor Filosofie*, 54, 1992, 280–304.

²⁰ We might analyze in a further step a distinction that reveals on the level of communicating communities—and this does not only refer to human communities but also to animal communities—i.e. the low level more or less casual self-determination of groups in living in different forms of “common manners” (*Sitten*, ethos) and the self-determination in high-level ideals that demand the concepts of language. While the last is obviously at the personalist level of free self-determination in agreement with others, the former seems to entail also an element of freedom, for the resulting regional manners differ so much. For this matter cf. my contribution: 2016. “Freiheit des Einzelnen und Freiheit der Gemeinschaft.” *Phänomenologische Forschungen Sonderband*, 129–144.

²¹ It is important to know that Husserl did not identify this ideal aim—which by definition cannot be realized by any community—with a regional cultural formation like the factual political and cultural entity of relative homogeneous European nations of his time. The deeper sense of this raising and establishing an ideal of rationality is the critique of the factual state of the regional and historical entity of Europa of his time. It is this function of critique that asks the historical Europa to adjust to the non-regional and non-historical idea of “Europa.”

Edmund Husserls 'Formale und Transzendente Logik.' Werkinterpretationen. Darmstadt; 2008. *Phänomenologie der schwachen Phantasie.* Dordrecht–Heidelberg: Springer; 2016. *Denken ohne Sprache. Der phänomenologische Zugang zum nichtsprachlichen Denken und Kommunizieren bei Menschen und Tieren.* Heidelberg: Springer.

E-mail: dieter.lohmar@uni-koeln.de

Mariannina Failla

DISTURBANCES OF TEMPORALITY AND THE POTENTIALITIES OF PHENOMENOLOGICAL PERCEPTION

ABSTRACT

The paper presents the phenomenological conception of bodily perception (*leibliche Wahrnehmung*) as a possible therapeutic model for treating melancholic depression. At the beginning, it discusses some key concepts of Freud's psychoanalysis: instinct (*Trieb*), memory, perception, narcissism and melancholia. Next, the Freudian theory of melancholia is compared with studies of phenomenological psychopathology (Binswanger). It is investigated how melancholia is based on the division of temporal relations. Finally, the main problem of the paper is investigated: can the structure of perception and its constitutive openness toward the future represent a theoretical model for therapeutic practices designed to treat melancholic depression?

Keywords: instinct (Freud), impulse (Husserl), perception, narcissism, mourning, melancholia, association, time.

1. INSTINCT, MEMORY AND PERCEPTION IN THE WORK OF SIGMUND FREUD

To explain the peculiar nature of perception in Husserl's view we begin with Freud's consideration. The latter immediately differentiated perception from instinct by using what he termed the "biological postulate": the goal of the nervous system is to maintain a permanent state of inertia, eliminating or reducing the level of neuronal excitability to which it is constantly subjected by external stimuli.

The coming and going of a state of inertia is, all the same, immediately complicated by the fact that the nervous system also receives endogenous excitations (instinct). "[They] have their origin in the cells of the body and give rise

to the major needs: hunger, breathing, sexuality. The organism cannot withdraw as it does from external stimuli ...”¹

These words already clarify the conceptual paradigm utilised in the text *Instincts and Their Vicissitudes*. It can be summarised as follows: instinct implies an investment of energy that does not arrive at the psyche from the exterior, but rather from the interior of the body; it cannot be discharged by muscle movements that generally preside over the activity of perception. As it is not discharged, eased, or at least reduced in strength by muscle movements, the endogenous stimulus is not fleeting and transitory, but instead permanent and constant. It is a free emotional energy that accumulates and induces pressure for its own satisfaction.

The dimension of emotional instinct thus receives an energetic-quantitative interpretation that qualifies it a threshold of the psychic and the somatic. The characteristic of the threshold concept and the accumulation of energy places instinct in relation to another dynamic tied to the accumulation and waning of energy: memory.

Like instinct, memory is an endogenous energetic-neuronal process. It corresponds to the internal relationship between body and psyche. For this reason its structure and constitution are far from the neuronal dynamics tied to perception.

Freud's *Project for a Scientific Psychology* presents us with significant passages that clearly separate the (quantitative) dynamics of memory from the (qualitative) dynamics of conscious perception. The text affirms that memory is a dynamic generally devoid of quality, in other words, devoid of relations with the reality of perception, hearing, touch and its elaboration through language.²

To describe mnestic dynamics, Freud turned to the theme of the energetic-quantitative investment of the nervous system. Like instinct, that was neither satisfied, nor diminished or eliminated by escapes (*Flucht*) of “motor apparatuses,” memory is born of the play between the blockage and conduction of flows of energy. Indeed, when speaking of memory Freud employed the terms permeability (*Durchgängigkeit*) and resistance (*Widerstand*) to the quantity of energy flowing between neurons.

These terms become crucial to the establishment of a clear demarcation between the ϕ neurons, those that offer no blockage to flows of energy, and the ψ neurons that, instead, resist the discharge or release of energy.

All the same, memory is not based on the rigid concept of impermeability and resistance, because within the system of ψ neurons Freud identified a relative permeability and conduction of energy that he referred to as *Bahnung* (the “facilitation” or channelling of neuronal energy). In its constitution memory already contains a choice or selection, due, in this context, to the difference,

¹ Freud, S. 1953–1974. *Project for a Scientific Psychology. The Standard Edition of the Complete Works of Sigmund Freud*, vol. 1. Strachy, J. (Trans.). London: Hogarth Press. Institute of Psycho-analysis, 297.

² Ibid., 308: “But here is one psychical process which is no doubt performed exclusively in ϕ -reproducing or remembering—and this, speaking generally, is without quality.”

merely quantitative, in the capacity to absorb and channel (*bahnen*) the energy of the ψ neurons.³ If we were to suppose that the capacity of neuronal conduction is equal and homogenous in any energy flow, memory could never come into being. We could never say why we remember or why there is a re-learning of some flows and not of others.⁴

As the fruit of the intrapsychic sedimentation of physical-energetic impulses, memory shares with instinct the idea of accumulation and resistance to the discharge of energy. If, however, we utilise the Freudian reflections on the aphasia of language, memory is tied not only to the internal relationship between soma and psyche. While not an act of perception, it represents the moment when the psyche is able to demonstrate its own dynamic of representation, aimed at the external world. In other words, memory enters into contact with that associative activity of the mind that manages to organise, or better yet, to reorganise sensory stimuli from vision, hearing and touch. While intrapsychic and tied to the quantitative hydraulic model of the congestion and lessening of energy, memory differs from instinct and gives rise to a recursive activity, a rewriting of neuronal flows, capable of branching out also into a perceptive-representational system. Freud mentioned this to Fliess in a confidential manner, describing to him the way in which mnestic traces are subject to a *reorganisation and rewriting* caused by new relations.⁵

Memory is thus a threshold concept for its capacity to enter into a relationship, on the one hand, with the energetic-quantitative dynamics of the nervous system and, on the other hand, with the perceptive dynamics of reality. The first deal also with the world of instinct, with its objects, destinations, etc., dominated by the categories of pleasure/displeasure. The second involve the qualitative sphere of physiological-representative activities, dominated by the principle of reality and closely tied to sensory-associative activity. The path leading from memory (quantity) to the *qualitative* representation of reality was opened to Freud by the associative logic of James Stuart Mill. In referring to it Freud spoke of the “idea (concept) of the object” (*Sachvorstellung*) as an associative complex of the sensory representations received from an object.⁶ The true motor

³ Ibid., 300 “We can therefore say still more correctly that memory is represented by the differences in the facilitations between the ϕ -neurones.”

⁴ Ibid., 301.

⁵ Freud, S. 1985. *The Complete Letters of Sigmund Freud to Wilhelm Fliess (1887–1904)*. [Letter 6 Dec. 1896]. Cambridge Mass-London: Belknap Press, 207: “As you know, I am working on the assumption that our psychic mechanism has come into being by a process of stratification: the material present in the form of memory traces being subjected from time to time to a *rearrangement* in accordance with fresh circumstances—to a *retranscription*.” See also chapter 7 of: Freud, S. 1953–1974. *The Interpretation of Dreams. The Standard Edition of the Complete Works of Sigmund Freud*, vol. 5. Strachy, J. (Trans.). London: Hogarth Press. Institute of Psycho-analysis, 539.

⁶ Freud wrote: “The word acquires its significance through its association with the ‘idea (concept) of the object’, at least if we restrict our considerations to nouns. The idea, or concept, of the object is itself another complex of associations composed of the most varied visual, auditory, tactile, kinaesthetic and other impressions.” see Freud, S. 1953. *On Aphasia*. London: Imago, 77–78.

of this complex resides in the possibility to include *a vast series of new impressions in the same associative chain*.⁷ The peculiarity of sensory representation is thus due precisely to the open nature of its associative re-modulation, to its constitutive openness toward the future, to future re-orderings. Precisely for this reason perceptive association is distinguished from word-representation, which is entirely closed and definitive.⁸ In a proto-phenomenological direction, the ties formed at the moment of perception become capable of true perceptive representations only as a function of possible future sensory aggregations. This concept could be paraphrased as follows: the connection of the body to its own associative capacity is given by the extension toward future associative-sensory activities. As Edmund Husserl stated in the *Lectures on Passive Synthesis*, it is the “not yet” of future possibilities that determines for one’s body the actuality of the perception-representation of an external object.

Perception, or object-representation (“idea of object”), presents however other aspects that emerge more clearly in the *Project for a Scientific Psychology* and *Instincts and Their Vicissitudes*. It is in this context that perception (quality) functions as an *inhibitor* to the flow of intrapsychic energy (quantity). The inhibitory action is due to the fact that the flow of mnestic and instinct energy becomes the site of possible hallucinatory events over which the activity of perception must be able to exercise an action of control, containment and easing.

According to the *Project*, the primary ego, tied to the quantitative energetic dynamics of desire (ψ stimulus), does not possess the ability to distinguish between image and reality; this ability is entrusted by Freud to another group of neurons, which possess the “indication of reality” and perform an inhibitory function toward the overinvestment of emotions (ω neurons).⁹ Moderating and governing emotional investment arriving from memory, the ω neurons thus consent one to distinguish even between a simple memory image and real perception.¹⁰

The primary phase of the ego is dominated by energetic investments (desires) which may lead to a hallucinatory state. Actually, Freud defines the primary condition of the ego as a “wishful cathexis to the point of hallucination.”¹¹ Only the inhibitory power of perceptive activity can regulate the overinvestment of emotions and consent, in this way, a normal cognitive orientation. A biological relationship with the external world¹² implies the inhibitory containment of the

⁷ Ibid., 78–79.

⁸ Finelli, R. 2005. *Tra moderno e postmoderno*. Lecce: Pensa, 111–112.

⁹ Freud, S. 1953–1974. *Project for a Scientific Psychology*, 326.

¹⁰ Ibid. “It is accordingly inhibition by the ego which makes possible a criterion for distinguishing between perception and memory.”

¹¹ Ibid.

¹² The biological perspective that considers the subject as a unity of the subject-environment was taken up by Victor von Weizsäcker, who united the Freudian perspective with that of Husserl’s notion of the kinaesthetic “I can”; see Weizsäcker, V. von 1997. *Der Gestaltkreis. Theorie der Einheit von Wahrnehmen und Bewegen*. In: *Gesammelte Werke*, vol. 4. Frankfurt a. M.: Suhrkamp.

charging of amnesic neurons, and thus the inhibition of their hallucinatory potential.¹³ The inhibitory dynamic also accompanies all cognitive activities: from perception to language to judgment.

2. LOVE, HATE, NARCISSISM AND MELANCHOLIA

If we move away from the pre-analytical phase and delve into the reflections of 1915, we find that Freud returned to the pleasure-displeasure principle not only in the analyses of the diverse components of instinct, but also in those of the love/hate relationship. This relationship would pave the way toward the definition of narcissism.

In the discussion of love and hate, narcissism is defined as an abandonment of the relationship with an object extraneous to the ego (the external world) and the substitution of the object-world with the ego-subject. Primary narcissistic gratification corresponds with a phase of the ego when the outside world is of no interest and is *indifferent*. It is precisely the indifference of the world that characterises auto-erotic love for the ego, intended as the pleasure-ego.¹⁴

There is, however, an instinct that has a relationship with the world opposed to indifference. This is hate. It reaches its development only when the worldly object makes its appearance. Its disappearance consents us to connect hate to the instincts of self-preservation. In fact, it is these instincts that offer the ego the objects of the external world to satisfy its instincts for hunger, thirst, etc.¹⁵ Thus hate has nothing to do with pleasure and its sexual function. It is clearly differentiated from sexual instincts and their pathological degenerations, analysed by Freud through the concepts of the aim and the objects of instinct (sadism and masochism). Sadism and masochism have to do with aims or objects of instinct dominated by pleasure. Instead hate is dominated by displeasure. The ego hates, detests and pushes away, to the point of destruction, all those objects that may procure it unpleasant sentiments without caring to know whether they represent a frustration to sexual satisfaction or the satisfaction of self-preservation.

Even while differentiating itself from the sphere of sexual instinct hate, all the same, has a retroactive effect on the pleasure-ego that complicates its dynamics.

¹³ Freud, S. 1953–1974. *Project for a Scientific Psychology*, 326.

¹⁴ Freud, S. 1953–1974. *Instincts and Their Vicissitudes*. In: *The Standard Edition of the Complete Works of Sigmund Freud*, vol. 14. Strachy, J. (Trans.). London: Hogarth Press. Institute of Psycho-analysis, 134–135: “At this time the external world is not cathected with interest (in a general sense) and is indifferent for purposes of satisfaction. During this period, therefore, the ego-subject coincides with what is pleasurable and the external world with what is indifferent (or possibly unpleasurable, as being a source of stimulation).”

¹⁵ *Ibid.*, 135–136.

The state of the pleasure-ego, in which the world is simply indifferent, is in fact disturbed by the experiences of the instincts for self-preservation. It is via these instincts that the ego receives objects from the exterior world and the relationship with the world is no longer one of indifference, but of the incorporation or refusal of worldly objects. If they are a source of pleasure the objects are welcomed and introjected, while anything that provokes displeasure is expelled (the mechanism of projection).¹⁶

Hate thus becomes the first form of instinct in which the ego encounters the world without yet being able to distinguish between its perceptive, visual, tactile and auditive qualities, without yet being able to explore it cognitively.

The arrival of hate instincts serves in reality to clarify the diverse phases of love: it passes from the initial auto-erotic phase, typical of narcissism, to the relationship with the world mediated by instincts toward self-preservation. Thanks to these latter, love/pleasure is transferred to objects, which are incorporated or refused through and by the “motor urge”¹⁷ (*motorisches Streben*) turned toward the external world. In this way, love is connected to two instinct aims: *das Einverleiben* and *das Fressen* (incorporate and devour) that push it to abolish any existence separate from the object. During this ultimate phase, which Freud termed anal-sadistic, the fight for the object is presented as an impulse to dominate that places no importance on destroying or damaging the external object.

With respect to the relationship with objects, it can be said that hate is older than love, that it precedes it. However, as the expression of the reaction of displeasure evoked by objects, hate remains closely tied to instincts of self-preservation. It is thus concomitant with love/pleasure.

However, if the ego remains inside the dynamic of pleasure/displeasure it is unable to establish the true moment of passage from the *world incorporated* in its instinct dynamics to the *represented world as something perceptive* (the reality principle) and even less to the world elaborated and represented through language. Merely by following the pairing pleasure/displeasure, the ego remains within this primary process dominated by emotional investment, which is potentially hallucinatory, and by defence mechanisms toward sentiments of displeasure.

What appears of interest in this Freudian analysis is its capacity to lay the foundations for some of the diagnostic elements of melancholia. The phases of the love instinct—both the auto-erotic phase of indifference toward the world-object and that of the incorporation/repulsion of the object—reveal, in the end, a closure of the ego within its own narcissistic pleasure. This may help us to better comprehend the particular relationship established by those suffering from melancholia.

¹⁶ Ibid., 136, Freud wrote “introjects (Ferenczi’s term) [...] expels (mechanism of projection).”

¹⁷ Ibid., 137.

In the *Mourning and Melancholia* Freud examined these two pathologies, establishing an analogy that he would not see through in all detail.

Like mourning, melancholia is also characterised by a lack of interest in the outside world, by the loss of the ability to love, by the inhibition toward any activity and a personal despondency that “culminates in the delusional expectation of punishment.”¹⁸ To these analogies, however, melancholia adds a few entirely particular characteristics: “In mourning it is the world which has become poor and empty; in melancholia it is the ego itself.”¹⁹ The ego is drained and at the same time resists, adverse to any libidinal investment in the exterior world; it is drained and closes in on itself in a narcissistic and hallucinatory manner. The narcissistic return to the self as a consequence of the loss of an object is thus the dominant trait of melancholia.

Mourning sees to it that the ego manages to move through pain and fulfil the experience of the lost object, reconstructing the possibility for a libidinal experience of the world through the shift toward another object (that is, by investing in diverse and new objects). Mourning is thus a work of symbolisation and introjection of loss, thanks to which it is possible to invest in new objects or objects “of a second nature.” The regaining of reality through the symbolisation of its loss and the production of new object relations may bring to mind the two-fold dynamic of loss and regain of the object relationship, typical of the artistic fantasy that Freud speaks about in *Lesson 23* of the *Introductory Lectures on Psychoanalysis*.²⁰ The possibility to move beyond reality and return to it, passing from the real object to the symbolic object, is entirely precluded to melancholia. It leaves no hope for the objective reproduction of fantasy and, in the end, for mourning.

We can now look at the particular dynamic of melancholia: (1) at the outset the ego chooses an object, it places a strong restriction on the libido of a given person, in other words an operation of powerful libidinal fixation (*Fixierung*) on the object of love; (2) the loved person becomes a cause of delusion to the ego; (3) the object relation is disturbed and the object investment, scarcely resistant, is suspended; (4) the libido, initially restricted by the object, is freed and, instead of being shifted onto another object, is led back to the ego; (5) this libido is utilised to establish an unconscious identification of the ego with the abandoned object.

¹⁸ Freud S., 1953–1974. *Mourning and Melancholia*. In: *The Standard Edition of the Complete Works of Sigmund Freud*, vol. 14. Strachy, J. (Trans.). London: Hogarth Press. Institute of Psycho-analysis, 244.

¹⁹ *Ibid.*, 246.

²⁰ Freud, S. 1953–1974. *Introductory Lectures on Psychoanalysis*. In: *The Standard Edition of the Complete Works of Sigmund Freud*, vol. 16. Strachy, J. (Trans.). London: Hogarth Press. Institute of Psycho-analysis, 376–377. On fantasy and the relationship with day-dreams and the pleasure principle see also Freud, S. 1953–1974. *Creative Writers and Day-Dreaming*. In: *The Standard Edition of the complete Works of Sigmund Freud*, vol. 9. Strachy, J. (Trans.). London: Hogarth Press. Institute of Psycho-analysis, 143–153.

The work of melancholia consists in preserving the obstinate adhesion to the object, though via an inversion: the loved and lost object is completely substituted by the ego. The melancholic response to the loss of the object tends to hold on to the object to the point that it produces hallucinatory results. As Freud wrote, the shadow of the object thus falls on the ego, that from this moment forward can be judged like an object, and precisely as the *abandoned object*. The abandoned object takes the place of the ego, deposing it, invading the space of the subject and triumphing over it. The conflict between the ego and the object from the external world is transformed into an intrapsychic disagreement between the critical activity of the ego and the ego altered by the identification with the *abandoned object*. In this manner the absence of the object (the lost object) becomes a hallucinated form of its presence in the ego.

The hallucinated identification of the ego-object is, however, possible because the same initial object choice made by the ego is activated on narcissistic foundations. It takes advantage, from the outset, of the dynamic of the incorporation of the object itself. In the state of melancholia there prevails the oral phase of the evolution of the libido, during which the ego aspires to incorporate the object within itself by devouring it (primary narcissism); it is for this reason that object investment can regress back to the hallucinatory inversion of the object into a subject. This inversion is made possible by the passage of the lost object (external world) into the abandoned object (ego-object).

If Freud had not conceived of a primary narcissistic phase of the ego, which is potentially hallucinatory, he would not have been able to account for the pathology of melancholia. The explanatory model for melancholia remains in the end the lack of a distinction between perception (external reality) and the representation of instinct (intrapsychic reality), a lack of distinction that structures the primary narcissistic phase of hallucination.

3. IMPULSE IN THE WORK OF HUSSERL

Our quest now is to investigate whether the Husserlian notions of bodily (*leiblich*) perception can offer stimulus for overcoming the hallucinatory inversion of the object into subject, carried out by melancholia. This attempt is certainly not owing to a consideration that the twentieth century took little or no heed of the attention focused by phenomenological psychiatry on the pathology of melancholia.²¹ In underlining the contribution to the phenomenology of mapping melancholic-depressive disturbances we do not wish, however, to stop at the aspect of diagnosis. Seeing in phenomenology only the descriptive and diagnostic source of psychiatric pathologies would, in fact, be a sterile repeti-

²¹ See Binswanger, L. 1960. *Melancholie und Manie*. Pfullingen; Neske, Minkowski, E. 1933. *Le temps vécu. Études phénoménologiques et psychopathologiques*, Paris: d'Artrey.

tion of the grand and visionary works of the early and second half of the twentieth century.

Instead, the intention is to capture from particular aspects of Husserl's vision of perception theoretical inspirations that remain suggestions, simple impulses for a possible kinaesthetic model, useful for confronting, transforming or possibly even identifying a cure for the architecture of depression-melancholia, as it was diagnosed by Freud.

To outline a possible path of investigation we must begin, even if only by mention, with the delineation of Husserl's theories of bodily impulse or drive (*Trieb*) and their supposed connection with structures of intention-perception.

Husserl, like Freud, also tied impulse to representation, yet this representation in its initial state is empty, devoid of content and the expression of a still entirely indifferent desire, which Husserl referred to as "of the same sort" (*das Gleichartige*). In doing so he immediately echoed the concept of passive matter as indiscernible similarity, proven by Leibniz in his *Preliminary Discourse* of the *Theodicy* and in § 15 of the *Discourse on Metaphysics*. The presence of representative content, it could be said the process of identifying the object, is tied to the satisfaction of impulse, to its *Erfüllung*. In *Die Grenzprobleme der Phänomenologie* the homogenous impulse is for Husserl the obscure and indeterminate representation that only its *Erfüllung* and *Befriedigung* have the power to determine in objective terms. It is thus a void, that of impulse, that concerns the complex interweaving of intentional references that are active also in the most elementary forms of bodily life.

Each instinctive activity, for example the construction of a nest, is based on an overlap of perceptive and volitional relations capable of providing objective determinacy (*Gehaltsbestimmtheit*) to the representation of impulse. The idea of a void that is representative by nature refers to a complex system of intentional relations. This offers a conception of impulse centred around the coupling of the actuality/non-actuality of the contents and experiences of impulse.²² The void of passive drive representation, its objective indeterminacy, as the indispensable presupposition of its possible future determinacy, recalls the Husserlian reflection on the emptiness of bodily acts of perception, of what Husserl refers to as the "I can." In phenomenological analyses of perception, the void is inverted, becoming a solid full of potential because it refers to an infinite proliferation of systems of perceptive intentions. Under normal circumstances, they tend to the perceptive object continually and with a different level of approximation.²³ The

²² This once again echoes the Leibnizian model of perceptive obscurity. We can look in particular to Leibnizian "nude strength" and the phenomenological concept of non-actuality. For the relationship between the philosophy of Leibniz and that of Husserl, see Bianchini, F., E. Pasini (Eds.). 2013. "L'incidenza di Leibniz negli sviluppi delle fenomenologia husserliana." *Discipline filosofiche*, XXIII, 2, 5–217.

²³ The infinite unfolding of perceptive activity and its ties with an always inadequate evidence must not lead to the sceptical hypothesis of the non-validity of perceptive contents, as if they were

void thus never corresponds with nothing, or with a structural loosening of temporal relations, but instead with a complex and open system of intentional cues (termed by Husserl *intentionale Hinweise*). This dynamic continually passes from non-actuality to actuality through the constantly new and diverse approach to an object.

The void of impulsive representations may thus represent the indeterminacy of the intentional aura not yet actualised by replenishments of objective (noematic) content; replenishments that in turn imply further void horizons of non-actuality.

In the case of impulsive life, these non-actualities are considered by Husserl to be pre-intentional, distinct and at the same time implicated in the intentionality of the psyche embodied by its own corporeality (*Leiblichkeit*).

In other words, all that is perceptive actuality and impulse makes the thing or object appear only for the fact that it is (actuality) *intertwined with and crossed by* a void horizon of intention. This is an aura (*Hof*) that circumscribes each impulsive or perceptive act and is such only as a determinable indeterminacy (*bestimmbare Unbestimmtheit*). In the case of perception the void is thus a dynamic concept that implies the passage from the unconscious (non-actual) to the conscious (actual) according to non-arbitrary rules able to give rise to infinite systems ordered by the manifestation of perceptive phenomena. Also in the case of impulse the void does not coincide with non-being or with nothing and refers to the dynamic of the progressive actualisation of the content of impulse.

The teleological significance of the Husserlian theory of passive instincts and impulses implies not only the idea of an ever newer and ever nearer trend, approximated (*neuer und näher*) to the instinct object until it is satisfied. The teleological significance of impulses regards also their relationship with more complex vital processes.

The vital process is continually moved by drive, instincts, longings and desires, by conscious intentionality and conscious action; intentionality and action that, however, confirm blind inclinations and are nurtured by urges (*Dränge*) and desires (*Begierde*). The vital process is thus a process of free actions that in the end includes the sphere of ethics. All the same, it intertwines, and this is the key word, with blind activities, which are not free and not rational (devoid of reason). The teleological model of impulse is thus an *intertwining* and *refer-*

bills of exchange, payable only upon presentation of similar bills. The contents of meaning depend on the continuous anticipations of intentions. While open to infinity, they do have an ideal limit which Husserl termed *optimo*. These limits, discrete elements in the continuous and infinite flows of perceptive acts, confer validity on the acts of the perceptive-bodily flow. Husserl, E. 2001. *Analyses Concerning Passive and Active Synthesis. Lectures on Transcendental Logic*. Steinbock, A. J. (Trans.). Dordrecht–Boston–London: Kluwer Academic Publishers, 61–62. For an analysis of the role of the *optima* in the normal and anomalous dynamic of perception, see Summa, M. 2014. “Normalità o processi di normalizzazione? Le analisi husserliane sulla dimensione orto-estetica e il carattere dinamico dell’esperienza percettiva.” In: *Percepire. Attualità fenomenologiche*. Failla, M. (Ed.). *Paradigmi* n.s., XXXII, 3, 73–90.

ence, both when we look at its passage from the indeterminate to the determinate and when we interpret impulse life as the basis of teleological progress toward more complex vital forms.

We now have just enough material to compare the Freudian notion of instinct and Husserlian notion of impulse: Freud conceived the object via the possibility to achieve an aim. He describes the object as the most variable element of instinct; the object is attributed to an instinct to the measure in which it lends itself to the satisfaction of instinct. Here we find an idea that may appear pre-phenomenological: the supposition of a correlation between object and satisfaction, a correlation in which the object is subordinated to the satisfaction of instinct (*Trieb-Befriedigung*).²⁴

Nevertheless, the object is in any case conceived by Freud as a determinate psychic representation and not as an indeterminate homogeneity, whose identification is entrusted to psycho-corporeal life and its intertwining systems of intentional references. Precisely on the basis of its being determined in one manner or another, it may prove functional or non-functional to the satisfaction of instinct. For Husserl, instead, it is only thanks to the fulfilling intention, the *Befriedigung* of impulses or instincts, that it is possible to determine their objective content. Only through its satisfaction does instinct achieve an objective determinacy (*Gehaltsbestimmtheit*).²⁵

If the object is a determinable and achievable intentional aim, only through the *Erfüllung* is it possible to see in this further proof of our proposal of interpreting the void of instinctual representation as an open system of instinctual references. This, however, leads to an important consequence for the differentiation of the phenomenology from the Freudian structure of the constitution of the ego.

If the void, as indeterminable determinability, can be interpreted as a “full” dynamic of references and intentional pre-delineations (*Vorzeichnungen*), the satisfaction of impulse in Husserl is not tied to an intrapsychic dynamic, dominated as in Freud by the danger of hallucinatory investments and possible narcissistic closures of the pleasure-ego. In Husserl impulse and perception have a horizon of meaning in which the correlation internal-external, body-world (*Leib-Welt*) is always already given. The real world does not become known to the conscience thanks to a constitutive inhibitory function toward the energetic and hallucinatory overabundance of desire. Remaining within the Freudian semantics, we can say: desire, for Husserl, already always possesses a relation to the thing, in other words, any instinctual-affective relation is always already cognitive (sensory-perceptive), it is already always a thing-presentation (“idea of object”).

²⁴ Freud, S. 1953–1974. *Instincts and Their Vicissitudes*, op. cit., 122–123.

²⁵ Husserl, E. 2013. *Grenzprobleme der Phänomenologie. Analysen des Unbewusstseins und der Instinkte, Metaphysik, späte Ethik. Texte aus dem Nachlass (1908–1937)*. Husserliana, vol. XLII. Dordrecht–Heidelberg–New York–London: Springer, 84.

The intertwining of affective and cognitive investments can also be borrowed from the way Husserl intends inhibition.

In the notes collected in volume XLII of the *Husserliana* (*Grenzprobleme der Phänomenologie*) instinct and impulse inhibition seems to reconnect to the phenomenological perceptive model, what is more, as with the concept of the void. Indeed, inhibition is inscribed in the gradual and multidimensional nature of the givenness of its content. *Erfüllung*, satisfaction, is gradual and multidimensional on par with *Hemmung* (inhibition).²⁶ They are not two opposing poles that reciprocally exclude one another. There is no relationship of domination between them. They overlap and alternate in the flow of psycho-corporeal experience.

Correlation is thus a constitutive element of the instinct relationship between the ego and the world; the process of impulse satisfaction unfolds in the field or aura of the variability of impulses themselves and inhibition is one of the many modalities of this field.

For Freud, inhibition represents the fundamental action for the discharge of affective investments, typical of the narcissistic phase of the ego, and for the relative passage to superior forms of cognition. For Husserl it is, instead, a way of filling an action and does not eliminate or alleviate primary hallucinatory states (pleasure principle), but constitutes a possible course of the same perceptive flow (that which in Freudian semantics corresponds with the secondary process). The inhibition of a perceptive manifestation may, in fact, favour the arrival of others. To better comprehend the notion of inhibition it is worth beginning from the reflection on interest, offered by Husserl in § 20 of the *Experience and Judgment*. Indeed, if we consider interest as an activity of continuous longing for new aspects for the same object, we approach the theme of inhibition as a modal variation (*Modalisierung*) of the perceptive act. Husserl affirms: the trends inherent to our interest toward new ways of givenness of the object may act retroactively and have repercussions (*auswirken*) in an inhibitory or non-inhibitory manner on its contents and its perceptive experiences.

In Husserl perceptive course is not given as the inhibition of primary hallucinatory psychic activities. Inhibition is considered a modal category, comparable to that of variation, derived from mathematics. Hence it is not a condition of the formation of an external world that is perceived and judged (known).

It expresses a way of filling the incomplete perceptive experience and opens the doors toward particular ways of being otherwise—such as negation, perceptive contrast and delusion, doubt, the open possibility and supposition and so on—which help account for the course of the variability of the psychic experience and its contents.²⁷ Even in its passive and instinct actions, the ego is

²⁶ Husserl, E. 2001. *Analyses Concerning Passive and Active Synthesis. Lectures on Transcendental Logic*, 48. “We cannot even imagine a mode of appearance in which the appearing object would be given completely.”

²⁷ *Ibid.*, 63–105.

always in the world of the constituent modality and always correlative; it does not experience entirely intrapsychic and hallucinatory primary events that must be inhibited in order to reach the external world.

Besides, we have seen how the same pre-intentional impulsive activities are always intertwined with intentional ones. Already and always the world-ego, even in the kinaesthetic manner of the body-ego, is the support structure of perception and impulse.

The passive actions of the ego are thus not comparable to the Freudian model of the formation of the conscience, based on the differentiation between the energetic overabundance of the pleasure-ego (with hallucinatory outcomes) and the perception of the reality-ego (inhibitory regulation of intrapsychic hallucination by the secondary cognitive ego).

The world-ego relationship in Husserl expunges hallucinatory risk from the normal dynamics that constitute and regulate the perceptive experience. Folly (as an imaginary-hallucinatory relationship with the external world) is only a particular part of the regulated experience of the empirical conscience of the world. This conscience, the “I can,” experiments with the external world as a contingent certainty, in other words as inadequate certainty. Even given its infinite approximation to apodicticity, this certainty, however, gives rise to an indubitable belief (*Glaube*).²⁸

4. CONCLUSIONS: THE POTENTIALITIES OF PHENOMENOLOGICAL PERCEPTION

Up to this point, we have sought to demonstrate the extraneousness of the Husserlian perceptive model to the idea of a primary hallucinatory-narcissistic dynamic.

Now we can perhaps add that the lack of an opposing vision between the pleasure-ego (or affective-ego) and the cognitive-ego in the phenomenological theory of perception may avoid also the risk—inherent to the pathology of melancholia—of the hallucinatory inversion of an object into a subject. For this we propose to interpret the Husserlian dynamic of perception as the zero degree of melancholia and also its probable therapeutic potential.

With this in mind we now mention a specific pathological aspect of melancholia. In the melancholia-ego we are witness to an impoverishment of temporal psychic dynamics, in particular the disappearance of the dimension of the future. In melancholia, the temporal succession of past-present-future is swallowed up by the past, which coincides with the oral phase of the ego, wholly characterised by narcissism. We can look here above all to Binswanger’s reflec-

²⁸ Husserl, E. 1959. *Erste Philosophie (1923–24). Theorie der phänomenologischen Reduktion*, Husserliana, vol. VIII. Den Haag: Martinus Nijhoff, 58–69.

tions on “temporal objectivity” (*zeitliche Objectivität* or *zeitliches Worüber*) in melancholia and its distortions.

According to Ludwig Binswanger, that which occurs in melancholic pathologies is a loosening of the temporal relations underlying the objective structure of the natural experience of the world. Above all in the dynamics of self-accusation typical of the melancholic person there is an overabundance of hypothetical linguistic expressions (“if I had done this or that,” “if I had not suggested” or “if I had not done,” etc., “I could have avoided this or that”) to induce one to think that the melancholic person relates to temporality only based on empty possibilities, and in so doing loosens the intentional references that make up objective and unitary experience.²⁹

The relationship with the future (the *protentions*) becomes extremely problematic, because each *protentio* can achieve only empty possibilities, crystallised in the past and impossible to realise. There remains nothing to produce if not the temporal objectivity of the void “future” or the void “as the future.”³⁰ It is precisely the void future that imprisons the psychic structure of the melancholic person in a timeless past, if I am allowed this oxymoron. It is possible to comprehend this past devoid of time by thinking of a temporality that sees its own internal and constitutive relational dynamics between past-present and future as disaggregated and loosened.

At this point the question arises as to whether it is possible to transform the visionary diagnostic lucidity of phenomenological psychiatry into a potentially curative model (and thus into a theory of therapeutic practice). The same question can also be formulated in the following manner: based on the prevalence of a hallucinatory state, rooted in the primary process of the formation of the ego, could the pathology of melancholia, as diagnosed by Freud, receive a correction precisely from the internal and external dynamics of the perceptive activity as it was analysed by Husserl?

We have already stated: for its internal structure the perceptive activity refers to an infinity of systems of presentation. These horizons of intention are distinguished—Husserl writes—in external horizons, that is in the constitutive openness to always new pre-delineations of the object perceived, and into internal horizons. These latter cannot be traced back to the external object of perception, but to what has already been perceived, to a perception that now belongs to the past. The “internal horizon” of the “already perceived” allows us to affirm that the activity of perception is structured as an infinite possibility to actualise past perceptions. Even the side of an object effectively viewed asks us to vary the perspective from which it is perceived. In other words: even the already seen (retention) is loaded with anticipatory intentions (protention). Every “already perceived” always contains an anticipation, a tracing (*Vorzeichnung*) of an out-

²⁹ See Binswanger, L. 1960, op. cit., 27.

³⁰ Ibid.

dated future. The relationship between the perceived and its new anticipation then involves the relationship between free bodily movements and non-free tracings of what is out-of-date. Even a diverse bodily motility can, in fact, actualize perceptions that have already occurred in a diverse manner. Free bodily movement, however, gives rise to a series of perceptive manifestations that are not free, or in other words non-casual and ordered. If in the free kinaesthetic system the ego moves in one direction, future manifestations are delineated in a preliminary manner. It is only thanks to the play of independent and dependent variables that what is manifest constitutes a transcendental perceptive object, as an object that is more than what we perceive. The transcendent object may, in other words, continue to persist even if it has disappeared from our perception because it will continue to exist through pre-grasplings and anticipations. The phenomenological reflection exclusively on the bodily movements of the ego leads to the opposing and correlative couplings of “already perceived” and “anticipating intentions,” free bodily movement/dependence on anticipations. Therapeutic work, based on the Husserlian model of perception, may thus exploit the capacity of these opposing couplings. Working exclusively with the bodily gesture of the melancholic ego it may for example be possible to activate the idea of a perceptive past destined to open up toward infinite systems of new anticipatory intentions against a fossilisation in a timeless past such as that of the narcissistic oral phase.

Against the dissolution of time, the reduction of the future to void possibilities or the flattening of the possibilities of the void future—so well diagnosed by Binswanger—we must strengthen the intertwining of temporality that we find in the most original and passive kinaesthetic dynamic of the body. In other words, against the fear of positivist naturalism that in the end dominates the entirety of Binswanger’s psychiatric phenomenology, we must promote a sort of phenomenological naturalism in which corporeality is already pregnant with intentional perceptive-temporal relations, as demonstrated by the Husserlian analyses of sensory association.³¹ This would mean turning our focus to a phenomenological naturalism—please allow me this daring neologism—following which bodily perceptive life is based on associative links (*Typus*)³² only

³¹ Moving toward the intertwining of corporeality and intentionality are the studies of Thomas Vongehr on tactile perception, Vongehr, T. 2014. “Husserls Phänomenologie der Wahrnehmung. Vom Tasten und Hauterleben.” In: *Percepire. Attualità fenomenologiche*. Failla, M. (ed.). *Paradigmi* n.s., XXXII, 3, 19–36 and those of Fuchs on body memory (Fuchs, T. 2000. “Das Gedächtnis des Leibes”. *Phänomenologische Forschungen*, vol. 1, 71–89; and Fuchs, T. 2012. “The Phenomenology of Body Memory.” In: *Body Memory, Metaphor and Movement*. Koch, S., T. Fuchs, M. Summa, C. Müller (Eds.). Amsterdam: John Benjamins, 9–22.

³² Regarding the notion of *Typus*, Dieter Lohmar considers the contribution of a particular genre of fantasy, known as weak fantasy, to perceptive associations. Weak fantasy is not aimed at the production or creation of new objects, but is capable of acting in a latent manner within the perceptive-sensory dynamics of an effective association. See Lohmar, D. 2008. *Phänomenologie der schwachen Phantasie. Untersuchungen der Psychologie, Cognitive Science, Neurologie und*

glimpsed by Freud in his encounter with Mill's logic. He espied the capacity to correct rigid neurological localism without taking to their ultimate consequences the potentialities of associative analyses for a concept of temporal identity, as emerges from the Husserlian lessons on passive synthesis. Indeed, in these the temporal structure of retention and protention (past and future) of the associative activity is always hinged on sensory actuality and constitutes the sole possibility to provide the perceptive ego with an identity.³³

ABOUT THE AUTHOR — PhD, Associate Professor in History of Philosophy at Università degli Studi Roma 3, Via Ostiense, 234-236 – 00146 Roma, Italy (affiliation). Member of the Scientific Committee of *Paradigmi. Rivista critica di filosofia* and of the *International Journal of Philosophy CON-TEXOS KANTIANOS* (Madrid). Author of the books: 2009. *Gadamer als Platon-Interpret: Die Musik*. Peter Lang; 2012. *Poter agire. Letture kantiane*. Ets; 2012. *Dell'esistenza. Glosse allo scritto kantiano del 1762*. Quodlibet; 2017 (forthcoming). *The Edenic Animal. A Kantian Study*. Noesis Press New Studies, Idealism Series. The Davies Group Publishers.

E-mail: mariannina.failla@uniroma3.it

Phänomenologie zur Funktion der Phantasie in der Wahrnehmung. Dordrecht: Springer. Also on this theme, see the phenomenological analysis of instinct in Pugliese, A. 2014. *Il movente dell'esperienza. Costituzione, pulsione ed etica in Edmund Husserl*. Milano: Mimesis, 73–83.

³³ Husserl, E. 2001. *Analyses Concerning Passive and Active Synthesis. Lectures on Transcendental Logic*, 162–196.

Jagna Brudzińska

HUMAN NATURE IN CONFLICT. REFLECTIONS FROM A PHENOMENOLOGICAL AND PSYCHOANALYTICAL PERSPECTIVES

ABSTRACT

This article tends to connect phenomenological research with the psychoanalytical approach by focusing on the issue of conflict as the crucial dimension of human nature and its dynamics. On this basis, it becomes clear that human nature cannot be explained through a strict causal schema; rather, it can be grasped by exploring the dynamic motivational structures of experience which are expressed in the ambivalent tensions and striving tendencies of persons as subjects of the lifeworld. I stress that conflict is not a mere additional and accidental characteristic of experience that can somehow be eliminated, but it rather affects the fundamental structure of personal experience and should therefore be understood as a constitutive moment of human nature. Thereby, my claim is that both self-experience and the development of community can only be understood in the light of motivational conflicts.

Keywords: ambivalence, conflict, individuation, lifeworld, motivation, polarity, phenomenology, psychoanalysis.

1. INTRODUCTION

This paper addresses a peculiar aspect of human experience that has been neglected or even misconstrued in naturalistic terms within the modern interpretations of human nature. It is the aspect of conflict that, in my view, fundamentally characterizes the situation of the human being in the lifeworld and essentially determines the nature of humans as personal unities.

Already Greek thinkers noticed that contradictions, paradoxes and oppositions characterize the concrete experiential reality in all its dimensions. The dialectical way of thinking that focuses on the conflicting traits of reality displays antithetic structures across the whole history of philosophy. At the same

time, the awareness of contradiction in reality also challenges the scientific approach to nature. Following this path, Aristotle already postulates that scientific systems must be free of contradictory claims.¹

Henceforward, conflict is treated in theory as an antithetic structure and in praxis as a collision of interests in individual or collective life. In both senses it represents a disruption of rationality, a prevention of evidence, and finally a problem that must be solved and hopefully eliminated.

However, such a view bears important consequences when it comes to the understanding of living entities, changing processes, and developing structures in the lifeworld. Science is forced to fix these connections; it has to freeze changing movement since a contradiction-free logic must be exclusively allowed. Science appears, therefore, as solely concerned with the discovery of identities. The knowledge process strives toward a unique determination of identical objects. This matter of fact is not substantially altered by Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel's focus on dialectic even if this still represents an impressing attempt to draw on contradictory thinking. Theodor W. Adorno did recognize the limits of Hegel's position by interpreting his logic of contradiction merely as the other side of identity-thinking. In Adorno's view, Hegel's contradiction is also not able to overcome the logic of identity. It rather confirms and acknowledges identity in a negative form as the general, all-encompassing frame of every kind of thinking.²

However, even before Hegel's dialectic, the history of philosophy presents a different and, in my view, more promising cognitive approach to contradiction: the polarity paradigm. The polarity thinking traces back to Heraclitus and goes over into transcendental phenomenology as theory of lifeworld experience.³ Such kind of thinking does not strive toward an even dynamic synthesis of antithesis. It rather recognizes the fundamental ambivalence within the experience as not eliminable and holds ambiguity as constitutive element of experience itself. As such, contradiction must be transformed within the living process rather than eluded or eliminated.

¹ Aristoteles. 2014. *De interpretatione*. Weidemann, H. (Trans.). Berlin: Walter de Gruyter. Among others, Whitaker innovatively discusses the meaning of contradiction in the context of the praxis of dialectic in Aristotle: Whitaker, C. W. A. 1996. *Aristotle's De Interpretatione: Contradiction and Dialectic*. Oxford: Clarendon Press.

² "Contradiction is nonidentity under the aspect of identity; the dialectical primary of the principle of contradiction makes the thought of unity the measure of heterogeneity. As the heterogeneous collides with its limit it exceeds itself. [...] Identity and contradiction of thought are welded together. Total contradiction is nothing but the manifested untruth of total identification. Contradiction is nonidentity under the rule of a law that affects the nonidentical as well." (Adorno, T. W. 1973 (1966). *Negative Dialectics*. Ashton, E. B. (Trans.). London: Routledge, 5–6.

³ With the relationship between Heraclitus and the transcendental phenomenology of the lifeworld in Husserl deals also: Held, K. 1980. *Heraklit, Parmenides und der Anfang von Philosophie und Wissenschaft. Eine phänomenologische Besinnung*. Berlin: De Gruyter, chap. 4.

In modern philosophy, the polarity thinking appears at first in the philosophy of nature (Friedrich von Schelling, Immanuel Kant, Novalis, Johann Wolfgang von Goethe). Later on, Friedrich Schleiermacher introduces it into the theory and psychology of knowledge. Moreover, in psychology the notion of polarity works as an important reference for research approaches that explicitly take distance from the method of natural science based on explanation and try to reach a hermeneutical understanding of subjectivity. In particular, the idea of polarity deeply influences characterology, descriptive and differential psychology, Gestalt psychology and finally also phenomenology and psychoanalysis—all approaches developed at the turn of the 20th century.⁴

In this context, Karl Jaspers' proposal is worth mentioning, since he further develops the notion of polarity introducing the idea of comprehensive or understanding psychology (*verstehende Psychologie*) as a structural comprehension of psychic dynamics. In his *General Psychology* (1913), he shows that the assessment of the conditions of understanding the psychic dimension requires a radical exploration of the opposite movements that constitute and characterize the nature of the psyche.⁵

Following this path, he develops a theoretical concept of genetic understanding differentiating it as a strict psychological understanding both from the process of causal explanation and from the static conception of consciousness—understood as the phenomenological comprehension of single psychological qualities and states. In Jaspers' view, the genetic understanding gathers the “arising one from another” (*Auseinanderhervorgehen*) of psychic elements.⁶ Such a process becomes visible in motivational structures, in contrasting effects, in almost dialectical turns that characterize the soul in its individuality. Here, the polarity notion rules the determining of the primary conflict of human living experience.

In this sense, Jaspers' inquiry implicit gets close to the psychoanalytical therapeutic work and the correlated research. Indeed, psychoanalysis displays a plurality of possible applications of the polarity notion to the understanding of the psychic dynamics. Ambivalence is for Freud and for the whole psychoanalytical tradition after Freud a distinguished trait of human nature, and, above all, the psychic dynamic of the human being. The relationship with Jaspers approach to polarity thinking is evident. Nevertheless, although longing for a coherent epistemological foundation of such a view, psychoanalysis cannot yet rely on the foundational work provided by Karl Jaspers due to his scepticism toward fundamental psychoanalytical presuppositions.

⁴ See Brudzińska, J. 1999. “Biegunowość w psychologii rozumiejącej Jaspersa i psychoanalizie Freuda.” *Świat psychoanalizy*, 1/99 (9), 69–80.

⁵ Jaspers, K. 1923. *Allgemeine Psychopathologie*, 8th edition. Berlin: Springer, 283.

⁶ *Ibid.*, 255.

By focusing his research mainly on the problem of the evidence of experience within his theory of understanding, the latter lets the notion of polarity and the idea of conflict itself ultimately disappear in the background, thus restraining his discussion with psychoanalysis on the question of evidence and the limits of understanding. In this context, Jaspers accuses Freud of disregarding the barriers that are imposed to understanding both by biology and existence, thus trying to extend the process of understanding to both these fields without any legitimacy. In Jaspers' view, this produces a methodological derangement that finally leads to what Jaspers considers a mere "as-if-understanding."⁷ Actually, his critique goes even further claiming the necessity of identifying ideal-typical structures within the psyche that can bear an evidence-based a priori foundation of his hermeneutical psychology. Among others, Graumann underlines that by referring to ideal-typical structures, Jaspers seems to fall back into a static theory of understanding, thus leaving the field of the genetic approach.⁸ For the same reason, also the idea of polarity loses its significance since it seems inconsistent with a static description of inner reality based on the analysis of singular psychic acts. Finally, a productive debate with psychoanalysis was also precluded by the fact that Jaspers' conceptual design remained attached to the modern conception of body-mind dualism.

In conclusion, Jaspers' influential approach to psychic life reinforced the reservations toward psychoanalysis, thus letting promising psychoanalytical insights into epistemological and anthropological issues disappear from the focus of psychological and philosophical research. In this way, a fruitful approach to the understanding of the crucial conflict in human nature and human experience was dismissed. Following this, the possibility to use phenomenological and hermeneutical instruments to corroborate the psychoanalytical understanding of ambivalence as a fundamental trait of human nature and the connected psychic conflicting dynamic was completely missed.

Nevertheless, in my view psychoanalytic results are central for the undertaking of an adequate interpretation of human nature far from naturalistic and idealistic misconstructions. However, in order to be fruitfully applied as a comprehensive theory of conflict, such results require a preliminary suitable phenomenological foundation that can be provided by the intentional-genetic phenomenology as developed by Edmund Husserl. Furthermore, such an effective encounter between psychoanalysis and phenomenology presupposes a new understanding of phenomenology itself. This should no longer only be taken into consideration as a source of essential descriptions of acts of consciousness. It should rather be acknowledged as an encompassing and complex theory of

⁷ Ibid.

⁸ Graumann, M. H. 1976. "Das Verstehen. Versuch einer historisch-kritischen Einleitung in die Phänomenologie des Verstehens." In: *Die Psychologie des 20. Jahrhunderts*, vol. 1: *Die europäische Tradition*. Balmer, W. (Ed.). Zürich: Kindler, 212.

personal experience.⁹ Indeed, the Husserlian elaboration of the phenomenological method already provides excellent tools for the analysis of the developmental processes of human subjectivity since at the core of his genetic phenomenology lie the understanding of the ambivalent structure of subjectivity as well as a strong theory of motivation as a dynamic structural law of personal experience.

In what follows, I unfold the psychoanalytical insights into the conflicting structure of human experience by interpreting them with the tools of the intentional-genetic analysis. On one hand, I aim at gaining an epistemological foundation suitable for the psychoanalytic claims, and on the other, I attempt at making a contribution to phenomenological anthropology. Finally, the great potential of the intentional-genetic method developed within the phenomenology of Husserl should become manifest.

2. CONFLICT FROM A PSYCHOANALYTICAL POINT OF VIEW

Leon Wurmser (2001) claims that psychoanalysis is properly a science of conflict. The point of departure of such a science is the experience of scission (*Spaltung*), the observation of the broken reality of self and world, the experience of “harsh oppositions,” and the polarisation of good and evil, justice and injustice, joy and pain, magnitude and nullity, and trust and horror.¹⁰

However, already for Freud psychic life is a fight and stomping ground of opposite tendencies or, if we do not want to describe it in dynamic terms, it consists of contradiction and opposition pairs.¹¹ The aim of psychoanalysis is to determine in which way these oppositions shape each other into a reciprocal relation, how one influences the other, and which tendencies radiate from the other.¹² Concepts such as opposition, contradiction, polarity and ambivalence are present in each stage and in each moment of the development of Freud’s psychoanalytic theory. They play a descriptive function but are also described as conclusive results and even as ontic postulates of the theory. By means of such concepts, he tries to determine factual and at the same time unavoidable

⁹ Husserl develops this view systematically in the *Idea II*: Husserl, E. 1989. *Ideas Pertaining to a Pure Phenomenology and to a Phenomenological Philosophy. Second Book. Studies in the Phenomenology of Constitution*. Rojcewicz, A., A. Schuwer (Trans.). Dordrecht: Kluwer, 183–293.

¹⁰ Wurmser, L. 2001. *Die zerbrochene Wirklichkeit. Psychoanalyse als das Studium von Konflikt und Komplementarität*, vol. 1: *Die Suche nach dem Absoluten und das Finden des Maßes*. Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 12.

¹¹ See Freud, S. 1963. *Introductory Lectures On Psycho-Analysis*. The Standard Edition of the Complete Psychological Works of Sigmund Freud, vol. XV Strachey, J. (Trans.). London: The Hogarth Press, the Institute of Psycho-Analysis. Lecture IV. (Freud’s texts from the Standard Edition will be cited in terms of: author, year of origin, S.E., volume (numeral), page.)

¹² *Ibid.*

traits of human nature. Already in 1892, he uses the term “opposite will” (*Gegenwillen*) to describe the primary conflict dynamic of the psyche. This notion works as a forerunner of the notorious concept of “defence” (*Abwehr*). Furthermore, with the progressive increment of the analytical material, more and more opposition pairs appear gathered directly from the psychic dynamic. Those are the tendencies and contra-tendencies responsible for Freudian slips—arising compromises in the form of symptoms of illness and production of dreams, conflicting active and passive aims of libido, antagonisms in the field of partial drives as well as daily experiences of ambivalence that every so-called “normal” human being may be familiar with.

Freud’s idea of polarity remains not thematized for a long time, even if implicitly widely used and unfolded in the descriptions of singular psychic dynamics. However, in the essay *Triebe und Triebchicksale* (1915) he appears to strive toward a general conception of this fundamental idea.¹³

In this essay, Freud claims that the awakening of drives is influenced and the drives’ destinations are determined by three fundamental polarities that rule on psychic life. The first is the polarity of activity and passivity that Freud interprets in terms of biological forces. The second is the polarity between the I and the outer world, which is understood as a real polarity. The last one is the economic polarity between pleasure and displeasure. Finally, polarity thinking gains its decisive significance in Freud’s psychoanalysis in the context of his structural model of the psychic personality in connection with the psychodynamic law of the drive-defence dynamics.

This model was presented for the first time in Freud’s work *Das Ich und das Es* (1923) and marked an essential turn in psychoanalytic thought about subjectivity.¹⁴ In contrast to the traditional philosophical subjectivity theories, it unfolds a very complex, multi-layered and dynamic structure of psychic personality. The I represents in this view no autonomous bearer of subjective action, but rather the structure of the person, which is developed as the last one, when the person itself is already involved in manifold dependencies and has to face conflicts on many levels. Therefore, the I is exposed to demands coming from its own corporeality as well as from drives (*Es*) and from the outer world characterized by moral norms and culture (*Überich*) where intersubjective social obligations play a decisive role. According to this view, the I is not understood as a pure residue of consciousness, but rather as an agent that at least partially, but in a fundamental sense, functions unconsciously and faces the life-determining task of conflict-coping. In order to accomplish such a task, the I must be able to integrate contradictory tendencies, demands and desires within the psychic personality and to make them suitable for the social interaction.

¹³ Freud, S. 1925. “Instincts and their Vicissitudes.” In: S.E. XIV, 117–140.

¹⁴ Freud, S. 1923–25. “The Ego and the Id.” In: S.E., XIX, 1–66.

In the context of this analysis, a crucial achievement of Freud's elaboration that has been carried forward by his followers consists in the description of the elementary processes implied by the conflict transformation. He describes both successful as well as failed solutions to conflict situations drawing on so-called "drive defence mechanisms" (*Triebabwehrmechanismen*) that function essentially on an unconscious level thus eluding the the subject's capability to reflect. Despite this elusive character, however, they can be made understandable in the context of the psychoanalytic work since the psychoanalytic understanding does not simply aim at a mere reconstruction of the past. It rather strives toward the unfolding of unconscious conflicts and conflict transformation processes that have taken place at the unconscious level. The psychoanalytical technique to achieve awareness of conflict consists of the method of free association, the analysis of dreams and especially the analysis of transfer and contra-transfer dynamics in current intersubjective situations.¹⁵

The conflict transformation as such connotes here the development of the personality toward different forms of integration of the contradictory poles depending on her own maturity. Concretely, this means training ourselves to abide the fear that comes together with each desire, to keep loving despite frustrating and aggressive impulses, to realize our plans despite unavoidable uncertainty and lack of experience. We do not always succeed in coping with such tasks.¹⁶ In this case, we persevere on the one desired pole of the contradiction while we split off the feared pole, trying to ignore that they belong together. We deny, idealise, rationalise. We hold on unrealistic plans or do not dare to begin anything new. We ascribe our negative impulses exclusively to others (projection) or blame ourselves even when we could not have any possible influence on the events (melancholia).

These processes determine our (subjective) psychogenetic development and at the same time extensively influence the formation of our social reality, our relationship with others, our valuation and assessment capacity.

However, conflict as such is considered here as a dynamic phenomenon not immediately accessible to argumentative analysis. We rather face fields of experience that can be designated from a phenomenological point of view as the pre-predicative sphere of experience. This is the field of passivity that essentially determines the motivational horizon of personal subjects. We will soon see how such passivity can be understood in the genetic phenomenology of the life-world. Nevertheless, before we proceed to this next point, it is important to

¹⁵ An excellent investigation of the psychoanalytical transfer notion presents: Neyraut, M. 1974. *Le transfert. Etude psychanalytique*. Paris: PUF.

¹⁶ Particularly the late psychoanalysis shows that the success or failure in front of such existential tasks do not only depend on us, but rather involve the experience of a "holding surrounding world" (cf. Winnicott, D. W. 1965. *The Maturational Processes and the Facilitating Environment: Studies in the Theory of Emotional Development*. Masud, M., R. Khan (Eds.). London: Tavistock Publications, 42–47.)

mention the significant role played by conflict dynamic in human experience both in the biographical ontogenetic perspective of becoming a self and in the understanding of current subjective and intersubjective experience connections in the sense of an actual-genesis.¹⁷

3. GENETIC DIMENSIONS OF CONFLICT: ONTOGENESIS AND ACTUAL-GENESIS

Stavros Mentzos dedicates much attention to the psychogenetic conflict. In the *Neurotische Konfliktverarbeitung* (1982) he systematizes and differentiates multiple conflict forms and levels all belonging to the psychogenesis of the human individual.¹⁸ In this context, he considers the early forms of individualizing dynamics that characterize the so-called pre-oedipal development of the human subject only rudimentarily treated by Freud. His investigation makes clear that in the human being's development, she does not get involved in conflict situations just as soon as the social integration takes place.

The development of the Self itself can rather take place only in the face of the challenge of conflict.¹⁹ More precisely, the process of coping—understood as conflict transformation—provides the condition for every possible development. The deepest and most elementary level of conflict that characterizes the human ontogenesis begins in Mentzos' view with the dynamics of incorporation and extrapolation. In feeding and care—as physiological and emotional processes—the human child is at the same time active subject and passive object of elementary processes. Along these processes, the baby attempts to reach an outline of the other on which basis she can finally form her own self-image.

Undoubtedly, from the point of view of the external observer such processes already bear a social character presupposing two individuals who are able to communicate with each other. However, the individual separation cannot be identified from the experiencing inner perspective. The I, i.e. the Self, is not by a long shot given as definite and separated unity. It rather arises and forms itself as a proper subjective structure only in the course of the differentiating process, which in turn implies coping with conflict and conflict transformation. Following this first phase, Mentzos shows how the diverse forms of conflict are transformed differently accordingly to the corresponding developmental stage and maturity of the subject. Only in this way conflict may reach its manifested intersubjective form. Conflict transformation does not namely refer only to social

¹⁷ The notion of actual-genesis traces back to Kurt Lewin, who develops this concept within his field theory. See: Fitzek, H. 2014. *Gestaltpsychologie kompakt. Grundlinien einer Psychologie für die Praxis*. Dordrecht: Springer, 9.

¹⁸ Mentzos, S. 1984. *Neurotische Konfliktverarbeitung. Einführung in die psychoanalytische Neurosenlehre unter Berücksichtigung neuer Perspektiven*. Frankfurt: Fischer, 23 ff.

¹⁹ *Ibid.*, 42–56.

conflicts already structured and visible in the interpersonal world, but conflicting tensions also inform both the inner and the intersubjective world and both need to be transformed since conflict cannot be eliminated from human subjectivity.

In his work, Mentzos admirably manages to describe human ontogenesis in a highly differentiated way on the basis of conflict dynamics, thus providing the understanding psychology and, in my view, also the philosophy of subject with a lively framework for genetic analyses. However, conflict also plays a significant role in the actual-genesis of human subjectivity. The focus on actual-genesis implies the consideration of a current experiential situation that is analysed by referring to its specific motivational dynamic. Such an actual-genetic approach is particularly adequate to overcome the limits of the naturalistic reduction since it allows us to drop the linear causal schema that immediately connects causes and effects and directly refer to motivation. This should not be understood as a weak form of causality. It rather indicates a dynamic force field (*Wirkungsfeld*), which is characterized by manifold tension structures and complex of needs.

Moreover, motivations do not indicate universal needs that firmly belong to the subject, for example, in the sense of Maslow's hierarchies of needs.²⁰ They are rather always concrete intentionalities and indicate specific and vivid possibilities of establishing a relationship with oneself and with the world. They are shaped through experience and are always specifically focused on determinate objects or classes of objects. Above all, motivations configure contrastive pairs, urge one to take a decision, and compel one to compromise one's behaviour, therefore shaping our development as subjects in the lifeworld.

Such an understanding of motivation can be traced back to Wilhelm Dilthey's life philosophy and his interpretation of motivational structures. He shows that motivations are composed in complex structures (*Strukturzusammenhänge*) that are at the same time described as developmental structures (*Entwicklungszusammenhänge*). According to his view, each lived experience does not identify a frozen metal state within the psychic context, but should rather be understood as an effectively working unity involved in multiple tension fields that cover the entire psychic life.²¹

Following Dilthey, Jaspers also refers to tendencies immediately generating contra-tendencies, desires permanently accompanied by fears, willing carrying an opposite willing in itself, and so on. Such an approach corresponds to the psychoanalytic understanding of motivational dynamics and promises a fruitful treatment both of daily phenomena and pathological conflict symptoms. As we

²⁰ Maslow, A. 1943. "A Theory of Human Motivation." *Psychological Review*, 50/4, 370–396.

²¹ See Dilthey, W. 1957. "Ideen über eine beschreibende und zergliedernde Psychologie." *Gesammelte Schriften V*. Stuttgart: B. G. Teubner Verlagsgesellschaft/Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 139 ff.

know, psychoanalysis addressed foremost the field of those failing conflict transformations that gained the title of neuroses. As a result, this discipline is prejudicially held to be exclusively committed to pathology thus being unable to provide a general psychology and, more importantly, a universal theory of the subject. In my view, recurring to the phenomenological analysis of subjective experience can invalidate such a prejudice.²²

4. THE PHENOMENOLOGICAL TURN

Phenomenology deals originally with consciousness as a structure of intentional experiences. However, in the course of Husserl's investigations, it develops into an encompassing theory of personal experience and lifeworld as the concrete environment of such experience. In this context the early turn impressed to the concept of experiential subjectivity that transforms it from a theoretical subject of consciousness into a complex and concrete person gains decisive importance. The notion of person emerges in phenomenology at first in Husserl's lectures from 1910–11 as the so-called, "natural person."²³ In contrast to the abstract subject of consciousness, the person is described as a holistic developing structure embracing bodily, psychic and motivational dimensions. In this context, the body is no longer grasped as a mere givenness within nature. We rather gain insight into the double givenness of the material body and the perceiving living body. Furthermore, in his *Ideas II* Husserl conceives such a person in terms of a spiritual person (*geistige Person*) who in the transcendental perspective is grasped as the personal I of habitualities. In a certain sense, his perspective throughout can be considered as egological, even if egology is here interpreted in an entirely new manner.

Husserl namely focuses on the differentiation of two attitudes of experience: the naturalistic and the personal attitude.²⁴ The last no longer refers to the person in terms of a layered model or a psychic-spiritual annex connected to the body. The person rather stands out as a unity characterized by two fundamental traits: the reference to the surrounding world and the social connection. Accordingly, it becomes clear that living body (*Leib*) and material body (*Körper*) belong to different experiential contexts and should therefore not simply be grasped as unities lived and experienced from inside or from outside. The living

²² I present a systematic attempt to ground psychoanalysis as a general psychology from a phenomenological point of view in: Brudzińska, J. 2011. "Depth Phenomenology of the Emotive Dynamics and the Psychoanalytic Experience." In: *Founding Psychoanalysis Phenomenologically. Phenomenological Theories of Subjectivity and the Psychoanalytic Experience*. Lohmar, D., J. Brudzińska (Eds.). Phaenomenologica 199. Dordrecht: Springer, 28–65.

²³ Husserl, E. 2006. *The Basic Problems of Phenomenology. From the Lectures, Winter Semester, 1910–11*. Farin, I., J. G. Hart (Trans.). Dordrecht: Springer, 2.

²⁴ Husserl, E. 1989, op. cit., 183–194.

body represents rather a personal and even passive sense-performing structure (*Sinnleistungszusammenhang*) that makes an elementary first awareness of the body itself as a natural thing possible in first place.

The bodily passivity, however, does not indicate a lower layer of experience. The last should rather always be grasped as a permanent interaction of passivity and activity. Within such a dynamic structure, passivity functions essentially as a pre-reflexive and an unconscious field of experience in the broadest sense. Addressing the instinctual, willing, and affective characters of the passive sphere, Husserl refers to them as the “bustle (*Getriebe*) in the sphere of passivity.”²⁵ It becomes clear that such a living structure that supports all intentional reference to the world cannot be characterized in a linear, unambiguous and unique way. It rather indicates a high conflicting structure characterized by contrasting streaking and interweaving tendencies, strivings and willing impulses. Therefore, passivity appears as an effective and functioning field that crosses the whole intra- and inter-subjective dimension of experience including the unconscious sphere. It emerges as a particular form of activity, also identified with the notion of receptivity.

In order to prove such a claim, we refer to Husserl's analyses on affective tendencies and receptivity as the lowest level of the egological activity as they are presented in the *Experience and Judgment*.²⁶ Here he points out the interests of the I expressed by its “tendentious behaviour” and its striving toward realization as well as all of the I's apperceptive performances even on the lowest level of passivity. In the context of such analysis, it becomes evident that even association cannot be understood as a formal law of consciousness, but must rather be interpreted as a content-laden and as such also motivational lawfulness based on the transfer of affection from one experience to the other and functioning as an awakening process.²⁷ Affective tendencies have an impact in each awakening of experience, either in an associative or in a dissociative way, i.e. either confirming the experience or destroying it. Affections are at work in the transfer as well as in the inhibition of the transfer of the affective content in present perceptions, in the constitution of past and future dimensions of consciousness, and finally in empathy, which is understood in a broader sense as phantasy performance.²⁸

²⁵ Ibid., 234.

²⁶ Husserl, E. 1973. *Experience and Judgment. Investigations in a Genealogy of Logic*. Landgrebe, L. (Ed.). Churchill, J. S., K. Ameriks (Trans.). Evanston: Northwestern University Press, 76 ff.

²⁷ Husserl, E. 2001. *Analyses Concerning Passive and Active Synthesis. Lecture on Transcendental Logic*. Steinbock, A. J. (Trans.). Dordrecht: Kluwer, 198 ff.

²⁸ I have discussed the relationship between affectivity and phantasy in conscious life in: Brudzinska, J. 2012. “Affekt und Phantasie im Aufbau personaler Realitäten.” In: *Affectivity and Its Vicissitudes in Contemporary Humanities and Social Sciences*. Archive of the History of Philosophy and Social Thought, vol. 57, Supplement, 195–215.

Moreover, whenever impressional present does not dominate consciousness, subjective inclinations, and impulsive and affective, need-, desire- and fear-determined anticipations gain high significance for the constitution of experience. This is what happens in dreams, memory, and also in interpersonal interaction and in practical action. Here the transfer-processes of the affective content appear to adapt in different ways to our practical necessities. Coherently with Freud's observations, we subsume these manifold processes under the title of 'logic of desire' since it is above all desire and need that work here as driving forces shaping the sense of experience.

In this context emerges the deep teleology of personal life, and the unfolding of the striving nature of experience finally reveals the practical character of intentionality. This is not restricted to particular classes of intentionality, such as phantasy or willing tendencies, but rather informs all kind of intentional experience and connects directly with the notion of affection. In contrast to the transcendental idealistic critique of knowledge developed by Kant, phenomenology does not identify affection with alleged passive-sensual sensibility of consciousness or with the mere reaction of a content-deprived I free from affections and bodily conditioning. The obscure reign of passive genesis rather appears as the motivated and concrete source of awakening interests of the subject. What follows is that it represents the most elementary level of subjective performance qualified through a striving character and pushed toward expression in the diverse dimensions of representation, corporeality or affectivity. Husserl also detects in this context instinctive and drive-based preferences that lead to an effective comprehension of the striving character of affective experience.²⁹ At such an elementary level of our experiential life, our attention and interests are awakened as we strive toward something or flee something when we follow our preference or feel disgusted by something. In this context, drives do not simply bear willing models, but rather unveil preferences which are grounded in subjective biography and trace back to the experiential history of the subject itself.

On the basis of such descriptions, the meaning of Husserl's claim assessing affection as the lowest level of subjective activity—an activity in passivity—becomes clear thus revealing it as co-determined by the whole stock (*Bestand*) of experience of personal life. In contrast to the classic perspective of transcendental philosophy, passivity does not indicate a sphere without I. This sphere rather determines the I itself in a fundamental way as subject of practical intentionalities. Therefore, passivity is not reduced to mere neutral affections and indifferent external sensual stimuli rushing in from outside. Each motion within this living sphere produces valuation, thus expressing willing, inclinations or repulsions.

²⁹ Husserl, E. 2001, op. cit., 197.

This is the subjective life form that can only be experienced through emotive motivational evidences, tendency and striving, and preferences and tendentious moods and can therefore be effective in form of actual awakened interests. This complex dynamic reveals the practical character of intentionality whose core consists essentially of conflict and is shaped by ambiguity.³⁰ Husserl calls the proper subject of such intentionality the “transcendental person.” He elaborates this notion in the 1930’s in order to address an apparently hybrid figure that he also calls, “concrete transcendental I.”³¹ This is a subject determined both by its corporeality and affectivity, which is temporally and historically structured and finally emerges as an encompassing motivational connection that can only be appropriately comprehended from within. In this context, personal corporeality appears not simply as the material bearer of the spiritual capacity to take position and commit to values, but rather as an organ of expression of evidences that are always already pre-shaped on the pre-reflexive level.

The personal world consists of an intertwined connection in which the I and the Thou function reciprocally in an intermingled way, affecting each other reciprocally.³² The past and future are in this sphere inextricably interwoven. However, the discovery of motivation as a fundamental lawfulness of the infinite stream of consciousness and the personal life indicates that such intersection of tendencies can still be understood despite their interwoven character. The attempt to achieve such kind of comprehension based on motivation and on its conflicting structures characterizes the genetic-phenomenological meaning of experience. Husserl’s statement from 1910 makes it clear that such an approach to experience constitutes a continuing character of phenomenology:

“And it is a discovery of enormous importance that each natural experience, taken as immanent being, motivates a manifold of other natural experiences and a manifold of real possibilities of natural experiences, and that we can explicate these motivational contexts, which are contexts of pure consciousness, and direct our gaze at them. And this gaze has the character of phenomenological experience.”³³

³⁰ In a text from 1934 devoted to the topic of the *Absolute Teleology* Husserl claims: “*Human life progresses in contradiction, in constant conflict of evidences*” (Husserl, E. 2014. *Grenzprobleme der Phänomenologie. Analysen des Unbewusstseins und der Instinkte. Metaphysik. Späte Ethik. Texte aus dem Nachlass (1908–1937)*. Sowa, R., Th. Vonger (Eds.). Hua XLII. Dordrecht: Springer, 249. (Trans. JB).

³¹ See Husserl, E. 2002. *Zur Phänomenologie der Reduktion. Texte aus dem Nachlass (1926–1935)*. Luft, S. (Ed.). Hua XXXIV. Dordrecht: Kluwer, 200. See also: Luft, S. 2002. *Phänomenologie der Phänomenologie. Systematik und Methodologie der Phänomenologie in der Auseinandersetzung zwischen Husserl und Fink*. Dordrecht: Springer, 302.

³² See Husserl, E. 2014, op. cit., 312.

³³ Husserl, E. 2006, op. cit., 75.

In conclusion, the vitality of the passive sphere draws on its conflicting nature that lets it appear as a motivational bustle. We face here synchronic contradictory tendencies, tendencies that immediately produce the opposite, inclinations intertwined with repulsion, just as Dilthey, Freud and Jaspers described it. In other words, we face the logic of ambivalence. As suggested by Husserl's analyses from 1920's, particularly by his investigation on passive synthesis, conflict is not an additional, accidental or merely possible character of experience that can and should be deleted. Conflict rather provides the fundamental structure of experience.

The insight into the motivational connections taken as developing structures of subjectivity characterizes phenomenology as an intentional-genetic theory of personal experience. However, the unfolding of motivational structures requires pursuing the tensional structures that already shape motivation on the pre-predicative and even associative level. Here, the significance of conflict as constitutive character of experience emerges fully. Moreover, it becomes unmistakable that motivation cannot be treated as a weak and imprecise form of causality since it is unveiled as a fundamentally different kind of experiential structure.

In order to clarify such a structure, I would like to consider in my conclusive remarks an example taken from the motivational analysis in psychological research. However, in order to undermine the prejudicial claim that psychoanalysis as a conflict theory can only draw on and treat pathological phenomena, I will consider an example taken from qualitative research in morphological psychology by means of psychoanalytical and phenomenological tools.³⁴ In this way, I intend on showing how a well-informed and methodologically aware motivational analysis should proceed and to what results such analysis focusing on the conflict structure of human experience can lead.

The following example is taken from morphologic research on peace organizations and peace workers.³⁵ The leading question of the investigation was "why do people engage in peace work?" On the basis of free associations, many reasons can be mentioned: the fear of external threat, the desire to achieve something good for the world or, as philosophers prefer to think, the striving toward the realization of higher values. Indeed, at first we face a manifold of impulses and tendencies, which can be revealed through free associations and are either conflicting or at least not immediately reducible to a unique coherent explanation.

However, the morphologic approach allows one to pursue the diverse motivations, and grasp and arrange them into determining tension structures. In this way, we can recognize the polarity between the need of harmony and security as a central tension field in the social world that we bear since childhood on the

³⁴ Morphological psychology is a everyday and cultural psychology developed at the University of Cologne by Wilhelm Salber in the 70-ties; see Salber, W. 2007. *Wirkungseinheiten*. Endres, N., A. Schulte (Eds.). Bonn: Bouvier.

³⁵ The motivational research developed by J. Brudzińska on behalf of Forum Ziviler Friedensdienst e.V. Cologne, 2015.

one side. On the other side, the opposite tendency toward active behaviour, the will of influencing the world, the need of keeping control of events, of facing inner and outer conflicts emerge. In other words, the polarity between passive and active tendencies comes to the foreground. To this point, it should be clear that both poles are understood as effective functioning unities that do not simply contradict each other, but on the contrary are reciprocally motivating and improving.

On the basis of this primary polarity, the peace worker is motivated to seek an adequate framework for her contrasting needs. She has to frame her own action and life project between passive needs for security and active desires to act. In this process, she considers concrete possibilities and struggles with different frameworks that promise more or less feasibility and a positive outcome in terms of reforming the world, but at the same time she faces existential insecurity in form of an often insecure, financially unclear and non-continuous career.

Furthermore, the concrete activity of the peace worker is also designated to raise more tensions. The often spiritually motivated and value-oriented dream of making the world better is confronted with boundaries. The other's pain, suffering and trauma might produce discouraging effects. Ideals hit reality. Also in this case, the peace worker requires ways to cope with the shadows of concrete experiences. More conflicting motivational tendencies emerge throughout this process. The peace worker pursues education, acquires technical competencies, and tries to prepare for new challenges by striving for a difficult balance between technical coverage and personal maturity. In this process, she experiences apparently unjustified since not pure altruistic and selfless motivations as determining. Those are desire of adventure, self-realisation and self-enhancement. Are all these motivational streams contradictory? Are we in need of a hierarchy, or an evaluation of the most important motives in order to take a decision about the reliability and adequateness of our engagement?

A comprehensive and unveiling motivational analysis teaches us the contrary. We learn that the motivational field of a peace worker is grounded on and supported by all the previously mentioned motivational poles and tensions. All of that makes up her vitality. The apparently contradictory constellations surely require solutions and these will be different according to the own biography, character, culture, etc. One will strive toward more risky activity and concrete outcomes, the other will prefer more passive, secure, or perhaps spiritual and appealing ways. Nevertheless, all those who engage in peace work live in and experience the same motivational field. In order to understand their decisions we must gain insight into the specific constellation of motivational poles that are in no way direct causes of their action but still define the framework of their concrete personal and individual development.

The presented example aimed at clarifying motivational dynamics in a field of relatively manifest phenomena. On the contrary, psychoanalytical understanding addresses deeper dimensions and attempts at unveiling also latent and

even unconscious motivations. To this means, specific techniques are required. However, in both cases the comprehensive understanding involves emotional insights and not merely logical evidences. Moreover, psychoanalysis aims not just at unveiling tension structures and motivational conflicts, but also at integrating them into subjectivity. In this sense Thea Bauriedl states the integration of motivational poles within the experience as the proper goal of psychoanalysis instead of the dissociation and elimination of undesired tendencies.³⁶ Along with her, I claim that conflict cannot be eliminated from human subjectivity; rather, it essentially determines human nature and must consequently be taken seriously as constitutive element of human experience. This represents a decisive challenge for every psychology, anthropology, and philosophy that want to avoid naturalistic misinterpretations.

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³⁶ In her work Bauriedl especially explores the social dimension of human conflicts and describes concrete ways of conflict transformation (Bauriedl, T. 1989: *Beziehungsanalyse. Das dialektisch-emenzipatorische Prinzip der Psychoanalyse und seine Konsequenzen für die psychoanalytische Familientherapie*. Suhrkamp: Frankfurt am Main).

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR — Associate Professor for Philosophy at the Institute of Philosophy and Sociology of the Polish Academy of Sciences, ul. Nowy Świat 72, 00-330 Warsaw, Poland (affiliation), and Research Fellow at the Husserl-Archive of the University of Cologne. Main research fields: Husserlian phenomenology, modern theory of subjectivity, psychoanalysis and social theory. She is author of: 2004. *Assoziation, Imaginäres, Trieb. Phänomenologische Untersuchungen zur Genesis der Subjektivität bei Husserl und Freud*. Dissertation, Köln; co-editor of an anthology devoted to the relationship between phenomenology and psychoanalysis (2011. *Founding Psychoanalysis Phenomenologically. Phenomenological Theory of Subjectivity and the Psychoanalytical Experience*. Dordrecht), and author of numerous articles. She is also professional psychologist working in the area of psychoanalysis and qualitative research.

E-mail: jagna.brudzinska@uni-koeln.de

Stanisław Czerniak

BETWEEN HISTORICISM AND ESSENTIALISM. THE CRITICAL AMBITIONS OF GERNOT BÖHME'S PHILOSOPHICAL ANTHROPOLOGY¹

ABSTRACT

Gernot Böhme's philosophical anthropology combines a historicist-descriptive and a normative approach ("historical models of man," the axiological "sovereign man" project). The author describes both types of philosophical narrative in detail, together with the categorial and argumentative inconsistencies which appear on their crossing point. His thesis is that the German philosopher attempts to neutralize these aporias by reference to the category of "relief" (*Entlastung*) and an argumentative strategy close to the position of thinkers like Jürgen Habermas, who made use of the "relief" category in his critical bioethical analyses.

Keywords: philosophical anthropology, historicism, essentialism, human nature, historical models of man, sovereign man, relief, body, consciousness, identity.

1. INTRODUCTION

Most 20th-century philosophical anthropology theories lack theoretical and methodological homogeneity. Essentialist assumptions appear alongside historical conclusions, and the descriptive approach next to the normative-critical. After Wilhelm Dilthey thinkers like Helmuth Plessner or Arnold Gehlen presumably found it difficult to abide by the notion of the unchanging character of human nature. Consequently, Plessner brought together the concept of the ahistorical "conditions of the possibility" of humanity—which he linked to his self-introduced "eccentric position"² idea—with the *homo absconditus* concept and

¹ The article was written thanks to the National Science Centre conferred on the basis of a decision number DEC-2013/11/B/HS1/04162.

² Cf. Czerniak, S. 2002. *Lorenz, Plessner, Habermas, Dylematy antropologiczne filozofii współczesnej* (Lorenz, Plessner, Habermas. The Anthropological Dilemmas of Contemporary Philosophy). Warsaw, 28–30, 77–97.

the belief that, “man cannot be precisely defined [...] All attempts to reduce human nature to any seemingly decisive factors are doomed to failure.”³ Of course one could ask if man’s “eccentric position” belongs to human nature as the “condition of his possibility”? Plessner never posed this question precisely in this way, nor ever attempted to answer it. Presumably, his answer may have been somewhat Kantian: conditions of possibility are an essentialist formal criterion, whereas in the “material” sense—i.e. in the sense of the unique content of his humanity—it is man himself who creates himself in history. Simultaneously however, in his *Die Grenzen der Gemeinschaft* [The Limits of Community],⁴ Plessner, in this “material” sense a historicist, used his “eccentric position” model as a point of departure for a severe critique of the social realities of his day. Thus, he saw the formal criterion as a legitimate measure for evaluating certain “material” features of specific social entities. The concept of the perpetual self-creation of the *humanum* in history proving insufficient, Plessner set out to find an *a priori* correspondence between form and matter—because not every type of social entity allows the full (or at least considerable) empirical expression of the concealed ontic/psychological/social potential of “eccentric positionality.” What we arrive at, therefore, is a unique categorial ambivalence expressed by concepts (or families of concepts) like “man’s historicity”, his ontic “conditions of possibility,” the “description” of humanity’s transformations over history, or the ethical and anthropological “norms” which define the boundaries of social criticism.

Neither are the anthropological reflections of critical theory free from this philosophical ambivalence between historicism/essentialism and descriptionism/critical normativism. An example is Jürgen Habermas, who in one of his more recent works, *The Future of Human Nature*, uses terms like “ethics of the human species” to articulate his critical thoughts about the possible negative effects of genetic engineering, but excludes the abortion issue from this “essentialist umbrella” because he considers it part of the historical value order and believes that its possible legal ban will be unable to substantiate a similar ban on the level of universal ethical reflection.⁵ Thus, this anthropological standpoint also contains the aforementioned ambivalence of the essentialist and historical order, the ideologically-entangled axiological dispute and criticism which refers to universal species norms and aspires to ideological neutrality.

The philosophical anthropology of Gernot Böhme, whose ties to critical theory are evident but not conclusive (owing to its borrowings from, for instance, thinkers like Hermann Schmitz with his “new phenomenology” and the corporeality philosophy which defines it), seems to reproduce this categorial

³ Plessner, H. 1969. “De homine abscondito.” *Social Research*, vol. 36, 509.

⁴ Plessner, H. 1999. *The Limits of Community. A Critique of Social Radicalism*. Wallace, A. (Trans.). New York.

⁵ Cf. Habermas, J. 2003. *The Future of Human Nature*. Beister H., Pensky M. (Trans.). Polity Press, Cambridge.

ambivalence.⁶ Böhme at once is and is not a historicist: he describes man's historical models, but at the same time resorts to normative criteria in his critique of humanity's historical embodiments. If I were to attempt a doctrinal characteristic of these ambivalences, I would say that, contrary to Habermas, Böhme is an anti-essentialist, but seeks the limits of his descriptive historicism in the postulates of a self-proposed anthropology and normative ethic. In other words, his variant of historicism is limited not by the universal norms which Habermas derived from a self-reconstructed ethics of the human species, nor by Plessner's formalistic conditions of humanity, but the postulates of his own normative standpoint—the "ethic/anthropology of sovereign man." While he manages to avoid the historicism-essentialism aporia, Böhme, as we shall see, fails to fully cope with the argumentative inconsistencies which exist between the critical/normative and the descriptive approach.

2. HISTORICAL TRAITS

Gernot Böhme resigns from defining humanity, noting that in today's era of advanced empirical anthropology philosophers lack the competence for authoritative declarations about who man is, and can at best offer fragmentary proposals based on the findings of various sciences. Such proposals do not submit to generalisation on any level of abstraction, neither can they be synthesised into a universal, above-historical and essential definition of humanity. In this context Böhme refers to the characteristic inductive character of his anthropology. This anthropology goes out from the precise theorems of scientific findings, including—or, perhaps, especially—historical research. Contrary to what the inductive method would suggest, however, it does not lead to a synthetic and general concept of man, confining itself precisely to historical analysis and diagnosis, and descriptions of human features and their constellations over history.

Here Böhme introduces the concept of "anthropological condition," a specific historical whole of the mutual interplay between the various dimensions of human existence—like corporeality, consciousness, work, love or fantasy.⁷ These dimensions are ascribed varying importance depending on the anthropological condition, they are bound by specific relations and form unique configurations. However, in Böhme's philosophical anthropology the transition from these general assumptions to historical illustrations is not a methodologically

⁶ Cf. Czerniak, S. 2014. "Filozofia Gernota Böhme'a i teoria krytyczna. Usytuowania doktrynalne i interdyscyplinarne mediacje" [The Philosophy of Gernot Böhme and Critical Theory. Doctrinal Positions and Interdisciplinary Mediations]. In: Czerniak, S., R. Michalski. *Filozofia jako samokrytyka rozumu* [Philosophy as the Self-Criticism of Reason]. Toruń, 29–79.

⁷ Cf. Böhme, G. 1985. *Anthropologie in pragmatischer Hinsicht* [Philosophical Anthropology. A Pragmatic Approach]. Darmstadt, 284–285.

trivial operation. Because, on one hand, Böhme, unlike Oswald Spengler or Arnold Toynbee, is not a philosopher of history or a philosopher of culture propounding a detailed map of the succession of historical eras described according to certain homogeneous criteria. In other words, the list of the constellations of historical anthropological conditions he distinguishes does not aspire to any form of completeness. On the other hand, however, also where he does attempt to reconstruct such constellations (which he alternatively calls “models”), he does not strive to exhaust the subject and does not focus on all their important features. Böhme pays most attention to three models: so-called Homeric man, modern man (whose roots he sees in the late Middle Ages, and for whose most mature and exemplary anthropological testimony he holds the Kantian vision of man⁸), and, finally, humanity’s transformations in today’s era with its pervading technification of human life.⁹ Whereby it should be noted that Böhme does not subject these models to his own empirical or source analyses, but often resorts to existing interpretations. For instance he surveys Homeric man using a category system propounded by Bruno Snell and Hermann Schmitz, his reflections on the beginnings of modern man base on a conceptual matrix used by Norbert Elias in his *Über den Prozess der Zivilisation* [The Civilising Process], and his anthropological analyses of the contemporary era often coincide with the conceptions of postmodernists like Zygmunt Bauman, or philosophy-sensitive sociologists like Anthony Giddens or Manuel Castells. In my opinion, Böhme’s originality in this case lies not in his observations or empirical-historical generalisations, but in something else: his striving to employ this comparative material for his own reflections on anthropology and normative ethics. This, however, we will deal with in more detail further on. Right now I want to briefly discuss the models themselves, although exclusively in the aspect of their two anthropological dimensions—corporeality and consciousness/spirituality (intellectual and emotional).

Homeric man, considered to be exemplified by the *Iliad* protagonists, did not experience his body as a whole, which went in pair with his unawareness of the existence of a psychological centre which governs the body—Böhme notes that the term “*soma*” used in Greece at the time referred to human remains and the term “*psyche*” to the soul leaving a deceased body. The heroes of the *Iliad* experienced divine intervention in their activities corporeally, in the form of external “atmospheric forces” which enveloped their bodies. It is Athena who guides Achilles’ wrath so as to quench it, and the physical island (the body is not experienced as a whole) through which this divine intervention visits Achilles is the area of the *phrene*, the diaphragm. It was not until Socrates’ and Pla-

⁸ Cf. the chapter “Historische Anthropologie” [Historical Anthropology]. In: Böhme, G. 1985, op. cit., 251–266.

⁹ Cf. Böhme, G. 2012. *Invasive Technification: Critical Essays in the Philosophy of Technology*. Shingleton, C. (Trans.). London–New York, Chapter 4: “The Technification of Human Relations,” section: “Anthropological Change in a Technological World.”

to's era, as Böhme claims after Schmitz, that emotions underwent a so-called introjection, and gradually began to be ascribed to the sphere of the soul understood as the guiding instance in human life.¹⁰ In Plato's philosophy divine atmospheric forces acquired the status of spiritual affections, and diverse areas of the body were deprived of their to-date splendour as independent mediators of divine presence. The body thus constituted itself historically in experience as a whole linked to a guiding spiritual centre, although man did retain the ability to experience his physicality in an insular way (Schmitz compares this to a so-called "phantom experience" like feeling an amputated leg, which cannot be eliminated by looking or touching).¹¹

The psyche-body relation acquires its modern form in the *humanum* model. This model, according to Böhme, was best reconstructed by Elias, who introduced the concept of a late-medieval-dated "civilising process" and its carrier—man as a being capable of controlling its aggression and natural reactions and generally compliant with the requirements of (however understood) self-restraint in bodily expression, and which subordinates its own impulses and drives to the demands of "the point of view of feudal suzerainty" in the form of royal and princely courts, whose norm-generating role rose considerably with the pauperisation of early-feudal knighthood (Elias calls this the "courtisation of warriors"). According to Böhme, it was only then that the super-ego Freud analysed appeared on the historical arena, with the Kantian categorical imperative as its later philosophical articulation. As of the 14th century human corporeality in Western culture is increasingly subject to social denial and sublimation as a source of egoistic impulses.¹²

In Böhme's view this structure of relations between corporeal and spiritual factors/moments is disintegrating in our era. Most of the symptoms of the post-modern transformations of the *humanum* which Böhme points to concern these relations either directly or indirectly. In a subsection of his *Invasive Technification* entitled *Civilisation in the Age of Technoscience*, Böhme describes these transformations as, "the obsolescence of ethics, the instrumentalisation of the body, the decoupling of emotional life from reality, the externalisation of constraints and the rigorous separation of human life into functional sectors."¹³

Böhme addresses the first of these issues (the contemporary character of ethics) in quite a few of his writings. For instance in *Weltweisheit, Lebensform, Wissenschaft* (World Wisdom, Life Form, Science) he wrote that, "a part of the

¹⁰ Cf. Böhme, G. 1985, op. cit., 252–254.

¹¹ For more on this cf. Czerniak, S. R. Michalski. 2008. *Cielesność, kompensacja, mimesis. Wokół pojęciowego instrumentarium współczesnej antropologii filozoficznej* [Corporeality, Compensation, Mimesis. The Conceptual Apparatus of Contemporary Philosophical Anthropology]. Warsaw, 18–19.

¹² Cf. Böhme, G., 1985, op. cit., 262–263.

¹³ Böhme, G. 2012. "Civilisation in the Age of Technoscience." In: idem. *Invasive Technification*, op. cit., 28.

modernity project was the postulate for humans to tame and control their own nature, and this battle with human nature was mainly carried out on the moral plane.”¹⁴ Internalised moral norms were used to combat human nature’s impulsiveness and civilise its reactions, and build resistance to its irrationality. At the same time, they were an instrument which helped tame suffering in the face of natural contingencies. In a situation, however, where

“pharmacology, prosthetic technologies, birth control, prenatal diagnostics and embryo selection, and the advancing possibility of genetic manipulation [...] have made problematic what man ought to continue accepting as his own nature [...], man’s status as a moral being has become similarly problematic.”¹⁵

What, Böhme asks, is the meaning of virtues like humility and patience today, when the sphere of what man must accept unconditionally has been so narrowed down? Admittedly, Böhme does not claim that scientific/technological civilisation will completely deprive morality of its regulating functions in favour of regulation by technology, but he does assume that it will be a morality of a different kind.

“Stripped of its social function, morality will become a kind of luxury .One foresees ethics moving closer to aesthetics (moving back, incidentally, towards the aesthetically modulated ethos of the aristocratic societies of the early Greek world.”¹⁶

These issues relate closely to what Böhme calls the “externalisation of constraints.” Where, as we have said, Elias’s “civilising process” led Western culture to internalise constraints and develop the superego/conscience into a kind of “predictability” mainstay, technological civilisation replaces the constraints of conscience by “structural exercise of force [...] the new constraints are constraints imposed by the technical mechanisms of social existence, by technological infrastructure.”¹⁷ Böhme remarks that today many customs and habits (e.g. punctuality) do not need to be formed in a time-consuming process of internalising norms by means of more or less refined educational strategies. Punctuality, abstention from radically unconventional or aggressive behaviour, etc., are forced upon people by their very participation in the collective use of technical devices.

¹⁴ Böhme, G. 1994. *Weltweisheit, Lebensform, Wissenschaft* [World Wisdom, Life Form, Science]. Frankfurt am Main, 97.

¹⁵ Ibid.

¹⁶ Böhme, G. 2012. “Civilisation in the Age of Technoscience,” op. cit, 24–25.

¹⁷ Ibid., 27.

The imperatives of scientific/technological civilisation also cause humans to instrumentalise their relation to their bodies. They begin to view the body almost exclusively as a natural organ (*Körper*), which they willingly entrust to the oversight of specialists (especially in the medical sphere), and the body thus loses its status of “lived body” (*Leib*), which is solely an object of intuitive and individual self-knowledge. For Böhme, another contemporary side-effect of the technological “reification” of the *humanum* is the autonomisation of the human emotional sphere, its emancipation from everyday life with its demand for users of technological networks to display a “objective, cool, decidedly *unemotional* stance towards reality.”¹⁸ Scientific/technological civilisation specialises in satisfying the human sense of security and stills the emotions that drive spontaneous reactions to unexpected threats. As Böhme concludes, “a large part of the individual’s emotional capacity lies fallow [...] within a technological civilization emotional life usually takes place in a detached part of reality populated by fictions.”¹⁹

For Böhme the diffusion of the human identity also lies on the border between philosophical and psychological/sociological discourse. While caste and early-capitalist societies based on strong individual identities initially linked to inherited social status and later to the roles played in the social division of labour—which in turn produced comprehensive biographies of “successful capitalists”—contemporary civilisation with its separation of leisure and worktime and professional life from private (family, social, etc.) roles carries the prospect that the social need to construct a well-integrated personality “might disappear altogether, if work were to [...] become nothing more than the exercise of particular skills or a strategically advisable way of spending a particular period of one’s life.”²⁰ On the other hand, however, these processes are enhanced by the “virtualisation of social relations” in information networks. As Böhme observes, for many “life online” has become a part of reality and this diffuses their identity, whose homogeneity has ceased to be a cultural requirement.

Let me sum up this reconstruction with two conclusions:

1. Böhme’s historicism is strong in the sense that he rejects the conception of human nature (however understood) on the assumption that “human essence” does not exist. However, as in the case of Plessner, this anthropological variabilism is countered by the concept of existentials, or “dimensions of the human condition,” which in Böhme’s opinion form diverse historical constellations. Although it must be said that he does not go as far as Plessner and poses no formal “conditions of the possibility” of humanness, like eccentric position. Böhme’s existentials (corporeality, work, spirituality) are empirical in character and described in what one might call a commonsensical way: man is as we see

¹⁸ Ibid., 26.

¹⁹ Ibid.

²⁰ Ibid., 27.

him, he has a body, works, participates in social rites, produces cultural artefacts, etc. And the only historical difference between the various humanity models lies in the way in which he does it, the way in which he creates himself in these existential dimensions.

2. At the same time—and also for programmatic reasons—Böhme’s historicism is not radically individualistic. As we have seen, contemporary man, like Norbert Elias’s man, exemplifies a unique constellation of *humana*. He has a specific relation to his own body, assigns specific roles to figurative and notional factors, creates his identity, controls his behaviour and communicates with his social environment in specific ways. Böhme, however, claims that such constellations can very rarely be regarded as the effect of individual and unhampered human decision (to which e.g. Jean Paul Sartre ascribed an enormous causative role), and are rather historical/cultural in character, constituting the subject of the mentioned historical anthropology.

3. CRITICAL/NORMATIVIST TRAITS

A) Interestingly for philosophy historians, the critical ambitions of twentieth-century philosophical anthropology were not always anchored in its essentialist elements—and if so, then to a varying degree, as in the case of, for instance, Thomism with its “natural law” category. While Plessner’s or Gehlen’s anthropological conceptions—which doubtless had essentialist ambitions, though articulated with different force—served them as the basis for a critique of contemporary society and culture, the *par excellence* essentialist philosophical anthropology of Max Scheler lacks such doctrinal leanings. Scheler defines man as a being endowed with spirit (*Geist*), and regards this predicate as an above-temporal attribute equal in metaphysical status to the spiritual attribute of substance (*ens a se*).²¹ Here man participates in spirit in a metaphysical dimension and his role as its empirical carrier is considered secondary, with issues like biological evolution and the evolution of human spirituality suspended altogether. In effect, Scheler does not grade human spiritual competencies empirically, and therefore does not see them as goods threatened by historical degeneration or in danger of being lost. And only this threat appears to activate the social criticism of Plessner or Gehlen,²² who register the unfulfilment by historical social entities of those criteria which they consider to be the conditions of the possibility of humanness. Scheler, on the other hand, used the ahistorical criterion of man’s spiritual essence, which deprived him of the possibility to delve deeper into—and hence also to criticize—the *historical* conditions of the fulfilment of the human.

²¹ Cf. Scheler, M. 2009. *The Human Place in the Cosmos*. Frings, M. (Trans.). Evanston: Northwestern University Press.

²² Cf. Gehlen, A. 1980. *Man in the Age of Technology*. Lipscomb, P. (Trans.). New York.

The critical parts of Böhme's philosophical anthropology have no essentialist origin, but do appear to collide conceptually with his programmatic historicism and the descriptive horizon of his analyses within this doctrinal context. In my view, Böhme's analyses are critical in tone for three reasons: the first is the way in which he orders and philosophically generalises his descriptive and historical reflections, a way which enables him to move from their factual level to certain normative conceptual constructs (axiological standards) which determine critical analysis. The second is that in his critique he doubtlessly follows the critical theory tradition defined by Max Horkheimer, Theodor Adorno and Habermas. Böhme's criticism is in many ways similar to the early Horkheimer's axiological materialism, or the *mimesis* concept propounded in the *Aesthetic Theory* authored by Adorno.²³ He differs from Habermas in his reluctance to use Kantian borrowings and concepts like the earlier-mentioned "ethical self-knowledge of the human species," he also rejects Habermas's juxtaposition of system/lifeworld (*Lebenswelt*),²⁴ and mistrusts the diagnoses and solutions Habermas formulates on the grounds of his deliberative democracy idea. However, like Habermas, Böhme is strongly critical of capitalism, propounding his critique of the system over the past decade in his "aesthetic capitalism conception."²⁵ The third reference point in Böhme's critical philosophical anthropology is its inclusion in his philosophy of technology conception under the rather derogatory term "technification."²⁶ Here, anthropological self-knowledge in a sense forms the critical conscience of all opponents of excessive technological interference in the anthropological order.

B) Böhme builds his anthropological normative model upon conceptual material which contains the earlier-mentioned "anthropological condition" category, which in turn forms a conceptual whole with the categories "difference," "resistance" and "sovereign man." Böhme claims that anthropological conditions enhance the formation of a difference—a gap between the empiricism of human self-experience in everyday life and the humanity ideal regarded as the culturally legitimate model or aim.²⁷ For example, modern Enlightenment man began to style²⁸ himself into a subject of cognition and will answering to the rational requirements of cognition and activity. At the same time he banned into subconsciousness (or at least distanced himself from) the corporeal, impulsive, subjective and emotional—i.e. the irrational—as divergent from the rationalistic anthropological ideal. Thus, anthropological conditions are a kind of "union of

²³ Cf. Czerniak, S. 2014. *The Philosophy of Gernot Böhme* ..., op. cit., 29–59.

²⁴ Cf. Böhme, G. 2012. "Civilisation in the Age of Technoscience," op. cit. 34.

²⁵ Cf. Böhme, G. 2013. "Ästhetischer Kapitalismus" [Aesthetic Capitalism]. In: *Sozialpsychologie des Kapitalismus heute* [The Social Psychology of Capitalism Today]. Bruder, K-J. et al. Gießen (Eds.), 43–59.

²⁶ Cf. Böhme, G. 2013. "Invasive Technification," op. cit., 1–9.

²⁷ Cf. Böhme, G. 1985, op. cit., 283.

²⁸ *Ibid.*, 285.

oppositions”—empiricism demoted to that which is “not fully human” and the ideal regarded as “humanity proper.” Typical for this situation, which Böhme calls difference, is the disparity between obligation and reality in the human sphere. Its inherent part is a stance which in this context is called resistance.²⁹ In his striving towards the ideal, man resists that in himself which does not (or does not yet) conform to it. What fails to conform to the ideal is banned into a sphere which could be called an “axiological underground” housing that which is unacceptable, devoid of higher value, regarded as evil or a deviation from the ideal anthropological order.

Against this conceptual background Böhme develops his own philosophical and normative humanity project, which no longer bases on opposition against any kind of degraded self-experience. The ideal here is “sovereign man,”³⁰ who is aware of the above-discussed processes and relations and sees the connection between anthropological self-knowledge and the negation/suppression of otherness—or that which does not conform to the preferred ideal. His kind of sovereignty requires: a) awareness of the limitations in pursuing anthropological ideals (i.e. the accompanying existential, personal or social costs); b) acceptance of suppressed otherness on the self-experience and personal identity level; c) knowledge that the endowment of ideals with the status of absolute “axiological monopolies” which oust all rivalling attitudes, reflections or manifestations from the sphere of human conduct does not serve their achievement well. Therefore, sovereign man understands that he is a union of oppositions and identifies with their various aspects. For instance, as a rationality-seeking being he does not obsessively seclude himself from the irrational, but instead knows how to succumb to moods and the impulses of his own body. One of his more important skills—and one Böhme lays special emphasis on—is his ability to change his anthropological conditions. Sovereign man is capable of changing the entire configuration of his *humana*, and this is precisely what distinguishes him from the Kantian autonomous subject, who irrevocably banishes all sensuality and impulsiveness. Sovereign man does not wish to rule over everything—hence neither over that which has proven different, or has been suppressed or parenthesised in himself along his path towards the ideal. Sovereign man is able to feel empathy towards what he is offered by the other side, and knows how to handle tabooised and culturally “forbidden” content.

In Böhme’s view sovereign man’s self-knowledge also entails the awareness of the fragmentary nature of all anthropological conditions.³¹ Anthropological conditions can always be placed within wholes, against which their one-sidedness becomes visible. Böhme, therefore, writes that man “should commune with himself as with a part of a bigger union.”³² This union can, for

²⁹ Ibid., 291–306.

³⁰ Ibid., 287–289.

³¹ Ibid., 284–289.

³² Ibid., 285.

instance, be life, where every anthropological condition is one of the many possible articulations of life which typify human and non-human animal existence. Here, however, Böhme means first and foremost the historical wholes which belong to the “long historical duration” sphere. It is through them that modern sovereign man can discover, that the humanness of the *Iliad* protagonists is simply another anthropological condition, which he will be able to comprehend only if he accepts that this otherness also exists in himself as a hidden, forgotten force, which he can try to at least partly revive and recreate as a part of his own experience. Only through the experience that mineness and otherness are a feasible alternative, that otherness is not only an ethnological, historical or hermeneutic riddle for the mind, but always also a challenge for experience as a newly-accessible (or long-forgotten) path of learning, can otherness be perceived in the context of mineness, which in turn allows human individuals to access self-knowledge more suited to their existential possibilities.³³

Thus, according to Böhme, the hermeneutic potential of sovereign man does not lie in his discovery of an *a priori* human essence, which he would then see as the fundament of all historically and culturally given human experience (here, the intentions and behaviour of contemporaries of other historical epochs would be perceived on grounds of the belief that humans always were and are the same in their deepest anthropological core), but in his presumption that his humanness is fragmentary and singular and contains suppressed sides and aspects—hibernating *existentialia*—which can be awoken to life by synthesising, holistic anthropological self-knowledge. People are not identical, but they are capable of realising who they are if they accept the anthropological position of otherness (also, but not only, in their imaginations). Consequently, with regard to Homeric man Böhme uses his aesthetic theory to build a concept of “objective moods” (atmospheres),³⁴ which influence man externally like the Olympian gods influenced the experiences of Paris, and which sovereign man, an individual who has himself experienced the “passages” and “bridges” between the various articulations of the *humanum*, should know how to give himself over to.

C) Böhme returns to these conceptual threads in his critical philosophy of technology, where he uses the sovereign man category to censure the various effects of technifications (especially in medicine). A detailed account of his reflections on the diverse existential problems suffered by contemporary medicine would exceed the scope of this essay, I will therefore only mention his often-used term “sovereign patient.”³⁵ Böhme especially emphasises one attribute of sovereign man as possibly crucial for the formation of his relation to him-

³³ Cf. Ibid.

³⁴ Cf. Böhme, G. 1995. *Atmosphäre. Essays zur neuen Ästhetik* [Atmosphere: Essays on the New Aesthetics]. Frankfurt am Main.

³⁵ Cf. Böhme, G. 2009. “Der mündige Patient” [The Sovereign Patient]. In: idem. *Der mündige Mensch* [The Sovereign Man]. Darmstadt, 143–157.

self in illness—the idea of an anthropologically capacious identity which to a large degree accepts corporeality. Sovereign man does not treat his body like an object entrusted to specialists (doctors), but considers it to be a vital part of his identity. And cringes away from medical techniques which in any essential way upset or disrupt it. Sovereign man must use his own judgment and make his own decisions even when carriers of expert knowledge attempt to coerce him into certain behaviour modes. For instance, he must know “how children have to be born” (whether only in clinical conditions), and whether he is ready to accept all the treatment options routinely offered by medicine (which also treats death as a disease), or would rather retain the capacity to refuse at least some of what medical technology offers to gradually eliminate contingency from human life (e.g. prenatal medicine, genetic engineering, or transplantology). Is, for example, cardiac transplantation ethically acceptable or contestable? This is something the subject—the sovereign subject—must resolve by itself basing on the sense of its own identity, and no universalistic argumentation like Kant’s categorical imperative ethics or Karl-Otto Apel’s discourse ethics can do the job for him. The ethics of sovereign bodily existence is a situational ethics. Someone, for whom the possession of his/her “own” heart, its mineness, is an inherent part of personal identity will either exclude transplantation, or will undergo it but carry away a sense of moral guilt. On the other hand, someone who treats his/her body instrumentally may have a different perspective and conclude that transplantation is ethically good if it brings him/her more good than harm in the utilitarian sense. Be it as it may, anthropological sovereignty in Böhme’s version certainly does assume the individual’s full responsibility for all it undergoes medically in this sphere.

4. ASSUMPTIONAL INCONSISTENCY

What has been said up to this point suggests we are dealing with a comprehensive doctrinal structure with corresponding descriptive and normative elements. However, it contains certain philosophical inconsistencies which seem to lead Böhme both beyond the normative model of sovereign man, and back—by a rather roundabout route—to the historicist assumptions and descriptive ambitions of his anthropology. The problem here is that the idea of sovereign man is an ethical ideal, one Böhme himself often treats as part of the ethics he calls “ethics of bodily presence.” But as we already know, postmodern man has a progressively diminishing need for ethics, which in the future is to melt into an aristocratic-like aesthetic stance. Thus, all resistance to the deviations of technification in this anthropological discourse appears to have rather frail foundations. Because how can one build one’s own sovereignty upon a singular ethical fundament when ethical awareness is disappearing from human civilisation? Of course here we could try to resort to a formula which, although rather

risky, is acceptable in the light of Böhme's philosophical anthropology: namely that in the postmodern man model ethics is an element which is being banished into collective unconsciousness, and therefore naturally deserves to be rehabilitated by the dialectical awareness of sovereign man. Such a revival of the ethical sphere as such by a chosen system of normative ethics would, however, encounter some difficulty. Because the question remains *how* this normative ethical proposal would find its full articulation and gain social influence in a culture that—as is assumed here—is increasingly indifferent to all ethics.

It is also unclear how the ethical concept of sovereign man is to be reconciled with such earlier-mentioned contemporary anthropological developments like the fictionalization of emotions and the traces of disintegration visible in the human identity sphere. Indeed, one may assume that sovereign man's emotional profile should display a close bond between his emotions and the realities of his life. Only someone who situates his/her emotions within the realistic framework of his/her corporeality, and not in the virtual world of cultural narratives about the body, will be capable of experiencing the various models of the "I-body" relation which have developed over history. Sovereign man must, in a sense, discover Homeric man within himself—this experience will not be provided by contemporary culture, which is focused on playing with the emotions of individuals in their virtual relation to the fictional sphere. Similarly, the symptoms of the contemporary disintegration of identity signalled by Böhme must be seen as standing in collision with the sovereign man model, as the very definition of sovereign man shows that anthropological sovereignty in Böhme's understanding should base on a firm sense of identity. Sovereignty can only be attained by subjects who begin their quest for it untorn between rivalling identity models, because how would they know which of their many "I's" would be best-suited for this moral task? At least this must be clear if the path to sovereignty is to base on a coherent identity project. The diffusion of the identity in competing social roles and virtual communication networks is unreconcilable with sovereignty.

Böhme, therefore, resorts to critical consciousness paradigms other than the ethics of sovereign man or the ethics of bodily presence. For example, he writes about the need to revive Horkheimer's critical theory project, which Horkheimer outlined in his 1937 essay *Traditionelle und kritische Theorie* [Traditional and Critical Theory]. In the article "Vom Interesse an vernünftigen Zuständen durchherrscht" [Pervaded by an Interest in Rational Conditions] he recalls the main assumptions of this neo-Marxian work, which refers to the views of the later Karl Marx propounded in the *Capital: Critique of Political Economy*. According to Böhme, Horkheimer followed Marx in his efforts to define the status of a critical theory pervaded by "the idea of rational human relations" which—from the perspective of this realisable social ideal—would not only be highly critical of capitalism as a social system but also sow the intellectual seeds of its transformation. Today, Böhme concludes, we need a criti-

cal philosophy of technification based on these ideas. However, it would have to go further than Horkheimer, who underestimated the anthropologically destructive potential of the productive forces themselves. Contrary to what Horkheimer claimed in Marx's footsteps, productive forces are not anthropologically innocent and do not *per se* serve progress and human welfare. In fact, their technological status alone frequently carries the risk of anthropological deviation. What would be needed, therefore, would be a revival of Horkheimer's model in something like a postmodern critical philosophy of technology, some of whose categories ("ecological technology," "technology of alliance with nature") Böhme introduces in his text in reference to the contemporary debate about various kinds of rationality (e.g. postmodern "weak mind" conceptions). Here Böhme postulates to take these reflections beyond the limitations of the utilitarian approach, as in his view a critical philosophy of technology cannot be limited to a utilitarian balancing of the positive and negative side-effects of technological progress.³⁶

Here too, however, there is some argumentational inconsistency. Böhme seems to believe that a critical philosophy of rationality could aid sovereign man in his efforts to curb the anthropological deficiencies of technification. But why should this philosophical proposition be trustworthy for contemporary man, who, as the same Böhme claims,³⁷ is relieved from daily intellectual strife by technology and rather given to esoteric, mystic and contemplative pursuits? In other words—what is the persuasive power of rationality theories in today's world, in which rationalism is losing ground (and, as Böhme teaches in his sovereign man theory, *should* lose ground) to various forms of the atmospheric, to non-cognitive, mimetic imitation, to what cannot be expressed by concepts, or is even outright irrational?

5. BACK TO HISTORY IN "RELIEF" MODE

In this somewhat inconsistent discourse Böhme appears to revert his critique of contemporary technification to historicist formulas and the descriptive method. Böhme himself does not openly state this, but in my opinion his personal argumentation is built upon the philosophical concept of relief. This is a rather bold interpretative hypothesis, which I think merits a brief historical-philosophical commentary.

³⁶ Cf. Czerniak, S. 2014. "Filozofia techniki Gernota Böhme" [Gernot Böhme's Philosophy of Technology]. *Filozofia i Nauka* [Philosophy and Science], vol. 2, 2014, 145–150.

³⁷ Böhme writes about the tendency to "integrate of all manner of esoterica into exoteric everyday life" (Böhme, G. 2012. *Invasive Technification*, op. cit., 124.). Technological progress enables us to cede to computers much of what earlier belonged to our daily intellectual activity, which leaves us with "free" intellectual energy which we apply to other- than rational spiritual activity. Machines are rational; contemporary man, on the other hand, can use the extra time they offer him to cultivate the irrational, e.g. variously understood meditations skills.

Johann Gottfried Herder was the first who used the concept of relief (*Entlastung*)—or at least the argumentation behind the category—in philosophical anthropology, but it was Gehlen who introduced it to contemporary anthropological discourse as a theoretically crucial category. The pillars of Gehlen's anthropology, like the philosophy of language and philosophy of institutions, take their innovatory character from its vast conceptual and explanative resource.³⁸ However, I want to place Böhme's philosophical proposals in a different historical and philosophical context, whose probably best exponents are the writings of Wolfgang van den Daele and the related philosophical anthropology of Habermas. Both resort to the relief concept in their comments on today's rising reference to nature as a source of legitimacy, e.g. by binding a person's status to the biological fact of his/her birth. Van den Daele writes:

“When we tie the status of the person to the natural event of birth, we avoid situations in which we would have to decide whether living human being is a person or not. We save ourselves the task of thematising and determining what properties this human being would have to possess to be a carrier for rights, especially the right to life—it simply must live.”³⁹

Habermas resolves such dilemmas in a similar way, stating that

“being endowed with reason means that birth, the moment of our entry into social world, at the same time marks the moment from which the capacity of being a person can be realized, no matter in which form. Even a comatose patient participates in this form of life.”⁴⁰

So both van den Daele and Habermas see reference to nature as the fact of birth as a legitimising and relieving mechanism in the face of the complex ethical controversies surrounding medical practices common in today's world.

I presume Böhme employs a similar relief topos, but in connection with history, not human nature. His above- reconstructed line of thought is that the postulated moral code of sovereign man and the critical rationality of technology theory which is the goal of philosophical pursuit are the founding blocks of a resistance strategy against the aberrations of modern civilisation, and possibly a starting-point for positive change and the extirpation of its pathologies. At

³⁸ Cf. Czerniak, S. 2015. “Antropologia filozoficzna Arnolda Gehlena jako model krytyki społeczeństwa” [Arnold Gehlen's Philosophical Anthropology as a Social Critique Model]. *Filozofia i Nauka* [Philosophy and Science], vol. 3, 57–77.

³⁹ V. D. Daele, W. 1987. “Die Moralisierung der menschlichen Natur und empirische Bezüge in gesellschaftlichen Institutionen.” [The Moralisation of Human Nature and References to Nature in Social Institutions]. *Kritische Vierteljahresschrift für Gesetzgebung und Rechtswissenschaft* [Critical Quarterly Journal for Legislation and Law], vol. 2 (70).

⁴⁰ Habermas, J. 2003, op. cit., 121.

least in the second case one may think back to Marx and his idea of bringing of theory into praxis. However, praxis here also includes moral change which promotes life attitudes based on the ethical code of sovereign man. Though as we said earlier, both these critical conceptions come in conflict with the anthropological facts Böhme states as the keen observer of contemporary reality he is. In a sense, we have here a conflict between two orders—the factual anthropological order of history and a postulated anthropological order of resistance to history. In other words, both the fulfilment of the sovereign man idea and the practical implementation of the conclusions arising from critical rationality of technology theory can be viewed through the prism of the considerable burdening of their potential carriers or followers. Even if these anthropological projects could be carried through, they would incur enormous costs for individual experience. We would have a kind of utopia with existential costs that are hard to estimate, as postmodern man's anthropological substance would to a degree influence the way in which he realized his sovereignty.

Böhme's writings carry no evidence of any conscious (or even partly conscious) departure from the normative superstructure of his philosophical anthropology, but there are strong indications that his analyses do contain threads one could view as attempted relief. In the earlier-quoted text *Science, Technology, Civilisation*, among others in the polemic with Habermas's concept of the life-world colonized by the demands of political and market systems, Böhme takes note of the contemporary decline of socialising media like private ownership and labour in favour of socialisation through social networks. Böhme writes:

“As individuals, we increasingly *come into social existence socially* through one or another set of keys which provide access to various social networks. Plainly, that does not mean that someone who does not have the right sort of connections or credit cards ceases to exist entirely. No one evaporates into thin air; however, many cease to exist in a meaningful social sense.”⁴¹

However, this desocialisation—the key element of Böhme's reflections in this context—is also an anthropological opening, as elsewhere he states:

“Maybe the contemporary rediscovery of the body is the flipside of the fact that large amounts of social action are set in train by codes and so no longer require human beings' physical presence. Last but not least, maybe the extraordinary intensification of communication between human beings in the contemporary world is a reflection of the fact that communication is becoming more and more irrelevant in practical social terms.”⁴²

⁴¹ Böhme, 2012. *Invasive Technification* ..., op. cit., 35.

⁴² Ibid., 36.

Böhme sums up this part of his inquiry as follows:

“The development of the bourgeois public sphere, which put an end to the arbitrary individual exercise of political authority by submitting everything and everyone to public forms of legitimation and the rule of law, simultaneously created the concept of bourgeois privacy: the intimate domain of family life. Similarly, a technological civilization is driving a process of sweeping social emancipation in the double sense of making existing social structures redundant and opening new fields of movement, imagination and free activity.”⁴³

In this connection Böhme also speaks about the “Janus-faced phenomenon of technological civilization”⁴⁴ and philosophically concludes that “technology on the whole is neither inherently progressive nor regressive—technification in a certain sense simply creates change.”⁴⁵

In the context of our earlier deliberations we could, therefore, ask what use sovereign man would have for a bodily awareness ethic supposed to restore his lost intimacy with his own body, if the same historical progression logic, this time as his “Janus face,” is to rehabilitate the human *Leib*? And does the conclusion that technological development causes neither progress nor regression but change not delegitimize all “critical rationalization of technology”? Indeed, why would we criticise something that is not regression but only change in the language of rationality theory?

Here Böhme appears to resort to the intellectual operation of relief in a dual sense, as on one hand he tries to leave the sphere of the earlier-mentioned aporia on the boundary between the normative ethical model of sovereign man and the descriptive anthropological model of postmodern humanity, and on the other he attempts to relieve the moral subject of all possible burdens that might accompany its adoption of an excessively utopian view of morality’s historical transformations. The causative functions of normative moral standards are suspended where historical progress itself compensates for the damage it does by creating a new level of equilibrium between good and evil in the social and individual sphere. In this case Böhme silently refers to Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel, but also to views supported by the compensation philosophers Joachim Ritter and Odo Marquard.⁴⁶ In the historical sense, compensation processes relieve history’s actors from the need to repair it from below by ethics or a philosophy of rationality. History repairs itself in a sense from above—by the very logic of its compensatory anthropological offer.

⁴³ Ibid., 38.

⁴⁴ Ibid.

⁴⁵ Ibid., 39.

⁴⁶ Cf. Marquard, O. 1991. *In Defence of the Accidental*. New York.

Finally, let us devote some attention to the similarities between the *Entlastung* strategies propounded by van den Daele, Habermas and Böhme. Although the main difference between them doubtless lies in one's reference to nature and the other's to history, they nonetheless share a specific kind of categorical reductionism. One need only compare the rich material content of Thomistic natural law with van den Daele's "pure fact of birth." Here "nature" means solely the biological roots of human existence, the biological form that is human life, and not e.g. the *logos* of moral laws or an objective, rational order governing human behaviour and social institutions. Böhme, on the other hand, refers to history as an abstract system of compensation. Actually, his line of thought moves from the historicist sphere of humanity models towards the Hegelian view of history as the reconciliation of opposites. This is no longer historicism with its diversity of views about the historical evolution of humanness but a dialectical historical formula with only one face—that of Janus.

Thus, the present reflections can be closed with two mutually corresponding conclusions: a) Böhme's philosophical anthropology is neither historicist nor normativistic, or it is both, but—to a limited extent defined by the mediating *Entlastung* formula; b) this status doubtless results from certain universal conditions accompanying the contemporary philosophical anthropology debate, which in turn belongs to a broader spiritual sphere whose "overload" Gehen described in his *Die Seele im technischen Zeitalter*.⁴⁷

ABOUT THE AUTHOR — PhD, full professor, Institute of Philosophy and Sociology of the Polish Academy of Sciences, ul. Nowy Świat 72, 00–330 Warszawa, Poland; head of Philosophical Anthropology and Social Philosophy Department. Main research fields: philosophical anthropology, contemporary German philosophy, especially critical theory. Main works: 1981. *Socjologia wiedzy Maxa Schelera* [Max Scheler's Sociology of Knowledge], Warszawa; 1990. *Pomiędzy socjologią wiedzy a teologią negatywną. Filozofia Maxa Horkheimera* [Between Sociology of Knowledge and Negative Theology. The Philosophy of Max Horkheimer], Wrocław; 2002. *Lorenz, Plessner, Habermas. Dylematy antropologiczne filozofii współczesnej* [Lorenz, Plessner, Habermas. Anthropological Dilemmas of Contemporary Philosophy], Toruń; 2006. *Kontyngencja, tożsamość, człowiek. Studia z antropologii filozoficznej XX wieku* [Contingency, Identity, Man. Studies on the 20th Century Philosophical Anthropology], Warszawa; 2008. *Cielesność, kompensacja, mimesis. Wokół pojęciowego instrumentarium współczesnej antropologii filozoficznej* [Corporeality, Compensation, Mimesis. On Conceptual Instruments of Contemporary Philosophical Anthropology]. With Rafał Michalski. Warszawa; 2014. *Filozofia jako samokrytyka rozumu. Meandry doktrynalnej ewolucji teorii krytycznej*. With Rafał Michalski. Warszawa (English translation: 2015. *Philosophy as Critique of the Mind. The Doctrinal Evolution of Critical Theory*. Peter Lang).

E-mail: stanislaw.l.czerniak@wp.pl

⁴⁷ Cf. footnote 21 refers to the English translation of that book.

Rafał Michalski

THE ORIGINS OF LINGUISTIC ANTHROPOLOGY —THE POSITIONS OF JOHANN GOTTFRIED HERDER AND ARNOLD GEHLEN

ABSTRACT

This article attempts to present Gehlen's concept of language in the context of his project of philosophical anthropology. The emphasis will be put on showing the role of language in: 1) the formation of motor and sensory imagination, 2) the crystallization of human drives and, finally, 3) the development of cognitive competences. Gehlen refers in his project directly to the thoughts of Herder, and therefore—according to the chronological order—a reconstruction of the origins of “the linguistic anthropology” will start from outlining the main objectives of Herder's philosophy of language (the first chapter), and then will consider Gehlen's considerations devoted to the genesis of language competence and to the impact of speech for the constitution of human self-knowledge (second chapter).

Keywords: anthropology, language, deficient being, relief, ontogenesis, sensorimotor process, functional cycle, excess of drives, flood of stimulation.

1. INTRODUCTION

Philosophical anthropology inaugurated by Max Scheler (1874–1928) and Helmuth Plessner (1892–1985) in the 1920s tried to establish the role and position of man in the world, and above all to understand its uniqueness in the biouniverse. Both they pointed to the different constitutional principles as a *differentia specifica* of our species: for Scheler it was the category of the spirit, for Plessner—the category of the eccentric positionality. However, neither of them saw the crucial role of language in the process of human development. A kind of linguistic turn within this tradition was made only thanks to Arnold Gehlen (1904–1976) who pointed out in his seminal work *Man, His Nature and Place in the World* that language is the main instance (directly related to action) which relieves human beings from the biological deficits.

This article attempts to present Gehlen's concept of language in the context of "elementary anthropology," a notion developed by him. The emphasis will be put on showing the role of language in: 1) the formation of motor and sensory imagination, 2) the orientation of human drives and, finally, 3) the development of cognitive competences. Gehlen refers in his project directly to the ideas of Johann Gottfried Herder (1744–1803), and therefore the reconstruction of the origins of linguistic anthropology will start from outlining the main assumptions and theses of Herder's philosophy of language, and then will take into account Gehlen's considerations of the origins of language competence, as well as to the impact of speech on the constitution of human self-knowledge.

2. HERDER—LANGUAGE AS A SENSORIMOTOR ORGANIZATION OF THE BODY

2.1. In search of linguistic *energeia*

Herder's philosophy contains most of the major theses of Gehlen's anthropology in "embryonic form." In his famous *Treatise on the Origin of Language* Herder describes man primarily as a deficient being (*Mängelwesen*). Humans have no stable instincts, no natural protection against inclement weather, no natural organs for defence and attack: "That the human being is far inferior to the animals in strength and sureness of instinct, indeed that he quite lacks what in the case of so many animal species we call innate abilities for and drives to art, is certain." (Herder, 2002, 77–78)

More than a century before Jakob von Uexküll Herder notes that every animal has its own sphere within which it is born, lives and dies: "... it is strange that the sharper animals' senses are and the more marvellous the products of their art, then the smaller their circle is, the more limited in kind the product of their art." (Herder, 2002, 78) Herder has discovered that a striking inverse proportion exists between the inferior nature of animal movements, diet, means of self-preservation, mating habits, rearing of the young, society and its drives and abilities. The narrower is its circle of life, the more certain and perfect its abilities (Herder, 2002, 78). Herder writes: "The sensitivity, abilities, and drives to art of the animals increase in strength and intensity in inverse proportion to the size and diversity of their circle of efficacy." (Herder, 2002, 79)

Instead, the man is not adapted to a specific biological environment, but he lives in the largest possible circle: "Born with such a dispersed, weakened sensuality, with such indeterminate, dormant abilities, with such divided and weakened drives, obviously dependent on and directed to a thousand needs, destined for a large sphere." (Herder, 2002, 80–81) Our sensuality, our social and cognitive skills develop extremely slowly. Therefore, we need an unusually long period of protection and care during our infancy and childhood—in short, we need a culture, i.e. an "artificial nature," which has been transformed by the

human community and adapted to its needs. The initial biological deficits are—according to Herder—compensated through language, which is the main cause and medium of the development of human reason, society and tradition. The linguistic competence defines humanity; language cannot be separated from reason and in this sense it is a necessary condition of human freedom and morality.

Herder created his concept of language at a time when the debate over what important properties of mankind made it unique, i.e. what distinguishes the man from the animal was still very lively. In response to this question, the thinkers of the Enlightenment primarily indicated the reason, but many of them viewed language as a key ability for understanding the human condition. At that time, Europe was trying to come to terms with the otherness of exotic cultures and with the stunning multitude of diverse languages. More and more researchers learned Near Eastern languages in order to be able to study the Bible, but it was also the time when Sanskrit gained popularity, together with the idea of the Indo-European language family. Despite the growing secularization of culture, German universities upheld the dominance of the concept of divine origin of language by the authority of Johann Peter Süssmilch (1707–1767), with whom Herder argued. The conflict between theology and rationalism concerning the origin of language resulted in a competition announced by the Berlin Academy. In 1771 Herder won a prize from the Berlin Academy for his best-known work on the philosophy of language, the *Treatise on the Origin of Language*.

The conclusion of Herder's refined considerations was innovative for his time: language is not a gift from God, but it derives from the natural predispositions and from the specific orientation of vital forces, therefore in order to understand how human speech comes into being and develops we must examine its biological conditions, historical evolution and social functions. Anticipating Gehlen's philosophical anthropology, Herder points out that the language is rooted in human corporeality. The mind needs external impulses, stimuli to develop its cognitive abilities and, above all, to be able to achieve self-knowledge. If the position of *homo sapiens* is unique among other animals because of language and reason, this uniqueness should manifest itself already at the somatic level. Herder conceives language ability as a predisposition contained in the structure of human sensuality, as a kind of potency, which is actualised via external stimuli.

The belief that the man comes into the world completely helpless prompts Herder to present a model situation in which the uncoordinated mind of an infant is trying to cope with the flood of impressions. The ontogenetically earliest stage of consciousness resembles an endless ocean of chaotic sensations. The streams of stimuli that have not yet been filtered exert pressure on the body and force the child to react, although its motor system is deprived of instinctive coordination. As long as the infant passively receives stimuli, it remains a slave to nature. As soon as it starts to identify, recognize and name its experience, it enters *via regia* leading to freedom and creativity.

The ability, which initiates the development of language, and thus lets the man to organize the primal chaos of impressions, Herder describes as “taking-awareness” (*die Besonnenheit*—he uses the term “reflection.” *Die Besonnenheit* operates already at a purely sensory level, it is therefore not an intellectual operation, although at a later stage of development it manifests itself first of all in the discursive acts. Verbal speech, which belongs only to man, is essentially intentional. Through reflection we can relate to the activity of our senses, and then extract distinct features from a stream of vague impressions which are embedded in the “ocean of feelings.” This first intentional act, which is an exclusive prerogative of human beings, Herder describes as follows:

“The human being demonstrates reflection when the force of his soul operates so freely that in the whole ocean of sensations which floods the soul through all the senses it can, so to speak, separate off, stop, and pay attention to a single wave, and be conscious of its own attentiveness. The human being demonstrates reflection when, out of the whole hovering dream of images which proceed before his senses, he can collect himself into a moment of alertness, freely dwell on a single image, pay it clear, more leisurely heed, and separate off characteristic marks for the fact that this is that object and no other.” (Herder, 2002, 87)

If the reflection extracts from the stream of sensory impressions and affects the structures of symbolic order, it means that in the human sensuality from the very beginning—in the ontogenetic and phylogenetic perspectives—is contained a specific form of reason which “[...] is no compartmentalized, separately effective force but an orientation of all forces that is distinctive to his species.” (Herder, 2002, 85)

In his essay *On the Cognition and Sensation of the Human Soul* Herder, following Leibniz, assumes that all mental processes (thinking, imagining, feeling) are underpinned by vital forces that are inaccessible to intellect. The whole mental life of man is to some extent a manifestation of the potential of latent energy which indeed cannot be fully expressed by a language (only “true poetry” is partially able to do so), but at the same time it initiates a linguistic communication. The body as a reservoir of primordial creative energy is the “counterpart of the soul” and “mirror of the universe” and most of all—it is “the place” in which the mental and somatic processes join together. (Herder, 1892, 245)

In the preceding sentence we used the term “the place” in quotes because Herder, following Leibniz, maintains that energy is outside, or “below” the dimension of space—so it cannot be localised through any spatial characteristics. According to this vitalistic topography of the human soul the true source of language flows from the place where this invisible energy of nature manifests itself in the form of sensory impressions, or rather “... where concepts intersect and get entangled, where the most diverse feelings produce one another, where

a pressing occasion summons forth all the forces of the soul and reveals the whole art of invention of which the soul is capable.” (Herder, 2002, 115)

In other words, Herder describes the birth of language as a certain act of translation: firstly, the invisible vital forces (“energy of nature”) are translated into sensory impressions; secondly, the latter are translated into the primordial language-images, into “the roots of language” (*Sprachwurzel*). The roots of language are the acoustic images around which the images from the other senses associated with them are accumulated. The element that unites heterogeneous components of the first words is the feeling (Herder, 2002, 106), and most often ambivalent emotional states, therefore this primordial language is characterized by redundancy, the semantic surplus. “Each family of words is an overgrown bush around a sensuous main idea, around a holy oak on which there are still traces of the impression that the inventor had of this Dryad. The feelings are woven together for him.” (Herder, 2002, 101–102)

We can interpret Herder’s concept as an attempt to naturalize the Platonic philosophy of ideas—at least in the context of the theory of language. In a sense, Herder brought the Platonic ideas from noetic heaven to the sensual world of concrete language. The idea appears in Herder’s concept as an acoustic “inward characteristic mark” (*das innere Merkzeichen*). (Herder, 2002, 89) It allows to recognize the difference between impressions, to determine a characteristic which represents a set of properties, and thus to reproduce the specific meaning regardless of the current situation and needs.

Produced in this way “inward characteristic marks” are not the result of arbitrary decisions, contracts, but are formed under the pressure of a unique experience which was shared by the community at some point in its history. Herder thus combines the contingency, the particularity of various languages with the necessity which is imposed on the development of a specific language by a specific structure of the human soul and by the unique history of a community. He does not agree with the view that the man experiences primarily the reality through “mute ideas” (simple sensual impressions) that later are called by a neutral and completely arbitrary language. On the contrary, only language allows us to contact with the world as a space in which we can consciously live and work together and realize our freedom.

According to Herder’s vitalistic ontology, subjectivity is involved in the process of energy exchange with nature. Our experience is successful when we, as soon as possible, transfer the energy which we received from the world back to the nature and to other people (ideally, the energy should not be stored in a human subject). A key role in this process is played by the language that regulates the flow of energy on input and output, we would say today. The energy converted into nerve impulses is then transformed into sensory impressions and at this point a language takes action—it organizes and channels a stream of sensations which leads to the formation of mental representations (that is why all available mental representations, images, etc. are—according to Herder—

linguistic). In the last phase of energy exchange the imagination ordered by language (strictly speaking by “inward characteristic marks”) affects bodily dispositions, i.e. it determines the human expression, interaction and any kind of activity. Thus the functional circle of action (and energy exchange) is closed—energy derived from nature returns to it, creating the state of equilibrium. Using modern terminology, we could also say that the man as a psychophysical whole becomes through language a homeostatic system, which is an integral part of biouniverse. (Herder, 1881, 207)

2.2. Symbolic communication at the level of sensory imagination

In the previous section we showed that Herder explains the origins of language, referring to his vitalistic metaphysics and sensualist concept of *Besonnenheit*. Equally important to his argumentation is the theory of sensuality and general anthropological laws that govern the development of the language. Below we will try to reconstruct the main theses and assumptions on this issue.

It should first be emphasized that Herder rejects theories which derive the human language from the expression of subjective feelings and from the elementary messages occurring in animal communities (warnings, threats, simple signals coordinating collective activity of animals). In the treatise on language Herder begins his reasoning by the famous statement that even as an animal, the human being has a language. However, it is not yet the language in the strict sense, but “the mechanism of feeling bodies.” (Herder, 2002, 65) Both human and animal bodies have an innate tendency to articulate affective stimuli—intense sensations of pain, dissatisfaction, greed, fear, threats, etc. Herder emphasizes the “sympathetic communion” of man with the animal world and in a broader perspective—with the whole of nature. The highly developed species are related to each other through the natural “language of sensation” which also played a role in the prehistory of humanity. “That the human being originally shares this language of sensation with the animals is, to be sure, evidenced more now by certain remains than by full eruptions.” (Herder, 2002, 66)

The remains of these natural sounds are still preserved in the oldest languages, in their interjections, in the roots of their nouns and verbs. Expressive sounds do not function as a means of communication in the strict sense of the word, because they are not accompanied by a conscious intentionality. The sounds of howling and lamentation, the cry of joy, fear or pain express only ambiguous states of inner stimulation, which are difficult to articulate, even in mature languages.

For this reason, Herder argues that in order to understand how language is actually formed and how it develops, we must analyse the structure of our senses. What distinguishes human language from animal language is 1) the specific human intentionality, i.e. the taking-awareness (*Besonnenheit*) in Herder’s terminology, and 2) the spontaneous symbolic communication between the senses.

According to Herder, the human senses are not closed, isolated sensory fields, but they cooperate with each other. In the *Ideas on the Philosophy of the History of Mankind* Herder also stresses that the structure of our visual world is related to our upright stance and basically vertical orientation. The profound cooperation between the eye, other senses and the hand results in our perceptual world in which symbols of experienced objects convey their potential usefulness. The external world is thus the product of a symbolic communication between the senses, not something objective, independent of the activity of the subject. (Herder, 2002, 106)

The ability to transpose impressions organizes the work of the senses even at the preverbal stage of development, but only the language integrally related to hearing enables a comprehensive communication between the senses which is unprecedented in the animal world. The fact that Herder admits the primacy of the audition among the other senses determines the novelty and singularity of his conception. In contrast to the classical positions (Locke, Hume, Kant, etc.), he stresses that a key role in the development of human imagination and cognitive processes is played by the auditory, and not optical experience. In this way he reversed the theoretical hierarchy of the senses with the leading position of sight, which has already been “ratified” in the philosophy of Plato (*Hippias Major*). Besides the auditory perception Herder has also rehabilitated the sense of touch. In this case he was certainly inspired by the famous experiments of William Cheselden (1688–1752). In 1728 Cheselden conducted a successful eye surgery on a boy blind from birth. His practical insights about the sense impressions confirmed and supplemented the theoretical considerations of George Berkeley on this topic, who found, “... that figures, magnitudes, situations, distances, are not sensations but inferences; [that] they are not the immediate revelations of sight, but the products of association and intellectual construction.” (Morley, 1887, 78) When the boy regained his sight, it turned out that he could not properly estimate the spatial relationships (the remoteness, size, shape, etc. of perceived objects). It was only after a month of exercises involving tactile sensations when the boy reached the normal ability to see.

Admittedly, Herder acknowledges the priority of the touch—because only through the tactile pre-impressions objects of the visual perception can emerge (Herder, 1892, 97)—but he also emphasizes that the most important sense in the development of linguistic competence and in the formation of human subjectivity is the auditory sense. This is determined by the following properties of that sense: 1) the acoustic impressions are marked by the moderate receivability—they transmit less information than the redundant visual perception, and also more data than a “punctual,” self-centred touch, so they can easily be identified and preserved in the current perception. Furthermore, neither vision nor touch help us to create images of the mental inside, because the first throws us far outside ourselves, whereas the latter closes us in a small space of feeling. The hearing brings (through the audible from outside sounds) the environment

into the inside of the human subject and thus becomes a natural medium for the synthesis of all the senses. (Herder, 2002, 109) 2) The hearing is a moderate sense with respect to the clarity and precision of the perceived qualities. (Herder, 2002, 109–110) 3) It is also a moderate sense in respect to the liveliness or the intensity of impressions. The audible sounds penetrate us, but they do not interfere with other senses. (Herder, 2002, 110) 4) This synthesizing function of hearing is directly linked to its temporality. It presents the world as a temporal succession of images that are formed by different senses, and at the same time allows us to distance ourselves from the internal mental representations. The temporal structure of hearing enables us to anticipate future situations and to reproduce the information from the past. Language “... counts sounds into our souls only one after another, gives and never tires, gives and always has more to give. She thus practices the whole knack of method: she teaches progressively.” (Herder, 2002, 110) 5) Hearing is best suited for the expression of human needs, the sense of touch acts selfishly, in turn, the sight is silent and ineffective in communication. (Herder, 2002, 110–111) 6). Finally, hearing is distinguished in view of its development. Its articulation skills are very plastic, and therefore they must be developed gradually. This benefits eyesight, because language development, which is linked to the development of thinking, has influence on the selection processes in the visual field. “Since all the senses function cooperatively, through the sense of hearing we are, so to speak, always in nature’s school, learning to abstract and simultaneously to speak; vision refines itself with reason—reason and the talent of referring.” (Herder, 2002, 111)

However, the privileged position of hearing among the other senses does not fully explain the origin of language. Herder complements the deduction of the language from the qualitative properties of the senses by pointing to the general laws of human development. The most important law is the principle of economy of nature, according to which the man as a deficient being compensates his biological deficits with the help of the reason and language. Language functions as an indispensable tool in the process of articulation and organization of human needs. It is also an ideal medium that accumulates human experience and supports people in the mastery of nature. The history is constituted by the development and tradition of different languages and therefore by the collective thought and culture.

Summing up, according to Herder, human speech begins at the moment of transition from a pure expression to the consciously-articulated sound (from the screaming to the word). However, the representational function of language is always intertwined with the expressive function. This is what Hans Dietrich Irmscher meant when he wrote the afterword to Herder’s treatise:

“The main intention of Herder in this writing can be reduced to attempting to demonstrate that the language comes from the human nature only where it is

still a whole, a unity of feeling and thinking, receptivity and action, and that the language in its unity of expression and meaning reflects the totality of human nature, and perhaps even enables it.” (Irmscher, 1975, 166)

The identity of expression and meaning, which defines human language is the result of the primordial mimesis. Hearing, which becomes at an early stage of phylo- and ontogenesis the main medium of language development, forms the first components of speech through imitation: “... only hearing actually gives sounds, and the human being cannot invent but only find, only imitate.” (Herder, 2002, 109) Therefore, Herder believes that the man could not find acoustic patterns in his own articulations, but he had to derive them from external sounds. The “resounding verbs” were the earliest conscious articulations. (Herder, 2002, 100)

The mutual translatability of human senses causes even the phenomena which are not directly related to the acoustic sphere to find their equivalence in the field of sound. This kind of synesthetic communication between senses takes place through feeling (*das Gefühl*): “Feeling forms the basis of all the senses, and this already gives to the most diverse sensations such an inward, strong, inexpressible bond that the strangest phenomena arise from this connection.” (Herder, 2002, 106) The feeling is *ipso facto* a kind of synesthetic synthesis that “merges” all (both sensory and emotive) stimulations into an indivisible whole.

Language analysed from the point of view of its origins is a sort of a bridge between man and external world which precedes the dichotomy of subject and object. The taking-consciousness (*die Besonnenheit*), which constitutes the human language, coordinates the operation of the senses, affections, imagination and thought processes, therefore, we should, according to Herder, reject the Enlightenment idea of autonomous reason. Sensuality is not limited to the receiving and processing of external stimuli, like a sphere of affects does not consist only of blind and selfish impulses. The punchline of Herder’s anthropology is the apodictic conviction that we cannot describe man as *animal rationale*, because humans are inherently sensual beings and “linguistic creatures.”

3. THE LINGUISTIC TURN IN THE ANTHROPOLOGY OF GEHLEN

3.2. Language as a process of relief

Arnold Gehlen refers directly to Herder’s linguistic anthropology, which he himself admits writing: “Philosophical anthropology has not progressed significantly since Herder. His is in essence the same approach I wish to develop using the tools of modern science.” (Gehlen, 1997, 84) In his programmatic work *Man, His Nature and Place in the World* Gehlen argues that language is the

main “tool” which relieves human sensuality and psyche from the flood of stimulation and the excess of chaotic drives. In actual fact, language continues the processes of relief that already takes place at sensorimotor level. What exactly is a relief? According to Gehlen, man has to transform his fundamental handicaps into opportunities for survival; his sensorimotor and intellectual skills (fostered by language) propel each other to higher levels, until a point is reached where control of action becomes possible. The process of relief is evident even in the relationship between suggestion and overview in the visual field. We do not perceive things in their entirety but, instead, the perceptual field becomes symbolic to a great degree in the course of our development of movement. Certain visual data—for example, the handle—suggest ways of manipulating an object. The eye can take in all the useful information at one glance. In this way the directness of impression and influence of the flood of stimulation is broken, the points of contact with it are reduced to minimum. The order of perception thus corresponds in the same way to man's indirect, future-oriented behaviour. The prerequisite to the development of this vitally important structure of perception is man's confrontation with unadopted, unsorted masses of stimuli. Only with the aid of this structure of perception can impressions be endowed with symbols and the visual field ordered and classified in the course of man's interaction with the surroundings. Relief allows human behaviour to concentrate increasingly on the “higher,” the most effortless, purely suggestive functions, that is on the conscious function whose substrate is language.

Speech acts are an integral part of the action (*die Handlung*) or, strictly speaking, of the functional cycle (*des Funktionskreises*) which involves initially the coordination of the hand, eye, motor system and, later, conceptual thinking. The particular components of the “action-cycle” can, depending on the requirements of the situation, bring under control other elements, unlike the totally involuntary, “unflexible” functional cycles which operate at the vegetative level. All action is communicative and flexible thanks to the unique character of our motor system, which underlies human speech. Man is characterized by his sensorimotor movements, which are integrated with sensations of sight and touch. These are circular processes which furnish the impetus for their own perpetuation.¹ They take place “independently of instinctive desires” and have no direct value for satisfying drives. They are communicative, focusing on any objects drawn into the movements. They are experienced on the same level as things, just as these things are involved in the awareness of the activity. This productive type of interaction is at the same time practical because new movements teach us new ways of dealing with changes in our world. Because of our

¹ The child already in the early stages of development can not only touch any part of its body, but, most importantly, can transpose any realized form of movement into other patterns of movement. This ability is conditioned by anatomical specificity of *homo sapiens*: his upright stance, the openness of his sensory organs on a wide spectrum of stimuli, the mobility of the head, the flexibility of the spine (especially of the lumbar region), a complex system of joints and muscles moving the skeleton.

ability to imagine, any of the phases in this process may serve as the motivation for an action. Gehlen stresses that the “objectivity” of our behaviour, its concern with exploring the properties of things, is inseparable from our “need-free” interaction with things through movement and the senses.

The action already at the level of basic motor reactions relieves man from unnecessary expenditures of energy, eliminates the intermediate links in the process of acquisition of new abilities and behaviours. Therefore, human development relies notably on a kind of involution—on simplifying and schematisation of functional cycles. The complex interrelated processes, by which we become intimately familiar with the world, create, at the sensorimotor level, a base from which the language grows. Our picture of the world is created through the symbolic media (perception, movements and language) which completely frees us from the flood of stimuli and direct pressure of external world and our drives. The most effective medium of relief is the language. It enables us, first, to recognize the things that are beyond the range of our physical capabilities, secondly, it allows us to use action, which is independent of the real existence of its objects, thirdly, it endowed our actions with a symbolic meaning, for which reason we can plan and anticipate very complex sequences of movements and actions, without realizing them in practice. Language springs from several roots which at first function independently of each other. We will discuss them in the next section. We can stress here, however, that the following mans achievements are developed to a high degree in language: communicative, interactive behaviour; the creation of “indicators” or symbols; self-perceived activity re-experienced through the senses; and, finally, reduced, relieved contact with the world. They are not, however, solely confined to language—indeed, they are features of mans relieved existence in general and are already present in pre-linguistic behaviour.

3.2. Five roots of language

According to Gehlen, the fundamental law of the structure of human sensorimotor behaviour is continued in language and it ultimately explains the uniqueness of human intelligence. He insists that a sound, and speech in general, must be considered as a movement, and belong in the category of movements that are re-experienced. Such movements play an important role for man because, above all, they make possible the experience of movement and thus promote self-directed, self-controlled improvements in skills. Within the realm of communicative, sensitive movements of interaction, “movements of sound” arise from several “roots.” Analogous to tactile movements, movements of sound articulation have an extraordinary quality of being re-experienced—in this case, through the sense of hearing. The “heard” aspect of these movements is experienced as a sensation, as originating from the outside world. The articulation of the sound resounds back from the world to the ear. When these sound

movements are employed, it then becomes possible to direct oneself toward something in a specific, free and effortless movement. In other words, man is able simultaneously to intend the movement and to perceive it. This intention, that is, directing oneself in a communicative manner toward things, is the “vital basis for thought”: “Intention here means the expectations in every controlled movement of a certain outcome or response. It is a very grave mistake to relegate intention solely to the spiritual or intellectual realm. Any controlled movement intends in its initial phases to be continued and to have a certain result. The anticipation contained within a sound of finding fulfilment through other, responding sounds, of course, of particular significance: it is the vital basis of thought, of the intention of something expressed in a sound, it is self-aware, directed, and hence freely available.” (Gehlen, 1997, 143) Through “resounding words”—as Herder would say—man achieves the maximal ability to orient oneself and create symbols with the freest access to what is perceived.

Gehlen’s considerations regarding the origin of language allowed him ultimately to extract five “roots of language” (*Sprachwurzel*), i.e. five general characteristics of the human sensorimotor system, which contributed to the creation of the developed symbolic language.

1) The “life of the sound.” This root of language originates in the context of man’s encounter with the world and his mastery of it through communicative interaction, through the cooperation between the hand and the eye. Following Max Scheler, Gehlen assumes that man is open to the world. Unlike animals, who live completely immersed in the environment, subject to their drives and to the environment, the human being is able to detach himself from his environment and transform it into a symbolic world, so openness is a typically human phenomenon. Man is exposed to an excess of stimulation toward which he remains world-open. Our sounds are played back from our surroundings and because of it a purely sensorimotor communication through sound is possible: we expect a certain result, we expect to hear the sound repeated. In this way a child learns to experience itself and becomes aware of itself by shifting its inner activity into the external world.

2) The expression of sounds prompted by visual impressions. The world-openness and receptivity of child is revealed in the fact that it reacts to visual impressions with unspecific movements of response, including sound articulations which are “need-free” and characterized by a vitality (“a sheer joy”). Gehlen assumes that in face of the external stimuli, the child’s self-expression automatically takes a phonetic course. (Gehlen, 1997, 196)

3) The call. Because of its immaturity, a child is not able to interpret its needs and wants, and so these are expressed as a state of general unrest, more specifically, in mindless babbling and the like. A child’s needs and distresses are attended to by external sources. The child ultimately anticipates the gratification that follows its cry in the “call.” Thus it cries with the intention of receiving comfort. The child’s call for help is significant for the development of

language because it establishes a connection between need, sound and gratification. The child learns to express its needs and impulses in sound. It must become aware of them and interpret them and this occurs for the first time in the call.

4) Sound gesture. At first, a child accompanies its movements and emotional outbursts with sound. This sound becomes more defined once specific patterns of movement have been worked out. Because human movements permit a change in the point of initiation, any sequence of action can be initiated by its accompanying sound phase. The child learns that specific sounds it makes can intend and usher in a certain sequence of actions. Gehlen uses his concept of sound gestures to explain the self-intended words which accompany children in their actions. Analogously to Arieti's concept of paleosymbols (Arieti, 1967), Gehlen conceives these quasi-words as particular, purely private sounds which stand for a holistic situation, which includes a variety of emotions, actions and sensations that are experienced by the child as an integrated whole. Thus the linguistic "paleosymbols" have a symbolic value, but this value remains private to the individual who experiences it. It cannot be shared with anybody else because a child does not yet have a fully developed language. Therefore, "words" may develop from sound gestures "with only situational value that were never repeated to children and that designate particular actions." Also, conventional words can initially operate as paleosymbols: "There is no doubt that in this root of language above all lie the beginnings of language learning. I have no trouble explaining why a child, when someone gives it a toy and then says 'ball,' will immediately acquire this word. It is not the ball, but rather the sound, interwoven into the movement of play, that is readily available to the child at any time so that its intention to play, to experience all that this entails, is expressed in the sound which also involves the call, help, participation, and community." (Gehlen, 1997, 230–231) From all elements in the total situation which could function as the signal that initiates the entire sequence of action a sound seems to be in every respect the most effective. According to Gehlen, a child prefers to express the intention to carry out an action in a sound symbol because this particular acoustic phase of the entire process is always readily available and requires no real effort. It also facilitates communication with others and creates the possibility of a common focus on the same action. The intention to carry out an action thereby becomes freely available, expressive, and public.

5) The sound of recognition. In case of young children (just as in animals) the act of recognition is simply a phase in the execution of movement—recognition and action become indistinguishable from each other. For each specific impression specific response movements are developed. At the initiation of movement "motor-memory" is awakened and it forms expectations. Recognition has a brief initial mechanical phase; the swift, automatic coordination of an impression with the initiation of movement—this is itself a product of earlier experiences. There is also—according to Gehlen—a second phase: the appro-

priate memories respond to the impression and action focuses exclusively on what has been recognized, “incorporating” it in some fashion into our activity. This process first constitutes recognition and leads to the automatic response to impressions in movement. Contrary to animals in young children the reaction no longer involves the entire body but is instead controlled by sound movement. These movements are the most intelligent, most gratifying and successful of movements because, within them, a whole series of skills are consolidated. This unique “audiomotor system” operates in the recognition response, in which entire body no longer responds to impressions, but to an even greater degree, sound movements alone. Gehlen stresses, however, that we are not dealing here with the language *per se* yet: “Vocalizing in response to pleasurable or painful events is in no sense merely the expression of emotion or the giving of a ‘name,’ but rather is a specific response of recognition.” (Gehlen, 1997, 199)

Therefore, the formation of language is primarily based on “motor imagination” (the ability to imagine movements), which allows us to carry out symbolic suggested movements, to coordinate any movement with any other, and transpose a movement from one limb to another. Human movements are predisposed toward self-direction and highly variable and controlled co-ordinations which are employed in our direct experience of the world. We can integrate imagined movements with images of their outcomes and the changes they might effect. This process, continued by language, is an audiomotor system which to a great degree determines the perceivable objectivity of things.

3.3. Language—drives and imagination

The communicative character of human movements and of human behaviour on the whole (including language and thought) proves, according to Gehlen, that all phenomena of consciousness should be understood from the perspective of, or in conjunction with action. The intentional action not only relieves man from the excess of drives, not only directs them and puts them under control, but above all it allows man to transform the world and ultimately to survive. Human drive impulses are structured so that they can be invested with experiences, images, and memories of gratification. Our drives are world-open and can be oriented toward specific things in the external world because they are not instinctive, and blindly certain of their goals. It is up to man to give vent to them—he behaves toward them in a communicative manner. Our desires are expressed through language words: in those cases in which a child already knows the name of the object it desires, this desire has become an interpreted conscious interest. In this manner, all our inner states become determined by words. Gehlen follows here Herder who proposed the same thesis when he wrote: “... all conditions of awareness in him (a man—R.M.) become linguistic; his chain of thoughts becomes a chain of words.” (Herder, 2002, 131) The orientation of desires is a uniquely human necessity which springs from our lack of

established instincts and can be met only through the language. Our impulses must be oriented, invested with images of situations and their outcomes. We can achieve all this only by experiencing and interpreting situations in which we are aware of our own motivation.

Following Freud, Gehlen assumes that the drives are “represented” in the psyche by two different components: the ideational representatives and the quota of affect. The ideational representatives include not only affective images of situations, but also outcomes and goals of our actions and desires. These images are organized and created by the language—we could also say: by linguistic imagination. Word is first of all the acoustic “motor-schema” which uses the raw material of our immediate, remembered impressions to create the freely mobile and readily available idea—an intentional image. Our memories, formed passively in us, become mobile and undergo a process of selection as a result of our movements. They then function as expectations of our intentional actions. When we are about to initiate a movement and are evaluating the existing situations, all the memories which are appropriate to the situation are aroused and appear as active images and expectations of what will happen. As our activity consequently becomes more focused and specific, these appropriate images come together to form a “new present,” appearing in the future. This ability to “mobilize” and summon up images from our memory Gehlen attributes to language because it does have a motor aspect. From this “memory-material” language creates relieved, mobile images, i.e. words, which can be repeated at will, independently of the particular situation, which can even take part in the intentionality of the word.

Through language, memories become imaginations—especially sensory images, as opposed to motor ones, which remain non-verbal. Language gives us access to the images in our memory, which can thereby become part of the intention of our thought. Insofar as language is action, it has the ability to release and call forth memories, as do our movements. These memories then follow our words, take part in their intentions and become ideas. In sum, our intentions become completely available to us through language, they become independent of what is actually given. Through the images in language the world of concrete, condensed symbols (which is result of sensorimotor symbolisation) becomes accessible to us once more on a pure symbolic level. Language draws extensively on human imagination because it (language) represents the system that ultimately directs and integrates and comes to monopolize expression and communication.

From it all, according to Gehlen, an important philosophical implication follows. Language does not differentiate between imagined and real things. For this very reason, it obscures the difference between reality and imagination for our consciousness. Because idea originates through word, the internal and external (idea and perception) are inevitably transformed into each other. That is why Gehlen uses Novalis’s expression in this context “the inner outer world”:

“... the world grows in us so that we find it within ourselves as ideas, as wishes, as interpreted needs; it can also be grasped in that all exhortations to action—wishes and intentions—appear as given to us because they contain images of their goals and substances. Thus they can be divorced from action, they can communicate within themselves, and a free inner life—relieved of the necessity of action—becomes possible.” (Gehlen, 1997, 196)

According to Gehlen, language primarily designates a perspective toward movement. Our cognitive acts refer first of all to actions, so the most important role is therein played by verbs which are not established through perception but rather through the act of being reproduced, either in real life or in our imagination. This difference is crucial for cognitive theory and it contradicts any philosophy that proceeds from the simple reflected perception of an object (i.e. post-Cartesian philosophy). The German anthropologist tries therefore to derive a typically human ability to think directly from movement and language: in fact thinking is for him identical with the language, and like the first (movement and language) it is a means of reducing the urgency of sensations. This topic will be discussed in the next part of section, but at the end of this part we go concisely into another problem which has already been mentioned—a problem of “imaginary language” of children.

Sound gestures (fourth root of language) and the responses in sound to something that is recognized (second root of language) lead to the first words—not only to conventional ones, but also to the imaged words. In both cases human drives are organized by sounds (names or imagined words). The oriented by language impulses remain bound to the images and intentions associated with the so called “explosive situations” (*Ausbruchssituationen*)—the situations in which they were first awakened. According to Gehlen, in this manner a portion of vocabulary was developed and, what is most important for us, a “semantic potential” which determines our future actions. For example, the word “ball” refers not only to the concrete object, but also to all experience which involves the call, the sequence of actions, the diversity of impressions and emotions associated with play. These “oldest names” integrate our “motivational energy” and create a sort of regulative ideas which, often unconsciously, determine our desires and decisions.

Gehlen also formulates an interesting hypothesis about “motor roots” of linguistic meaning: within the meaning of an individual word there is an image of fundamental meaning (*Grundbedeutung*), which in the majority of cases is an image of concrete movement with unequivocal form which tends to allow the meaning of a word to extend to similar objects. Different objects which are similar in some way from the perspective of this fundamental image of meaning become associated with each other. (Gehlen, 1997, 285)

3.4. Language and nonverbal thinking

Our analyzes clearly show that Gehlen follows the fundamental idea of Herder's anthropology maintaining that human beings are inherently "linguistic creatures". Language develops in a truly organic manner from the substructure of human senses and movements, and can be described in the same words. Ultimately, it consolidates and controls the entire development of human capabilities through our thought and consciousness. It provides complete relief from the present and necessity of responding to immediate stimuli. It allows us to come to terms with our world-openness in a productive manner so that an infinite number of plans for action becomes possible for us. Language, finally, serves as the best vehicle for communication with other human beings by facilitating a common focus on common activities and a common world.

Language is—in Gehlen's view—a sort of "twilight world" between consciousness and the real world, linking but also separating the two. The meaning of a word, the concept, exists only on the level of language, not "above" it in a pure conceptual realm: "Thought is an intention directed toward a thing which is conveyed in a word; however, because the word-thought (*Wortgedanke*) encounters resistance from the thing, it is reflected back upon itself and realizes that the word that is dying away has not completely exhausted it. It then strikes back in order to be re-created in another word." (Gehlen, 1997, 248) However, Gehlen stresses that in the direct usage word and concept are indistinguishable from each other. The word is, above all, a real action and its motor aspect should be never overlooked.

Thinking is a form of inner "silent speech" (*lautlose Sprache*). Unexpressed speech signifies an increase in our indirect behavior toward the worlds, i.e. thanks to it a direct sound-motor interaction does not take place. On purely descriptive level, thought is first and foremost a means of reducing the urgency of sensations. It behaves toward language as language does toward the perceivable abundance of impressions in the world. In thought our intentions follow a course that is detached to a great extent from the concrete material of ideas and memories as well as from the phonetic material of word-ideas. The anthropologist describes this process as follows: "Our intentions follow a course that skirts the 'kernels' of word-ideas without these actually becoming concrete, and in this way, intention apparently become free to link up with each other and thereby form trains of thought." (Gehlen, 1997, 264) Thus, Gehlen describes thinking as the highest degree of relief—a form of behaviour that reduces our contact with the sensory world, that is abbreviated, and that is purely suggested.

The specificity of Gehlen's concept of language lies in the fact that it presents its subject in a wider anthropological perspective, in conjunction with other human activities. The sensorimotor system, verbal communication, volitional acts and conceptual thinking are essentially structural moments of action. As subsystems subordinated to multifaceted *praxis* they are closely intertwined

with each other, creating a self-referential “functional cycle.” Although Gehlen’s concept of language is very complex, it does not provide sufficiently for the reference to the Other, to the speech community. Gehlen tries in the first place to derive language competence from the biological determinants of the human condition and probably because of this he ignores the intersubjectivity of language. Despite this theoretical deficit his theory seems to be still worthy of attention. Experience shows us that sometimes we can learn more based on errors and omissions than on the basis of ideas that are indisputable, but do not bring anything new to our self-knowledge.

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR — Assistant Professor, Chair of the Department of Philosophical Anthropology, Institute of Philosophy, Nicolaus Copernicus University, Toruń (affiliation).

His main research fields: contemporary German philosophy, philosophical anthropology. He among others authored: 2008. *Cielesność Kompensacja Mimesis. Wokół pojęciowego instrumentarium współczesnej antropologii filozoficznej* [Corporeality, Compensation, Mimesis. Around the Conceptual Instruments of Modern Philosophical Anthropology]. Warszawa (with Stanisław Czerniak); 2014. *Homo defectus w kulturze późnej nowoczesności. Geneza i ewolucja antropobiologii i teorii instytucji Arnolda Gehlena*, Toruń 2014 [*Homo Defectus in the Culture of Late Modernity. Origins and Evolution of Arnold Gehlen’s Anthropology and Theory of Institutions*]. Toruń; 2015. *Philosophy as Critique of the Mind. The Doctrinal Evolution of Critical Theory*. Frankfurt a. M. (with Stanisław Czerniak).

E-mail: metasis@umk.pl

Alice Pugliese

THE CENTERED REALITY. HELMUTH PLESSNER'S ANTI-NATURALISTIC ACCOUNT

ABSTRACT

This paper discusses the criticism of naturalism based on the irreducibility of first-person-perspective facts. This critique considers naturalism insufficient since it proposes the view of reality as a centerless dimension. However, simply reintegrating subjective facts into a naturalistic view of reality we eventually produce a split situation in which conscious and self-conscious forms of life require a special consideration, thus appearing as separated from the whole of reality. In order to overcome what turns out to be a dualistic interpretation of reality, this paper considers Helmuth Plessner's non-naturalistic approach. It elaborates the notion of positionality and aspectivity as characteristics of all natural forms of life, thus leading to the consideration of reality an essentially centered dimension and of humans as part of nature.

Keywords: naturalism, philosophical anthropology, Helmuth Plessner, positionality.

1. INTRODUCTION

In everyday life the question about human nature is a question about inclusion and exclusion, not a question about the definition of a special object or abstract natural laws. When we wonder what it is like to be human, or when we try to identify characteristics and traits that mark a human being, we are not chasing an abstract classification of an object among others. We are rather seeking valid criteria to decide who is or is not the bearer of certain rights, how and at what cost are we required to protect and support this particular form of life, and finally which kind of distance or closeness should we keep from this form of life in order to guarantee its integrity and flourishing. The question about human nature is a question about us and about the forms of distance and closeness we should keep to our social and natural environments. It is a question about how to articulate such a distance.

Today naturalism is considered a standard stance in philosophy. Even though it is possible to reconstruct several different accounts of naturalism, each one intended to refine its argumentation in a more strict or liberal way,¹ it still seems possible to identify (1) the contiguity with methods and results of natural sciences, and (2) the refusal of supernatural entities as the core thesis of this “current orthodoxy.”² The first point characterizes naturalism as a product of a long-term fascination. It is a powerful promise of the durable success of science that leads to the methodological choices of naturalism as not only justified, but rather almost necessary. The advancing disclosure of the secrets of the natural world and, moreover, the life-changing success in applying such discoveries to breakthrough technology seem to put a seal on the validity of empirical science. This assumption plays an important role in the definition of the task of philosophy, as well as in the anthropological and philosophical struggle with the puzzling relation between mind and body of conscious subjects.

Even when expressed in a cautious way, as David M. Armstrong does, the naturalistic faith in the evidence of scientific success is unmistakable:

“The present state of scientific knowledge makes it probable that we can give a purely physico-chemical account of man’s body. It seems increasingly likely that the body and the brain of man are constituted and work according to exactly the same principles as those physical principles that govern other, non-organic, matter. The differences between a stone and a human body appear to lie solely in the extremely complex material set-up that is to be found in the living body and which is absent in the stone.”³

Already in 1935, Edmund Husserl observed the same phenomenon and analyzed its philosophical and cultural consequences at the conference held in Vienna and published in 1936: the same year in which the chair of the most influential circle of positivists, Moritz Schlick, was murdered, thus leading to the diaspora of the members and the spreading of the positivistic ideas in the international academic debate. In the *Crisis of European Sciences*, Husserl

¹ The anthology edited by James D. Chalmers in 2002 was aimed at comparing naturalistic and non-naturalistic approaches to the problem of consciousness (see: Chalmers, J. D. 2002. *Philosophy of Mind. Classical and Contemporary Readings*. New York–Oxford: Oxford University Press). More recently and with focus on the problem of subjectivity, Antonio M. Nunziante shows how different forms of naturalism are developed along the common problem of finding a solution to the problem represented by conscious subjects (see Nunziante, A. M. 2013. “The ‘Morbidity of the Subjective.’ Privateness and Objectivity in Mid-twentieth Century American Naturalism.” *Metodo. International Studies in Phenomenology and Philosophy*, 1 (2), 39–57). Finally, Mario De Caro and David Macarthur explicitly explore the limits of naturalism suggesting the possibility of a liberal naturalism, which could ease the restrictions of reductionism (see: De Caro, M., D. Macarthur (Eds.). 2004. *Naturalism in Question*. Cambridge, Mass: Harvard University Press).

² De Caro, M., D. Macarthur. 2004, op. cit., 1.

³ Armstrong, D. M. 1981. *The Nature of Mind*. Brighton: University of Queensland Press, 19.

moves from the striking paradox, intended to raise protest, of a crisis of science properly resting on its own success.⁴ In his analysis he does acknowledge the explanatory power and the exactness of the scientific method, but at the same time, he points out a certain level of openness and variability as essential traits of science itself. Even physics, Husserl argues, is constitutionally exposed to main revisions in order to update contents and methods. Nevertheless, such internal criticism is not sufficient. Husserl claims that science still requires a critical revision of a completely different kind, a critique not motivated by internal questions, but rather by a more general tension affecting the social role of science and its last justification as a human undertaking. The philosophical source of the radical critique of science lies in the tension between prosperity and sense of empirical knowledge.

In Husserl's view, the efficacy of scientific theories is not identical with and cannot exhaust the sense of knowledge. That implies something we are increasingly and painfully becoming aware of, at least since the debate about the destructive potential of technology in world conflicts. The successful applicability of scientific results to technical production, although able to radically change human and non-human life and to improve or destroy natural and social environment, does not provide automatically a guarantee of the good sense and even of the rationality of human knowledge.⁵ Husserl traces this unresolved tension back to an "enigma," which characterizes the proper object of philosophy: the enigma of subjectivity.⁶

In order to avoid what could strike the reader as a big leap, it might be convenient to go back to what can be considered as the common root of scientific and ontological naturalism, i.e. the thesis of "causal closure."⁷ This states the universal validity of causality as the only epistemological model for the explanation of phenomena, as well as the only law holding the existing things together.⁸ The common firm confidence in causality as the universal explanatory

⁴ Husserl, E. 1954. *Die Krisis der europäischen Wissenschaften und die transzendente Phänomenologie. Eine Einleitung in die phänomenologische Philosophie*. Von Biemel, W. (Ed.). Husserliana VI. The Hague: Martinus Nijhoff.

⁵ See the reflections on the ambiguity of technology developed by Hans Jonas as practical application of his ethics of responsibility in: Jonas, H. 1985. *Technik, Medizin und Ethik. Zur Praxis des Prinzips Verantwortung*. Frankfurt am Main: Insel Verlag, chap. 2.

⁶ Husserl, E. 1954, op. cit., 3.

⁷ Kim, J. 1993. "The Myth of Non-Reductive Materialism (1989)." In: *Supervenience and Mind: Selected Philosophical Essays*. Cambridge University Press, 280; Apineau, D. 2015. "Naturalism," *The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* (Fall 2015 Edition), Zalta, E. N. (Ed.), URL = <http://plato.stanford.edu/archives/fall2015/entries/naturalism/>, § 1.2

⁸ The commitment to the unity of science and to a unique and reductive form of causality is not uncontroversial even in the naturalistic debate. See Macarthur, D. 2010. "Taking the Human Sciences Seriously." In: *Naturalism and Normativity*. De Caro, M., D. Macarthur (Eds.). New York: Columbia University Press. The concept of causation involves a variety of meanings and theories that are broadly reconstructed in Beebe, H., Hitchcock, C., Mentzies, P. (Eds.). 2004. *The Oxford Handbook for Causation*. New York: Oxford University Press.

model *and* as the valid description of all kinds of possible relations among things makes the difference between methodological and ontological naturalism ultimately irrelevant.⁹ What emerges is the view of a substantially homogeneous world, which in turn requires and justifies a homogeneous epistemological approach to things.

2. THE PERSPECTIVE OBJECTION

As it happens to all orthodoxies, despite of its broad diffusion, naturalism is facing increasing criticism.¹⁰ Among the critical voices is Lynne R. Baker, who provides a relevant contribution to the debate by choosing the promising strategy of focusing on the methodological and ontological peculiarity of the first-person-perspective.¹¹ A significant characteristic of Baker's reconstruction is that it neither reduces naturalism to a special epistemological approach, to the technical solution of particular argumentative problems, nor to an ontological position intended to draw up the inventory of allowed or dismissed entities. Baker recognizes in naturalism the function of a comprehensive worldview, indicating how the difference between its methodological and its ontological meaning can be considered as merely derivative. On this basis, she poignantly focuses on the consequences of naturalism for practical, ethical and political issues, shedding light on a central effect of a coherent naturalistic view.

Even though Baker reviews a large range of philosophical positions, she seems to lead an undercurrent fundamental dispute with Thomas Nagel's well-known philosophical undertaking. In *A View from Nowhere* he tries to develop an account of epistemological objectivity that can implement a subjective perspective by putting it in continuity with objectivity.¹² Nagel's proposal arises from the well-established assumption that subjectivity and its peculiar perspective on things is unavoidable. Nevertheless, it is a common goal of science to gradually leave it behind in the search for objective reality.¹³ Once again, as we have already observed with regard to Husserl, the enigma of subjectivity and of its peculiar status provides the issues that end up putting naturalism in question.

⁹ The substantial equivalence between methodological and ontological approaches to naturalism is poignantly summed up by one of the pioneers of contemporary naturalism, Wilfrid Sellars: "In the dimension of describing and explaining the world, science is the measure of all things, of what is that it is, and of what is not that it is not." (Sellars, W. 1963. "Empiricism and the Philosophy of Mind." In: *Science, Perception and Reality*. London: Routledge and Kegan Paul, 173.)

¹⁰ The anthology edited by De Caro and Macarthur quoted above gives a comprehensive account of modern criticism of the naturalistic view (see De Caro, M. and Macarthur, D. 2004).

¹¹ Baker, L. R. 2013. *Naturalism and the First-Person Perspective*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

¹² See Nagel, T. 1986. *The View From Nowhere*. New York–Oxford: Oxford University Press, 5.

¹³ "We may think of reality as a set of concentric spheres, progressively revealed as we detach gradually from the contingencies of the self" (Ibid.).

For both Nagel and Husserl the problem lies in the understanding of a particular “piece” of the world. As Husserl formulates it in the § 53 of the *Crisis*: “The paradox of human subjectivity: being a subject for the world and at the same time being an object in the world.”¹⁴ More precisely, the problem concerns the relation between a part and the totality of the world and thereby it affects the possibility to grasp the world as totality. As Nagel puts it:

“A succession of objective advances may take us to a new conception of reality that leaves the personal or merely human perspective further and further behind. But if what we want is to understand the whole world, we can’t forget about those subjective starting points indefinitely.”¹⁵

Baker’s dispute against Nagel bears therefore a broader meaning than the assessment of the ontological and epistemological status of a peculiar kind of facts, i.e. subjective and perspective, value-laden facts. It rather concerns a general view of the proper constitution of reality. What she appropriately and repeatedly holds against naturalism is that it implicitly presupposes the idea of the world as “centerless”¹⁶ and as a “thoroughly dehumanized”¹⁷ impersonal reality. Admitting only material objects and their properties, the fundamental assumption of physicalism reduces all complex objects to their atomic elements and shifts the whole complexity and diversity of things and facts to the level of mere descriptive differences. Hence, the world appears as an inventory of pieces, one next to another, completely undistinguished and uniform. The result is a landscape without relevancies, as continuous as mute. The comforting certainty of the “explanatory transparency” implies that every phenomenon is explicable in the terms and with the detachment of science, thus leaving us with no world at all. Baker makes it clear that not only the possibility to carve out a space for subjective facts in order to find a proper legitimation for practical issues as agency and personal responsibility is at stake. At stake is rather the possibility of rethinking naturalism as a general account of the world.

However, despite her determination in stating that “no wholly impersonal account of the world can be adequate,”¹⁸ her counterproposal seems to not completely fulfill the task implied by her own critical assessment. The radicalism of her criticism, focusing on the neutralized quality of reality as it is displayed by naturalism, requires a more general assessment of reality itself. Her “near-naturalistic” approach is based on the integration of both a rudimentary and a more robust first-person-perspective, intended roughly as consciousness and self-consciousness in different moments of subjective development.

¹⁴ Husserl, E. 1954, op. cit., 182.

¹⁵ Nagel, T. 1986. *The View From Nowhere*. New York-Oxford: Oxford University Press, 5–6.

¹⁶ Baker, L. R. 2013, XIII.

¹⁷ Ibid., 26.

¹⁸ Ibid., XVI–XVII.

However, self-consciousness as the core element of Baker's near-naturalistic worldview is significantly shaped on linguistic abilities of self-attribution, i.e. on the linguistic capacity of saying "I did it, I felt it." According to her view, it is due to language-based abilities that a human being recognizes itself as subject of action or experience. Therefore, Baker's challenge to naturalism, even if radical, is grounded on a high level capacity reserved to human beings. Such a restriction could leave the whole non-linguistic, pre-verbal living reality untouched. Perspectivity, far from being a substantial objection against naturalism, could simply amount to an exceptional quality that does not affect the most part of objective reality and even of natural life. Near-naturalism thus appears as an important, but not yet sufficient adjustment of naturalism.

3. PLESSNER'S PHILOSOPHY OF NATURE

As we already observed with reference to the late work of Husserl, the question about the problematic attraction exercised by natural science on every other field of knowledge is not a recent one. As Husserl shows in his reconstruction of modernity, the whole history of philosophy and of modern culture can be read from the point of view of the polarity between natural science and human or social science. In this respect the *Crisis* can be considered as bearing the heritage of the debate on the method of science that characterized Neokantianism and found in Wilhelm Dilthey its original and eclectic interpreter.¹⁹

At the beginning of the 20th century, the debate focused on the relationship between philosophy and biology. The peculiar issues raised by the sciences of life inspire the work of the Cologne School of Philosophical Anthropology.²⁰ The philosophical-anthropological approach is characterized by the effort of setting up a fruitful dialogue between hermeneutics and phenomenology, considered as one of the main streams in the continental philosophy of the 20th century, and the questions and outcomes of contemporary biology. In his book from 1928²¹ Helmuth Plessner tackles the newest results of the evolutionary and

¹⁹ See: Dilthey, W. 1957. *Einleitung in die Geisteswissenschaften. Versuch einer Grundlegung für das Studium der Gesellschaft und der Geschichte*, GS I. Stuttgart-Göttingen: Teubner Verlagsgesellschaft.

²⁰ A well-informed and critical reconstruction of the development and inner relations of the German philosophical anthropology is provided in: Fischer, J. 2009. *Philosophische Anthropologie. Eine Denkrichtung des 20. Jahrhunderts*. Studienausgabe. Freiburg-München.

²¹ Hans-Ulrich Lessing inquires into the genetic relation between the famous essay that provoked the well-known controversy with Max Scheler and Martin Heidegger and ended up making Plessner one of the most relevant author of philosophical anthropology and his first book from 1923, *Die Einheit der Sinne*, dedicated to a critical account of sensation and to the consequent polemic against sensism. Lessing points out the necessity of a new philosophy of nature as deep root of Plessner's undertakings and highlights how both books are guided by the view of the inseparable intertwinement of spirit and nature. Despite the focus on the inner differentiation of

naturalistic theory, taking on the task of making sense of the biological theories that influenced his own medical education and provided the basis for his fruitful relation to Hans Driesch. Despite his admiration for and involvement in biological research, however, he has to recognize the attractive heuristic power of such refined accounts of reality is put in question by their own pretense of absolute-ness. By considering themselves as the unique and wholly coherent explanation of life and the world, natural sciences forget to give an account of the phenomenological level of reality. They are thus reduced to abstract schemas unable to shed light on the concrete "how" (*Wie*) of life-processes. Therefore, the insufficiency of the naturalistic view does not depend on the radical denial of all supernatural issues, which nevertheless strongly reduces its object field. According to Plessner, naturalism ignores and conceals the actual structure of everyday experience.

As a counterproposal, his intent is to develop a method that he defines as non-deductive, but critical, i.e. focused on the conditions of possibility of natural phenomena.²² With this remark, however, he does not mean to situate himself in the crowd of the Neokantian epistemological debate. He rather seeks a way to trace concepts and theories back to the preconditions of experience, to our way to be alive, to our life form. On this path, the human being appears neither as an object of science nor as a pure subject of consciousness, but rather as "subject-object" of his own life.²³ The reference to life as a dynamic dimension in which physical and intentional sense-related phenomena are necessarily intermingled justifies the paradoxical formulation of a subject-object-entity. As we will see, the constant switching from the subjective to the objective aspects of phenomena is a characteristic to take into account if life should be understood in its peculiarity as a concrete dimension.

However, before moving to this central point that will mark the distance between philosophical anthropology and naturalism, it is important to observe a similarity that still allows considering the comparison between the two philosophical approaches as meaningful.

The core of Plessner's analysis reveals namely the same central motivation of naturalism. In this respect both can be considered as alternative programs for the solution of quite similar issues. Like naturalism, Plessner's philosophical

the sense organs, Plessner's view of the relation between man and world is radically unitary and anti-dualistic also in his first analysis. This in a certain way supports the idea of the originality of his position, later exposed in the more explicit and questioned anthropologic book from 1928. Far from being the result of external influences, *Die Stufen des Organischen und der Mensch* (1928) rather provides a broader but contiguous account of the "hermeneutic philosophy of reality" already outlined in *Einheit der Sinne* (Lessing, H.-U. 1998. *Hermeneutik der Sinne. Eine Untersuchung zu Helmuth Plessners Projekt einer "Ästhesiologie des Geistes" mit einem Plessner-Ineditum*. Freiburg-München: Alber, 297–308).

²² Plessner, H. 1975. *Die Stufen des Organischen und der Mensch. Einleitung in die philosophische Anthropologie*. Berlin: Walter de Gruyter, XX.

²³ *Ibid.*, 31.

anthropology struggles against Cartesian dualism, but unlike the dominant forms of reductionist naturalism, the German philosopher does not react by denying reality and ontological consistency to non-material, supernatural entities. He does not try to identify an objective realm sealed by absolute validity and thus able to either reabsorb the whole of reality or dismiss the non-conforming elements. He takes on the burden of looking into the Cartesian distinction of *res cogitans* and *res extensa*, questioning it from the immanent point of view of experience. In this way he uncovers a revealing anthropological trait that will furthermore turn out to provide a heuristic key for the whole of reality. It is what Plessner calls “double aspectivity”²⁴ (*Doppelaspektivität*). With this notion he indicates the peculiar relationship each living entity has to its own “boundary”, to its own profile.

Characteristic of organic life is its organization in closed organisms, i.e. in entities that do not merely happen to have borders and to be distinguished from the surrounding medium. Organic entities live due to their distinction from and exchange with the surrounding environment. The quality and structure, the rhythm and direction, and the specificity of their life form depend on the modality of their closeness. The specific form of organic life depends on the kind of relation organisms entertain with respect to their own boundary.

A double and dynamic relation to their boundary characterizes human beings. This form of life can see itself from within and from outside. It can experience itself from the first and from the third person perspective. The ontological consistence of the human being lies in the living unity of the inner and the outer perspectives and its own vitality depends on the permanent shifting, on the permanent dynamic between these two configurations of experience.

Hence, Plessner’s approach does not isolate the first person perspective as an exception of nature, as an isolated quality that affects a peculiar kind of facts as an additional feature. The first person perspective rather represents an important variation within the continuous field of possible relations to the boundary characteristic of all organic forms of life. The human beings are not separated from the rest of the natural realm. Yet, this does not mean to disregard their specific characteristic. Plessner seems rather to proceed like the biologist who is interested in discovering the specific quality of each living being. By seeking the element that characterizes it as a new life form this kind of research does not imply the elaboration of a highly specific classification intended to cut out the discovered entity from the whole of nature.

The problem of Cartesianism does not consist in focusing on a difference, which is anyway hard to be ignored, since it is actually structuring the experience. The dualist mistake rather consists in substantializing such a qualitative difference, thus disregarding the authentic meaning of the duplicity that characterizes life. Such duplicity cannot be reduced to the separateness of two con-

²⁴ Ibid., 81.

fronting things (*res*) alien to one another and inert. The essence of the duplicity that distinguishes human life is rather the never-ending moving, the oscillation between two forms of the same totality and the contrast, the irreducible conflict, the instability, the displacement that transform the human adaptation to reality into a creative and unpredictable undertaking, even into an utopian challenge.²⁵

The human subject, able to identify itself with an "I", lives in contraposition. It lives in the permanent divergence of striving to distance itself from itself and at the same time striving to come back to itself, striving toward coincidence with itself. The kind of self-realization reserved to the subject is the paradoxical union of division (*Spaltung*) and of the revocation of this same division (*Aufhebung*).²⁶ It becomes clear that the immediacy of the subject, its adherence to itself and to the world, its communication with the environment and other living beings by means of its sense organs cannot be grounded on identity, but can rather only be characterized as the highest form of mediation.

Plessner seems to fulfill his promise. Instead of simply stating the privilege of subjectivity as bearer of a unique first person perspective, he looks into this same privilege trying to disclose the many forms of realization of this phenomenon, inquiring into its manifold "how," and describing its internal movement, rather than aiming for an abstract definition. Therefore, he explicitly avoids the equivalence between the "double aspectivity" and the "inside-outside" or "concave-convex" metaphors.²⁷ Such images presuppose, namely, spatiality as an existing dimension, while suggesting a substantial identity, an inert unity of separated, but finally identical sides of the object.

Furthermore, he requires caution even with regard to the idea of perspective. Coherently with the fact that life is not to be divided into separated subjective and objective dimensions, the use of the term "perspective" should not suggest the view of a universal subjectivism. His aim remains, in fact, a philosophy of nature, not the justification of an isolated and exceptional subject. For this reason, aspectivity is not considered as a special quality of humans, but rather as a universal heuristic principle useful for interpreting life.

Aspectivity inherits the world. Things are constantly given as surpassed by their own phenomenon, by their own appearance. The phenomenon, understood as the peculiar givenness of the thing, outreaches the thing itself. While things are always directly visible only from a determined point of view and each grasp of a spatial thing properly presents only an aspect of the whole thing, the phenomenal givenness of the thing presents it as a totality. The outreaching of the phenomenon over the thing regards the internal core as well as the multilateralism of the thing itself. This namely appears as provided both with an invisible

²⁵ The last paragraph of *Die Stufen* is dedicated to the utopian positionality. On the basis of this analysis Plessner provides an original account of religion and spirituality (see Plessner, H. 1975, op. cit., 341–348).

²⁶ Ibid., 48.

²⁷ See ibid., 80.

and yet co-functioning, real internal structure and with a manifold of not-actually visible layers (qualities of different kind, back, lateral, underneath parts), all contributing to its complete and meaningful givenness.

Plessner characterizes this inner relationship between visible and invisible components of the thing as a “trespassing structure”²⁸ (*Transgredienzverhältnis*) and points out once more that the moving relationship between the core of the thing and its changing aspects should not be understood as a spatial relationship. The “core” of the thing is not itself a thing; it is not “in” space. It rather seems to bear a *constitutive* meaning with regard to the space. It is the inner dynamic of living things that shapes the space as an experiential dimension.

Thanks to this last observation, a crucial meaning of aspectivity is revealed, together with its significance as characteristic of every form of organism. As the unsolved tension between self-coincidence and self-alienation, as the tension between the double inward-outward direction of givenness, aspectivity derives from the fact that every organism is an “absolute here,”²⁹ a modality of being in space that cannot be reduced to occupying a place, but rather founds the intuitive structure of space itself. This provides the crucial difference between physical objects and living things. Rather than being a possibility given in spatiality, the living organism represents the possibility of “spatialization,” of revealing space as a performing dimension.

Such a characteristic relation to oneself and to the surrounding space is what Plessner calls “positionality,” sketching it out as the decisive concept of his own approach to nature. Moreover, it seems to me that it is exactly this somehow opaque term that leads the transformation of his anthropological account into a comprehensive philosophy of nature. By discovering positionality as a universal feature of natural life, Plessner rejects the task—typically assumed by philosophical anthropological accounts of the early 20th century—of defining a special position of man in the cosmos.³⁰ The central core of his book of 1928 seems therefore not to be the well-known distinction between vegetal, animal and human forms of life. Its philosophical value lies rather in the previous, laborious methodological assessment that substantially contributes to Plessner’s originality in the horizon of philosophical anthropology.

²⁸ Ibid., 84.

²⁹ Ibid., 53.

³⁰ Volker Schürmann stresses the encompassing meaning of positionality defining it as “die kategoriale bzw. logische Dimension der Bestimmung der Lebendigkeit” (Schürmann, V. 1997. “Anthropologie als Naturphilosophie. Ein Vergleich zwischen Helmuth Plessner und Ernst Cassirer.” In: Rudolph, E., I. O. Stamatescu (Eds.). *Von der Philosophie zur Wissenschaft. Cassirers Dialog mit den Naturwissenschaften*. Hamburg: Meiner, 164). Furthermore, far from reducing Plessner’s account to an empirical interpretation of life based on biology, he considers anthropology as a transcendental undertaking *strictu sensu*. According to his view, anthropology should be considered as “Ort der spezifisch transzendental philosophischen Fragestellung, nämlich der Frage nach den Bedingungen der Möglichkeit von Erfahrung überhaupt” (Ibid., 135).

Furthermore, it is by means of this methodological reflection that he can also make a contribution to the debate on naturalism. By taking positionality not as an outstanding privilege of conscious subjects, but rather as a characteristic of the whole organic nature and as the basic difference between living beings and mere physical objects, he does not presuppose any fracture within reality, nevertheless stating the necessity of a differentiated heuristic principle to understand life—particularly conscious life. On the basis of a convinced anti-Cartesian position, Plessner does not understand aspectivity as a quality produced and smuggled into the world by an observing subject, opposed to inert objects. As result of the immanent positionality of living things, aspectivity cannot be reduced to appearance. It is rather a way of being. It is the mobile characteristic of “being an aspect.” It does not simply mean accidentally being partially visible, but structurally being partial, endorsing partiality as an ontological and differentiating characteristic of life. While mere physical things can only passively be seen from different perspectives since their inner structure is homogeneous and continuous, living things produce their own partiality. As indicated by the term “positionality,” the peculiar partiality of living beings is not a matter of perspective. It does not indicate their relative position within space. It rather arises from the relation to its own boundary. It is this relation, as the mobile essence of positionality and aspectivity and as the distinctive character of living nature, that produces the center of each single thing, or better that generates the living reality as a constitutionally centered reality. The alternative to the centerless reality of physicalist naturalism lies therefore not only in reaffirming first-person-perspective facts as an irreducible but delimited area of reality, but even in discovering the relation between the center and the boundary of every living thing as the heuristic principle of nature. As the boundary and the center thus become the proper way of realization of the thing, reality does no longer appear as a static puzzle of separated pieces, but as a dynamic landscape animated by an inner non-deterministic regularity.

Plessner dedicates a large part of his essay to differentiate the peculiar positionality of plants, animals and finally human beings. While plants present a relatively open form, which integrate them into the surrounding environment and can therefore be considered as a weak form of positionality, animals and human beings both belong to the same category of closed forms. This kind of positionality allows the role of the center in structuring the life form appear strongly. Animals are “put in themselves;”³¹ they coincide with themselves, while their sensibility transforms their boundary into a communicative surface wholly belonging to the living being and at the same time involved in a constant exchange with the environment. This double status of the organic boundary discloses it as a mediating element that fulfills the role of organizing the living being into a coherent and still developing totality.

³¹ Plessner, H. 1975, op. cit., 237.

While commentators mostly stress the exceptionality of human positionality—described by Plessner in terms of excentricity³²—which is characterized by a permanent instability, by a constant rearranging of experience and priorities, and the simultaneous urge to escape its own center and find its way back to it, it seems to me that the first result of his description consists in uncovering the deep commonality between humans and other animals. Although plants are not alien to a centered form of life, humans and animals are both characterized by the unifying function of their inner center. Even if their lives and behaviors are strongly interconnected with the surrounding world, they are not merely externally delimited. Therefore, instead of attributing the centering performance to the first-person-perspective, Plessner seems to deduce consciousness itself from the possibility of feeling the own centrality against the surrounding world.³³

Such continuity between human and non-human life does not make excentricity one of man's peculiar characteristics irrelevant. It rather helps make a last point that is going to shed light on the practical and ethical implications of Plessner's account.

4. CONCLUSIVE REMARKS: BECOMING A HUMAN IN THE CENTERED REALITY

Putting Plessner on the heels of Kant's transcendental revolution and Dilthey's historical interpretation of experience, Hans-Peter Krüger notices: "*eine Exzentrierung wird durch Rezentrierung lebbar*."³⁴ The excentric position of the human being—its never completed and never steady coincidence with itself that makes it restless and homeless and faces it with the challenge of creativity—cannot be understood as a static quality. The excentric positionality is rather the source of a permanent becoming. Its essence is movement and development. It can be experienced as a form of life only through the counter movement that leads back to the center of the living thing. The movement that

³² Jos de Mul gives a comprehensive account of the multiple aspects of Plessner's thoughts in: de Mul, J. (Ed.) 2014. *Plessner's Philosophical Anthropology. Perspectives and Prospects*. Amsterdam: Amsterdam University Press. In his introduction he discusses the different translations of the German term "Exzentrizität," finally opting for the standard spelling "eccentricity" and thus conforming to the previously published translations of Plessner's works, such as: *Laughing and Crying: A Study of the Limits of Human Behaviour* [*Lachen und Weinen. Eine Untersuchung der Grenzen menschlichen Verhaltens*, 1941] (Plessner, H. 1970) (de Mul, J. 2014. *Artificial by Nature. An Introduction to Plessner's Philosophical Anthropology*. In: idem. 2014, op. cit., 11–12). On the contrary, it seems necessary to me to maintain a spelling closer to the original word in order to underline the non-dismissive meaning of Plessner's term.

³³ See Plessner, H. 1975, op. cit., 67.

³⁴ Krüger, H.-P. 2012. "De-Zentrierungen und Ex-Zentrierungen. Die quasi-transzendentalen Unternehmungen von Heidegger und Plessner heute." In: *Dezentrierungen. Zur Konfrontation von philosophischer Anthropologie, Strukturalismus und Poststrukturalismus*. Ebke, T., M. Schloßberger (Eds.). Berlin: Akademie Verlag, 29.

restores the coincidence of the thing with itself allows at the same time the manifestation of the distance. Excentricity is therefore less of a substantial mark-up of the human being and more of a distinctive expression of the all-encompassing stream of life, which properly not simply "is," but rather constantly becomes. As Plessner observes, "process is neither simply a coming into being, nor a new determination, optional and external, of the entity; it rather operates as authentic property of the thing and therefore stays within the essential borders of the thing."³⁵ The constant process of becoming itself is, hence, the modality of being of every positional thing.

The human being's excentric form of life provides the best example of this phenomenon. However, the recognition of the "centered quality" of reality allows putting the human being's excentric position in a frame that encompasses the whole of nature. Thus, the facts characterized by a first-person-perspective quality do not stand out as a peculiar realm of events, to make sense of which is necessary to break the rules of nature as they are sanctioned by naturalism. It rather acquires ontological consistency the claim that appears to Plessner himself as an "absolute antinomy": the task of the human being consists in becoming that, what it already is.³⁶ To be a human is no more a fact, not even a peculiar fact that requires a special epistemological treatment. It is rather a charge, the assignment to discover anew the center that anyone already is, to realize one's own center by developing a distance to one's own immediate identity, to develop one's own individual first-person-perspective on the world rather than taking it for granted, to reflect and recognize one's own individual place in the world rather than abstractly stating a peculiar position of the human species within nature. In this way, Plessner can grasp Dilthey's suggestion, even within the new frame elaborated by philosophical anthropology in dialogue with contemporary biology. Human excentricity makes us historical entities. The characteristic first person perspective is not an epistemological particularity that can be isolated from the comprehensive form of life. This determines our way of experiencing space and time not as geometrical quantities, but rather as the value-laden, perspectival, always partial but meaningful dimension that can never be fully exhausted and controlled, but rather requires a permanent effort of separation and renewed coincidence.

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³⁵ Plessner, H. 1975, op. cit., 135–136.

³⁶ Ibid., 310.

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR — PhD, Assistant Professor of Moral Philosophy at the University of Palermo, Department of Humanities, Viale delle Scienze – Edificio 12, 90128 Palermo, Italy (affiliation). She collaborates with the international research group *Phänomenologie und Wissenschaft* (Cologne). Main research topics: Husserlian phenomenology, phenomenological theories of subjectivity and intersubjectivity, philosophical anthropology, ethics. Main publications: 2009. *Unicità e relazione*. Mimesis; 2014. *Il movente dell'esperienza. Costituzione, pulsione ed etica in Edmund Husserl*. Mimesis.

E-mail: alice.pugliese@unipa.it

Flávio Vieira Curvello

FRANZ BRENTANO'S MEREOLGY AND THE PRINCIPLES OF DESCRIPTIVE PSYCHOLOGY

ABSTRACT

I analyse Brentano's argumentative strategy from his lectures in the *Deskriptive Psychologie* and how he introduces and reframes his fundamental psychological theses. His approach provides us with the reasons why psychology can be distinguished into different domains of investigation and how the tasks of one of these domains—the descriptive-psychological one—imply a specific understanding about the structure of consciousness. Thereby a mereology of consciousness is developed, which offers the theoretical background to the aforementioned reframing of the Brentanian theses.

Keywords: mereology, unity of consciousness, inner perception, descriptive psychology, genetic psychology, epistemology of psychology.

In this paper I analyse Brentano's argumentative strategy applied in his lectures in *Deskriptive Psychologie*,¹ delivered in 1890–1891 at the University of Vienna, and consider how it leads to a new way of introducing and reframing his fundamental psychological theses. A comparative examination of these lectures and Brentano's most influential work, *Psychologie vom empirischen Standpunkt*,² reveals a striking difference of their argumentative procedures. Whereas the latter is characterised by a strong dialogical approach with clear Aristotelian overtones, the former exposes the logical relations between the analysed concepts and paves the way for each further step of the investigation in the course by following a precise order of reasons.

Brentano's procedure in PES consists of a constant interlocution with a philosophical, psychological scenario, so that both the investigated themes and the

¹ Henceforth DP.

² Henceforth PES.

ways of methodically dealing with them are deeply influenced by the manner through which such a dialogue is conducted.³ Consequently we often find concepts that play a role in earlier discussions of the work, but whose systematic exploration can only be found later in the text.⁴ The necessity to deal with preliminary descriptions of themes that are still to be correctly substantiated neither prevents the comprehension of the arguments in which they occur nor indicates a flaw of Brentano's approach. Rather, it points to a peculiarity of such an approach, which admits of a certain zig-zag.

That is what the lectures set aside in favour of a new procedure that shows directly the theoretical unity between the introduced theses. The argumentation is structured so that the relations between the postulated concepts and theories are clear and constitute the very criterion for why the sequence of investigated problems is ordered as it is. The most important distinguishing point is then that Brentano does not follow an order of themes introduced by a constant dialogue with a tradition. Instead, he follows the theoretical implications and logical demands of the introduced theses so that his argumentation is guided by intrinsically rational criteria, ascribing a secondary role to the critique of other approaches to the problems he addresses.

A brief glimpse at the structure of DP should suffice to elucidate the aforementioned difference. Brentano's argumentation comprises: (i) a definition of psychology and its essential tasks, which leads to the partition of its unity into the fields of descriptive and genetic psychology; (ii) the definition of the tasks of both fields and an emphasis on the tasks of descriptive psychology; (iii) the demonstration that these tasks imply an insight into the essential structure of consciousness; (iv) the development of a theory of such structure, which would offer the theoretical basis for psychology. The orderly sequence of steps and their clear hierarchy provide us with a strong and unified way of introducing psychology, its methodological possibilities and fundamental concepts.

This paper intends, therefore, to analyse how this new approach consists not merely in an alternative way of reintroducing the same theses of PES, but further contains a strategy that has conceptual consequences, stressing theoretical concerns of the later developments of Brentano's thought, which were not yet present in that book. For this purpose I will offer an interpretation of the main arguments of the lectures and show how their approach to the structure of con-

³ cf. Albertazzi, L., M. Libardi, R. Poli. 1996. "Introduction. Brentano and his School: Reassembling the Puzzle." In: *The School of Franz Brentano*. Albertazzi, L., M. Libardi, R. Poli (Eds.). Dordrecht: Springer, 10–12.

⁴ Examples of this may be found in Brentano, F. 1874. *Psychologie vom empirischen Standpunkte*. Leipzig: Duncker & Humblot (henceforth quoted as PES with indication of the respective book, chapter, paragraph and page). One of the examples is the case of inner perception, introduced in PES I.1, §1, partially analysed in I.1, §2 and I.2, §2, but only examined in depth in II.2, §8. Another one is the case of the unity of consciousness, briefly explained in II.1, §8, but rigorously explored in II.4, §2.

sciousness plays an essential role in the introduction of the fundamental psychological concepts into a different philosophical framework. So, the above considered overview of the main moments of the argumentation of DP serves also as an overview of the different parts of this paper.

1. THE DEFINITION OF PSYCHOLOGY AND ITS MAIN METHODOLOGICAL RESOURCE

In DP Brentano defines psychology as the science of human soul's life (*Seelenleben des Menschen*), i.e. the science of that specific part of human life, that can be apprehended and known through acts of inner perception.⁵ Even though his argumentation does not evolve into any critical examination of a concept that is so important for his method, we can take a look at PES to arrive at a clear conceptualization. In its First Book inner perception is defined as a spontaneous activity of self-apprehension carried out by consciousness whenever it performs its proper function of directing itself toward an object. Brentano clarifies such activity through its contrast with the idea of inner observation, which was frequently vindicated by experimental psychologists back then. Strictly speaking an observation can only take place when the observer concerns itself with objects of outer perception, i.e. of sensible perception that relates to physical phenomena.⁶ In this context, the examination of such objects is led by attention, which directs itself to the objective properties with an analytical interest. It throws different properties into relief, varies the perspectives out of which they may be considered and assures, by means of a direct manipulation of the ways through which the object is given, a more comprehensive knowledge of it.

Such an accuracy of attention is nevertheless impossible when the examined objects are the conscious processes themselves. The relationship of exteriority to be found in the first case—in which the given and the related cognitive activity are not parts of the same sphere—is not preserved in this second case. Whenever attention is directed toward psychic phenomena, their nature is immediately corrupted or even destroyed. This can be exemplified through a simple mental experiment which focuses on the observation of someone's own experience of rage. If a subject attempts to examine the rage he himself feels, this rage becomes increasingly fainter, up to a point in which it can completely disappear. It is therefore clear that this feeling cannot be turned into such an object of observation that would preserve the same features it actually has when it occurs

⁵ Brentano, F. 1982. *Deskriptive Psychologie*. Hamburg: Felix Meiner, I.1, §1, 1 (henceforth quoted as DP with indication of the respective section, subsection, paragraph and page).

⁶ The physical phenomena comprise all sensible data we can experience through outer perception or phantasy, from discrete sensations to complex sensible formations. (PES II.1, §2, 104).

under natural conditions, i.e. when one is enraged. That is why Brentano states that it is a universal psychological law that we are unable to direct our attention to objects of inner perception—a claim that already confronts the thesis that psychology should be a science of observations.

According to Brentano, inner perception can only be understood when we direct our attention toward the objects that are related to by consciousness in its natural activities—i.e. when it engages in acts of presentation, judgement, phantasy etc.—as opposed to events that take place in consciousness. Whenever we proceed this way, the descriptive examination of consciousness shows that we are not only conscious of the objects implied by such basic activities, but also of the psychic processes that relate to them, which are also brought to a certain perceptual activity. Whenever we have a sensible perception of any extended object whatsoever, we have an incidental consciousness that such a specific experience takes place, that we live now in the perception of such an object. Whenever we judge, we apprehend in the same way that our consciousness performs a judicative achievement through which we take a specific stand on a given state of affairs. In general, whenever we have consciousness of something we have simultaneously and without effort a collateral consciousness which informs us about what we actually experience. To live in the achievement of an act is, thus, by definition, to have an immediate awareness that such an achievement takes place. Brentano then concludes that the observation in its proper context—i.e. the consideration of physical phenomena—enables us to acquire knowledge not just of nature itself, but also of psychic occurrences, since the experience of external objects and states of affairs furnishes points of reference to the acquisition of the latter kind of knowledge.⁷

Inner perception is then an unprompted, direct turn of consciousness to itself while it relates to the main objects of its activities—the perceived in the case of perception, the affirmed or the denied in the case of judgement, etc. The epistemic value of inner perception is quite unlike that of outer perception, which does not provide us with a sharp knowledge of its objects, whose modes of apparition are characterised through the obscurity that is common to sensibility.⁸ Inner perception provides us rather with absolute certainty concerning the existence and the distinctive character of its data, which appear through the clearest evidence rendered possible by immediate intuition. To experience the conscious processes themselves consists in dealing with data given in an entirely reliable way to the subject, since experiencing something and doubting that this something was experienced precisely in the way it was is inconsistent and devoid of sense. In other words, it would not be possible to experience

⁷ PES I.2, §2, 35–36.

⁸ To physical phenomena can be ascribed only a phenomenal existence and no actual one. We can rarely know something that exceeds our own capacities of being affected (PES II.1, §7, 120–122), with the exception of some analogies between sensible data and real properties of things, e.g. the size and the figure of spatial apparitions (I.1, §3, 24).

something without an immediate acceptance that *this* specific experience is actual, lived through, and characterised by radical subjective evidence. The phenomena of inner perception are therefore true in themselves and perceived as they really are.⁹

A further clarification of inner perception, as well as the introduction of a specific terminology to it, are offered by the Second Book of PES, in the description of acoustic perception. As already evinced by the explanations above, whenever we listen to a tone, we are conscious both of the listened tone and of the fact that we listen to it, which means that the psychic phenomena comprehends *two presentations*. One of them directs itself to a physical phenomenon, assuming it as the fundamental object of its activity. This object is the listened tone, and Brentano calls it the primary object. A second presentation directs itself to the activity that renders the first presentation possible, assuming it as its object. In so doing, the second presentation relates not to a physical phenomenon, but to a psychical one, i.e. the act of presentation of the tone. This defines, according to Brentano, a secondary object of experience. The main aspect of such duplicity is that the presence of two objects in the frame of experience does not imply two different acts that relate to them in a point-to-point correspondence. What is at stake here is *one sole activity* that encompasses *two distinct moments*, two achievements of consciousness that turn themselves to specific components of it. Instead of a second full-fledged act, inner perception is a property of the act that already characterises the psychic phenomenon.¹⁰ Further inquiries into the structure of inner perception show that it comprises not just a presentation of the act in its relation to a primary object, but also a cognition of that act, in which its real existence is known in the already mentioned evident way, and a feeling of it, in which it is experienced as causing pleasure or aversion.¹¹ Despite the overall significance of such theses to the general framework of Brentano's thought, a deeper view on them does not match the interests of this paper. The basic features of inner perception and the reasons why it is the main methodological resource of psychology were already clarified so far.

⁹ PES I.1, §2, 10–12. Dewalque, E. 2013. "Brentano and the Parts of the Mental. A Mereological Approach to Phenomenal Intentionality." *Phenomenology and the Cognitive Sciences*, 12, 452; Soldati, G. 2005. "Brentano on Inner Perception, Intrinsic Truth and Evidence." In: *Experience and Analysis. The Proceedings of the 27th International Wittgenstein Symposium*. Reicher, M. E., J. C. Marek (Eds.). Vienna: ÖBV & HPT, 67.

¹⁰ PES II.2, §8, 167. Dewalque, E. 2013, op. cit., 450. Huemer, W. 2015. "Franz Brentano." In: *The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*. Zalta, E. N. (Ed.). <http://plato.stanford.edu/archives/fall2015/entries/brentano/>; Soldati, G. 2005, op. cit., 65.

¹¹ PES II.3, §7, 202–203.

2. THE DISTINCTION BETWEEN GENETIC AND DESCRIPTIVE PSYCHOLOGY

With the aforementioned explanations in mind, we can come back to the argumentation of DP itself. As soon as Brentano provides us with his definition of psychology and mentions the relevance of inner perception to its practice, he points out that the unity of such discipline can be distinguished into two fundamental domains: *psychognosis* or *descriptive psychology* and *genetic psychology*. It is already well known that the distinction between problems that may be understood and solved just on descriptive grounds and problems that demand experimental consideration is by no means a novelty of DP. Such distinction is already approached in PES¹², even though its systematic treatment and its elevation to a distinguishing criterion between psychological domains occur later.¹³ The first domain, descriptive psychology, is the one that interests Brentano in particular and occupies him throughout his argumentation in the lectures. The second one, genetic psychology, concerns the experimental unfoldings of the referred science and serves as a counterpoint to the characterisation both of the methodological procedures and theoretical priority of the first domain.

A genetic psychology therefore aims at a *causal* consideration of conscious life by means of a clarification of the preconditions upon which all apparitions depend. Such preconditions consist in physiological or physical-chemical events, which take place in the human body and lay the basis for the occurrence, cessation or possible transformations of psychic life, defining their immediate, real causes.¹⁴ Such a psychology is thus distinctively psychophysical or physiological, since it does not examine the psychic processes from an absolute standpoint. Rather, it subordinates such an examination to a series of other investigations which, due to their interest in identifying causal connections, lead to a veritable explanation of the apparition. According to Brentano, this implies not only an *impure*, mediate approach to the psychic life, but also an inevitable *inexactness* of the laws it postulates, which consist in merely inductive generalisations of experience and can be described just through propositions that imply observations on the frequency and objective preconditions of its validity. These are empirical laws and, as such, they cannot assume categorical, principal validity, always including exceptions.¹⁵ The psychophysical correspondence between a frequency which stimulates the eye and the elicited impression of colour are

¹² PES I.3, §2; 55–56; §4; 58–59.

¹³ Dewalque, E. 2013, op. cit., 452; Kraus, O. 1919. *Franz Brentano. Zur Kenntnis seines Lebens und seiner Lehre*. München: C.H. Beck. 21; Marek, J. C. 1988. “Psychognosie — Geognosie. Apriorisches und Empirisches in der deskriptiven Psychologie Brentanos.” *Brentano-Studien*, 2, 58; Mulligan, K. 2004. “Brentano on the Mind.” In: *The Cambridge Companion to Brentano*. Jacquette, D. (Ed.). Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 67.

¹⁴ DP I.1, §§1–2, 4, 5.

¹⁵ DP I.1, §§ 9, 10, 12, 13, 15; 3–4.

an example. Even though there may be a constancy in the relationship between the stimulus and the psychic response, there are concrete circumstances in which this regularity is no longer valid, such as colour-blindness, severance of the optical nerve, negative hallucinations, etc.¹⁶

Such features of the study undertaken by genetic psychology serve as counterpoint to the consideration of descriptive psychology, since the latter has different tasks and achieves sounder results with respect to the purity and exactness of its theses.¹⁷ Descriptive psychology aims at delimiting: (i) the elements or fundamental component parts of human consciousness, to which the totality of apparitions that we may experience can be reduced and (ii) the different modes of connection through which they assemble and constitute complex phenomenal unities. Its purpose is therefore to obtain a general concept of consciousness without taking non-psychic events into account, to which such a sphere may be connected in its real foundations.¹⁸ Such an inquiry does not relate consciousness to what exceeds its frame, considering positively no extra-conscious facts, neither in the conduction of its own analysis, nor in the content of the propositions that it substantiates. And precisely these features point out the reasons why Brentano states that descriptive psychology is the only distinctively *pure* psychological domain.¹⁹ Furthermore, it deals with psychic facts exclusively through inner perception, without taking into account empirical facts which offer the basis for inductive generalisations and result in circumstantially valid and falsifiable knowledge. Such a feature points out why descriptive psychology is characterised by an *exactness* that is fundamentally unattainable for genetic psychology. The already considered epistemic privilege of inner perception allows us to understand the theoretical reasons for Brentano's ambition to render descriptive psychology into an exact science, to be placed side by side with formal disciplines such as mathematics. Its propositions have precisely the character of categorical validity that exclude modulations either of frequency or dependence upon extra-conscious factors.²⁰

3. ARGUMENTS IN FAVOUR OF THE UNITY OF CONSCIOUSNESS

The fundamental features of descriptive psychology are so far exposed. In strict accordance with them, Brentano introduces the first theoretical contribution provided by such a domain: the defence of the *unity* of conscious-

¹⁶ DP I.1, §18; 4–5.

¹⁷ DP I.1, §§2,3; 1.

¹⁸ DP I.1, §§1,5; 1–2.

¹⁹ DP I.1, §§2,8; 1–2.

²⁰ DP I.1, §§9,10,12–14; 3–4. Melle, U. 1984. "Die Seins- und Erkenntnisfrage in der Philosophie Brentanos." *Tijdschrift voor Filosofie*, 46 (3), 424.

ness, which is not to be confused with its possible *simplicity*.²¹ The introduction of such a problem is directly linked with the basic task of descriptive psychology: since it investigates both the elements of consciousness and their modes of connection, it becomes clear that it conceives consciousness as a *plurality of parts*, i.e. as a complex whole constituted by the organisation of more fundamental components.²² Brentano's understanding of such thesis confronts the classic metaphysical doctrine according to which the soul should be characterised by both aforementioned attributes—its unity implying its simplicity. The point of distinction is already clear, since Brentano defends the disjunction of the two attributes and the analysis of the unity of the consciousness, without admission of its simplicity. However he does not agree with some well-known attempts at refuting the same metaphysical doctrine, such as the one introduced by David Hume. On the contrary, he develops his own positive thesis by means of a dialectical examination of Hume's ideas.

According to Hume, whenever we commit ourselves to an inquiry into the genuine character of our experience, the affirmation both of the unity and simplicity of consciousness would be fiercely contradicted by our immediate apprehension of it. The data of experience would rather consist in an intense, fast flux of presentations essentially detached from each other, and in continuous movement, which may eventually connect only in virtue of incidental factors, extrinsic to the presentations themselves. These factors are Hume's well-known principles of association—resemblance, contiguity in time and space and causation—according to which the structuration of the apparition is fundamentally arbitrary. They consist of nothing other than the very theoretical foundations for Hume's so-called *bundle theory*.²³ Brentano's disagreements with such a description of consciousness are grave and aim at refuting its main assumptions, which would be characterised by descriptive mistakes. Three out of these assumptions must be here addressed since they point out Brentano's reasons to defend the unity of consciousness.

(i) The first one is that consciousness does not basically consist of presentations. According to the classification of psychic phenomena introduced by PES, the acts of consciousness can be divided into acts of presentation and acts that acquire their foundation through acts of presentation, like judgements or phenomena of love and hate. These latter acts presuppose presentations, since they must refer to an appearing content, but have their essential features precisely in the ways they turn them into other phenomena—either the statement of validity or invalidity of certain state of affairs, or an affective commotion whatsoever.²⁴ Thus, if we consider that the mere appearing of contents is the fundamental

²¹ The problem is also introduced in PES II.1, §8; 125–126, but rigorously analysed only in II.4, §2; 206–213.

²² DP I.2.A, §§1,4; 10. Dewalque, E. 2013, op. cit., 458.

²³ DP I.2.A, §5; 10–11.

²⁴ PES II.1, §3; 104–106.

mark of consciousness, despite the various ways through which they aggregate and disaggregate with each other, we actually overlook that some psychic activities consist essentially in their modification and the production of something other than presentations—of phenomenal data which must necessarily be described in another way.

(ii) The second aspect of Brentano's critique points out that the usage of the term "bundle" of conscious data is misleading. It implies the idea of a factor of juxtaposition, of something that "ties" the conscious data together and should be as easily identifiable in experience as the contents it comprehends. Nevertheless it is an immediate descriptive fact that our experience does not contain any moment that can be understood in such a way. No aspect of it can show us directly that its contents can appear only in virtue of some factor that sets them into relation with each other, a factor that should, on its turn, also appear along with the contents it rules. Even if the term "bundle" were understood in a broader sense denoting that the experienced should consist of a plurality of contiguous data that present themselves together and remain next to each other, it would still not be suitable. Such an understanding of apparitions is not substantiated by the way we experience them, and is thus ultimately counter-intuitive.

(iii) A third and central aspect of the critique refers to the assumption that characterises experience as a plurality of disconnected data. Brentano states that such an assumption overlooks the fact that experience is always given as a unity, as an orderly whole that comprehends all that concerns human consciousness in a certain moment of its unfolding. Brentano's argument against such dissolution of consciousness into parts independent from each other is guided by the Aristotelian principle according to which it is impossible for a thing to be concurrently something real in itself (*ein Reale*) and something whose component parts have such a character of reality, i.e. a group or collective of real things (*ein Kollektiv von Realen*). If reality is ascribed to the thing in its totality, it cannot be at the same time ascribed to a number of components which constitute such a thing, as if they would be the ultimately real subjects and the thing merely a subsequent datum, an aggregate devoid of any proper integrity. Being real is therefore something that pertains only to one of the two instances of such a relationship which is marked by a clear categorial difference: either to the original whole, which can be analysed into components that necessarily depend upon the primitive context of its apparition, or to a certain group of dispersed data, which constitute a whole only if they are set into relation.²⁵ If the Humean perspective is understood through such a principle, it becomes clear that reality must be ascribed to those simple representational data and that the collective rendered possible by them is something with no proper character of reality. Brentano's interest, however, is to show that the descriptive examination of

²⁵ The Aristotelian distinction is also addressed in PES II.4, §1, 204–206.

consciousness demands the opposite point of view, which ascribes reality rather to consciousness itself than to its possible components.

Whenever we perceive a coloured object, we have a sensible presentation of its colours. It is not possible to say that these colours, considered in their individuality, are real, autonomous data merely juxtaposed when they are presented by us through a psychic achievement of ours. If it would be so, they would have to *appear* as individual things that would not be essentially related to each other and could therefore be considered to exist on their own. In order to recognise such an autonomy, we would have to accept that the most fundamental psychic activities through which those individual data appear are also a multiplicity of discrete activities, each one directed to one appearing content. However, this is not what inner experience shows. The presentation of each colour in its individuality results from one unitary, widespread activity of consciousness and not from a number of isolated activities, each one relating to an individual appearing property. Thus, rather than a dispersion, we descriptively find a unity. The same applies to perceptual activities of different senses which can be simultaneously experienced, like the visual and acoustic ones, or to the relationship between different acts that relate to the same object, like the presentation of a thing and a judgement about the same thing. The conscious activities in these circumstances may be distinguished from each other—the perception comprehends the moments of seeing and listening; the judicative experience comprehends the moments of presenting an object and accepting or refuting an assertion about it. Nevertheless they pertain to the same real unity that encompasses the whole of present consciousness. It is clear then that consciousness cannot be fasciculated into activities that do not relate at all to each other and consequently thematize in an absolute manner the objectivity to which they direct themselves. It rather consists of a unified reality that comprises a variety of different moments.²⁶

4. A MEREOLOGY OF CONSCIOUSNESS

The investigation of consciousness must then pursue the most general aim of comprehending such a complexity—i.e. how the whole of consciousness must be described in its specific relations to its constitutive parts. What is at stake here is a radical theoretical preponderance of the investigation of the part-whole structure of consciousness, which illustrates the central role of mereology for the development of Brentanian psychology in DP. Brentano's steps in the introduction of the basic concepts of his psychology coincide with the steps through

²⁶ DP I.2.A, §6; 10–12. Dewalque, E. 2013, op. cit., 457–458. Mulligan, K. 2004, op. cit., 86–87; Smith, B. 1988. “The Soul and Its Parts. A Study in Aristotle and Brentano.” *Brentano-Studien*, 1, 82–86.

which he clarifies the different parts of consciousness and how they relate to each other.

The examination of such a structure first shows that some of its parts can be detached from each other and dealt with as if they were parts of a spatial continuum, although these are not the actual conditions of their appearing. If an extended body is divided into parts, these parts may still subsist as independent things, even if they are nothing but pieces of an original whole. The fact that they were detached from this whole does not lead to their dissolution and they become new individual wholes themselves. With consciousness such an operation is also possible: the parts that originally pertained to the same real unity of experience can subsist in abstraction from such a unity without a connection to those parts to which they were previously connected.

Two main criteria for divisibility are introduced by Brentano. The first one is the *bilateral* or *real divisibility*, which assures the possibility of detaching originally connected parts and preserving them as consistent data after such detachment. An example of this is the relationship between seeing and listening. Outer perception may comprise simultaneous visual and acoustic experiences, but both can be detached from each other without a modification of their descriptive content. The second criterion is the *unilateral divisibility*, which assures the possibility of detaching only one part of its original whole and having it as a consistent datum, since the other ones with which it was given depend upon the relationship to subsist. Examples of this are the relationship between representing and desiring and between a conclusion and its premise. The activity of representing can be abstracted from that of desiring, but the contrary is not possible, since desiring implies reference to a desired content. Likewise a premise can be thought without a following conclusion, but the conclusion does not have this autonomy, since it can only be considered as such in relation to premises. Without connections to other propositions to assure its status as a conclusion, it is only a proposition without argumentative character. These parts are called *separable parts*.²⁷

This abstractive procedure may nevertheless be successively applied, so that within the abstracted parts themselves still other parts may be identified. At the limits of such operation there can be obtained those ultimate parts that cannot be divided any further and characterise the *elements* of consciousness. Once such final separable parts are obtained, it is still possible to conduct the analysis further—not in terms of real separability any longer, but rather in terms of mere distinction. The parts that can be obtained in this way are called *distinctional parts* and characterise those components of the actually irreducible data that can be described in an absolute way without detaching from their original wholes and being presented as autonomous data.

²⁷ DP I.2.B, §§3,6; 13.

From these two fundamental concepts it is precisely the distinctional part that plays a decisive role in the postulation of the basic concepts of descriptive psychology. Such parts can be described as two fundamental classes: the distinctional parts in a *proper sense* and those in a *modified sense*. Since the second class does not refer to basic psychological concepts, only the first one must be addressed here. It comprises four kinds of parts:

(i) The first are *mutually interpenetrating parts* that consist in those parts of a whole that have a necessary relation to each other led by specific unalterable patterns. If they happen to be altered, the preconditions of the constitution of the whole would no longer be satisfied. The examination of the act that instantiates, for example, the judgement “There is a truth” shows that it comprehends as essential parts: (a) an affirmative quality, which makes the judgement the assertion of a state of affairs; (b) the relatedness of the act to the object *truth*, which is the correlate about which something is affirmed; (c) the character of evidence, which shows it to be immediately recognisable in its validity; (d) and the apodictic modality, which shows such validity to be necessary. These moments constitute the referred act and cannot be abstracted from it without leading to its dissolution. How then could it be possible to understand such a judgement as an affirmative, evident and apodictic one and take its object to be any other than the truth? How then could someone accept its affirmative character and its directedness to the object truth, but not recognise its evidence and apodicticity, assured by the simple fact that deeming the proposition to be false would lead to the nonsensical conclusion that it would be true that there is no truth? Without comprising all four traits mentioned above such an act is unconceivable.²⁸

(ii) The second are *logical parts* that express the necessary relation of a conscious datum to the species that comprehends it. Even though the species is clearly more eminent than the data whose nature and possible manifestations it defines, it is the instance of the species that can be found as a logical part of the respective datum. Therefore such parts can be defined as those general traits graspable in the concrete data which they essentially structure—i.e. that which make such data what they are. An example is the relation between an affirmation and its judicative character, since the affirmation of something consists in nothing other than a specific mode of an act of judgement. The general properties of every judicative activity would be identifiable in the particular act instantiated by an affirmation.²⁹

(iii) The third are the *parts of the intentional pair of correlates*. PES already shows it to be the most essential trait of psychic phenomena—the first positive distinguishing criterion between them and the physical phenomena³⁰ and the

²⁸ DP I.2.D.1, §§1, 2; 20.

²⁹ DP I.2.D.2, §§1–2; 20–21; Mulligan, K., B. Smith. 1985. “Franz Brentano on the Ontology of Mind.” *Philosophy and Phenomenological Research*, 45 (4), 635–636.

³⁰ PES II.1, §5; 115–116.

trait that more clearly discloses the nature of conscious activities.³¹ It is the mark of the mental, whose obvious historical and systematical influence will not be considered here. According to Brentano, it is a general property of consciousness that it always exhibits a relation that comprises a subject and an object. Such a relation can be found in each of its separable parts, like the experiences of seeing, listening, judging and desiring. Its character of intending an objectivity—i.e. directing itself toward it—is summarized by its designation as an *intentional relation*, which assumes, on the one hand, the psychic act as one of its correlates and, on the other, that to which the act directs itself. The relationships between seeing and that which is seen, presenting and that which is presented, wanting and that which is wanted, etc., serve as examples of the thesis. Whereas the first correlate, the act itself, is considered real due to its evident accessibility through inner perception, the second one, the related object, is not real. It must be rather understood as a merely immanent datum that has an objective character and to which no formal reality independent of consciousness must be ascribed in order to render its psychological consistency understandable. The object is therefore something to which consciousness directs itself and which can be analytically found in the constitutive structure of the psychic phenomenon—a descriptive unity that “inhabits” (*einwohnt*) experience. The emphasis on its unity shows that the pair of correlates are not separable parts, but are rather distinctional ones.³²

(iv) The fourth are the *primary and secondary psychic relations* which also play an essential role in the conceptual determination of Brentanian psychology. They designate the already known duplicity of reference of the psychic act, which relates not just to its primordial content, but also incidentally to itself. The explicit character of unity of such relation renders both achievements into moments of one psychic activity and not into discrete full-fledged acts operating together. Consequently, the same constraints to abstraction mentioned in the case of intentional relation hold true in the case of primary and secondary psychic relations. They can be an object of distinction but not of real separation since they imply each other and constitute a descriptive whole. This essential trait of psychic phenomena renders inner perception possible—it clarifies the concrete mental foundations of the main methodological resource of Brentanian psychology.

5. CONCLUDING REMARKS

Brentano's argumentation has its further developments in considering the distinctional parts in a modified sense and providing us with an approach to the descriptive method in all its phases. The problem upon which this paper focuses

³¹ PES II.1, §9; 127.

³² DP I.2.D3, §§1–3; 21–22.

demands however no examination of such passages. The progression of Brentano's thought is clear. He arranges the different psychological tasks into the domains of descriptive and genetic psychology and explains their peculiarities through the same criteria—exactness and purity. The nature of each task leads to epistemic discrepancies in the form of different ways of accessing psychic phenomena and different criteria for the substantiation of laws and theories. The crucial point of his argumentation is the demonstration that the task of descriptive psychology *implies* a definite concept of consciousness. Its attention to elements and modes of connection shows that the analysed object must be a plurality of parts whose systematic comprehension constitute the fundamental aim of such a psychology. This understanding first demands an analysis of *what is really meant by a plurality of parts*. Brentano refutes, on the one hand, ascribing primacy to the parts and taking the unity of consciousness to be a latecomer, dependent upon synthetic processes that set the parts into relation. On the other hand, he shows that—seen through purely intuitive motives—consciousness must be considered in the opposite way and primacy must be ascribed to its unity, upon which all its possible parts depend. Only after such a clarification of the meaning of the part-whole structure of consciousness, the objective of descriptive psychology to identify elements and modes of connection can be pursued. Brentano's procedure consists then in drawing a concept of consciousness from the very task of descriptive psychology and showing that the clarification of its meaning is a precondition to the rigorous fulfilment of the task. Such a fulfilment is nothing other than the development of a mereology of consciousness.

The most important conceptual contributions of such an approach are linked with its ontological interests.³³ The specification of the constitutive moments of consciousness are not only an attempt to depict the topology of its processes and to show its necessary constraints—i.e., to describe phenomenal structures that always can be grasped as actual traits of our experiences, whenever we proceed to their intuitive examination. Instead of assuming a merely psychological validity, they reach out further and appear as constitutive features of consciousness itself, as parts of its real consistency and fundamental traits of its being. Brentano's argumentative strategy in the lectures shows how elementary the mereological approach is and how basic psychological concepts, such as the intentional and the primary and secondary psychic relations, depend directly upon it. The most essential feature of the psychic phenomena and the very activity of inner perception figure here as *mereological categories*, as parts of the general framework of consciousness. In PES these concepts are introduced before the problem of the unity of consciousness is addressed because they follow the aforementioned dialogical agenda and figure as important, but punctual

³³ Albertazzi, L. 2006. *Immanent Realism. An Introduction to Brentano*. Dodrecht: Springer. 127; Mulligan, K.j, B. Smith, 1985, op. cit., 627; Smith, B. 1988, op. cit., 86. Smith, B. 1992–1993. "The Soul and Its Parts II. Varieties of Inexistence." *Brentano-Studien*, 4, 37.

aspects of more comprehensive contexts of discussion. Their theoretical importance is then not accompanied by their explicit ontological substantiation or by any systematic view on how these concepts play a role in the definition of the real integrity of consciousness. Thus, the lectures provide us not merely with a new way of introducing Brentanian psychology, but also with such a rearrangement of the theoretical priority of its problems that leads to a rigorous clarification of the ontological foundations of experience.

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR — PhD student in Philosophy at the Universidade Federal do Rio de Janeiro and research fellow at the Husserl-Archives of the University of Cologne. Affiliation: Universidade Federal do Rio de Janeiro, Instituto de Filosofia e Ciências Sociais. Largo São Francisco de Paula, n. 1, sala 310. Centro, 20051070 – Rio de Janeiro, RJ, Brasil. His current research interests include the theoretical and methodological relationships between the Brentano School and Edmund Husserl's early works as well as the relationships between early phenomenology and psychology.

E-mail: fv.curvello@hotmail.com

Saulius Geniusas

VASILY SESEMANN'S PHENOMENOLOGICAL AESTHETICS

ABSTRACT

The paper offers a systematic account of Vasily Sesemann's aesthetics. First, I argue that, due to the primacy this aesthetics grants to intuition, intentionality and the objectivity of aesthetic values, its underlying principles are decidedly phenomenological. Secondly, I offer an account of the general structures of perceptual acts and I contend that the distinctive nature of aesthetic perception lies in the unique disposition of the aesthetic attitude. Thirdly, I maintain that there are three fundamentally different ways in which one can speak of aesthetic truth: in terms of formal requirements, subjective material requirements, and objective material requirements. Fourthly, I open a short dialogue between Sesemann and Maurice Merleau-Ponty and argue that an artwork fulfills the objective requirements of material truth when it succeeds in disclosing those levels of experience, on which the theoretical and practical attitudes rest and from which they take their departure.

Keywords: phenomenology, aesthetics, aesthetic attitude, aesthetic perception, aesthetic truth.

INTRODUCTION

Here I will focus on Vasily Sesemann's *Aesthetics*¹—a work, which provides a remarkably rich phenomenological analysis of aesthetic experience. In light of Sesemann's analysis, which is hardly known in the Western world, we obtain fresh resources to reconsider the “waning of affects” and the “anaesthetization of aesthetics,” which characterize many trends in recent analytical and continental aesthetics.² My analysis will unfold in four steps. I will begin with a clarifi-

¹ See Sezemanas, S. 1970. *Estetika*. Vilnius: Mintis.

² See: Carroll, N. 2008. “Aesthetic Experience, Art and Artists.” In: *Aesthetic Experience*. Shusterman, R., A. Tomlin (Eds.). New York: Routledge, 145–165, as representative of the critical stance that contemporary analytical aesthetics has taken toward the concept of aesthetic

cation of the fundamentally phenomenological principles of Sesemann's analysis. Secondly, I will focus on the general structure of perceptual acts and on this basis inquire into the specificity of aesthetic perception. Thirdly, I will demonstrate how aesthetic perception constitutes the phenomenological basis to conceptualize aesthetic truth. I will conclude with some reflections on the philosophical relevance of Sesemann's aesthetics in light of Maurice Merleau-Ponty's concept of the primordial world.

SESEMANN'S AESTHETICS AND ITS PHENOMENOLOGICAL COMMITMENTS

Sesemann understands aesthetics as a branch of philosophy, which aims to clarify and determine the essence and significance of aesthetic phenomena. Since beauty constitutes the essential characteristic of aesthetic phenomena, aesthetics is to be conceived as a theory which aims to determine the nature and significance of beauty. According to Sesemann, this determination can be reached only on the basis of first-hand experience.³ Methodologically, instead of relying on deductive or inductive forms of reasoning, an aesthetic theory must be built on the basis of (eidetic) intuition.⁴

Although aesthetic experience is only accessible to the experiencing subject, aesthetics is not destined either to subjectivism, or relativism. There are a few reasons for this. First, aesthetics is meant to focus on the general nature of the experiencing subject and to discover in this nature the non-arbitrary subjective conditions that underlie aesthetic experience. For Sesemann, aesthetics is a distinctly transcendental discipline, which strives to disclose the essential subjective conditions that are common to all humanity and that render the experience of beauty possible. Secondly, aesthetic experience is marked by intentionality. This means that aesthetic experience has an objective foundation, namely, it intends an aesthetic object. Following Max Scheler and his account of the objectivity of values, Sesemann argues that beauty is a quality of the object, not of the subject; moreover, this object is not private, but public. We know this be-

experience. See also Shusterman, R. 1997. "The End of Aesthetic Experience." *The Journal of Aesthetics and Art Criticism* 55, 1, Winter, 38, as representative of the approach that calls for a renewed investigations of aesthetic experience.

³ "Only that theory can clarify the essence of beauty which relies upon direct aesthetic perception, that is, which is fed by matter that derives from aesthetic perception" (Sezemanas, S. 1970, op. cit., 17). Or as Dalius Jonkus notes in his commentary on Sesemann's *Aesthetics*, "in the very definition of the aesthetic object there lies a reference to its relation with the special perceptual and valuating act. This is a characteristic feature of the phenomenological definition of value" (Jonkus, D. 2013. "Fenomenologinė Vosylio Sezemano estetika: estetinio objekto ir estetinio akto koreliacija." *Žmogus ir Žodis* 15, 4, 30).

⁴ In this regard, Sesemann follows Moritz Geiger. See: Geiger, M. 1974. *Beiträge zur Phänomenologie des ästhetischen Genusses*. Tübingen: Max Niemeyer Verlag, 1–7.

cause we can take joy in the works of art that reach us from other times and places.

How can beauty be experienced? It is accessible only to a unique conscious attitude and can only be given in a special perceptual act. While beauty is a peculiar characteristic of the aesthetic object, to clarify the nature of this object, one must fix the nature of that very attitude in which it is given, and of those acts, in which it is constituted. To determine the nature of the aesthetic object, aesthetics must, first, determine the structure of perceptual acts in general, and, secondly, of aesthetic perceptions in particular.

Thus the fundamental methodological outlook of Sesemann's aesthetics is phenomenological in three ways. What is at stake here are three commitments: commitment to intuition, conceived as a fundamental source of evidence; commitment to intentionality and to the principles of intentional analysis, which clarify the structure of experience by investigating acts and objects constituted in these acts; finally, commitment to the view that values such as beauty are objective: they are qualities of the intentional objects, rather than qualities of the acts of consciousness.

THE STRUCTURE OF PERCEPTION AND THE SPECIFICITY OF AESTHETIC PERCEPTION

The general structure of perceptual objects consists of two general characteristics. The first concerns *immediate impressions*, which constitute the material foundation of perception. However, we do not perceive impressions, but full-fledged objects of experience. For instance, I hear a buzz (an immediate impression) and I immediately apperceive it as the ring of my mobile phone (an object of experience). The immediate impression is the material core, which consciousness (to borrow a Husserlian expression) conceives of together with its *inner horizon of sense*, and this inner horizon makes up the full-fledged object of one's experience.

In each sensuous perception we perceive more than we sense. For instance, as I walk by the closed door in a building, I hear a few sounds played on the piano, and I immediately apperceive them as moments of Rachmaninov's Piano Concerto No. 2. Yet *in each sensuous perception, we also perceive less than we sense.* To recognize the sounds of the piano as Rachmaninov's Piano Concerto No. 2, I must disregard many other sounds that I hear simultaneously, be it the sounds of someone else's footsteps, or the sounds of someone coughing.

What is it that motivates consciousness to "dress up" the sensuous givens in specific patterns of meaning? The motivation derives from past experience. Had I never heard Rachmaninov's Piano Concerto No. 2 before, I would experience the chords I now hear in a fundamentally different way, either as moments of a still undetermined whole, or as elements of a different musical piece.

Just as the structure of perception relies upon consciousness of the past, it also relies upon consciousness of the future. Perceptual consciousness is selective in that it singles out particular sensuous impressions while disregarding others. This selectivity relies on the conscious *intention*. So that it could intend full-fledged objects of experience, consciousness must anticipate its own future experiences. I must anticipate that the sounds I now hear will be followed by other sounds if I am to apperceive the heard chords as moments of Rachmaninov's Piano Concerto No. 2.

The particular intention that guides our attention is largely determined by the *attitude* of consciousness. Thus while crossing a busy street, my attention will mainly be focused on the cars around me, whereas when I am engaged in an important conversation, I will mainly focus on what my interlocutor has to say. As we all know, under such circumstances a remarkable number of things escape our attention.

Such, then, is the general structure of perception: what we perceive is largely determined by sensuous impressions, which consciousness intends from within a particular attitude and which consciousness apperceives on the basis of past experiences and the future-oriented conscious anticipations.

At this point we can ask the crucial question: Which of the structural moments of perceptual acts, which we have just singled out, determines the specificity of aesthetic experience? First, aesthetic experience cannot be determined on the basis of immediate impressions, since these impressions, conceived as the sensuous matter of full-fledged perceptions, are common to all perceptions. Secondly, aesthetic experience cannot be determined either on the basis the lasting significance of past experience, or on the ground of conscious anticipations, since all perceptions rely on past experience and come along with motivated anticipations. We are thereby left just with one factor, which could differentiate aesthetic perceptions from other perceptions—the unique attitude of aesthetic consciousness. This means that to clarify the specificity of aesthetic experience, one must clarify the uniqueness of the aesthetic attitude.

Sesemann takes three steps while addressing this question. He begins with the analysis of poetic language, then turns to painting, and finally to music. His general answer to the question concerning the peculiarity of aesthetic experience is grounded in the details of this descriptive analysis.

In everyday use of language, the words perform a purely practical function. When we hear others speak, we do not focus on how the words sound, but directly grasp the word's meaning. By contrast, poetic language *embodies* meaning: it unifies the phonetic with the semantic, the sensuous with the meaningful. The poetic word "stops at the word's surface, although not because it is superficial or because it does not care about perceptual depths, but because in the word's sensuous surface it intuitively understands all its inner content and the wealth of its meaning."⁵

⁵ Sezemanas, S. 1970, op. cit., 34.

The distinction between sounds and meaning, characteristic of everyday language use, is missing in the case of everyday visual experience.⁶ Nonetheless, in our everyday practical encounter with things, we recognize their qualities only insofar as they help us orientate in the surrounding world, insofar as they help us distinguish one thing from the other and use these things appropriately. For the most part, we do not notice the colour of the pen we write with or the somewhat yellow pages of the book we read. Just as in the case of language we for the most part overlook the sensuous nature of the words we use, so also in the case of visual encounter with things: for the most part, we do not see them.

Just as in the case of poetry, so also in the case of painting, the aesthetic attitude is marked by the interest in the object's sensuous appearance and by the refusal to depart from this appearance. When it comes to painting, only that attitude of consciousness, which focuses on the object's spatial form, the colourfulness of its contours and its relation to light opens our eyes to the object's aesthetic value.

Music occupies a special place among all the arts because no other art has the means needed to depict so powerfully our inner emotional world: our ambitions, feelings, moods and passions. This does not mean, however, that music lacks an external object of representation. "We would be mistaken if we thought that music is a special language of feelings."⁷ *The object of music is the sensuous structure of tones.* For the most part, in our everyday experience, we do not hear tones in their purity, since we immediately subject them to specific practical or theoretical interpretation. Thus I immediately apperceive the sound I hear as a knock at the door or as a voice calling my name. I have already lost and am already beyond the purity of tones. Yet just as poetry returns us to the sensuous nature of the word, which we for the most part overlook, and just as painting places us in front of the sensuous appearance of things, which we no longer see, so music also enables us to hear the tones in their purity, which we have already heard, although have not listened to.

This brief analysis of poetry, visual art and music demonstrate that the object of aesthetic perception is an expressive phenomenon, which shows itself as a sensuous form. We thereby obtain an insight into the essence of aesthetic perception: aesthetic perception must be directed *at* the sensuous surface of things, its object must be embodied *in* this surface. For this reason, as soon as perceptual intention departs from the object's sensuality, the perceptual act loses its

⁶ Although we sometimes draw a distinction between the painting's literal and symbolic meaning, this distinction is by no means analogous to the distinction between the word's sounds and its meaning. On the one hand, in our everyday experience, we do not focus on the word's physical appearance but on its meaning. By contrast, in our everyday visual experience, we focus on the thing's physical appearance, not on its symbolic sense.

⁷ Sezemanas, S. 1970, op. cit., 38.

aesthetic quality.⁸ As soon as we comprehend the object within the practical or theoretical framework of sense, we lose sight of the object's sensuousness. Art strives to counteract this limitation.

THE EMOTIVE AND CONTEMPLATIVE DIMENSIONS OF AESTHETIC EXPERIENCE

As we just saw, the focus on the sensuous surface of things is essential to aesthetic perception. There are, however, two further dimensions—an emotive and a contemplative—that characterize the essence of aesthetic experience. With regard to the first dimension, one should stress that the essential characteristic of aesthetic phenomena lies in the fact that they affect us emotionally. This does not mean that phenomena first touch us in an emotionally free way and only subsequently induce in us an emotional response. Aesthetic objects are charged emotionally from the very start. If an object does not touch our emotions, it cannot be qualified as an aesthetic object.

To be sure, aesthetic objects are not the only types of objects that touch us emotionally. The essential peculiarity of the emotional dimension of aesthetic perception lies in the fact that aesthetic perception values emotionally the aesthetic object's *inner sensuous characteristics*. Aesthetic perception is not guided by practical or theoretical interests, which subject sensuous phenomena to extrinsic purposes. Aesthetic perception alone stops at the object's sensuous surface, and for this very reason it is marked by openness to its intrinsic emotional characteristics. These characteristics, from which aesthetic phenomena are inseparable, are intrinsic features of their direct sensuous expressibility.

So as to identify aesthetic attitude with greater precision, Sesemann qualifies it as *aesthetic contemplation*. Much like theoretical contemplation, aesthetic contemplation is also fundamentally *non-practical*. However, while theoretical contemplation abstracts from the subject's sensuous relation to phenomena, aesthetic contemplation, in its focus on the sensuous, overrides practical and theoretical considerations. It turns back to sensuous impressions and reawakens their original significance, which is suppressed and surpassed once subjected to practical and theoretical interests. Moreover, "aesthetic approach (contemplation) does not only restore (recover) the qualitative peculiarity of the original impres-

⁸ In his recent critique of aesthetic experience, Noel Carroll has remarked that the standard characterization of aesthetic experience "is effectively useless from the point of view of empirical research." He further suggested that the standard qualifications of aesthetic experience "fail to differentiate it from what many enthusiasts are likely to say of the chess experience" (Carroll, N. 2008, op. cit., 158). Sesemann's emphasis on the sensuous dimensions of aesthetic experience makes clear that there are solid phenomenological grounds to differentiate such forms of experience.

sions, but it also actualizes, develops and forms what only commences or hides in an unclear, undifferentiated form.”⁹

To summarize, there are three essential features that characterize the structure of aesthetic experience. First, aesthetic experience is focused on the object's sensuous surface. Aesthetic perception does not aim to subject the object's sensuality to any external goal or purpose. It does not look through the sensuous, but is focused on the sensuous. Secondly, aesthetic perception relates to phenomena in an emotionally charged way. The sensuous phenomenon of aesthetic perception is the terminus of emotive intentionality. Put it otherwise, the aesthetic emotions are directed not through, but at the aesthetic phenomenon's intrinsic sensuous features. Thirdly, aesthetic perception is grounded in aesthetic contemplation. Much like theoretical contemplation, aesthetic contemplation is also fundamentally non-practical. However, unlike theoretical contemplation, aesthetic contemplation is focused on the object's sensuous surface and develops further what is presented at this surface in an undifferentiated way.

PHENOMENOLOGY OF AESTHETIC TRUTH

There is an important implication to draw from this phenomenology aesthetic experience, which concerns art's relation to truth. As noted earlier, Sesemann conceives of aesthetics as the study of aesthetic qualities, which he further qualifies in terms of beauty. However, when it comes to art, Sesemann argues that beauty is not the only characteristic of aesthetic objects. The reason for this concerns the fact that works of art have representational powers. In this regard, Sesemann speaks on the aesthetic object's “thingly meaning.” This awkward expression suggests that the artwork can, besides combining sensuous elements, also represent real objects, be they animate or inanimate; so also, it can represent ideal objects, be they thoughts or ideas; finally, art can also represent feelings and, more generally, the endless variety characteristic of the human being's inner life.¹⁰ Besides clarifying the meaning and significance of beauty, aesthetics must also address the artwork's “thingly meaning,” and it is here, in this framework, that the question of truth proves inescapable.¹¹

⁹ Sezemanas, S. 1970, op. cit., 67.

¹⁰ In this regard Sesemann anticipates the general trend in phenomenological aesthetics, characterized by the attempt to broaden the aesthetic field by breaking through the boundaries that had been drawn around the concept of the aesthetic. The articles compiled in Part II of *Aesthetic Experience* (I have in mind the contributions by Richard Shusterman, Martin Seel, Kathleen Higgins and Carolyn Korsmeyer) all represent this general tendency to broaden the domain of aesthetic experience by incorporating within it what at first glance appears to be essentially non-aesthetic.

¹¹ To clarify the ambiguity that concerns the relation between aesthetics and philosophy of art, one could put it as follows: on the one hand, Sesemann does not judge art only in terms of its capacity to express aesthetic values but also takes into account its representational function. On

In the context of theoretical reason, one commonly draws a distinction between formal and material truth. Formal truth is concerned with cognition's immanent unity and consistency, which is based upon the logical relation between different judgments. Yet even though formal truth suspends the question concerning the relation between cognition and its object, all formal systems of thought rely upon material presuppositions. This becomes especially clear in the case of deductive logic. As it provides rules of reasoning to link premises to conclusions, it relies on the truthfulness of fundamental premises. This truthfulness, however, can be measured either on the basis of direct intuition of what is stated in these premises, or in accordance with how the logical conclusions drawn from these premises correspond to experiential data. In either case, the truthfulness of cognition ultimately relies upon material truth, which is meant to determine whether cognition corresponds to the cognized object. Material truth is the standard that determines whether the object, or some of its aspect, is cognized the same way as it shows itself intuitively.

Besides meeting formal and material criteria, truth claims must also correspond to the subjective intentions of the speaker. Here we face the subjective moment of material truth, which is to be distinguished from the objective moment, namely, that moment, which concerns the judgment's correspondence to the intuitive givenness of the judged object.

Of what significance is such a distinction between three moments of truth in the case of art? So as to answer this question, one first needs to distinguish three moments, which decide the artwork's aesthetic value: 1) the purely sensuous form, which concerns the totality of sensuous impressions whose unified presentation constitutes the depicted image; 2) the (re)presented meaning, which can be either directly depicted or symbolically indicated; 3) the expression characteristic of the work of art, which concerns its mood or emotional attitude.

The work of art is *formally true* insofar as it embodies the sensuous requirements of beauty. All the elements depicted in the work must constitute a unified whole in a way that no sensuous element could be either changed or removed without disturbing the effects of the work's aesthetic sensuality. The sensuous components should support each other so as to enable the work to bring out each component's formal significance. The artwork fulfils these formal requirements at the purely sensuous level.

As far as the artwork's material truth is concerned, its subjective aspect is determined on the basis of whether the work can intrinsically express what the artist meant it to express. "Does the realization of the artistic plan correspond to the plan itself? Did the artist succeed in solving the problem he was aiming to solve?"¹² If the artwork itself does not provide answers to these questions, that

the other hand, he explicitly conceives of aesthetics as a theory of beauty and of art as a branch of aesthetics. It remains unclear if these two standpoints are compatible with each other. For an account that denies their compatibility, see Carroll, N. 2008, op. cit., 145–165.

¹² Sezemanas, S. 1970, op. cit., 241.

is, if these questions can only be answered by relying on what is external to the artwork itself (for example, on the basis of the artist's letters to friends or notes in diaries), then the work fails to meet the truth requirements, as far as the subjective aspect of the material truth is concerned.

Sesemann's analysis of the objective aspect of material truth in art unfolds in two directions. On the one hand, the objective aspect concerns *the truthfulness of emotional expressivity*. On the other hand, it also concerns *artistic imagination's compliance with actuality*. The truthfulness of emotional expressivity concerns artistic representation and artistic interpretation of those feelings, which come to be expressed in the artwork. Consider the case of an artist, who presents a particular emotion in his work, although he fails to present it accurately or appropriately. In such a case, we face a falsified presentation—a presentation that is not faithful to the depicted feeling, either because the artist lacks the technical means, or because he misunderstands the nature of the feeling he strives to depict. In either case, under such circumstances, the artwork fails to meet the objective requirement of material truth. In this case, material truth has to do with genuine depiction of those feelings that come to be expressed in the artwork.

How are we to understand the second objective requirement of material truth, that is, *artistic imagination's compliance with actuality*? In this regard, the general insight that Sesemann is trying to articulate concerns the apprehension that all art, although in significantly different forms, de-realizes the depicted object. However, no matter how fantastic art might be, that is, no matter how far it might depart from our lived actuality, it nonetheless retains the power to describe some hidden aspects that relate to our actual existence. It is precisely here that one can locate the relevance of artistic imagination. No matter how deeply an artwork might rely on imagination, it nonetheless highlights some of the concealed, essential, and significant dimensions of human existence.

The problematic of artistic imagination's compliance with actuality leads to another issue, which is central to Sesemann's aesthetics, namely, the issue that concerns *phenomenal depth*.

"The established habits and associations in practical life usually enable us to understand phenomena only in a schematic and superficial way and what lies in the depths for the most part eludes our vision. By highlighting these hidden aspects, the artist discloses the deeper meaning."¹³

Art becomes truthful not when it imitates everyday practical reality but, on the contrary, when it succeeds in breaking through the established customs and disclosing a more basic manifestation of things, which in the practical context of life remains concealed.¹⁴

¹³ Ibid., 246–7.

¹⁴ Here the concept of phenomenal reality should be understood as a general concept that covers everything that appears to a human being in her inner or outer life.

The proposed return to the depths of phenomenal reality is paradoxical. As mentioned earlier, the task of art is precisely that of returning us to the sensuous *surface* of events and phenomena. It is by focusing on the object's sensuous surface that we reach aesthetic depth. What is at stake here is the change of attitude, from the practical to the aesthetic, for it is this change that renders the sensuous surface of phenomena once again visible. Moreover, what is at stake here is the disclosure of those aspects of phenomenal reality, which, besides being hidden from practical life, are also highly relevant in that they transform our everyday experience.

According to Sesemann, what comes into view in the work of art concerns not facts, but essences.¹⁵ All art isolates and purifies events and phenomena, thereby separating what is essential from what is non-essential. "Art singles out what is essential and specific to reality and what corresponds to the artist's intention."¹⁶ Art does not copy reality; it rather embodies and thematizes the essential aspects of phenomenal reality. In this regard, one can provide the second requirement of material truth with two correlative determinations. From the noematic perspective, the truth of art can be qualified as the sensuous manifestation of the essential features of phenomenal reality. From the noetic perspective, it can be further conceived in terms of the subject's openness to the essential features of phenomenal reality.

AESTHETIC TRUTH AND THE PRIMORDIAL WORLD

At this point, I would like to open a brief dialogue between Sesemann's aesthetics and Merleau-Ponty's phenomenology of painting. Here I will limit myself to Merleau-Ponty's "Cezanne's Doubt" (1945), which is the first of the three essays he wrote explicitly on painting.¹⁷ According to one of Merleau-Ponty's central claims in this work, the greatest power of painting lies in its capacity to return us to the *primordial world*. This expression plays the role of what, following Eugen Fink, one could call an *operative concept* in Merleau-Ponty's thought on painting: while it sheds light on a number of other concepts and themes, it itself remains without definition.

¹⁵ Concerning this difference between facts and essences, consider Mikel Dufrenne's insightful observation: "Homer remains true when the cannon replaces the lance and the Fifth Column replaces the Trojan Horse. Homer is true precisely through what is conventional in the epic and not because there is exact description of the equipment of the Achaean infantryman." Dufrenne, M. 1973. *The Phenomenology of Aesthetic Experience*. Casey, E. S., A. Anderson, W. Domingo, L. Jacobson (Trans.). Evanston, Ill: Northwestern University Press, 526.

¹⁶ Sezemanas, S. 1970, op. cit., 237.

¹⁷ As far as Merleau-Ponty's two other essays on painting are concerned, see Merleau-Ponty's "Indirect Language and the Voices of Silence" and "Eye and Mind," both they appeared in: idem. 1993. *The Merleau-Ponty Aesthetics Reader: Philosophy and Painting*. Johnson, G. (Ed.). Smith, M. (Trans.). Evanston, Illinois: Northwestern University Press, 76–149.

To the best of my knowledge, in the corpus of Merleau-Ponty's works, we come across this concept only on one occasion. In "Cezanne's Doubt," Merleau-Ponty writes:

"He [Cezanne] makes a basic distinction not between 'the senses' and 'the understanding' but rather between the spontaneous organization of the things we perceive and the human organization of ideas and sciences. We see things; we agree about them; we are anchored in them; and it is with 'nature' as our base that we construct our sciences. Cezanne wanted to paint this primordial world, and his pictures therefore seem to show nature pure, while photographs of the same landscapes suggest man's works, conveniences, and imminent presence [...] He wishes, as he said, to confront the sciences with the nature 'from which they came'."¹⁸

Here Merleau-Ponty focuses on the fundamentally arbitrary nature of the cultural worlds. These worlds are based upon human, all-too-human organization of ideas, by which we are to understand that in our everyday worlds, each and every thing has a specific meaning (be it moral, practical, religious or scientific), which we have assigned to it. Nonetheless, all these cultural worlds are themselves rooted in a more primordial givenness of the world, which cannot be thematized in terms of human configurations. This primordial world is a strange world, in which we are all destined to be foreigners. This strange world is rooted not in the human, but in the spontaneous organization of things. This primordial world, despite its non-human character, is the subject matter of Cezanne's paintings.

"We live in the midst of man-made objects, among tools, in houses, streets, cities, and most of the time we see them only through the human actions which put them to use. We become used to thinking that all of this exists necessarily und unshakably. Cezanne's painting suspends these habits of thought and reveals the base of inhuman nature upon which man has installed himself."¹⁹

Thus the primordial world is essential *pre-practical*. It is essentially an "in-human world" in the sense that it does not serve any human goals or purposes. Precisely because this world remains indifferent to all human efforts and aspirations, "it is an unfamiliar world in which one is uncomfortable and which forbids all human effusiveness."²⁰ It is a world, which precedes and resists "the

¹⁸ Merleau-Ponty, M. 1964. "Cezanne's Doubt." Dreyfus, H. P. Dreyfus (Trans.). In: idem. *Sense and Nonsense*. Evanston: Northwestern University Press, 13–4.

¹⁹ Ibid., 16.

²⁰ Ibid., 16.

imposed order of humanity.” This strange, cold and inhuman world is the subject matter of Cezanne’s paintings.

One could provide the concept of the primordial world with the following determinations. Besides being *pre-practical*, it is also *pre-cultural*, insofar as it precedes the “human organization of ideas and sciences.” Moreover, it is also a *pre-scientific* world, which refuses to be determined according to scientific concepts. Last but not least, the primordial world is *the world of experience*. The last qualification calls for further clarification.

Although the primordial world is the world of experience, we remain unaware of this experience, and only through art can we become conscious of it. In this regard, the function of art is fundamentally *mnemonic*. Yet even though it is meant to be mnemonic, art is not meant to copy or imitate reality. Here it is crucial not to confuse imitation with expression.²¹ While we can only imitate what has already been expressed, we can only express what conceals itself, what is distorted, obscure or unnoticed. Art strives to fulfil its mnemonic function in its aim to *express* the pre-human nature by making it live again.

One could say that Cezanne (as Merleau-Ponty understands him) tries to take hold of the unreflected perceptual life to which reflection refers and from which it takes its departure. The task of the artist is to raise nature, which everyone “knows” individually, to the level of the universal and to transform individual nature into a general signification.

The primordial world is the world of pre-reflective experience, a world both strange and familiar. Its strangeness derives from the fact that we inevitably overlook it since we schematize it through practical and theoretical concepts. The primordial world is the world of experience, even though it is not the world of *everyday* experience. We are confronted here with a world, which is strange and almost impenetrable precisely because it is familiar.

An artwork fulfils the objective requirements of material truth when it succeeds in disclosing the primordial world, that is, when it brings one back to those levels of experience, on which the theoretical and practical attitudes rest and from which they take their departure. In our practical and theoretical engagement with things, we look, yet we do not see; we listen, yet we do not hear. The peculiar characteristic of the aesthetic attitude lies in its aim to overcome this ingrained limitation. The aesthetic attitude enables us to see what we were always looking at, yet never observed; it enables us to hear what we were

²¹ Carroll (with reference to A. O. Scott) remarks that the major American novels of the last twenty-five years “are all concerned with history: with figuring out and illuminating both how Americans as a people have gotten to this stage of their history and what perilous tensions that passage has compounded and exacerbated. These authors write with the primary intention to clarify our national identity” (Carroll, N. 2008, op. cit., 156). In this regard, the following remark by Dufrenne is quite telling: “But if their [the artists’] sole ambition is to present the real world to which they belong, why do they not become historians—or even politicians, if they wish to be active in this world? The reason is that they aim at something else, above all to express themselves, and perhaps even lose themselves in what they express” (Dufrenne, M. 1973, op. cit., 525–6).

always listening to, although never heard. This capacity to see what one for the most part overlooks and hear what one for the most part does not hear is the return to the primordial world, which Merleau-Ponty qualifies as the fundamental accomplishment of Cezanne's paintings. Reading Merleau-Ponty alongside Sesemann provides one with the insight that such a return to the primordial world is a characteristic feature of aesthetic experience in general.

Sesemann's aesthetics provides reasons to maintain that the forgetfulness of the primordial world is *inescapable*. This is because, as Sesemann's analysis of aesthetic perception in poetry, painting and music demonstrates, the practical and the theoretical attitudes (without which we could not survive) are only possible on the basis of transcending our more basic exposure to the sensuous unity of things. The function of aesthetic experience is fundamentally *mnemonic*, if by this one understands that aesthetic perception purifies and objectifies what one has always already seen, yet never observed, what one has always already heard, but never noticed.

As Sesemann has it, "the one who knows how to see and observe, also knows how to create. He re-creates only what he discovered and perceived in nature."²² The task of the artist is none other than that of drawing out from experience what is already there, disclosing what is given in a concealed form, rendering actual what is only potential.

CONCLUSION

On the basis of the foregoing analysis, I would suggest that Sesemann's phenomenology of aesthetic experience provides one of the most detailed analyses of the structures of aesthetic perception in phenomenological literature in general. I tried to show how these structures enable one to raise the question of aesthetic truth. Aesthetic truth can be conceived in three fundamental ways: in terms of formal requirements that guide over the organization of sensuous shapes; in terms of subjective material requirements, which demand that the work be a truthful expression of the artist's intentions; finally, in terms of objective material requirements, which demand that the artwork be a truthful presentation of the concealed aspects of phenomenal reality. It is worthwhile noting that we come across the same tripartite distinction in Mikel Dufrenne's discussion of aesthetic truth in his voluminous *Phenomenology of Aesthetic Experience* from 1951. The inquiry into Sesemann's conception of aesthetic truth alongside Merleau-Ponty's conception of the primordial world enables one to claim that while art's hidden ambition is that of returning us to the primordial world, this task should be conceived in terms of generating direct insights into the essential structures of phenomenal reality.

²² Sezemanas, S. 1970, op. cit., 119.

The emphasis Merleau-Ponty places on doubt rightly highlights the uncertainty that accompanies the artist's attempt to return to the primordial world, conceived as the sphere of the original manifestation of things. Presuming that this uncertainty cannot be overcome, one could say that in the arts, aesthetic truth can only play a regulative role: it clarifies the impetus that underlies the artist's work, although it neither holds any promises nor carries any guarantees with regard to the artwork's actual accomplishments. Perhaps, as Dufrenne would have it, when it comes to material truth in art, absolute knowledge lies in the realization that there is no absolute knowledge; perhaps the last word is that there is no last word.

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR — PhD (from New School for Social Research, New York, USA, 2008); present academic position: associate professor of philosophy, Chinese University of Hong Kong, Fung King Hey Bld, Department of Philosophy, CUHK, Shatin, New Territories, Hong Kong (affiliation). Research fields: continental philosophy, especially phenomenology and hermeneutics. Publications: 2012. *The Origins of the Horizon in Husserl's Phenomenology*. Springer; over forty articles.

E-mail: geniusas@cuhk.edu.hk

Andrzej Gniazdowski

SCHELER AND CLAUSS ON THE POSSIBILITY OF A PHENOMENOLOGICAL THEORY OF RACE

ABSTRACT

This paper attempts to answer questions about, first, the historical motives which brought the “race” issue into the focus of phenomenological reflection, and, secondly, the theoretical grounding for calling such reflection “phenomenological.”¹ The basis for this reconstruction will be the psychological race theory developed in the 1920s and 30s by Ludwig Ferdinand Clauss, a somewhat forgotten student of Edmund Husserl, and its rooting in the history of the phenomenological movement. Discussed will be both, the theory’s historical background—which, in keeping with the paper’s main thesis, is best-expressed by Max Scheler’s reflections on “European patriotism”—and its relation to Husserl’s concept of phenomenology as a “strictly scientific philosophy.”

Keywords: phenomenology, political theory, European patriotism, race psychology, national socialism.

INTRODUCTION

Edmund Husserl was utterly convinced about the universal character of phenomenology—not only as the absolute fundament of science, but also as a specific logic of being. As he assured, phenomenology “by no means professes to stop short of the ‘supreme and ultimate’ questions.”² And in his last major work entitled *The Crisis of European Sciences and Transcendental Phenomenology*,

¹ The present paper recapitulates and develops reflections contained in the essay: Gniazdowski, A. 2014. “Stil und sein Mensch. Der ‘tolerante’ Rassismus Ludwig Ferdinand Clauss” [Style and Its Human. The “Tolerant” Racism of Ludwig Ferdinand Clauss]. *Orbis Idearum*, 1 (2), 113–126; and in the book: Gniazdowski, A. 2015. *Antynomie radykalizmu. Fenomenologia polityczna w Niemczech 1914–1933* [The Antinomies of Radicalism. Political Phenomenology in Germany 1914–1933]. Warsaw: Institute of Philosophy and Sociology Publishers.

² Husserl, E. 1960. *Cartesian Meditations. An Introduction to Phenomenology*. Cairns D. (Trans.). The Hague–Boston–London: Martinus Nijhoff Publishers, 156.

he stated outright that “there is no conceivable meaningful problem in previous philosophy, and no conceivable problem of being at all, that could not be arrived at by transcendental phenomenology at some point along its way.”³

Seen from this perspective it is not surprising that “at some point along its way” (in fact, a rather early point) phenomenology encountered the issue of “race.” As confirmed by today’s heated debates around the antisemitism Martin Heidegger revealed in his “black notebooks,” phenomenology’s embracement of the race problem has become a very expressive measure of the radicalism of Husserl’s distinction between science and worldview (*Weltanschauung*). Insofar as the political history of the race concept—which, as Werner Conze stated in his lexicon, belongs to the vocabulary of German social and political language—ended after World War Two,⁴ it has become a litmus test for the radicalism of phenomenology’s critique of the objectivity of scientific knowledge.

MAX SCHELER AND THE IDEA OF “EUROPEAN SPIRITUAL STRUCTURE”

Max Scheler pointed to the need for phenomenological inquiry into the race issue in his writings on war. These writings—the December, 1914-finished *Genius des Krieges und der deutsche Krieg* [The Genius of War and the German War],⁵ the lecture *Ursprünge des Deutschenhasses* [The Sources of Hatred towards the Germans]⁶ and the essay collection *Krieg und Aufbau* [War and Reconstruction]⁷—are arguably the phenomenological movement’s biggest contribution to the treasury of German “philosophical ideas in the year 1914.”⁸ Decisive for the inclusion of Scheler’s war reflections in this context was the fact that, in attempting to justify the empire’s martial goals from the position of a material value ethic, they addressed most of the issues which characterize it as a whole. As in the case of other German thinkers who “did not want to remain silent when guns were firing,” Scheler’s writings on warfare tended to present

³ Husserl, E. 1970. *The Crisis of European Sciences and Transcendental Phenomenology. An Introduction to Phenomenological Philosophy*. Carr, D. (Trans.). Evanston: Northwestern University Press, 188.

⁴ See: Conze, W. 1984. “Rasse” [Race]. In: *Geschichtliche Grundbegriffe: Historisches Lexikon zur politisch-sozialen Sprache in Deutschland*, vol. 5 [Basic Historical Concepts: a Historical Lexicon of Political and Social Language in Germany]. Brunner, O., W. Conze, R. Koselleck (Eds.). Stuttgart: Klett-Cotta, 169.

⁵ Scheler, M. 1915. *Genius des Krieges und der deutsche Krieg* [The Genius of War and the German War]. Leipzig: Verlag der Weissen Bücher.

⁶ Scheler, M. 1917. *Ursprünge des Deutschenhasses* [The Sources of Hatred towards the Germans]. Leipzig: Verlag der Weissen Bücher.

⁷ Scheler, M. 1917. *Krieg und Aufbau* [War and Reconstruction]. Leipzig: Verlag der Weissen Bücher.

⁸ Cf. Lübke, H. 1963. *Politische Philosophie in Deutschland* [Political Philosophy in Germany]. Basel: Benno Schwabe & Co., 171f.

Germany's conflicts with its enemies as primarily ideological. Also, Scheler considered one of his main tasks to be not so much explaining as praising the political and cultural specificity of German national consciousness. His aim was as much to reveal the historical conditioning of this consciousness, as to present it—to use Hermann Lübbe's words—as the revelation of a “quasi metaphysical ‘German essence’.”⁹ Like other creators of philosophical ideas in 1914, Scheler strove to justify German warfare as warfare which did not merely seek self-affirmation, but also global victory.

Scheler developed his phenomenological psychology of race conception in the context of his reflections on the fundamentals of “European spiritual unity” in the aforementioned *Genius of War*. In an essay on the subject entitled “The Spiritual Unity of Europe and Its Political Requirements” he set the idea of a “good European” against modern German nationalism in the Nietzschean understanding. Scheler's European patriotism project defined the European *per se* as a lasting, above-national “European human and cultural type,” and saw the world's future determined by a “European cultural community” already visible in a “European spiritual structure” common to all European nations.¹⁰

In Scheler's conception this community reached beyond the simple distinction between nationalism and internationalism (or cosmopolitanism), which he held for primitive. For Scheler this distinction, which in World War One determined not only the war propaganda of the Entente states, but in its footsteps also the political consciousness of Germany's liberal and social-democratic elite, was historical deadweight, a leftover from the formation period of Europe's nations. True, he considered various forms of patriotism—like affinity for one's native surroundings, country or people—to be necessary and perennial forms of love, but, like Nietzsche, he held both nationalism and internationalism (or cosmopolitanism) with its love of an abstract “humanity” for pseudo-love built upon resentment. And he predicted that such pseudo-love could be replaced by proper love only in the form of a new and positive love of “Europeanism” founded on common goals and a common longing for certain values. Patriotism, Scheler wrote, “was still to be born from the blood and iron of this war!”¹¹

Europeans, Scheler wrote, realized that there existed something like a European unity of style and expression above national differences only after seeing themselves through the eyes of non-European cultures.¹² In Scheler's words, this unity was a never-questioned, unconscious canon which underlay all spiritual and mental communication in Europe, and was visible already in facial expressions and gestures. Scheler saw its manifestations in the harmonies that were typical for European musical reception, in the way of perceiving space, but most of all in the European ethos itself and the categories and structures under-

⁹ Ibid., 22.

¹⁰ Scheler, M. 1915. *Genius des Krieges*, 250.

¹¹ Ibid.

¹² Ibid., 258.

lying European spiritual cognition, which differed from those present in other cultures and found expression in the continent's languages, mythology, sciences and religions. Thus, unlike Kant, who sought the conditions of the possibility of experiencing the world in a pan-human "table of categories," Scheler admitted the existence of certain "spiritual regularities" that were typical of Europeans, and whose possession he considered to be a necessary condition for building a real culture.¹³

In his search for the fundamental factors which determined European unity, and without which attempts to "Europeanise" other cultures ended at best in their "technification" or "capitalisation" (as in the case of Japan), Scheler did not omit to address the racial issue. As a student of Ernst Haeckel in the winter semester of 1896/97,¹⁴ and well abreast of the racial theories propounded by this natural scientist and member of the prestigious German Society for Racial Hygiene, Scheler in his war writings questioned the belief in the spiritual and corporeal unity of human nature. Against it, in his opinion, spoke not only the findings of racial comparative anatomy and physiology, but also studies of the ontogenesis, anthropology, ethnology and psychology of nations. In his text on the issue Scheler claimed that, "the idea of 'Man' is, in fact, as already Plato, Descartes and Malebranche taught, in a certain sense a theomorphism."¹⁵

In reference to the paleoanthropological research conducted by Hermann Klaatsch, who, in analogy to primates, explained racial differences between humans with the multifariousness of human forms before the hominisation process,¹⁶ Scheler declared that although the anthropological debate between the monophyletic and polyphyletic theories was still underway, "no one (today) would dare to resolve this issue lightheadedly like Wilhelm von Humboldt."¹⁷ Scheler held the belief in the unity of human nature for naive and claimed that it effectively hampered all rational—also Christian—missionary activity towards non-European cultures. Despite distancing himself—like Nietzsche—from "ridiculous, pompous Germanic idolatry," he saw true hope for the rational Europeanisation of other cultures in a "psychological theory of race" which would investigate racial differences in a value-free way and which, to his chagrin, was still in its infancy in his day.¹⁸

¹³ Ibid.

¹⁴ Henckmann, W. 1998. *Max Scheler*. Beck, München, 17.

¹⁵ Scheler, M. 1915, op. cit., 270.

¹⁶ Cf. Klaatsch, H. 1911. "Die Stellung des Menschen im Naturganzen" [Man's Position in the All of Nature], in: *Die Abstammungslehre. Zwölf gemeinverständliche Vorträge über die Deszendenztheorie im Licht der neueren Forschung gehalten im Wintersemester 1910/11 im Münchner Verein für Naturkunde* [The Science of Origin. Twelve Comprehensible Lectures on Descendence Theory in the Light of more recent Studies delivered at the Munich Association for Natural Study in the Winter Semester 1910/11]. Abel, O., A. Brauer et. al. (Eds.). Jena: Fischer, 332f.

¹⁷ Scheler, M. 1915. *Genius des Krieges*, 269.

¹⁸ Ibid., 270.

In the same measure as he considered the theory about the unity of human nature scientifically untenable, Scheler also held for illusive the belief that there existed one “world” common for all humans and cultures. In his view the radical—i.e. qualitative and not only quantitative—differences between cultures revealed by race psychology concerned the most elementary categories of experience, hence he believed that it was better to describe the world in this context as a “multiverse” rather than a “universe.” According to Scheler humans had to cease seeking one, single, universally-shared “world-view” understood as an objective, reality-consistent and cognitively-grounded “perception of the world.” On the premise that also science itself, which was to guarantee us such a world outlook, was, from Thales and Thomas Aquinas to Newton and Spencer, no more than a reflection of the structure of the European spirit, Scheler claimed that we had to accept that “our forefathers’ ‘universe’ was nothing but the European world.”¹⁹ There is no way in which we can leave behind us or overcome this world because it accompanies us like a shadow wherever we go, be it the African interior or China: “even the Moon— Scheler writes—would appear to us as a ‘European Moon’ if we found ourselves on it.”²⁰

In Scheler’s interpretation the multiverse concept, according to which the European world was only one of many worlds, was by no means relativistic. As in his remaining writings on war, its polemic context was English utilitarianism, which ordered the world’s artefacts according to their applicability in satisfying so-called “general human needs,” which humans shared with the higher vertebrates. “Who sees ‘cognition’ only as an economic ‘cataloguing of the world’, will, of course, perceive the world as a certain whole,” Scheler wrote.

“However, the more we elevate ourselves from gain-based civilisation to true culture—i.e. the more objectively and ‘soberly’ we behave, leaving behind us that which is ‘animal’—the more the existing unity of the world’s reality, in which our forefathers so ardently believed in the ‘humanistic’ era, will appear to us only as a superficial *fable convenue*.”²¹

Thus, in Scheler’s belief liberation from naive faith in the “fable” about the world’s unity was the precondition for the formation of European patriotism. The more lost in the distant chill of other worlds the “European world” appears to members the European nations, he wrote, the more clearly they will begin to perceive it as their one and only common space for existence, life and activity. Scheler believed that the unity of Europe as a certain kind of community of love and not just a community of interests, a unity he himself perceived, was by no means the product of modern communication means or

¹⁹ Ibid., 275.

²⁰ Ibid.

²¹ Ibid., 276.

lower protective tariffs. According to Scheler, modern technological means only discovered Europeanism like an astronomer discovers a new star. Although the European world this star was the centre of was no universe, this did not mean, Scheler claimed, that the European world-view was only a narrowed-down version of a presumably reality-compliant “perception of the world.” Just as he saw the idea of human unity as no more than a theomorphism, he considered the conviction that the European world was closer to the world of “things in themselves,” or the world created by God, to be more a matter of faith than knowledge.

LUDWIG FERDINAND CLAUSS’S PSYCHOANTHROPOLOGY AND THE PHENOMENOLOGICAL MOVEMENT

The phenomenologist who devoted his life to the systematic study of race as a problem of being was one of Husserl’s Freiburg students—Ludwig Ferdinand Clauss. However, one would be hard put to find any closer information about his race theory in Herbert Spiegelberg’s history of the phenomenological movement. It was not until its 1982 third edition that mention was made about his role as one of Husserl’s unofficial assistants in Freiburg and subsequent turn to race psychology.²² In the *Husserl-Chronik* compiled by Karl Schuhmann we read that in the winter semester of 1917/18 Clauss attended and passed Husserl’s theory of judgment seminar.²³ Besides Peter Weingart’s 1995 book *Doppel-Leben* (Double life),²⁴ a few articles and some reference in writings on the history of racism,²⁵ the life and work of Ludwig Ferdinand Clauss is today rarely a subject of scholarly pursuit, especially in any connection with the phenomenological movement.²⁶

²² Spiegelberg, H. 1965. *The Phenomenological Movement. A Historical Introduction*, vol. 1. The Hague: Martinus Nijhoff, 249.

²³ Schuhmann, K. 1977. *Husserl-Chronik. Denk- und Lebenswerk Edmund Husserls* [The Husserl Chronicle. The Thought and Lifework of Edmund Husserl]. Den Haag: Martinus Nijhoff, 217 and 237.

²⁴ Weingart, P. 1995. *Doppel-Leben. Ludwig Ferdinand Clauss: Zwischen Rassenforschung und Widerstand* [Double Life. Ludwig Ferdinand Clauss: Between Racial Research and Resistance]. Frankfurt am Main: Campus.

²⁵ See: Gray, R. T. 2004. *About Face. German Physiognomic Thought from Lavater to Auschwitz*. Detroit: Wayne State University Press, 273–332; Conte É. C. Essner. 1995. *La quête de la race*, Paris: Hachette, 76–79; Hutton, Ch. M. 2005. *Race and the Third Reich*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 56–60; Walz, R. 1962. “Ludwig Ferdinand Clauss zum 70. Geburtstag. Die Entstehung einer Psychologie der Psyche” [Ludwig Ferdinand Clauss on His 70th Birthday. The Emergence of a Psychology of the Psyche]. *Jahrbuch für Psychologie, Psychotherapie und Medizinische Anthropologie* [Yearbook of Psychology, Psychotherapy and Medical Anthropology], 9, 149–165.

²⁶ One exception here is an article Bernasconi, R. 2013. “Ludwig Ferdinand Clauss and Racialisation.” In: Embree, L., Th. Nenon, (Ed.). *Husserl’s Ideen*. Dordrecht: Springer, 55–70.

However, there are strictly objective reasons for associating Ludwig Ferdinand Clauss with the phenomenological movement. All his three 1920s books—*Die nordische Seele* [The Nordic Soul, 1923],²⁷ *Rasse und Seele* [Race and Soul, 1926]²⁸ and its extended version *Von Seele und Antlitz der Rassen und Völker. Eine Einführung in die vergleichende Ausdrucksforschung* [The Soul and Physiognomy of Races and Peoples]. An introduction to comparative expression study, 1929)²⁹—can be perceived as an attempt to apply the phenomenological method to studies of race psychology.³⁰ As Clauss himself wrote in the preface to the first edition of the *Nordic Soul*, the phenomenological method enabled “a turn to the soul”³¹ and—as he noted in the preface to the first edition of *Race and Soul*—contributed to the clarification of the relation between the soul and the body.³² Most essential in this context, however, is his belief that the imaginative variation and primal insight method made it possible to overcome the natural paradigm in race research, freeing it from positivist prejudice and the need to produce a clear and strictly scientific concept of race.³³

Like Scheler, Clauss took up the race issue not only as a pure theoretical problem, but also for strictly practical reasons. However, where Scheler saw it as one of the founding blocks of European spiritual unity and consequently appealed for Europe’s support of Germany in its war for this unity, Clauss linked it to the unity of Germany itself. And, confronted with Germany’s defeat in the war for Europe against Europe, asked: “which races are active in the German nation through their blood, and which only through their ‘spirit,’ the standard-setting force of their works?.”³⁴ What Clauss was concerned about was the question “if the power of these standards has made us more German, or has rather led us away from our most innate essence?”³⁵

In the preface to the third edition of his richly illustrated main work *Race and Soul*, in which he developed on the race psychology conception Scheler outlined in *The Genius of War*, Clauss especially underscored its undeniable political importance. He reminded that already Bismarck saw the need for an “international psychology,” which he held for indispensable in diplomatic contacts with members of other cultures and nations. Clauss radicalised this and stated that in the post-war years there was an even greater need for a national

²⁷ Clauss, L. F. 1923. *Nordische Seele. Rettung, Prägung, Ausdruck* [The Nordic Soul. Salvation, Formation, Expression]. Halle: Max Niemeyer.

²⁸ Clauss, L. F. 1926. *Rasse und Seele* [Race and Soul]. München: Lehmann.

²⁹ Clauss, L. F. 1929. *Von Seele und Antlitz der Rassen und Völker* [The Soul and Physiognomy of Races and Peoples]. München: Lehmann.

³⁰ Bernasconi, R. 2013. *Ludwig Ferdinand Clauss and Racialisation*, op. cit., 55.

³¹ Clauss, L. F. 1923, op. cit., 9.

³² Clauss, L. F. 1926, op. cit., VI.

³³ Bernasconi, R. 2013, op. cit., 55.

³⁴ Clauss, L. F. 1938. *Rasse und Seele. Eine Einführung in den Sinn der leiblichen Gestalt* [Race and Soul. An Introduction to the Sense of Bodily Form]. Berlin: Büchergilde Gutenberg, 10.

³⁵ Ibid.

psychology, which he understood as knowledge about the psychological characteristics of one's nation and the races which formed it. From the perspective of 1938, the year in which, as he wrote, "the rule of internationalism in Germany ceased,"³⁶ Clauss argued that such knowledge should have been possessed by those who ruled the country, hence were also responsible for the well-being of the Germans, during the war. Clauss pointed out that the lack of this knowledge was why,

"towards the end of the war our enemies' psychological advantage manifested itself with terrifying force. [Indeed,] the Germans and their enemies did not only fight only on the battlefield, but also on numerous other fronts. They fought for the souls of the neutral states, and while the Germans carried away victory after victory on the battlefield, on this front they soon began to suffer only defeat."³⁷

Clauss openly declared, especially in the late-30s and World War Two editions of the *Race and Soul*, that the motives behind his studies of race psychology were instrumental, that in this way he wanted to play on the "soul of the masses." Aware that "the masses do not want logic, evidence, argumentation, only that their impulses, their emotions, good and bad, are played upon,"³⁸ he nonetheless shared Husserl's view that research should base on absolutely evident theoretical foundations. He wrote, "there is nothing I am more distant from than recommending Anglo-American false propaganda as a model to follow."³⁹ Clauss believed that in order to be able to resist such propaganda, "what others have at their fingertips the German must let pass through the eyes and head," hence Germans had a greater need of "theoretically grounded, but at the same time applicable, knowledge about Man"⁴⁰ than other nations. In Clauss's view such knowledge, obtained exclusively by scientific means, was to provide nothing beyond rigid formulas (*strenge Formeln*)—which, however, were simultaneously to serve as "a kind of manual in encounters with people of a different type than ourselves."⁴¹

The starting-point of Clauss's theory was his view on the human being as a psycho-physical entity, an approach he shared with Husserl and which broke with anthropological naturalism. As is occasionally pointed out, this theory was related to Husserl's inquiries into the constitution of human reality in the second volume of *Ideas*. Like Husserl, Clauss also concentrated on the human "psychised body," which, together with the soul (psyche) he saw as "two sides

³⁶ Ibid., 7.

³⁷ Ibid., 8.

³⁸ Ibid., 9.

³⁹ Ibid.

⁴⁰ Ibid.

⁴¹ Ibid.

of the same thing.”⁴² The breakthrough in the theory’s evolution was to be Husserl’s conclusion in *Ideas* that “no mere simple connection and perhaps no absolutely simultaneous connection can exist here and in fact there is none. The Body is not only in general a thing but is indeed expression of the spirit *and is at once organ of the spirit* (italics E. H.).”⁴³ Accordingly, also Clauss defined the body in relation to the psyche as a “stage” for the latter to express itself on⁴⁴ and saw bodily movements as “expressions of the mobility of the psyche.”⁴⁵

There was possibly a direct relation between Clauss’s investigations of race and his mentor’s research on constitution. As Richard Gray, for whom Clauss’s race psychology is a branch of German physiognomy “from Lavater to Auschwitz,” noted in his book, Clauss may have in a sense naturally regarded Husserl’s phenomenology as a theoretical “legitimation of physiognomic research.”⁴⁶ However, in view of the fact that the second volume of *Ideas*, which treats about the constitution of the natural and spiritual worlds, remained unpublished during Husserl’s lifetime, one may suspect a closer connection. Especially as this volume was edited by none other than Edith Stein, who, as Husserl’s chief assistant, also oversaw the work of younger scholars, among them Clauss, in a self-founded “philosophical kindergarten,”⁴⁷ simultaneously developing on the ideas contained in this then only emerging book in her doctoral work *On the Problem of Empathy*. Therefore, it appears by all means possible that Clauss arrived at his idea of “physical type” as the expression of a racially-determined human psyche among others through Stein’s research of the experience of others, which he must have surely been acquainted with. Indeed, as early as in 1917 Stein in one of the sections of her dissertation pointed to an alien body as the carrier of the phenomena of expression, “which in a specifically characteristic way enable us to access the broader sphere of the soul.”⁴⁸

Through the prism of the influence Edith Stein’s understanding of phenomenology’s tasks may have exerted on Clauss’s conceptions, the eidetic methods he applied in his studies of race can be seen as a continuation of the research program of the Munich and Göttingen realistic phenomenology school. The fact that Clauss himself called his research “psychoanthropological”⁴⁹ suggests connections with the ontology of the human psyche Stein was occupied with at the

⁴² Ibid., 57.

⁴³ Cf. Husserl, E. 1989. *Ideas Pertaining to a Pure Phenomenology and to a Phenomenological Philosophy—Second Book: Studies in the Phenomenology of Constitution*. Rojcewicz, R., A. Schuwer (Trans.). Dordrecht–Boston–London: Kluwer Academic Publishers, 102.

⁴⁴ Clauss, L. F. 1926, op. cit., 19.

⁴⁵ Clauss, L. F. 1943. *Rasse und Seele*, 18.

⁴⁶ Gray, R. T. 2004, op. cit., 243.

⁴⁷ Stein, E. 2014. *Letters to Roman Ingarden*. Hunt, H. C. (Trans.). Washington: ICS Publications, letter 18 from 31 May 1917.

⁴⁸ Stein, E. 1917. *Zur Problem der Einfühlung* [On the Problem of Empathy]. Halle: Buchdruckerei des Weissenhauses, 85f.

⁴⁹ Clauss, L. F. 1938. *Rasse und Seele*, 113.

time. Both Clauss's psychoanthropology and Stein's psychology of the person asked about Man's social, political and religious identity, hence were not empirical but ontological, and both sought for an in-depth description of this identity's "ontic structure."⁵⁰ In both cases the object was not to research human behaviour by the quantitative methods of the natural sciences, but qualitative study of the human psyche, for which Stein and Clauss used the traditional and phenomenologically explicated term "soul." However, where Stein focused on the distinction between the psyche and consciousness (or between the soul and the spirit) which is a constituting part of personal ontic structure, Clauss in his comparative psycho-racial studies occupied himself with the "soul" in its individual-experience-underlying distinction from "body."

RACE AS A STYLE OF EXPERIENCING OF THE WORLD

Despite his claims to pursue human science as an exact field which fully embraced the uniqueness of its research object, Clauss in his writings paid little attention to theory. In his frequently redrafted work *Race and Soul*, which by 1943 had gone into its eighteenth edition, he described his inquiries into racial psyche as "research which strives to seek out that which is racial, hence naturally conditioned, in human psychic life."⁵¹ This way Clauss achieved "a new, heretofore psychologically uninvestigated dimension of psychic existence,"⁵² and not so much accepted or rejected the "natural" biological conditionings of race as put them in methodological parentheses. "Our work is presuppositionless, it depends on itself,"⁵³ he wrote. Clauss did not research human races—which he described by the general term "human types" (*Menschenarten*)—as objectivistic and reductionistic constructs of the factual sciences but as rational creations (*Sinngebilde*) of everyday experience.⁵⁴

Thus, Clauss's racial physiognomy did not pursue race as "a combination of hereditary features of a specific variability determined by genotype, which manifests itself in an objectively measurable way in the human phenotype."⁵⁵ What for him made a human type a "type" in the racial sense was the "way of experiencing" (*Erlebensweise*), which was not so much objectively embedded in the

⁵⁰ See: Beckmann-Zöllner, B. 2010. "Einführung" [Introduction]. In: Stein, E. *Beiträge zur philosophischen Begründung der Psychologie und der Geisteswissenschaften* [Philosophy of Psychology and the Humanities], Edith Stein Gesamtausgabe" [The Collected Works of Edith Stein], vol. 6. Freiburg–Basel–Wien: Herder, XXI.

⁵¹ Clauss, L. F. 1943. *Rasse und Seele*, 20, 9.

⁵² Ibid.

⁵³ Clauss, L. F. 1938, op. cit., 123.

⁵⁴ Cf. Clauss, L. F. 1934. *Rassenseelenforschung im täglichen Leben* [Race Soul Research in Daily Life]. Berlin: Brehm, 14.

⁵⁵ Cf. Saller, K. 1930. *Leitfaden der Anthropologie* [Leading Threads in Anthropology]. Berlin: Verlag von Julius Springer, 133.

body, as found in it a form of rational expression. These ways of human experiencing, Clauss wrote, which “differed in every race” and determined races as races, could not be investigated by “even the closest observation,” nor by “definition, notes or comparisons and statistical surveys of individual features.”⁵⁶ As Clauss remarked, the essence of race as a phenomenon experienced naturally in the living world eluded him to the extent in which descriptive natural science (*beschreibende Naturkunde*), which based on observation, “grasped and gathered only the external shreds of life.”⁵⁷ Differently from “birds in the woods” or “flies on the windowpane,” Clauss wrote, plain observation of the forms in which human life took place did not enable insight into the race-determined “soul”⁵⁸ by way of the body as a sphere through which this life expressed itself.

According to Clauss the only source of research into expression forms was “co-living, coexperiencing with those we want to examine in an understanding way.”⁵⁹ Consequently, understanding expression was “coexperiencing the experience that expression expressed.”⁶⁰ In Clauss’s variant the co-living and coexperience method meant that the expression researcher, “still under the first, general impression made on him by a specific living human being,” first became aware of the “disposability of this phenomenon” and only then gradually penetrated to its “living diversity.”⁶¹ Clauss also called this method “mimic,” because the expression scholar who used it was to participate in the life of the examined human being “to the extent to which circumstances allowed”—“walk with his footsteps, move like he moved, speak his language, love with his love, be angry with his anger, happy with his happiness, and suffer with his suffering.”⁶² It was only on the ground of thus-effected co-experience of the life forms of individual people that Clauss pursued “types” or “figural ideas” (*Gestalt-Ideen*)—“a plan according to which a specific human being is created (*geschaffen*), and which it (perhaps imperfectly) embodies.”⁶³

In the context of the first volume of *Ideas*, which Clauss had thorough knowledge of, his “mimic method” can, in a sense, be defined by Husserl’s term as a “regional eidetic.”⁶⁴ Thus, the “leading thread” of his studies were “human types” he identified as “races,” which were given in daily experience and differed in the way they were experienced, and whose investigation by the mimic method was to enable the creation of a “race soul science” as a material-

⁵⁶ Clauss, L. F. 1938, op. cit., 113.

⁵⁷ Ibid.

⁵⁸ Ibid.

⁵⁹ Ibid.

⁶⁰ Ibid.

⁶¹ Ibid.

⁶² Ibid., 117.

⁶³ Ibid., 115.

⁶⁴ See: Husserl, E. 1983. *Ideas Pertaining to a Pure Phenomenology and to a Phenomenological Philosophy—First Book: General Introduction to a Pure Phenomenology*. Kersten, F. (Trans.). The Hague–Boston–Lancaster: Martinus Nijhoff, 18f.

ontological discipline. Clauss's thus-established science was also to provide "an essential theoretical fundament" for empirical studies of race, which, according to his observations, negated but could not quite avoid essential intuition. In such research, Clauss wrote, "there could be no talk of 'race' at all if the subject of their (even unconscious) inquiry were not figural ideas whose accepted representatives are individual people ordered into groups described as 'races'."⁶⁵

Clauss's mimic studies of the racially-determined differences in expression forms could also be called a "critique" of race in the Kantian sense of the term, or a quest after the limits to which it can be experienced. Because the object of these studies was to be race understood as a "figural idea" or "primal model," race, Clauss wrote, "like all form, is what it is through its contours, through its boundary. Exploring the psychology of races (*Seelenkunde der Rassen*) is exploring boundaries."⁶⁶ Whereby he stressed that in this context form did not refer exclusively to the body but "concerned humans as a whole, hence also their experience of their psyche, which expresses itself through their bodies."⁶⁷ Clauss believed that only mimic study of human beings in their entire concreteness, as a whole together with their social lives, enabled discovery of the regularity which determined human types and all that they experienced. This regularity, which he explored, he called the "racial style" of human experience and wrote: "the human experiences in a certain way, which we call the style in which it experiences and which it presents always and constantly."⁶⁸

Thus, the main category in Clauss's race psychology studies was the earlier mentioned rhetoric-derived concept of "style," which already in the Romantic period gave birth to a number of physiognomic conceptions.⁶⁹ Jean Paul followed Comte de Buffon in calling style "the second, pliable body of the spirit," Schopenhauer spoke about the "physiognomy"⁷⁰ of style, and Clauss used the term for what distinguished races from each other. Indeed, Clauss was fully aware of the complex historical context surrounding the style category. "This term is ambiguous"—he admitted—and used in a different sense in other sciences, for instance to describe the variations in the cultures related to a given period.⁷¹ This understanding of style derived from art history, but in Clauss's view was also applicable to race psychology. As he observed: "The here-applied idea of style has some connection with what is called style in the history of art. Our concept of style differs from the other but both are related."⁷²

⁶⁵ Clauss, L. F. 1938, op. cit., 115.

⁶⁶ Clauss, L. F. 1943, op. cit., 13–14.

⁶⁷ Ibid.

⁶⁸ Ibid., 118–119.

⁶⁹ See: Müller, W. G. 1998. "Stil." In: *Historisches Wörterbuch der Philosophie* [A Historical Dictionary of Philosophy], vol. 10. Ritter, J., K. Gründer, G. Gabriel (Eds.). Basel: Schwabe, 152.

⁷⁰ Ibid.

⁷¹ Clauss, L. F. 1943, op. cit., 33.

⁷² Ibid., 34.

Therefore, otherwise than the naturalistic racial ideology of National Socialism, Clauss believed race was not determined by somatically-conditioned individual properties. In his opinion such properties could only be found in individuals, while race had to do with the style and expression of their psychological experiencing.⁷³ “The racial-psychological factor,” Clauss remarked, “does not lie in such-and-such a characteristic, but rather in the manner in which these characteristics express themselves with each individual.”⁷⁴ As Richard Gray observed in his study of German physiognomy, the core of Clauss’s conception, and what mainly distinguished it from the theories of anthropologists who investigated the biology of race, was that he made race more a matter of “form” than “content.”⁷⁵ For Clauss, Gray wrote, “race was not manifested in the substance of the body or an individual’s personality, but rather in the style in which that which was psychophysically given expressed itself.”⁷⁶

Together with the art-history-borrowed category of style Clauss—similarly to Karl Mannheim’s sociology of knowledge, which also referred to this category—inherited (and at least admitted) its typical relativism. In his introduction to the 1943 edition of *Race and Soul* devoted to the “issue of values,” Clauss refuted accusations against German racial research, which was blamed for its treatment of the Nordic race as the only one of value and others as inferior. The immediate cause of his quest was a critique of the “findings of racial studies” in Germany in the April 30, 1938 issue of the daily *Osservatore Romano*, which also openly attacked his own position. Where “evidence” of the German racial theoreticians’ conviction about the superiority of the Nordic race “meets with belief,” Clauss wrote in his explanation why he considered it important to reject this critique, “there it indeed speaks against us, the more so if the term ‘Nordic’, so easily misinterpreted by laymen, is accompanied by trite and ridiculous associations.”⁷⁷

In his reply to the said accusations in his introduction, Clauss called it a misconception to “create the impression that German racial science gives each race its individual grades like a teacher grading his pupils, that it, therefore, in a sense orders races and allots the top position among them to the Nordic race.”⁷⁸ While he conceded that such claims could be found in some German and foreign “books and pamphlets,” Clauss himself staunchly claimed that,

“from the beginning, the psychology of race clearly teaches us that each race finds ultimate value in itself [...] In the final analysis it is the only factor that determines racial-spiritual values. Every race bears within itself its own val-

⁷³ Clauss, L. F. 1938, op. cit., 124.

⁷⁴ Clauss, L. F. 1943, op. cit., 17.

⁷⁵ Gray, R. T. 2004, op. cit., 287.

⁷⁶ Ibid.

⁷⁷ Clauss, L. F. 1943, op. cit., 15.

⁷⁸ Ibid.

ue system and standard of excellence; and no race can be evaluated by the standards of any other race.”⁷⁹

In his view measuring the value of races by science, whose investigations were strictly comparative, ran against fundamental logic. Clauss rejected the possibility of stating any “tangible hierarchy of value” with regard to races and observed that “the value of a given human race could be ‘objectively’ established only by a human being who itself stood above races. However, such a human being does not exist, because to be human is to be racially conditioned. Maybe God knows the hierarchy of races, but we do not.”⁸⁰

In his book Clauss goes out from Scheler’s idea of the world’s “multiversality” to present his own phenomenological race psychology as a presuppositionless and value-free science. As he remarked, the statement that each race represented the highest value in itself was also to be the fundament of German race policy, and printed on tables with illustrations of the human races which the Nazi Party’s Office of Racial Policy put up in German schools.⁸¹ Thus, in his response to *Osservatore Romano*’s charge that German science identified races by those or other properties it ascribed to them, he felt compelled to distance himself from official Nazi racial policy in this respect. Contrary to this “policy,” according to which the Nordic race distinguished itself from other races by its analytical skills, activity, sense of responsibility, conscientiousness and heroism, Clauss claimed that these and other properties were evident in other races to the same degree. In his view racial difference lay only in the way in which these properties manifested themselves, hence races differed not in their properties but the earlier-mentioned style.⁸²

Insofar as Clauss considered racial difference to lie not in the material, measurable properties of races but the qualitative psychological regularities which determined the style in which they experienced the world, he considered the very question about their greater or smaller value nonsensical. “Each in his own way, each in his own style,” he wrote.⁸³ The application of race psychology’s findings on the degree to which these styles could differ in international and colonial policy was to serve nothing but the fulfilment of Bismarck’s and Scheler’s hopes that this will prove useful in encounters with differently-formed people. The aim of race psychology, Clauss emphasised, “is not to divide but connect nations to the extent in which it fosters scientifically explained communication between different types of people.”⁸⁴

⁷⁹ Ibid., 16.

⁸⁰ Ibid.

⁸¹ Ibid.

⁸² Ibid.

⁸³ Ibid.

⁸⁴ Ibid.

The reception of Ludwig Ferdinand Clauss's psychoanthropology in the 1920s and 30s was essentially conditioned by the fact that his race research method inscribed itself into a discourse commonly considered as scientific in the Germany of his day.⁸⁵ This widespread scientific atmosphere was also largely responsible for the popularity of other philosophical anthropology conceptions, for instance those Max Scheler and Helmuth Plessner developed at the time in opposition to politically instrumentalised studies of the human being through the prism of race.⁸⁶ Owing to their philosophical character, however, neither Scheler's and Plessner's philosophical anthropology nor Clauss's race psychology met the criteria of an "objective" science in light of the physical anthropology which dominated in Germany at the time. This was so, because the general opinion was that they bypassed the necessity to "base race psychology on empirical foundations, a necessity which is crucial in race research which resorts to the inductive method," which physical anthropology propounded.⁸⁷

An expertise of Clauss's race psychology, carried out for the needs of a party court before which he was placed in 1943 in connection with hiding his Jewish assistant from the police, flatly branded it as a "phenomenological theory."⁸⁸ The objection was against its insufficient acknowledgement of the fact that the style of experiencing with which Clauss identified race was also to a large degree determined by the environment, and that it was therefore impossible to separate racial heritage from influences which shaped style.⁸⁹ According to the expertise authors, Clauss undertook no attempt to confirm the hereditary constancy of the style of experiencing empirically, nor was he able to prove that that what he was investigating were really differences in psychic expression conditioned by racial heritage and not the environment. Although Clauss himself believed that the mimic coexistence method, which based on intuitive insight and the ability to co-experience, enabled him to distinguish between the racially-inherited and environmentally-conditioned in the stylistic structure of the psyche and body, from the perspective of physical anthropology this was seen as a strictly "subjective" approach.

However, as a style-related phenomenological race psychology Clauss's theory seemed to meet all the requirement of the realistic phenomenology pursued by Scheler, Stein and other Husserl students. Indeed, insofar as its starting-point were anthropological theories held for scientific in the then intellectual context, it in fact sought nothing else but to provide them with ontological

⁸⁵ Cf. Weingart, P. 1995, op. cit., 92.

⁸⁶ Cf. Fischer, J. 2009. *Philosophische Anthropologie. Eine Denkrichtung des 20. Jahrhunderts* [Philosophical Anthropology. A 20th-Century Line of Thought]. Freiburg–München: Karl Alber, 181.

⁸⁷ Cf. Weingart, P. 1995, op. cit., 82.

⁸⁸ Ibid., 83.

⁸⁹ Ibid.

grounding by way of eidetic research—which was absolutely in keeping with the realistic phenomenology program. A separate question is to what extent the race problem Clauss encountered upon his path can be regarded as one of the rational “problems of being” from the perspective of Edmund Husserl’s transcendental phenomenology. If it cannot be, it would seem important to answer the question to what extent, in light of its transcendental character, also the end of the career of race as a political concept was terminated by science, and to what extent by ideology.

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR — a philosopher and translator from German. Associated Professor at the Institute of Philosophy and Sociology of the Polish Academy of Sciences, Nowy Świat 72, 00–330 Warsaw, Poland (affiliation). His main fields of interests are phenomenology, history of ideas and political theory. He wrote among others: 1996. *Philosophy and Guillotine. The Traditionalism of Joseph de Maistre as a Political Hermeneutics*; 2007. *Antinomies of Radicalism. Political Phenomenology in Germany 1914–1933*; 2015. *Politics and Geometry. Edmund Husserl and the Problem of Democracy*;

E-mail: agniazdo@ifispan.waw.pl

Mansoorah Khalilzand

THE STRUCTURE OF THE BODY DYNAMICS: TELEOLOGY OF THE INSTINCTS AND THE INTENTIONALITY OF THE BODILY MOTIONS

ABSTRACT

One of the constitutional moments of the structure of kinesthesia—that is the motions of the body—is the practical orientedness of motions towards something. In this article I will deal with this structural moment in the practical life of the subject. I will first differentiate between teleology in the instinctive movements of the body and the intentionality in the practical activities of the subject. Whereas the former refers to the primary and instinctive orientedness of the bodily motions toward something generally determined fulfilling the instinctive needs of the body, the latter is to be understood as the pre-reflexive orientedness of the bodily motions toward a goal in the practical sphere of subject-life. At the end I will examine Husserl's idea of the universal teleological structure of reason, which has its roots in the primary instinctive life of the subject.

Keywords: instinct, teleology, intentionality, primordial body, kinesthesia, practical synthesis.

1. INTRODUCTION

In his phenomenological discourse, Husserl's intended clarification of the transcendental function and structure of the instincts in the life of the subject has been already extensively analyzed in many respects and further developed. Here I primarily refer to Nam-In Lee's book *Phänomenologie der Instinkte* in which these themes are systematically elaborated.¹ However, what stands out in

¹ Nam-In Lee. 1993. *Edmund Husserls Phänomenologie der Instinkte*. Dordrecht, 225. On this topic see also: Bernet, R. 2013. *Force-Pulsion-Désir. Une autre philosophie de la psychanalyse*. Paris, 299; idem. 2006. "Zur Phänomenologie von Trieb und Lust bei Husserl." In: Lohmar, D., D. Fonfara (Eds.). *Interdisziplinäre Perspektiven der Phänomenologie*. Dordrecht, 38–53; Depraz, N. 2001. "Pulsion, instinct, désir. Que signifie Trieb chez Husserl? – A l'épreuve des

this book is the significant absence of a concept of the body, with the help of which the body-relatedness of the instincts and thus the nature in the subject could be clearly articulated. The body-relatedness of the instincts is not clearly expressed by Husserl either. The instincts, like the motions of the body, i.e. the kinesthesia, are to a great extent reduced to their mere transcendental function by him.

However, below I will not develop this critical insight. Rather, I will convey Husserl's concrete description of instinctive processes and the experienced teleology within them in a general way and reconstruct the addressed body- and nature-relatedness in them. Further, I will address the intentional structure of the body activities of the subject which, as will be demonstrated, proceeds the instinctive processes in the nature of the subject.

Of great importance in doing so is the difference that is made between two dynamic-practical structures in the experience of the body. I refer to the teleological structure as long as it concerns the body as an organic nature in the subject and the passive but not the mechanical orientation of instincts towards something generally determined; more precisely something predetermined.² The intentionality will be applied when the dynamic of free bodily motions in the practical sphere of the life of the subject is to be analyzed. The intentionality of the bodily motions, the kinesthesia, in this context implies a continual tendency towards something that evolves through and in manifold motions, and ultimately constitutes the action. The practical intentionality persists through the multiplicity of bodily motions and synthesizes them towards a goal.³ Over the course of the analysis, it will become more clear why two different terms, i.e. "teleology" and "intentionality," are here applied, why the passive dynamics of the instinctive processes and motions of the body—different from the ones in the

perspectives de Freud, Merleau-Ponty, Jonas et Scheler." *Alter (La pulsion)*, 9, 113–125. For a sketchy description of the intentionality of the instinct and drive within the Monadology of Husserl see: Strasser, S. 1975. "Grundgedanken der Sozialontologie Edmund Husserls." *Zeitschrift für philosophische Forschung*, vol. 29, 15; Bower, M.E.M. 2014. "Husserl's Theorie of Instincts as a Theory of Affection." *The Journal of the British Society for Phenomenology*, 133–147; Pugliese, A. 2009. "Triebphäre und Urkindheit des Ich." *Husserl Studies*, vol. 25, 2, 141–157.

² On the theme of the teleological structure of the bodily dynamics cf. Bernet, R. 2013. *Force-Pulsion-Desir. Une autre Philosophie de la Psychoanalyse*. Paris, 314.

³ It was Merleau-Ponty who first systematically and consequently surveys the bodily-practical intentionality extensively. Merleau-Ponty coins the expression "intentional arc", with which the specifically bodily intentionality in the practical sphere of the subject's life and the specifically bodily intentionality in the practical sphere thematized. See Merleau-Ponty, M. 1962. *Phenomenology of Perception*. London, xvii, 137, 243. In this regard see also: Waldenfels, B. 2000. *Das leibliche Selbst. Vorlesungen zur Phänomenologie des Leibes*. Frankfurt am Main, 144 ff; Kristensen, S. 2012. „Maurice Merleau-Ponty, Körperschema und leibliche Subjektivität." In: *Leiblichkeit. Geschichte und Aktualität eines Konzeptes*. Alloa, E.T., C. Bedorf, Grüny, Klass (Eds.). Tübingen, 23–36, especially 30 ff.; Schnell, A. 2012. "Leib und Leiblichkeit bei Maurice Merleau-Ponty und Marc Richir." In: *Gelebter Leib—verkörpertes Leben. Neue Beiträge zur Phänomenologie der Leiblichkeit*. Staudigl, M. (Eds.). Würzburg, 73–97.

bodily motions during acts—are defined as teleological. However the inevitable distinction in the theoretical branch should not prevent us from acknowledging the connection and fusion of these processes in their factual implementation.

2. INSTINCTIVE-TELEOLOGICAL DYNAMIC IN THE PRIMAL BODY

In the beginning of the life of the subject the instinctive needs awaken sequentially in their vagueness. In this phase, the practical consciousness regarding the ways and means of the fulfillment of these needs and their required concrete capabilities, as well as the consciousness regarding these needs in their differentiation, are missing. “As long as an instinctive need has not been fulfilled, the missing thing, which would satisfy the need, is unknown ...”⁴

Only “through the fulfillment” could the instincts be constituted in their “definiteness” and “differentiation.”⁵ At the beginning, there is a fully undifferentiated sphere of needs, powers and motions, and across from it, on the noematic side, stands “the dark horizon of fulfilling things, inanely undetermined at the beginning.”⁶ Something makes the newborn restless: “something is missing.” Only later, after the periodic repetition of the awakening and the fulfillment of the needs, the needs of the early, dark spheres differentiate and evolve. Only after this process will they be experienced as the absence of something generally determined.

The capability of goal-setting, which is a result of the primary differentiation of the needs, and thereby perceiving the satisfying objects is apparently a simple ability in the practical life of the subject; yet, from the genetic-phenomenological point of view, it is already a very developed capability: “Only later the baby has space with spatial bodies and the mother as body in his spatial field. Initially is the mother as the identical, the recognized and as ‘premise’ for the fulfillment of the desire; when she comes and is there, the fulfillment happens.”⁷

The forming of these capabilities—i.e. the capability of the goal setting after the constitution and the recognition of the objects as “efficient,” “comfortable” and “enjoyable” that are motivated by instinctive primary needs—occurs evidently in an intersubjective context and is shaped through the culture and tradition in which the subject lives and builds his history. Therefore, the goal settings in this context do not follow the objectively existing order of valued objects. For example, something that is regarded as a delicacy in a specific dining culture can be totally unappealing in another. In this sense the goal settings car-

⁴ Husserliana XLII, 84.

⁵ Ibid., 84–85.

⁶ Ibid., 85.

⁷ Husserliana XV, 605.

ry in them already a historicity, which implies a history of family, society, and tradition.

The instinctive needs of the primal body motivate the constitution of the objects. These objects alternatively serve the differentiation of the needs and additionally their refinement. In this sense, the growing refinement and revelation occur simultaneously on both the noetic and noematic sides. Through the compact experience of the instinct-fulfilling objects, the needs refine and reshape themselves in the course of the subject's life as well.⁸ This way, at the beginning the instinct of hunger is merely targeted towards the food consumption and satiety, but it gradually evolves into an aesthetic need; for example it always seeks the more pleasant tasting, delicious and enjoyable food. This way it improves and refines itself constantly.

The bodily dimension of the life of the subject that is already awakened in the embryonic phase will never disintegrate itself as a result of the development of the subject's life. It rather slips into the darkness, so to speak, becoming more and more under the visible scene of the life of consciousness as well as the acts of the subject, and there it continues to function.⁹ "The instincts undergo modification, but they are always there. The repressed drive is itself a mode of the same drive, etc. The genesis within the constitution of the given world always already implies drive and instinct."¹⁰

Now the irresolvable and constantly efficient sphere of the nature in the subject and its life do not remain without consequence. It builds rather a structure, a teleologically functioning system, which generally sketches out the constitution of the higher layers of the objects. Husserl refers to the ideal of clarification of the constitution of the world based on the primary instincts that comprise the constitution of the ethical and the values of reason as well:

"The primal child and its 'instinctive' world-relatedness—it grows up generatively among the adults, it begins with primary needs, and primary pleasures, and increasingly new needs and pleasures always arise on the basis of the old ones—in the sociality of the generatively self-renewing, self-maintaining. A single system of drives, drive-fulfillments, goal-settings, purpose-buildings: world constitution."¹¹

The nature is not separate from the subject and its conscious life, and the consciousness does not build an access only through which the subject could approach the nature indirectly. The subject lives and experiences the nature

⁸ Cf. *Husserliana* XXXIX, 476.

⁹ This is a famous metaphor of Merleau-Ponty: the body is like "the darkness needed in the theatre to show up the performance." See Merleau-Ponty, M. 1962, op. cit., 87.

¹⁰ *Husserliana* XLII, 102.

¹¹ *Ibid.*, 222.

rather indirectly, in its phenomenological givenness and proximity. The consciousness is awakened and generally oriented by nature before it can understand and subsequently objectify and idealize nature: "The ego in primary beginning (the primary birth) is already ego-oriented instincts."¹² With it, "the constitution of the first surrounding world is regulated from there."¹³ This phenomenologically experienced nature, about which the natural sciences can only give a quantitative and mathematized interpretation, stimulates motion, practice, perception of objects and subsequently their evaluation.

The teleological dynamic of the instincts and their significant constitutive function in the transcendental life of the subject are indeed analyzed by Husserl. He explicitly articulates the relativity of the activities of life through the primal passive sphere of instincts as well. Nevertheless, he is far from viewing this sphere as nature and he does not problematize the concrete space- and body-relatedness of these instincts, their establishment in the non-transparent and anonymously functioning organic nature of the subject. How can consciousness and its subject, which constitutes nature, be formed through nature and even be nature itself? This is the fundamental difficulty that brings the idea of a subject, which is profoundly determined by its own bodily nature, into trouble.

In addition, the central question that arises is how we, i.e. the finished subjects, can retrieve the primal naïve dimension of the subject's life and the primal beginnings of our awakening "in order to shed some phenomenological light in this darkness."¹⁴ How can we remind ourselves of the dark and forgotten past of the subject's life? It is by no means secured from the beginning that phenomenology has sufficient theoretical media to re-find this obviously lost phase of life at its disposal. Husserl, on his part, raises the question of how and whether he can move himself as a phenomenologist into this research field: "[W]hat I can reconstructively and yet a priori state about the necessary structure of the first childhood, from which the second must stem, about the 'forgotten' constitution. Meanwhile the necessity of such oblivion is to be eventually explained as well."¹⁵

Not only on the passive-instinctive level is the concealed dynamic of the body with its functions involved, not only in the body, provided that it is understood as an organic nature in the subject. Likewise, in the practical dimension of the subject's life is the form, respectively the structure of the bodily dynamic, clearly very effective. Therefore it can be justifiably claimed that the analysis of the functionality of the bodily motions in the practical sphere belongs neces-

¹² Husserlina XXXIX, 477.

¹³ Ibid., 475.

¹⁴ Husserl, E. 2001. *Analyses Concerning Passive and Active Synthesis. Lectures on Transcendental Logic*. Steinbock, A. J. (Trans.). Edmund Husserl Collected Works IX. Dordrecht–Boston–London, 201.

¹⁵ Husserliana XXXIX, 468.

sarily to a phenomenology of acts, provided that, as Ludwig Landgrebe believes, it should stay loyal to the concrete experience of the act.¹⁶ Hereafter I attempt to closely investigate, above all, the dynamic structure of the bodily motions and their connection to the passive-instinctive sphere of the subject's life.

3. KINESTHETIC INTENTIONALITY AND THE PRACTICAL SYNTHESIS

The needs that disturb the body in its primary state are not experienced distinctively—exactly like the means that satisfy them. Moreover, the needs in the embryonic phase are not distinguished from their satisfying means. The absolute intimate ties between the body of the embryo and its surroundings, which satisfy the needs of the embryo, do not allow it to experience the specific “my-ness” of the body vis-a-vis all of the other things in its surroundings.¹⁷ The embryonic body is completely integrated in the nature and in the natural processes, in the body of the mother. “The child inside the body of the mother already has kinesthesia and his kinesthetically moving ‘things’.”¹⁸ However, a motion that should be conducive to the fulfillment of a need can be clearly realized first in the newborn. Only after birth can a detachment between the needs and the means that fulfill them emerge; this detachment motivates the motions of the body and later demands the refinement of these motions when the needs become complicated.

With the development of the bodily motions, the subject will come across a variety of objects and ways that are conducive to the satisfying of its needs; this situation actually motivates the reflection on the practical possibilities. The reflection that at the beginning involves the concrete, practical moments of the action can later be removed from this ground and moves itself towards merely theoretical realms: “I infringe on the horizon—at first practically, then out of curiosity and ‘theoretical’ interests.”¹⁹

The primary bodily needs bring the newborn into restlessness so that it initially moves itself unskillfully and aimlessly. However, these motions, which at the beginning are still unformed and uncontrolled, later shape themselves during the course of a practical life of the subject and to some extent through conscious goal-oriented exercises. Consequently, they build a consistent system of manifold motions, that belong to the organs of the body and nevertheless can be consistently and harmonically moved towards reaching a unique goal or satisfaction

¹⁶ See Landgrebe, L. 1976. “Die Phänomenologie als transzendente Theorie der Geschichte.” *Phänomenologische Forschungen*, vol. 3, München, 35.

¹⁷ Cf. Husserliana XIV, 58. See also: Pugliese, A. 2009, op. cit., 144.

¹⁸ Husserliana XV, 604.

¹⁹ Ibid., 564.

of one of the needs.²⁰ How is e.g. the movement of the lips to be understood when a newborn sucks in breast milk? Regarding this, Husserl writes: “As soon as the smell of the mother’s breasts and the sensation of touching the lips happen, an instinctive tendency towards drinking is awakened, and an originally adapted kinesthesia comes into play.”²¹ Do we have to presume that some body motions, even when they are very basic and limited, are already instinctively evolved from the very beginning so that the fundamental instinct of self-preservation, that constant attempt to live and survive, can be fulfilled? Is this practical synthesis with a specific motive, goal and a relevant body motion that leads to the accomplishment of the need, nothing but the work of nature? Is it the nature of the subject itself, which generates a synthesis before consciousness comes into play? Are not the traces of a history visible in bodily motions that precede the practical life of the body of the subject, as well as capabilities and abilities, from which one cannot tell that they have been acquired? Here it involves mainly the capability of the synthesis in the practical sense that exists in the very beginning of the subject’s life before every conscious goal setting and practical reflection. Birth in this sense is not an absolute beginning. The history of nature precedes the primal body and its kinesthetic activities.²²

Husserl repeatedly speaks of “foundedness of the kinestheses and also the acts of volition in instincts” and in addition “the impact of the instincts in the kinesthesia”²³ in a clear way: “primary drives and instincts are not mechanical forces. They are the sources of all of the competences, all of the competence systems.”²⁴

The pure bodily needs of the subject’s nature urge their fulfillment, which are only going to be realized with the help of bodily-subjective motions, i.e. the kinestheses. Not only the kinestheses that are conductive to the satisfaction of the needs, but also the periodically awakened bodily-natural needs are subjectively given moments in this process. This implies that the experience of hunger

²⁰ The body as the practical-functional unity, to which the constitution of all the material syntheses is conditioned, is thoroughly examined and discussed by Merleau-Ponty particularly in the *Phenomenology of Perception* under the term of “body schema.” This concept, which originates from the field of neurology and psychology, obtains a phenomenological-philosophical interpretation by him. The body schema is a system of practical capability of the body, which evolves in the context of the factual-practical surrounding. On this topic see Kristensen, S., M. Merleau-Ponty. 2012. „Körperschema und leibliche Subjektivität.“ In: *Leiblichkeit. Geschichte und Aktualität eines Konzeptes*. Alloa, K., Bedorf, Grüny, Klass (Eds.). Tübingen, 23–36; Gallagher, S. 2005. “Dynamic Models of Body Schematic Processes.” In: *Body Image and Body Schema*. De Preester, H., V. Knockaert (Eds.). Amsterdam–Philadelphia, 233–250.

²¹ Husserlina Materialien VII, 326.

²² This natural history that precedes my body and me can be viewed as bodily dimension of the past, “which has never been a present.” See Merleau-Ponty, M. 1962, op. cit., 217. In this regard see also Waldenfels, B. 1983. *Phänomenologie in Frankreich*. Frankfurt am Main, 166.

²³ Husserliana XV, 599; see also Husserlina Materialien VIII, 328 and Husserliana XLII, 104.

²⁴ Husserliana XLII, 102.

cannot be sufficiently explained as the absence of nutritional substances in the physical-biological body. The hunger is experienced rather in its phenomenality, and thus merely biological or mechanical explanations cannot appropriately clarify it. "Primal drives and instincts are not mechanical forces"²⁵ and the question regarding its impact on subjective kinestheses is not a question about the manner of the impact of an external cause on the subject's life. Instinct is the name for a special element in the experienced nature of the subject. We call this dimension nature, not only because of its anonymity or the relative independence of its dynamic vis a vis the subject. It is indeed true that the subject must experience forces in itself, over which it hardly holds power. They function uncontrollably and attract the practical intentionality and the attention of the subject towards itself. It is the anonymous forces of the nature that are directly experienced by the subject. They can be to some extent dominated and thus cultivated. However, as long as the subject lives bodily in the world, this anonymously functioning dynamic of nature in the subject cannot be deactivated and obliterated from the sphere of its life. Yet, this is not everything that makes us define the instinctive dimension of the subject's life as nature in the subject.

In the body we are given a multiplicity of characteristics and dynamic connections that we rediscover and recognize as well in our surrounding world and nature. The bodily experiences are codetermined by a phenomenological experience of our organic body, which distinguish themselves through a specific density, severity and extension. Exactly in this sense the body is the nature, more precisely, the subject's nature, and according to Landgrebe "the source of all our ideas" of space and special-mechanical relations.²⁶

Through analysis of the anonymously functioning nature of the subject in the passive sphere of the subject's life, Husserl develops a remarkably rich terminology that enables him to penetrate the dark "natural side of the subject" and the thematization of its dynamic.²⁷ Thereby no anthropology is intended. Husserl's position remains—and he is always going to be insistent about it—strictly transcendental.²⁸ He attempts to clarify the inherent structure of instincts and their dynamics, which further form the life as early as its primal beginning and generally sketches out the direction of its further constitutions. "Every transcendental I", as Husserl says, "has its innateness"²⁹ and this is not different from

²⁵ Ibid.

²⁶ Landgrebe, L. 1977. "Das Problem der Teleologie und der Leiblichkeit in der Phänomenologie und im Marxismus." In: *Phänomenologie und Marxismus I*. Waldenfels, B. J. M. Broekman, A. Pazanin (Eds.). Frankfurt am Main, 83; see also Dodd, J. 1997. *Idealism and Corporeity. An Essay on the Problem of the Body in Husserl's Phenomenology*. Dordrecht, 64.

²⁷ See Husserliana IV, 279 and 338.

²⁸ See Husserliana XLII, 111 and 120. The phenomena related to "natural I" (Husserl) like the problems of sleep, birth and death are approached in their transcendality: See Husserliana XLII, Texts 1, 2.

²⁹ Husserliana XLII, 121.

the instinctive state of the awakening of I. “The I of the constitutive beginnings is not an empty I-pole and the beginning of affection is not fully undetermined, it is already instinct-affection.”³⁰

The factual mode of being of the subject in its primary beginning implies in itself the teleological dynamic, i.e. the uncontrollably occurring motions and changes, under a generally determined structure and regulation. In a frequently quoted passage, Husserl speaks about the factual and irrational primal state of subjectivity that, precisely because of the implied teleology inside of it, is not less important than the origin and the entelechy of rationality and reason.³¹

“This innate primal essence, the primary state of the I presupposed for the whole constitution. In it is the constituted world with its essential forms, and the universe of rationality statically and ‘genetically’ determined. In this way the innate state of subjectivity is the irrational state, that makes the rationality possible, or its rationality lies in its being the ‘teleological base’ for everything rational.”³²

Husserl’s reflections on theology, which is already given in the experience of the factual dynamic of the subject-nature as well as the functionality of the instinctive and bodily needs and their fulfillment, lead to the idea of a “universal Teleology” and connect with the context of comprehensive insights on intersubjectivity, the constitution of reason, the historicity of the world constitution and monadology.³³ Husserl talks as well about the idea of a god that, according to him, is phenomenologically possible and legitimate, which as “idea of the absolutely Good” and as “infinite absolute value” enables the inner and relative development of the whole monadic system in the direction of something eternally good.³⁴

³⁰ Husserliana XXXIX, 474.

³¹ In this regard Husserl writes: “Im Triebssystem liegt schon die Anlage für die gesamte Weltkonstitution als Entelechie.” See: Husserliana XLII, 102.

³² Husserliana XLII, 116.

³³ This aspect in Husserl’s philosophy has been already extensively explored in various respects in the research literature. To teleology as the constitutive moment of action see: Tengelyi, L. 2014. *Welt und Unendlichkeit*. Freiburg–München: Karl Alber, 368; Sepp, H.-P. 1992. *Praxis und Theoria. Husserls transzendentalphänomenologische Rekonstruktion des Lebens*. München, 247. Regarding the teleology and a phenomenological theory of history: Landgrebe, L. 1977. “Das Problem der Teleologie und der Leiblichkeit in der Phänomenologie und im Marxismus.” In: *Phänomenologie und Marxismus I. Konzepte und Methoden*. Waldenfels, B., J. M. Broekman, A. Pazanin (Eds.). Frankfurt am Main, 71–104; Janssen, P. 1970. *Geschichte und Lebenswelt*. Den Haag. For a critical debate on this topic see Richir, M. 2004. *Phantasia, imagination, affectivité*. Grenoble, 116.

³⁴ See Husserliana XLII, 203 and 242. With regard to the relation between the teleology and the idea of god by Husserl see particularly: Chun, L. L. 2008. *Die Gottesauffassung in Husserls Phänomenologie*. Frankfurt a. M.; Held, K. 2010. “Gott in Edmund Husserls Phänomenologie.” In: “Philosophy, Phenomenology, Sciences. Essays in Commemoration of Edmund Husserl.” *Phaenomenologica* 200. Ierna, C. H. Jacobs, F. Mattens (Eds.). Dordrecht–Heidelberg–London–New York, 723–738.

In this way new horizons appear in phenomenology, along with all of the extremely complicated difficulties in need of explanation. As a result the boundaries of a transcendental-empirical phenomenology³⁵ that can methodologically and legitimately involve themselves only with single phenomena are transcended. Moreover, one sort of “transcendental-phenomenologically based metaphysics”³⁶ as “absolute observation of the world” is introduced; the framework of which is yet to be withdrawn phenomenologically by experience.³⁷

If the ideal and the highest goal of phenomenology is to be the universal observation “from the primary infancy to the world constitution,”³⁸ and if the constitution of the reason as “reversion of the primary instincts”³⁹ from the factual primary construction of the subjectivity is to be clarified, then phenomenology of the experience of the body has precisely the task of explaining the primal and factual state of the subject’s life prior to its awakening; a state that indicatively conditions the constitution of other stages both factually and transcendently.

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³⁵ On this point see Pieper, H. J. 1993. *Anschauung als operativer Begriff. Eine Untersuchung zur rundlegung der transzendentalen Phänomenologie Edmund Husserls*. Hamburg, 9–12.

³⁶ Husserliana XLII, 160.

³⁷ See Husserliana XI, 343; also Husserliana XLII, Textes no. 11, 235. In Rochus Sowa’s draft introduction on Husserliana XLII one finds a general explanation of Husserl’s Idea of metaphysics and remarkable citations from Husserl’s correspondence with Roman Ingarden, Wilhelm Dilthey and Eduard Spranger, see Husserliana XLII, page LXI.

³⁸ Husserliana XLII, 218.

³⁹ Ibid., 440, 134.

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR — PhD; visiting researcher in Husserl-Archive; University of Cologne, Husserl-Archive, Albertus-Magnus-Platz, 50923 Köln, Germany (affiliation). Research fields: phenomenology, Husserl, Merleau-Ponty, phenomenology of the body.

E-mail: faribakhililizand@gmail.com

Karel Novotný

SUBJECTIVITY AND EMBODIMENT OF THE EVENT OF APPEARING¹

ABSTRACT

The question of the subjective and embodied character of appearing that was an important issue particularly in post-Husserlian phenomenology is posed in different ways and contexts by Edmund Husserl. One can see how—even according to the *Ideas Pertaining to a Pure Phenomenology and to a Phenomenological Philosophy*. The second book. *Phenomenological Investigations of Constitution* subjectivity was not grounded in the acts of the I that it lent the body its subjective character—thanks to the originally egoic character of its own experiences my body also can be my own. In the paper this position is confronted with a deeper foundation of subjectivity than the I of acts. Husserl also sees in deeper levels of lived experience an immediate, non-intentional self-immersion in one's own experiences. The question that we would like to outline here is: in what sense this self-experience is necessarily bodily, what is the mutual relationship between subjectivity and bodiliness in the later Husserl's works in respect to his conception of phenomenality.

Keywords: Body, lived body, lived experience, kinesthesia, ego, subjectivity.

1. INTRODUCTION

In a manuscript from the 1920s, Husserl, on one hand, characterizes what we want to ascribe to him as the classical conception of the relationship between subjectivity and bodiliness; this relationship is dominated by a spiritual I. However, he also opens up another perspective on the issue that is more important since it cannot be captured clearly in a static analysis or in phenomenology's philosophical reflection. This perspective leads to the need of revising and ex-

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panding the phenomenological method with a genetic, backward-looking inquiry into the involvement of the given with that which is beyond the reach of clear evidence in reflection. For this reason, to introduce this extensive problem, which we only can outline roughly, we cite the mentioned text:

“When we as individuals are directed towards individuals and their personal life, our perspective is not especially directed toward the spirit that is conferred in its own sense upon bodiliness by the specifically bodily life above the physical-organic activity or organic life of the body. By this, is not a certain difference indicated between *a personal spiritual selfhood and the bodily life that precedes selfhood*? Thus, on one hand, the egoic spirituality that radiates, as if from one center, actively governs in the body or through it such activities as considering, comparing, differentiating, establishing aims and means, etc., a spirituality that also acts from this center as the hegemonic principle of bodily life, directing its organs of perception or freely putting bodily movements as well as corporeal-outerworldly effects into play by the application of pressure, pushing, etc. On the other hand, as I have said, bodily life here precedes selfhood, which continues as a subjective life within the stream of experiences without the active participation of the I, which, however, it always nevertheless assumes.”²

The stream of experiences is constituted in a passive manner, “without the active participation of the I,” but that which flows in that stream is from the outset subjective in another sense and even loses its “infra-egoic (*unterichlich*)” character, for the I is always already experienced in it implicitly. Therefore even if one must distinguish infra-egoic passivity from the activity of this I, Husserl nonetheless claims that it is already subjective, as in the passive auto-constitution of the stream of experiences in which the I is always presupposed. What is the relationship between this implicit I and the flesh? Shortly after the passage cited above, Husserl notes:

“It is evident that the center of the I is the constant central point for the subject, and it is evident that at the same time this I finds its body in its experience as a thing that belongs to it in a special way, as the original field of its control (*Urfeld seines Waltens*), as an immediately practical object with which all practical relationship with other things are mediated, as a central object of spatial localization, etc. At any rate, the main theme for a science of the natural conception of the world is indicated here: to study exactly how

² Husserl, E. 1973a. *Zur Phänomenologie der Intersubjektivität. Texte aus dem Nachlass. Zweiter Teil: 1921–1928*. Kern, I. (Ed.). Den Haag: Martinus Nijhoff, 89. Appendix no. X “Personal Egoic Spirituality and the Bodily Life Preceding Selfhood” (*Personale Ichgeistigkeit und unterichliches, leibliches Leben*). Henceforth I will use the abbreviation Hua for the critical edition called Husserliana.

subjectivity stands with regard to bodiliness and how that which is specifically somatological differs from a higher spirituality and from specific functions of the I and how, nevertheless, both remain inseparable.”³

Now we have evidence of the continuity of this problem thanks, among other things, to the publication of later manuscripts in the volume called *Lebenswelt* in Husserl’s collected works. The body as the organ of the self-giveness of all worldly being is a subject of reflection in the part 53 of the text in this edition. The reflections take as their starting point⁴ a fundamental difference between one’s own body and another’s body and the difference between the experience of bodies—among them living bodies, one’s own or another—and then concentrates on the experience of that “peculiar group of properties” that the subject’s own body has for it, for its I. First among them is that that the subject’s own body is the “organ” of the human subject. This property contains several further aspects related simply to the fact that, as an organ of perception, it is a unity of a certain number of particular organs. In addition, it is a “practical organ,” a function founded in the body as an organ of perception with the influence or activity of the I standing behind it, as we read in Husserl’s note: “The body is not like an instrument which can be set aside. Each instrument is an ‘organ’ only by mediation; an instrument no less than the setting aside of an instrument, presumes an immediate bodily activity, which is the activity of an I.”⁵

That the body is at work in all perception of external objects, that it “*is present*” means that it is “therefore *constantly sensorily co-experienced*” and Husserl goes on to emphasize this circumstance:

“... and it is not only co-experienced; it is *at work for the experience of everything*: I perceive—that is, I see with my eyes, which are visually sensitive, and in seeing with them I move and, based on how I carry out this egoic movement, have this or that perspectival phenomenon corresponding to my oculo-motor and other ‘kinesthetic situations;’ in other words, in kinesthetic movement I have processes corresponding to the phenomena.”⁶

This is true of each sense. The relationship between bodiliness and a functioning subjectivity is then concretely described later in Husserl’s text: “an egoic kinesthesia always belongs to egoic functioning and through it I have the corresponding phenomena and changes in the phenomena as phenomena of the same object, which presents itself in them as itself.” For this reason I experience

³ Ibid., 90.

⁴ Husserl, E. 2008. *Die Lebenswelt. Auslegungen der vorgegebenen Welt und ihrer Konstitution. Texte aus dem Nachlass (1916–1937)*. Sowa, R. (Ed.). Springer: Dordrecht–New York (Hua XXXIX), 615.

⁵ Ibid., 616, note 2.

⁶ Ibid., 616.

phenomena as “bodily perceptions” such as those of “touching fingers, the smelling nose, etc.” and do so thanks to the fact that in the process of experiencing external bodies “I also experience in a certain manner the movement of organs as a bodily movement, as a bodily movement proceeding from me thanks to kinesthesia.”⁷

The subjectivity of experiences and their progression is, according to these considerations, grounded in the fact that this progression devolves from me, out of me, but in such a fashion that in doing so it depends on kinesthesia—that is, on the perceptions of the movement of bodily organs. The link between subjectivity and the experienced movement of the body through kinesthesia is thus a demonstrable component of experience grounded in sensory perception. On one hand, I move my eyes; on the other, it is the sensation of the movement of my bodily organs that contributes to the fact that my perceptions and phenomena are experienced as *my* phenomena and *my bodily* perceptions. This is the concrete interconnection between subjectivity and bodiliness in experience, and it is also Husserl’s argument for the relevance of a bodily functioning subjectivity against attempts to naturalize this connection—that is, to explain it independently of a functioning subjectivity.

In *The Crisis of European Sciences* he then qualifies his views on naturalization in §28, which clears “The Way into Phenomenological Transcendental Philosophy by Inquiring back from the Pregiven Lifeworld.” Among the forgotten assumptions of classical transcendental philosophy he emphasizes in the first place the body “which is never absent from the perceptual field, and specifically its corresponding ‘organs of perception’ (eyes, hands, ears, etc.). [...] they function in seeing, hearing, etc. together with the ego’s motility belonging to them, i.e., what is called kinesthesia.”⁸ This functioning is conscious precisely thanks to kinesthesia which is thus a connection of functioning subjectivity and bodiliness on the level of sensory perception, observation, or feeling.

Nevertheless in these texts and contexts we also may see that for Husserl selfhood and bodiliness are inseparable and different ways of grounding the subjectivity of appearing. To show this, let us cite another passage from the manuscripts on intersubjectivity that evinces parallels with other places in his texts, such as §54 of *The Crisis of European Sciences*. In the former manuscript in question Husserl writes:

“I directly experience myself as the ‘I’ of my life of consciousness and I experience my body in its original bilaterality, but I do not experience myself as ‘localized’ in the corporeality of the body but as myself as in control in my body; only that which is specifically somatological is localized [...] in

⁷ Ibid.

⁸ Husserl, E. 1976. *Die Krisis der europäischen Wissenschaften und die transzendente Phänomenologie. Eine Einleitung in die phänomenologische Philosophie*. Biemel, W (Ed.). Den Haag: Martinus Nijhoff (Hua VI), 108.

the case of original self-experience, it is evident that in order to capture and show my I and my life of consciousness, I do not need to show beforehand that my corporeal bodiliness and nature are in truth in any way, and it is therefore evident that the egoic is given in an immediate manner, so immediately that it would not be possible to think it more so.”⁹

Husserl speaks on the paradox of subjectivity; on one hand, there is a subjectivity that constitutes everything, including my own body, a subjectivity different from that which constitutes, as basic phenomenology distinguishes experience from that which is experienced in it. On the other hand, experience takes place in an always already constituted world and in an embodied subjectivity that can be bodily experienced only because it is always already bodily. In several places, Husserl explicitly calls attention to this fact, e.g. in the following reflection:

“Experience of the body as a spatial body, an experience containing its variety of appearances and kinesthesias, once again refers back, as in all such experience, to the body as a functioning body, so the perception of what is bodily and of the entire body itself already presupposes the body—that is, psychophysical experience.”¹⁰

To disentangle this paradox, Husserl repeatedly carried out a reductive descent from the phenomenology of the natural world to ever deeper layers of its passive constitution into a “primordial sphere” where the intersubjective forms of objectivation are disregarded. The aim of the following section is to noting two of his interpretations that have been important in the formulation of our questions.

2. BODILINESS AND SUBJECTIVITY OF THE APPEARING FROM THE PERSPECTIVE OF GENETIC PHENOMENOLOGY

1. The article “The Problem of the Passive Constitution” (1982) by Ludwig Landgrebe summarizes the work that the author had done in the field as early as the late 1920s on the problem of passive constitution. He formulated in it three theses, the second is the most significant for the considered

⁹ Hua XIV, 461, 463.

¹⁰ “Die raumkörperliche Erfahrung vom Leib, mit ihren Mannigfaltigkeiten von Erscheinungsverläufen und Kinästhesen, ist wie alle solche Erfahrung wieder zurückbezogen auf den Leib als fungierenden, so dass die Wahrnehmung vom Leiblichen und vom ganzen Leib schon den Leib, also psychophysische Erfahrung voraussetzt.” Husserl, E. 1973b. *Zur Phänomenologie der Intersubjektivität. Texte aus dem Nachlass. Dritter Teil (1929–1935)*. Kern, I. (Ed.). Den Haag: Martinus Nijhoff (Hua XV), 326.

issue.¹¹ The study discusses what precedes the subjectivity of appearing in the sense of an “active constitution and synthesis” as the “acts of the I.” The character of this dimension of lived-experiencing is that “it takes places without the ‘I do’” (*Ohne Tun des Ich*); it is not a subjective act in the sense of an active I but a presupposition for it. But this supposed that passivity is what accomplishes the I in life or the life of the I in its opposition to what is foreign to it: “The entire originally streaming event is not a dead event (which is apparently what *Ichfremdes* means—that which is foreign to me), but the ‘I do’ is its innermost motor.”¹²

According to Landgrebe, the question of subjectivity and the embodiment of the original streaming of experiences that is the origin of appearing beyond reflection must be thought in keeping with the following remark by Husserl, which expresses not only the paradox of embodied subjectivity but of subjectivity as such: both the pre-egoic anonymous stream of passively constituted lived-experiences and the I are original.

As Landgrebe puts it, passive streaming cannot be thought of as a diffuse process which might explain the individuation of the I; rather, the principle of individuation must already bear this process within itself. He says, on the one hand, that this

“... process is indeed anonymous and cannot be brought within the purview of reflection in its original occurrence; nevertheless, we may say of it that it cannot produce individuation. Rather, it is the case that in order for the process to exist at all, an organization is already presupposed that can then be experienced as ‘my body’ and ‘the I belonging to it’.”¹³

It would seem that this centering brings into the anonymity of the experiencing of the original stream of experiences a feeling of the body, as in kinesthesia for example, and that in this sense the body is not only the origin of what I experience as mine¹⁴ and what precedes the explicit consciousness of the I, but that this centering also takes place through the feeling of my own body and thereby a certain individuation of the stream of experiences takes place through the lived body as well.

However, Landgrebe denies this, on the other hand, in his interpretation of the relationship between the I and the body in his article when he says,

¹¹ The three theses are: 1) The “depth-dimensions” of the process of constitution cannot be attained by phenomenological reflection; 2) the functions of bodiliness belong to the functions of passive pre-constitution and together with it to “transcendental subjectivity;” and 3) the primal streaming occurrence of “transcendental subjectivity” must be understood as a creative process. L. Landgrebe, “Das Problem der passiven Konstitution,” in: Landgrebe, L. 1982. *Faktizität und Individuation. Studien zu den Grundfragen der Phänomenologie*. Hamburg: Felix Meiner, 73.

¹² Husserl C 10, cited in: Landgrebe, 1982, op. cit., 75.

¹³ Ibid., 85ff.

¹⁴ See also section 3 below.

“Subjectivity is therefore not individuated by the body as Merleau-Ponty thought; for the presupposition for there being a body at all is that someone has it and learns to use it before that someone discloses himself as an I. I disclose my body, the body does not disclose itself as an I.”¹⁵

In this manner, Landgrebe defends Husserl’s concept of the “pure I” as an irreducible moment of subjectivity, albeit with the qualification that for Husserl himself it only concerns an I *per aequivocationem*; in reality, it concerns a stop-gap expression chosen for an “absolute principle of individuation.”¹⁶

Thus, for Landgrebe, the body seems not to be the origin of subjectivity in the sense of an individuation or a singularity of the stream of experiences. The I has to be presupposed, and is a “pure I” because “it cannot be apprehended as embodied,” says Landgrebe quite plainly and adds: “The pure I is a prerequisite for the possibility of something like the body being given.” If both the stream and the I are original, it follows for Landgrebe that “the being of each single I is in the same manner an absolute facticity as an original streaming.”¹⁷ In this sense we may say, on the basis of this interpretation of Husserl’s genetic phenomenology, that there is no appearing that is not an appearing for an I; for Husserl, therefore, the event of appearing always has a subjective character in which embodiment participates to a significant extent. Embodiment is not the origin of the subjective character of the event of appearing, according to Landgrebe, but it is indeed a certain condition that allows him to say that transcendental subjectivity has a bodily character. The facticity of embodiment, the fact that before the I becomes conscious it is preceded by the feeling of the body as mine (in the accomplishments of involuntary kinesthesia, for example), is not an *Urfacticity*; this character of irreducible facticity holds rather to the fact “that there is always such a center of spontaneity” that, according to Landgrebe, cannot be derived any further—that is why it is a kind of *Urfactum*.

¹⁵ Ibid., 85 ff.

¹⁶ For this reason as well as that what Landgrebe says elsewhere in his article (“It may not be further derived that there exists such a center of spontaneity.”). Ibid., 83.

¹⁷ Ibid., 87. There is no “pre-individuated subjectivity [...] that might be additionally ‘centered;’ instead, transcendental subjectivity comprises transcendental subjectivity within itself (Hua XV, 75) as a place for its own development.” Dan Zahavi explains Husserl’s concept of intersubjective subjectivity, noting further “that Husserl evidently held the view that it is possible to speak on the I as a principle unifying the flow of consciousness without drawing into it the occurrence of the other. On this rudimentary level, there exists a functioning activity that is really solitary and is not realized by others.” The sphere of primordality is thus justified, according to Zahavi, in view of the fact that “intersubjectivity may not be thought independently of the (possible) plurality of individuated subjects.” Zahavi, D. 1996. *Husserl und die transzendente Intersubjektivität*. Dordrecht: Springer, 67.

3. DAN ZAHAVI'S ACCOUNT OF SELF-AFFECTION AND HETERO-AFFECTION

Moreover, one of the most important new systematic interpretations of Husserl seems to support this conclusion. The distinction and the relationship between activity and passivity in Husserl's work is key to understanding this "subjectivity of bodily life preceding the I," a "point which is also highly pertinent when it comes to an understanding of self-awareness," writes Dan Zahavi in the introduction to his account of the central problem of the relationship and interconnections between self-affection and hetero-affection.¹⁸ Whereas self-affection is primarily a matter of time consciousness, a relationship between experiences within the framework of the stream of experience, on the contrary, hetero-affection is also a relationship between consciousness and that which is not yet a part of the framework, that which has yet to become an experience. It is important (among other things from the perspective of the confrontation between the positions of Husserl and Michel Henry we began with) that for Husserl, "the concrete ego cannot be thought independently of its relation to what is foreign to it."¹⁹ Zahavi summarizes his thesis in the following words:

"If [...] self-affection is always penetrated by the affection of the world, and if inner time-consciousness presupposes a hyletic content, an affection by something not generated by consciousness, it is untenable to introduce a founding-founded relation between self-affection and hetero-affection, since they are inseparable and interdependent."²⁰

This is the key thesis Zahavi's book brings to bear on the specification of the status of the subjectivity of appearing postulated by Husserl. It is a different type of self-affection in the relationship to bodiliness than that posited by Henry for whom the flesh, *la chair*, and self-affection blend into one event independently of the affection of experiencing from the outside. By contrast, for Husserl, the "affection of the primal hyletic fact" has the express character of the original relationship to what is foreign to the I.²¹ The foreignness of *hyle* is relativized here in the sense that, no matter how pure the I is, it cannot be outside the relationship to the other, which as other, however, continuously consti-

¹⁸ Zahavi, D. 1999. *Self-Awareness and Alterity. A Phenomenological Investigation*. Evanston: Northwestern University Press, 117.

¹⁹ Ibid.

²⁰ Ibid., 123 ff.

²¹ It is true that in Husserl we read of *hyle* "as of an *interior* nonegological dimension which surrounds and affects the ego" so that it "is an *immanent* type of alterity which manifests itself directly in subjectivity." According to Zahavi, nevertheless, *hyle* remains foreign: "It is not produced by me, but is a domain which escapes my control. It is a facticity which is passively pre-given without any active participation or contribution by the ego [...] essential to the self-manifesting existence of subjectivity." Ibid., 120 ff.

tutes it. Without being in a relationship with the constituting not-I on the basis of hetero-affection, the I cannot even experience itself in the inwardness, the immanence, of the stream of experiences.

And here it becomes apparent that bodiliness does not play the same fundamental role as Henry's passive *chair* in the sense of self-affection; on the contrary, it is tied to movement—that is, to activity, albeit involuntary, not under the control of an act of representation. For Husserl, the inseparability of the egoic and hyletic moment of experience demonstrates the concrete interconnection of two types of experience, kinesthesias, that can be interpreted noetically—that is, as egoic experiences of egoic activity, and hyletic perceptions that provide information about aspects or attributes of what that noetic activity itself is not and what is foreign to it, even though experience is not constituted on this level as an object yet. For Husserl, this corresponds to the distinction between “hyletic sensations as being non-egological and the kinesthesia as being egological.”²² In his reflections on Husserl's work Zahavi relies on this connection citing the passage:

“The constitution of beings of different degrees, worlds, times, is based on two primal suppositions, two primal sources on which [...] it always ‘rests’: 1) my primal ego as a functioning ego, as a primal ego in its affections and actions [...] 2) my primal non-ego as the original stream of temporalization and as itself the primal form of temporalization of the constituting temporal field, a field of primal objectivity. *Both primal foundations are unified, inseparable and, taken separately, are abstract.*”²³

“Both grounds are [...] inseparable, both are irreducible structural moments in the process of constitution, in the process of bringing to appearance.”²⁴ This duality seems to be Husserl's last word on the matter. Thus Zahavi, in light of Landgrebe and other interpreters notes that neither embodiment nor temporality can in the end be understood separately for Husserl, independently of each other, and therefore he concludes that the grounding of reflective self-awareness in

²² Ibid., 120. Zahavi refers to manuscript C 3 41b. We find another such passage in manuscript C 16: “Among the first constitution in a fundamental way (*grundwesentlich*), in addition to the unities of passive time constitution, are kinesthesias, involuntary happenings (*unwillkürliche Geschehnisse*) that are, however, quite immediate egoic occurrences (the so-called passive occurrences of the will, activities that can be, through practice, transformed into activities that can be voluntarily controlled).” Husserl, E. 2006. *Späte Texte über Zeitkonstitution (1929–1934). Die C-Manuskripte*. Lohmar, D. (Ed.). Dordrecht–New York: Springer (Hua Mat VIII), 336.

²³ Ibid., 121. Cited from C 10 15b. A bit further on, the idea is repeated of the stream of a constituting hyletic universe—that is, a field of primordial prior givenness independent of the contributions of the I, which is nonetheless always present. C 10 16 a. Another quotation from Husserl: “The I is not anything for itself and what it alien to the I is not something separate from the I; moreover, there is no space between them for any sort of overturning. Instead, the I and that which is alien to it are inseparable.” C 16 68a.

²⁴ Ibid., 121.

prereflective self-experience has two sources: “We are dealing with an incarnated temporality, with an embodied, prereflective self-awareness, and it is exactly this prereflective *bodily* and *temporal* self-affecting that makes reflective self-awareness possible.”²⁵ It appears that, like Landgrave,²⁶ Zahavi also emphasizes Husserl’s distinction between both modes of self-experience, neither of which is reducible to the other.

4. AFFECTIVITY AND MOVEMENT

One also finds in Husserl a foundation of subjectivity’s appearing in the flesh, which is attested to by kinesthesia as the carnal experience of a doing that can be voluntarily accompanied by the explicit experience of the ego as the subject of my actions, but which in most cases is involuntary and not as explicitly conscious as is my doing, my activity; I only assume it after the fact. There is thus a subjectivity that is pre-egoic, in the sense of an anonymity; and yet it is experienced, for Husserl, and one would have to see how it is related to the Cartesian idea of the coincidence of experience with oneself, on one hand, and with the auto-affective test—that is, with the idea of the auto-affective flesh in Henry’s sense.

There are studies on the auto-affective test of each experience in Husserl. For instance, Rudolf Bernet in his last book *Force—pulsion—désir* studies the issue of drives in Husserl.²⁷ What is important for our question regarding the grounding of subjectivity in the flesh is that

“Every execution of a drive-based movement is accompanied by an experience of pleasure. This drive-based pleasure results from a discharge of tension associated with the drive impulse [...] For Husserl, the goal of the carrying out of the drive is [...] at once a doing and the sensation of pleasure that arises on the occasion: ‘the drive turning away from something disagreeable and toward something agreeable.’ Similarly, ‘The sensual pleasure of sensa-

²⁵ Ibid., 127.

²⁶ We have mentioned his thesis on the prior unity of the I and the world in which the differentiating and unifying factor between the pure consciousness of the I (the pure I) and hyletic contents as a moment foreign to the I is the bodiliness.

²⁷ “For Husserl, the most typical instance of an instinctual action is that of the involuntary bodily movements that are not initiated by the conscious I, but that have as their source an ‘obscure’ or ‘unconscious’ drive provoked by a bodily need. They are, therefore, either automatic actions (such as the ‘I extend my hand toward my cigar’ or ‘the fact of lighting a cigarette mechanically, of bringing it to my mouth, etc.’) or voluptuous bodily, spontaneous, rhythmic movements [...]” Cf. Bernet, R. 2013. *Force – pulsion – désir. Une autre philosophie de la psychanalyse*. Paris: Vrin, 320. There are “original instinctual movements—that is, spontaneous movements—that have to do with an unconscious bodily doing in which the *vital mobility* of a living being is expressed and accomplished.” Ibid.

tion and of experience [of an act] shares with the pleasure of a drive that it does not involve any intentional representation. The two sorts of pleasure (acts and sensations) consist, on the contrary, of the experience or sensation (which is on the order of sentiment) of the contents of intimate consciousness: ‘sensual feeling’ (*Fühlen*) is thus nothing but an intimate consciousness (constituting something temporal)...”²⁸

Here, one would be tempted to conclude that the “Pure Ego” could be reabsorbed by this auto-affection of the flesh that takes place particularly in the involuntary movement of drives but which also takes place constantly—in breathing or, for example, the beating of the heart.

Nonetheless, we might begin with some of Husserl’s thoughts concerning kinesthesia as the original form of the subjectivity of living bodiliness or with the flesh. At the level of reflection, living bodiliness itself also translates as carnality (*eigene Leiblichkeit*) which has its subjective character not only through the *accomplishment* of an explicitly egoic activity but also as a function of an involuntary doing by the “passive Ego,” the “subject of tendencies” that are passive, “attracted by this or by that,” tendencies that are thus always accomplished by my body. That is, once accomplished, these tendencies are attributed to my unique I, to the body that I do not only have but that I am, which, precisely, confers upon the living body, operating in such a doing, a subjectivity in such a way that it might be experienced and seized upon as my living body.

5. RECAPITULATION

When the thesis maintaining that the subject of perception or even of all lived experience is the lived body and not consciousness was put to the test it was directed against the classical philosophy of consciousness, which required, in Kant’s stance at least, that the “I”, as a certain representation, must not only accompany all experiences but also be their supposed agent. As a phenomenological antithesis to this, the thesis of the lived body as the subject of experience does not signify a transition from the first to the third person perspective, for not only do I *have* a body, but I *am* my body,²⁹ as far as I am alive, and this bodily “I” or Self is the “subject” of appearing and this “bodiliness” (*Leiblichkeit*) of the Self—together with the self-referential character of each of its living experiences—makes up the subjectivity of appearing.

²⁸ Ibid., 323–324.

²⁹ Cf. Joonas Taipale who in his recently published book: 2014. *Phenomenology and Embodiment: Husserl and the Constitution of Subjectivity*. Evanston: Northwestern University Press, defends the thesis that in order to *have* my body I have already to *be* my body.

What do we mean by the subjectivity of appearing in Husserl? Already from the static phenomenological perspective, at the very beginning of Husserl's thinking, one elementary sense of the subjectivity of appearing as lived-experience has been established: that of the pre-reflective self-awareness of every lived experience. Lived experiences exist and are accessible to me as my experiences; no matter how strange they might appear in their content, still are they lived by me, otherwise, they could not be any experiences at all. In that elementary sense they remain mine even if in a non-thematic, merely implicit or "tacit" way (Zahavi). The appearing of phenomena—through all the apperceptive forms of objectivation that are discovered in many ways as intersubjective forms—presupposes the primordial, subjective event of lived experience. Its subjectivity is an irreducible *Urfactum* (Landgrebe).

The spontaneity of movement justifies, in another way, a positing of the I as an occurrent instance of activity, originally undisclosed to itself, that is characterized more precisely as a "bodily feeling" or a "feeling of the body" that we might interpret as the inwardness preceding the developed consciousness of the I lived as a (fulfilled or unfulfilled) bodily feeling connected with the accomplishment of kinesthesia (Bernet).

One might speak of a certain circularity in the Husserlian grounding of appearing, because doing, the activity which is at the origin of subjectivity, is impossible without a passivity toward the motivating stimulation coming from the outside and awakening the experience that, in its fulfillment, gives itself over to itself in different bodily manners—notably in pleasure and in non-intentional kinesthesias—without coinciding with them.

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR — Research Professor in the Institute of Philosophy of the Academy of Sciences of the Czech Republic in Prague, Department of Contemporary Continental Philosophy, Jilská 1, 11000 Praha 1 (affiliation). Associate Professor at the Faculty of Humanities, Charles University of Prague. Coordinator of the Erasmus Master Mundus “German and French Philosophy in Europe (EuroPhilosophie)” program at Charles University of Prague. Together with Hans Rainer Sepp co-director of Central-European Institute for Philosophy (www.sif-praha.cz). Research domains and interests: phenomenology, hermeneutics, philosophical anthropology. Recent publications: 2016. *Relevance subjectivity. Tělo a duše z hlediska fenomenologie afektivity*. Červený Kostelec; 2012. *Neue Konzepte der Phänomenalität. Essais zur Subjektivität und Leiblichkeit des Erscheinens*. Würzburg; 2012. *La genèse d'une hérésie. Monde, corps et histoire dans la pensée de Jan Patočka*. Paris; 2010. *O povaze jevů. Úvod do současné francouzské fenomenologie*. Červený Kostelec. Several editions and numerous articles in the domain of phenomenology.

E-mail: novotnykcz@yahoo.de

Wolfram Högrefe

INDISTINCTNESS AND DISUNION

ABSTRACT

In the paper the concept of indistinctness is examined. In the author's view, indistinctness is present in all the aspects of the world. The problem of indistinctness is apprehended in four steps, namely, by 1. claiming and proving that the world of indistinctness and vagueness enhances our creative intelligence; 2. examining who and when discovered the advantages of indistinctness; 3. maintaining that precision is usually of advantage, but not always; 4. proving the misery of reductionistic programmes.

Keywords: indistinctness, disunion, space of meaning, space of being, Turing machine, Galileo Galilei, Leibniz, Willard Van Orman Quine, Wilhelm Dilthey.

It is sometimes good to begin with a consoling triviality—which in this case will be the concession that the notion of indistinctness is itself indistinct. From measurement readings to conceptions which rely on interpretation, from the *objet ambigu* to obscure magical incantations, from semantic vagueness and every sort of ambiguity to unavoidable, i.e. objective, inexactness—indistinctness is everywhere, often to our chagrin and at times to our advantage. I am, however, far removed from pursuing such petty and boring distinctions. What I do intend I will try to outline in four progressively (and very noticeably) less detailed subsections. First of all,

1. THE WORLD OF INDISTINCTNESS AND VAGUENESS ENHANCES OUR CREATIVE INTELLIGENCE

Of course the very term “world” is indistinct. Translated into the mathematical and logical language of set theory, it would have to mean something like a set of all sets—which, as we know since Bertrand Russell, can lead us onto rather slippery ground. However, it can also be used untranslated and uninter-

preted, simply to express our apprehending of wholeness. There can be no doubt that in this uninterpreted sense we know that we inhabit a spot within a whole. Why not? For the reason that true doubt is possible only where it contests the claims of knowledge, but we are unable to prove that we inhabit a whole, because how could it be contested? Here we are evidently faced with a non-conceptual, sub-semantic kind of certitude, a fundamental self-knowledge about our existence. Thus, our contestable knowledge is preceded by our *inner certitude* of the circumstance that we inhabit a spot within a whole. Already on the level of the epistemic base we are simultaneously and uninterpretedly idio- and holomorphic, and this is what forms our “scenic existence.”¹ So, from the very start we exist in conditions of meaning which since Wilhelm Dilthey and Edmund Husserl are in their entirety defined as the *lifeworld*. Only in such a lifeworld can there exist reasons, numbers, meanings, the menacing and the affectionate, as well as that which is clear-cut, precisely measured and formed, and whose progress can be exactly calculated. In short: our lifeworld, as we can still today learn from Husserl, is the unfortunate “forgotten fundament of meaning” of not just the natural sciences but our entire cultural existence.²

The conditions of meaning are characterised by relations which take place on a polar plane, e.g. in juxtapositions like subjective–objective, material–formal, quantitative–qualitative, internal–external, global–local, extentional–intentional, etc. Such relations are not part of a broader genus, hence are called categorial. They form the structural base of the conditions of meaning, dimensionalise them, and open a *space of meaning* of which the *space of reason* (Wilfried Sellars) is only an element or subset. This “space of meaning” exists precisely in the same sense in which conditions of meaning exist. The *space of meaning* is simultaneously the graspable *space of being* in which we live. To be means to “occur as”—i.e. to “occur in conditions of meaning.” Meaningless existence is nonsense. The first and so far only philosopher to give this any thought was Friedrich Wilhelm Joseph von Schelling.³ Certainly not the conservatively-minded Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel.

This *space of meaning* is significant in all its aspects, and precisely for this reason open to interpretation, i.e. generally ambiguous. We live in a world full of contrasts which are graded, can escalate or diminish. This is the world we find ourselves in first, where human childhood and our individual growth

¹ Cf. Hogrebe, W. 2009. *Riskante Lebensnähe. Die szenische Existenz des Menschen* [Risky Proximity to Life: the Scenic Existence of Men]. Berlin.

² Cf. Husserl, E. 1970 (1936). *Die Krisis der europäischen Wissenschaften und die transzendente Phänomenologie* [The Crisis of European Sciences and Transcendental Philosophy]. Carr, D. (Trans.). Evanston: Northwestern University Press), § 9; also cf. Schwemmer, O. 1997. *Die kulturelle Existenz des Menschen* [The Cultural Existence of Human Beings]. Berlin.

³ Cf. Hogrebe, W. 1989. *Prädikation und Genesis* [Predication and Genesis. Metaphysics as Fundamental Heuristics Beginning from Schelling’s “The Ages of the World”]. Frankfurt a. M.

begins. It is here that we learn to cooperate, though our efforts in this respect sometimes are under our equally strong competitive drive. In the long run an adolescent mankind, like an adolescent human being, needs reliability, predictability, justice, accuracy and precision as steadying forces. This is why argumentation, logical conclusion, figures and documentation—all themselves manifestations of meaning—move to the forefront of the *space of meaning*. Elaborate craftsmanship increasingly submitted to the demands of geometrical precision, and when Aristotle, in the first book of his *Nicomachean Ethics*, remarked that we should “not look for the same precision (ἀκριβεία) in everything” for the simple reason that “a carpenter and a geometrician approach the right-angle in different ways,”⁴ the always firmly praxis-rooted and down-to-earth Stagirite could not have known that this diversity of precision, this *warranty of tolerance for indistinctness*, carried an explosive load which would detonate nearly two millenia later with Galileo Gailei (1564–1641) and his statement of a fundamental split between two accessways to the world, which could not be retreated from at will.

In his 1623 book *The Assayer* (Il Saggiatore) Galiei made the since famous claim that the Book of Nature, or the Universe, was not written in the language of the carpenter but the geometrician, and was therefore incomprehensible to the carpenter, i.e. us. In order to decipher this book’s specifically-written content, we first have to learn a new language, the language of geometry and mathematics, as without it is “humanly impossible to understand a single word of it (*é impossibile a intenderne umamente parola*)”⁵ and one is left “wandering around in a dark labyrinth” (*per un oscuro laberinto*).⁶ However, while for Aristotle the carpenter and geometrician, though different, still belonged together as craftsmen in the practical sense, they definitely drifted apart after Galileo Galilei: the carpenter, and with him all who were unversed in the language of mathematics, were left in the sphere of the vague and obscure and only geometricians and mathematicians were able to read the Book of Nature.

Nonetheless Galileo still believed that both directions—revelation through nature and revelation through holy scriptures—belonged together. Although he did already then plead for

“the thesis that each side requires its own hermeneutics. This places Galilei [...] on the crossroads between two cultures, which in the contemporary era have often enough proven no longer capable of finding to each other: one

⁴ Aristotle. 2000. *Nicomachean Ethics*. Crisp, R. (Trans., Ed.). St. Anne’s College, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 12–13.

⁵ For the quotations cf. Galileo Galilei. 2005. *Schriften. Briefe. Dokumente* (Writings, Letters, Documents). Mudry, A. (Ed.). Wiesbaden. Horst Bredekamp offers a picture that is much more diversified than the common interpretations in 2007. *Galilei als Künstler* [Galileo as Artist]. Berlin, 328 sqq.

⁶ Wikisource.

based on understanding human and broader meaning relations, the other on the explication of external concreteness.”⁷

This disunion was of decisive import for the history of the world and is also responsible for the progress of indistinctness today. Since Galilei, the paths by which we access the world have been growing apart, and this is true for the entire *condition humaine*. Mathematical naturalism has distanced itself from comprehending humanism, the former remaining clear and precise, the latter essentially vague and obscure (even if quite able to provide convincing evidence for its claims).

In fact what we are dealing with here is the universalisation of an old picture which even its protagonists are unaware of. Since Hesiod literature has repeatedly shown people faced with crucial choices, a convention whose evolution Wolfgang Harms investigated some years ago in his still readable book *Homo viator in bivio*.⁸ Literature has always portrayed situations in which people, similarly to Hercules at the crossroads, had to make choices of decisive import for them.⁹ Such decisions were symbolised by the letter Y, whose forked part indicated the disunion determined by such choices. For our purposes we can apply this model to mankind as such, i.e. universalise it. Mankind as a whole is also upon a frequently-dividing path, and one such historical—and still valid—bifurcation began with what Galileo Galilei pointed to and carried through. His methodical disconnection of the mathematical and comprehending paths to nature has remained intact until today. A similar split can occur between modernisation and its established regulations and obligations—and it is precisely this disunion, first (and still validly) analysed by Joachim Ritter in connection with Hegel, that underlies today’s global politics.¹⁰

Nonetheless, there were always voices which contested Galilei’s disunion theory. Not necessarily in the sense that one of its elements could be replaced with the other, but in the sense that also measurable access ways to nature occasionally led through areas which escaped a clear definition. The history of science offers many excellent examples. Quite instructive is the turbulent history of the concept “gene.” In the early 20th century, when genetics was still in its

⁷ Hoffmann, T. S. 2007. *Philosophie in Italien* [Philosophy in Italy]. Wiesbaden, 336–67.

⁸ Harms, W. 1970. *Homo Viator in Bivio. Studien zur Bildlichkeit des Weges* [Homo Viator in Bivio. Studies on the Metaphoricity of the Path]. Munich.

⁹ *Ibid.*, 40 sqq.

¹⁰ Cf. Ritter, J. 1956. “Europäisierung als europäisches Problem.” [Europeanisation as a European Problem]. In: idem. *Metaphysik und Politik* [Metaphysics and politics]. Frankfurt a. M. 1969, 321–340, here page 329: “What leads on into the future has no continuity with what has become history.” And page 333: “The bridge between the old and new learning is missing.” This particular and irreversible severance can only be compensated for (reconciled) by more education. For more on this cf. Ritter, J. 1974. “Die Aufgabe der Geisteswissenschaften in der modernen Gesellschaft” [The Task of the Human Sciences in Modern Society]. In: idem. *Subjektivität* [Subjectivity]. Frankfurt a. M., 105–140.

fledgeling phase, the term was understood as “the postulated unity of heredity, something like an ‘empty’ concept.”¹¹ This emptiness was richly imbued with content only after research showed that in the case of living organisms we were dealing with nucleic acid macromolecules, which in the mid-20th century allowed the so-called “genotype’s” identification as deoxyribonucleic acid and distinction from the “phenotype” which underlay the structure and functions of proteins.

Finally, the term was even reconceptualised, or in a sense dematerialised into a byword for genetic information. Hans-Jörg Rheinberger, to whom I owe this observation, summed up the strange evolution of the gene concept as follows:

“Whereas on one hand the epistemic object ‘gene’ took on the material form of a macromolecule, hence manifested itself in a class of substance, on the other it simultaneously assumed the quite immaterial form of information, hence disembodied itself [...] to the transferable form of biological meaning. The gene became semantically charged.”¹²

This example gives good insight into the interplay between indistinctness and distinctness, both also underlie heuristic processes in the natural sciences, which programmatically go out from “epistemic objects” like “atom,” “molecule,” and “gene,” as well as in mathematics, if one were to trace the path of $\sqrt{2}$ from the antique until today. Although still disputed, an example closer to our times is the incompressible and hence impenetrable number Ω representing the halting probability of all algorithms (Gregory Chaitin).¹³

Nonetheless, the indistinctness at the outset of all programmes is always *the* heuristic provocation: “[E]pistemic objects [...] have indistinct edges; and it is this indistinctness which constitutes their challenge. Whereas the instruments with which research is conducted usually have distinct edges ...”¹⁴

We are unable to free ourselves of this asymmetry, therefore it is quite often precisely the instruments which hinder us in exploring the potential of vague but promising speculation. However, they also protect us from simply slipping

¹¹ Rheinberger, H.-J. 2012. „Epistemisches Ding und Verkörperung [The Epistemic Object and Embodiment]. In: *Verkörperungen* [Embodiments]. Blum, A. L., J. M. Krois, H.-J. Rheinberger (Eds.). Berlin, 3–9.

¹² Ibid., 7. For more and also extensively cf. Rheinberger, H.-J. 2006. *Experimentalsysteme und Epistemische Dinge. Eine Geschichte der Proteinsynthese im Reagenzglas* (Experimental Systems and Epistemic Objects. A History of Test-tube Protein Synthesis). Frankfurt M.

¹³ Chaitin, G. 2000. *The Unknowable*. Singapore, 98 sqq. Here also cf. Bromand, J. 2009. *Grenzen des Wissens* (The Boundaries of Knowledge). Paderborn, 122 sqq.

¹⁴ Rheinberger, H.-J. 2012, op. cit., 3. The form in which we, in our condition of half-baked knowledge (conjectures, premonitions), nonetheless remain effective as researchers is the experiment. For more on this cf. Hans-Jörg Rheinberger’s lecture: 2014. “Über die Kunst das Unbekannte zu erforschen.” [On the Art of Investigating the Unknown]. *Neue Zürcher Zeitung*, June 9, 2014.

on the ice of *phlogiston*-like conjecture. The laboratory with its apparatus is a relentless rectifier, but sometimes also a club lounge in which wrongly-forgotten (and only seldom retrieved) ideas are discussed.

However, it is indeed indistinctness that stimulate us cognitively—as philosophers with good psychological insight have always known. Hegel, for instance, says that the spirit occupies itself with objects only as long as they harbour mystery, the non-obvious.¹⁵ Objective vagueness stimulates our will to know and our inventiveness—in short, our creative potential. And usually we have nothing at our disposal but our will to know, also in cases where we are simply seeking greater precision. There are, however, objective boundaries here which are connected with the complexity of the conditions and known in equal measure to physicists, meteorologists and football players. If the world's conditions were by nature more distinct—like in a world made of building blocks—there would probably be nothing like spirit. Instincts need Constance in narrow tolerance but the spirit starts out in unlimited (i.e. constant) tolerance, in contrariness to expectations, in other words—in indistinctness.¹⁶

Such a full-bodied thesis, however, calls for immediate passage to the next issue, namely

2. WHO AND WHEN DISCOVERED THE ADVANTAGES OF INDISTINCTNESS?

It is highly improbable that mankind suddenly just began to value indistinctness. How can one value something that is deficient? People noticed, however, that indistinctness carried with it certain advantages related to the ancient idea of “saving the phenomena” (σώζειν τὰ φαινόμενα).¹⁷ Who wishes to embrace contexts must do so from a distance, who desires detail, however, must draw closer. Who wants to bring out the whole must “dim the lights.” Such dimness is also advantageous for cognitive-theoretical reasons if what we are after is experiencing the whole—which no one knew better than the Romantics.

In any case, this is how the evaluation of the indiscreet, i.e. the vague and diffuse, began after Descartes' monopolisation of crystal-clear distinctness and discretion. This also led to the emergence in 1750 of a new discipline, which Alexander Baumgarten (1714–1762) named “aesthetics.” Baumgarten noticed that darkness carried an enormous wealth on semantic content which needed to

¹⁵Cf. Hegel, G. W. F. 1975. *Aesthetics. Lectures on Fine Art*. Knox, T. M. (Trans.), 2 vols, Oxford: Clarendon Press.

¹⁶ Some analytical philosophers have meanwhile also realised this. Cf. Unger, P. 2014. *Empty Ideas. A Critic of Analytic Philosophy*. Oxford.

¹⁷ Cf. Mittelstraß, J. 1962. *Die Rettung der Phänomene. Ursprung und Geschichte eines antiken Forschungsprinzips* [Saving the Phenomena. The Origin and History of an Antique Research Principle]. Berlin.

be brought to light, either by means of art or thought. For Baumgarten “darkness” was not only the mother of error, but also “an indispensable prerequisite for discovering the truth, as nature makes no leap from darkness into the clarity of thought. The path from night leads only through dawn to midday.”¹⁸ Thoughts which bring out the whole even if they are somewhat vague (cognitiones obscurae vel confusae) are not bivalent in the usual sense—i.e. true or false—but, as a monovalent “yes,” simply nice. Here Baumgarten went out from a claim by Leibniz (1646–1716), the father of an explicative theory of pure observation:

“Every soul knows infinity—knows everything—but knows it in a confused way. It is like what happens when I walk along the seashore: in hearing the roar of the sea, I hear—though without distinguishing them—the individual ‘little’ noises of the waves out of which that total noise is made up.”¹⁹

This is also the source of the true epistemic power of art. Artists “see” what has been painted well and what badly, and are also able to explain why up to a point, but beyond it “all they can say is that the works that displease them lack a certain *je-ne-sais-quoi* (French for ‘I don’t know what’) ...”²⁰

The poet expresses himself in a similar way when, in an initial confession, he declares: “I don’t know what it should mean that I am so sad ...”. All expressive utterances draw on the power of the vague to bring forth something which moves us as a whole, possibly even as a “fairy tale from ancient times.” Indistinctness extends the scope of expressive articulation to the border of stammering or even silence. In this sense the precise vocabulary of discreet conditions is not expressive and insofar both the discreet and indiscreet actually belong together.

This was precisely what Leibniz wanted to show as the last thinker professing a universal *reunion*, but to no avail—Galilei’s split theory won the upper hand. The human and natural sciences adopted an opposing stance which was groundless under the circumstances. Both *essentially* strove to propound truth, although *methodically* along different paths. This led to the establishment of two realms, which Dilthey called the realm of explanation and the realm of understanding. However, neither realm needs to hide from the other when it comes to their balance of precision. Even such a naturalistic thinker as Willard Van

¹⁸ *Aesthetica* § 7, Schweizer, H. R. 1973. *Ästhetik als Philosophie der sinnlichen Erkenntnis* [Aesthetics as the Philosophy of Sensuous Cognition]. Basel–Stuttgart, 109.

¹⁹ Leibniz, G. W. 2004. *Principles of Nature and Grace Based on Reason*. www.earlymoderntexts.com/assets/pdfs/leibniz1714a.pdf, copyright 2010–2015, all rights reserved. Jonathan Bennett, 6.

²⁰ Leibniz, G. W. 2004. *Meditations on Knowledge, Truth and Ideas*. www.earlymoderntexts.com/assets/pdfs/leibniz1684.pdf, copyright 2010–2015, Jonathan Bennett, 2.

Orman Quine (1908–2000) appreciated the subject-specific precision advantage of indistinct over exact vocabulary:

“A painter with his limited palette can achieve a more exact rendition by thinning and combining his colours than a mosaicist with his limited variety of tile [...]. The clever layering of vague things has similar advantages over the fitting together of precise technical terms.”²¹

The sphere of vagueness has its own form of precision.

In the sphere of experience, e.g. in historical conditions, we usually need the painter’s palette and not mosaic stones to articulate classified phenomena like the Renaissance or the Baroque, but also experiences like melancholy or nostalgia, which escape precise description. Of course we could use mosaic stones here—as proven by the virtuosity of Byzantine art—but then we would have to do without Michelangelo Merisi da Caravaggio’s chiaroscuro. Thus we arrive at a kind of interim conclusion, that

3. PRECISION IS USUALLY OF ADVANTAGE, BUT NOT ALWAYS

If we were to sum up at this point, we could say that indistinctness in the lifeworldly and historical sense is rooted in the sphere of meaning-apprehending agents. Exactness is of advantage when we, despite remaining in our lifeworld, i.e. in our scenic existence, pursue explication and technical application. In such cases we resort to a *discreet* ontology which is best represented in digital devices (the Turing machine). Apprehension of meaning, or the realm of indistinctness, requires an *indiscreet* ontology in which all relations are a matter of context and degree.

Such gradation is naturally alien to discreet ontology unless it tries to broaden its logical apparatus by infinite-valued systems (fuzzy logic). However, as these must consistently all be reducible to two-valued systems, here too we in fact never leave the ground of discreet ontology. Transition, contrast, similarity and all kinds of modulation like nuance and mood belong to the domain of indiscreet ontology. This ontology proves itself in the life-practical sense in that it offers a speed advantage in the realm of the indistinct and vague. Of course there are analogical representations at play here too, but everything takes place really fast. The analogical models are practically indispensable, at least in situations where precision and nuance are important but time is scarce.²²

We will easily see how this is a life-practical advantage over processing information by means of discreet ontology if we imagine a scene in a crime

²¹ Quine, W. V. O. 1960. *Word and Objects*. MIT Press, 5.

²² Hogrebe, W. 2013. *Metaphysik und Mantik* [Metaphysics and Manticism]. Berlin, 177.

thriller: someone enters a dark cellar in the night, and there sees four armed figures at a table weakly lit by a swaying lamp. Unless this is a trusted group of conspirators to which this someone belongs, he/she will sense with lightning speed that the situation is “risky.” Such indiscreet-ontology-driven apprehension is important, among others because it activates our flight and rapprochement instincts. Were we to write a computer programme for this kind of perception with the help of discreet ontology, it would quickly transcend the disk space of computers. What is needed here are stories that convey the situational context.

In any case, the architectures of computers and brains do not appear to be isomorphic. All computers are Turing machines, and if all intuitively calculable functions are also Turing-calculable—as has been assumed since Alonzo Church—then evidently brains, like other organisms, are not calculable in this sense.

However this may be, the human sciences will remain indispensable as long as the context-sensitivity and resulting complexity of life conditions make them inaccessible to calculation. This is why restricting complexity has become a new train in cognition theory with studies currently still in progress.²³ What is in progress should not be interrupted, so let us pass to the fourth and very brief final point of our reflections on indistinctness and disunion:

4. THE MISERY OF REDUCTIONISTIC PROGRAMMES

The postulate that indiscreet ontology must be converted into the discreet variant—if need be even at the cost of phenomena—would perforce entail adherence to a reductionistic programme which puts *method* before *phenomenon*. One can well imagine what this would mean for man as the object of science. Unfortunately quite popular today, reductionism is only possible given the partial destruction of phenomena. This is not *iconoclasm* but—please excuse the neologism—*phenomenoclasm*. However, both these destructive options are attacks on the human being in its metaphysical depth, i.e. on man as a sense-oriented being.²⁴

Thank goodness I in my moribundity have never yet encountered a physician who would back such a reductionistic approach. Thus, we can say that our reflections carry the following message: methodical differences are praiseworthy

²³ Especially noteworthy here are studies by Graham Priest, Patrick Grimm, Gregory Chaitin and others. For more cf. Joachim Bromand’s abovementioned lucid study *The Boundaries of Knowledge*.

²⁴ Cf. Hogebe, W. 1974. *Kant und das Problem einer transzendentalen Semantik* [Kant and the Problem of Transcendental Semantics]. Freiburg–Munich, 43, footnote. 80: “Every *field of meaning* [...] is always a semantic field, a *field of sense*.” In this context cf. a new conception: Gabriel, M. 2015. *Fields of Sense. A New Realistic Ontology*. Edinburgh.

insofar as they do not infringe on our orientation on truth. One can also link this to a *modified* maxim from Juvenal (ca. 60–138), which is always quoted but no one can verify,²⁵ or its later pronouncement by Claudio Aquaviva (1543–1615), the fifth and first non-Spanish Superior General of the Society of Jesus: *Fortiter in veritate, suaviter in methodo*.²⁶ Some accounts also contain an important complement: *constanter in se*.

However, this principle of faith to oneself opens another issue, which would be hard to discuss under the heading “indistinctness and disunion.”

ABOUT THE AUTHOR — professor of theoretical philosophy, University of Bonn, Regina-Pacis-Weg 3, 53113 Bonn (affiliation), Germany, since 2013—professor emeritus. In 2006 he was awarded by the professorship of the Gadamer Foundation at the Heidelberg University (German name: *Ruprecht-Karls-Universität Heidelberg*), Germany. 1999–2002—President of the German Philosophical Society. Main publications: 1974. *Kant und das Problem einer transzendentalen Semantik*. Freiburg–München; 1977. *Archäologische Bedeutungspostulate*. Freiburg–München; 1987. *Deutsche Philosophie im XIX. Jahrhundert. Kritik der idealistischen Vernunft*. München; 1989. *Prädikation und Genesis*. Frankfurt a. M.; 1992. *Metaphysik und Mantik*. Frankfurt a. M. 1997. *Ahnung und Erkenntnis*. Frankfurt a. M. 1997; 1999. *Subjektivität*. München; 2006. *Echo des Nichtwissens*. Berlin; 2007. *Wirklichkeit des Denkens*. Heidelberg; 2009. *Riskante Lebensnähe. Die szenische Existenz des Menschen*. Berlin; 2011. *Beuyssianismus. Expressive Strukturen der Moderne*. Paderborn; 2013. *Der implizite Mensch*. Akademie Verlag, Berlin; 2014. *Philosophischer Surrealismus*. Berlin.

E-mail: wolfram@hogrebe.info

²⁵ I was also unable to verify this passage by Juvenal. Theo Kobusch referred me to similar passages in the *Book of Wisdom* [Old Testament] and Boethius, for which I am grateful. Practically all we have is Aquaviva. This is also a historical indistinctness whose clearance must be left to a future effort.

²⁶ *Industriae ad curandos animae morbos* 2,4.

Jerzy Kochan

FREEDOM AND INTERPELLATION OR ABOUT FREEDOM ACCORDING TO LOUIS ALTHUSSER

“The beginning and end of all philosophy is freedom.”

– Friedrich Wilhelm Joseph von Schelling

ABSTRACT

The paper presents a new understanding of freedom. It refers to the concept of ideology and the interpellation of Louis Althusser. In this new perspective freedom is a phenomenon from the sphere of social communication, and, more broadly, a process of socialization, in which plays the role of a subtle medium of interiorization of ideological philosophical universalisms. This specific role of freedom and especially its prevalence in the contemporary world has its fundamental anchored in the common within the framework of capitalism society private ownership of the workforce

Keywords: Freedom, interpellation, ideology, universalisms, socialisation, Karl Marx, Louis Althusser.

I would like to begin with the idea of neoclassicism in philosophy or, more broadly, the idea of neoclassicism in social sciences and the humanities. My intention is to redefine from a contemporary point of view classical philosophical problems, notions and ideas. I want to apply new experiences and fresh sensitivities to the traditional philosophical dictionary in order to check whether it is still alive or rather completely frozen. From this point of view the main problem of this paper is about freedom in general. Is it possible to speak about freedom in intellectually serious way? And if so, how can we do it?

TRACKS OF FREEDOM

Writing about freedom is a difficult and unrewarding task. Everybody knows freedom, not only philosophers. Freedom concerns everyone, so everyone seems to be competent to discuss it. However, regardless of such feelings, and in spite of Giambattista Vico's spontaneous stress on the humanistic rather than natural accessibility of research, such an apparently normal proximity and commonness of the question of freedom does not seem to be of much use when it comes to the understanding of this phenomenon. Freedom implies mystery, and the very few who might attempt at solving it, optimistically believing in a possibility of a comprehensive theory, end up looking in despair for an answer at the level of novelty in natural sciences.

Before I start to investigate the issue, I first offer some tips that will help to define some specific conditions of thinking about freedom in general.

Although it may seem strange, in history freedom was a hardly popular and desirable phenomenon. In the Middle Ages, with their feudal hierarchy, it was deemed more valuable to find a good seigneur, and thus gain protection and security. Freedom was not a principal problem for philosophy, politics nor religion. It was reduced to the role of free will, the ground for morality and conscience. In fact, freedom became a topic for discussion only at the end of the 18th century and in the 19th century, after Friedrich von Schelling said that "*the beginning and end of all philosophy is freedom*," and when, according to Benedetto Croce, freedom became a new religion.¹ Since that time freedom became the central problem of history and culture. Clearly, it has taken up the place and role once occupied by religion, church and clergy. Previously connected with the religious function of pastoral power in reproduction of social consciousness, freedom was secularised by secular experts of the idea-making craft. Clergyman substituted an ideologist. Ideology substituted religion. This new secular form of pastoral power contrasts ideas with the tradition, custom and routine.

Ideology is understood here as creating science-like system of views on nature, society and man. Such system is expanded and organised by intellectualists (ideologists), popularised within large social groups who become aware of the motivation of their historical activity. Ideology is being used by them as a tool for coordinating their social behaviour.

The question remains: why freedom, ideology and ideologists came together in a certain point in history and what were the economic foundations of these three?

Such a coincidence is *prima facie* connected with the origin of capitalist society and essence of capital. Private property in its capitalist form is traditionally treated as fundamental for individualism, competition, rivalry and social contradictions. The role of the individual and private property of the labour power

¹ Croce, B. 1933. *History of Europe in the Nineteenth Century*. Harcourt, Brace & Co., 21.

are not so often emphasised. Freedom in capitalist society means both: freedom for capital and capitalists, but also freedom for wage labour, for workers etc. Of course, we speak about them in terms of commodity and labour market. We can easily understand this freedom when we compare ancient slaves and medieval peasant with free capitalists workers.

History should not be treated as a process of the increasing of the division of labour and socialisation of labour. Historical epochs, despite their diversity, always are associated with the partition of society into the rich and poor, the exploited and the exploiters who just are differently called. In such thinking distinctions between slave, feudal peasant and worker in capitalist society often become obscure. These people are portrayed as an object of the imminent or scandalous exploitation, which in fact is not so different from the exploitation taking place in other epochs. At the same time, the main features of the position of slaves, peasants and workers are essentially different. Otherness depends not only upon the transformation of nature, things or changing capital conditions. In order to unveil this, an extensive analysis of *the notion of labour power* is required.

It is extremely important to notice that slaves do not own their labour power and cannot make their skills the object of commercial transactions. Of course, slaves do not have their own means of production. In this sense the position of peasants tied to the land in feudal society seems to be fundamentally different. It is so, because usually peasant is the owner of land, livestock, tools, even though—like a slave—he does not own himself. An indignant description of how peasants were expelled from their land, presented by Thomas More in the *Utopia* (1516), was repeated a couple of hundred years later by Karl Marx in the first volume of the *Capital*, in the discussion on the so-called primitive accumulation. There is a dramatic description of the process where peasants lose ownership of the land and are transformed into *Johns without land*, free workers selling their labour power. The phrase that the capitalist workers has only themselves for sale has a pejorative value. Yet the opportunity to freely sell their labour force is something that neither slave, man nor medieval craftsman (tightly bound by the corset of the guild organisation controlling production) ever had. Social space generated by the French Revolution generates not only a free market for capital, but also a room for the freedom of the market for the owners of the labour power. Free property, as capital and labour, is not only a source of frustration and joy, but also a result of the increasing growth of the complexity of social relations and intensity of social life. It is also an engine of development for the units subjectively participating in the market game. It is not a coincidence that the whole Hegelian story is woven around the formation of subjectivity and obtaining self-consciousness. This ontological link of freedom reveals its radically new universal social experience and social praxis.

This fundamental fact determines the necessity of development for all social reproductions of democratic forms. In this sense, ideology can appeal to the will

of an individual and to personal responsibility. For almost all citizens the awareness of freedom has a deep economic basis in individual possession, the private property of labour power and everyday necessity for struggle for getting a good exchange—rate for it.

In general, possession of labour power plays more fundamental role in capitalist society and from this point of view, possession of capital is only a specific form of enjoying possessing labour-power.²

According to this, unemployment does not mean lack of jobs. It involves blocking the rights of the owner of labour—power to use his property. Contradictions between the owners of labour-power are very important for the efficiency of class struggle in capitalism and also after socialist revolutions.

This fundamental role of seller's freedom helps us to understand why the idea of freedom was treated as a "new religion" by people since the 19th century. In recent consumption-based capitalism seller's freedom is complemented with the role of the consumer.

In order to summarise these freedom tracks, we could say that freedom must be:

- connected with capitalism;
- established on common private property in its two forms (capital and labour-power);
- tied with new forms of pastoral, secular and scientific powers; in other words—with ideologies and ideologists;
- play important role in the production of ideal conditions for process of social reproduction as such.

These initial remarks may seem a little strange. First, because they lead us away from traditional debates about the human brain, soul, consciousness and other naive materialistic categories. Second, because they drive us away from the realm of miracle and its nickname—chance. Instead they lead us to problems related to capitalism, culture, social communications, social construction of human subjectivity, socialisation and to historical and dialectical materialism.

My effort to create a new conception of freedom, which would go beyond paradoxes and traps set by the traditional approach to philosophy of freedom, is expressed in the title of this article. Freedom and interpellation are two key concepts of the presented idea, according to which *freedom appears to be a historically determined social medium of ideological interpellation for participation in realising a social project, or—in a wider sense—a subtle medium of social interpellation, appellation for taking part in forms of production and reproduction of society.*

² One can find a more extensive information about this concept in Johann Gottlieb Fichte's *The Closed Commercial State*. I wrote about this in: 2008. "Johann Gottlieb Fichte jako prekursor nowoczesnej koncepcji własności." [Johann Gottlieb Fichte as a Forerunner of Modern Conception of Possession]. In: *Zróżnicowanie społeczne w teorii i empirii* [Social Diversity in Theory and in Empiria]. Suchocka, R. (Ed.). Poznań, 46–55.

What is this *interpellation/appellation*?³

The simplest way to explain this is by presenting the following scene: imagine a crowded street. Someone suddenly calls: “Hey, you!” These words would probably make us all turn around in reaction, as if the call applied directly to each of us. This is the *interpellation/appellation* I am concerned with, not the strict definition of it—as related to the parliamentary or legal tradition. Of course, the abundance of *interpellations* considered in categories of ideology or reproduction of bourgeois society cannot be easily reduced to a case illustrated by this simple example, although it includes a basic content of grasping freedom as a moment of *interpellation* constituting the subject as a phenomenon in the sphere of social communication, and not as a specific trait in the biological constitution of man.

I am aware that explaining this idea in such a way leaves one with a strong yearning and only provokes dozens of questions. Here we are faced with the situation similar to the one where the subject of philosophy is meant to be determined. Even if adversaries finally agreed (after many arguments) that historically speaking it deals with general laws and knowledge of reality, the brevity of this statement would contrast strikingly with individually experienced wealth of philosophical questioning. In those instances I prefer to invoke such an understanding of philosophy which assumes it to be a history of philosophy.

A similar historical approach seems to be fruitful in the case of freedom, although in the paradigm of freedom we face troubling overabundance of literature, concepts and ideas whose historical understanding resembles the effort similar to the one young people face while looking at hundreds of volumes and books, differing in rank and value, nonetheless luring potential readers. It is possible that reading intently throughout whole life a person reads mostly irrelevant market-produced scribbling, or as Albert Camus’s hero reads systematically following only the alphabetical index of the authors to finally reach, let us say, letter “F”. Therefore, I am not suggesting a simple repetition of historical traces of the notion of freedom, which would go beyond powers of the reader and author. I suggest taking the direction of the historical–logical form of a conceptual understanding of freedom. It is a lecture free from contingent assumed by freedom, absolved of peripheral and mutated forms, yet opening a way to new interpretation and localisation (thus it lacks presentation—or describes them in a sketchy manner—of many philosophical conceptions, also those for which the question of freedom might seem central, e.g. existentialism and personalism). The basic analysis relates to forming the idea of freedom in German philosophy at the turn of the 18th and 19th centuries. It is exactly in the critical depiction of Kant’s, Fichte’s and Hegel’s philosophy where understanding of freedom as *interpellation* gains content and takes up a full shape.

³ I tend use these two terms alternatively.

FREEDOM IN CLASSICAL GERMAN PHILOSOPHY

In this context it would be interesting to check shortly what we can find about freedom in classical German philosophy. It is not an easy task. Epistemological obstacles made by academic praxis are very difficult to overturn. Especially in Poland, where Immanuel Kant is considered by most philosophers not a thinker who reduced the role of religion to the vehicle of morality, but as creator of the best moral evidence *for the existence of God*.

Kant's philosophy is fundamental when it comes to understanding the position of God in the German philosophical tradition and in the case of freedom as such. From Kant's point of view the main contradiction that one faces when trying to create a philosophical system is the contradiction between the scientific world of necessity and free will, fundamental for morality. In other words, there is a contradiction between the modern building of scientific knowledge and the need for free will as related to responsibility and morality as such. Kant, who lived in Königsberg and was truly a walking *Encyclopaedia*, fully accepted all the optimistic views that were connected with the Enlightenment. Kant caged free will in morality. It does not play any role in general ontology and epistemology. Kant simply understands free will as a special form of causality at work between people—the fact that people act *as if*⁴ (“as good as”—in German “*als ob*”) means that they are free.

What does it exactly mean?

First of all, such an explanation presents the uncertain status of free will, when compared to the traditional certainty of human freedom as received straight from gods or nature. Next: free will is still in the cage of morality and is not dangerous for the world of scientific laws. And at last, freedom is still real, because the authentic motivation of human actions is equally real as the idea of freedom.⁵

The description of Kant's understanding of freedom in categories: “not full freedom,” “freedom antinomy,” “contradiction” and so on, are fundamentally wrong. They do not grasp that Kant created and operated at a completely new ontological level of existence.

There is not much more to be found in Kant's works on this subject. It is enough to say that whilst facing this phenomenon Kant felt almost ecstatic: “Two things fill the mind with ever new and increasing admiration and awe, the

⁴ Kant's *als ob* has been translated this way to English by Hans Vaihinger's in his work *Die Philosophie des Als Ob* (1911) (1924. *The Philosophy of 'As-If'*. London.)

⁵ “Every being that cannot act otherwise than *under the idea of freedom* is precisely for this reason actually free in a practical respect, i.e., all laws inseparably combined with freedom are valid for it, just as if its will had also been declared free in itself and in a way that is valid in theoretical philosophy.” Kant, I. 2002. *Groundwork of the Metaphysics of Morals Grounding for the Metaphysics of Morals*. Woo, A. W. (Trans., Ed.). Yale University Press.

oftener and more steadily we reflect on them: the starry heavens above me and the moral law within.”⁶

Methodological individualism did not allow Kant to go over these forms of insight (notion and emotion) and get to “dumb” generality of freedom, but—just like in case of whole Kant’s philosophy—the naturalistic standpoint in understanding freedom was finally destroyed. It is not a minor achievement. Up to this day philosophy has problems with the consumption of this revolutionary insight.

The revolutionary power, which is shown a bit *in nuce* in Kant’s philosophy and his approach to freedom, exploded in works of Johann Gottlieb Fichte. Fichte, whose first book was mistaken for Kant’s work, expanded subjectivity on the whole world and prepared grounds for Marx and his monistic historical materialism. For him, freedom is the essence of human being. It is the starting point in the realisation of the human pursuit. From now on, the main goal of philosophy is the attempt to answer the question of the human pursuit.

As a philosopher Fichte wanted to be a secular priest, appealing to people to fight for human happiness in the mundane dimension. The continuation of Kant’s idea of universal human morality, which Kant tried to attain by means of the *categorical imperative*, takes a form of a fully developed social project presented in *Der Geschlossene Handelsstaat* [*The Closed Commercial State*].⁷

The philosopher’s individual activity and his social influence have a great impact at the target very precisely described in *The Closed Commercial State*. Fichte’s interpellation—let me freely use this word from now on—has to take the form of secular religion, formed just like a scientific project and inserted to social consciousness as new ideas by an individual philosopher—in this case Fichte. What we find in *The Closed Commercial State* is not a national propaganda, as it is sometimes misunderstood. In fact, it is a gorgeous program of the socialist worldwide revolution. Fichte takes the role of a classical idea-maker, ideologist, creator of ideology. In his *Addresses to the German Nation* (1808) he says that the German nation consists of all the people who accept ideas of German philosophy and principles of human calling, even if they cannot speak German at all, and that “German nation” does not include German-speaking people who do not accept new ideas of human pursuit. The criterion of acceptance does not rely on nationality but on ideology. Fichte’s philosophy is hot-headed and aggressive. For him it is not only the problem of a social project. He offers a general answer to the question on the meaning of life and *sui generis* infinity, immortality. For contemporary readers his writings are sometimes too emotional, unscientific, pushy etc. It is so, because we might have gotten accustomed to the way ideology is being presented to mass society, to

⁶ Kant, I. *Critique of Practical Reason*. Abbott, T. K. (Trans.). Web edition published by eBooks@Adelaide: <https://ebooks.adelaide.edu.au/k/kant/immanuel/k16pra/index.html>

⁷ Fichte, J. G. 2012. *The Closed Commercial State*. Adler, A.C. (Trans.). Suny Press.

the industry production of ideology and this type of handicraft is too personal and too direct for us. But it is precisely why Fichte is such a wonderful model, an epitome of ideological *praxis* of interpellation. In his papers and in his life we can trace a new ideological practice personalised in the form of individual activity, which is easy to recognise and easy to love or hate.

In the middle of this ideological interpellation we find freedom. We must understand that Fichte's *The Science of Knowledge* broadens the space for freedom. If the subjective "Ego" destroys the "thing-in-itself," then the whole world is "moral." So freedom is now—as the element of human activity—an irremovable moment of the whole world.

We can see now that the inception, roots of the category "praxis" takes up the meaning that Marx used. It is necessary to remember that Fichte is not Kant's epigone but rather Hegel's and Marx's precursor. The specific human form of determination occurs like a form of overdetermination in relations with the nature. The world can exist now without *fate*, *fortune* and *moira*. The whole existence shines thanks to freedom and creation of the subjective person loyal to its call and duty. In other words, human freedom has here two dimensions. First, it is simply connected with the idea of human essence as "the ensemble of the social relations" or "social humanity." Second, it is defined by human activity in changing the surrounding world.

For Fichte freedom is not only an idea. It is a real possibility of the whole social project described in *The Vocation of Man* and *The Closed Commercial State*. If we act for human happiness, we are free. If not—we are slaves. This is an important point usually presented in the discussions about freedom. Our free will seems to be free only at the moment of our decision. We have to decide, before the ink is dry, and choose the way of our activity, ideas, religion, God, social project. In this case it is necessary to hurry as well. *We have to answer for the scientifically built vocation of man*. Fichte throws religion out—even as a vehicle of morality. The place of religion, its holy essence, is taken over by social sciences. The positive, active answer for calling gives us freedom, happiness and immortality. What we see is that freedom is not accessible for all. The one who does not answer for interpellation must be sentenced for slavery, misfortune, finitude. Freedom is in fact necessity to accept the concrete social project.

If we want to avoid "newspeak" in this context, we have to answer the question on the function of "freedom" in a little more detailed way. Unconditional freedom and free will seemed to be *sui generis* decoy for the people, citizens, ideological subjects. Just like a rabbit is for greyhounds racing an electrically controlled and propelled mechanical hare. Everyone—including the dogs—knows that this is not a real rabbit, nor a real hunt. But this impossible structure still works! The same happens with freedom. Of course, freedom is not understood here as a form of independence from determinism or social influence, but rather as an instrument or form for creating ideological subjectivity, an actor on

the historical scene open for different ideological contents. *This is why freedom is deemed so precious for different, contradictory ideologies.*

Everybody is for freedom. Freedom offers different universalities for everyone. True freedoms and true universalities which are rival to one another. Once they get a specific social, ideological and political content, they lead us to the centre of the class struggle in its various forms.

This early form of ideological interpellation is strictly connected with Fichte's skillful form of expression. Yet the real locus of interpellation is not personal. Fichte represents something more—classical German philosophy and a particular social project, in the same way as Kant was interested in the possible conditions of the natural science, but not in a way in which someone thinks about time or space. In these cases the point of reference is a cultural ideal construct. Therefore, if we name it as the *other*, it will be a big step back and simple form of anthropomorphisation of impersonal social expectations. Today we can speak about many *others*. But these different mirrors that could help us to recognise ourselves when we are hailed seem now to be completely broken and mixed.

According to Hegel, the mirror is one and it belongs to the state.

Hegel was a philosopher of freedom. In fact, all his philosophy concerns the process of understanding freedom. It deals with the general transition from *consciousness* to *self-consciousness*: *The history of the world is none other than the progress of the consciousness of Freedom.* He treated himself and other people only as *agents* in the division of labour happening in the spiritual development. The state, law and philosophy are a salvation for freedom. It is departure to the rational subject of the Enlightenment. Freedom is for the *spirit* and for the *state*, ordinary people have to feel satisfied by *desire*.⁸ This act of nationalisation, giving control to the state, goes together with the development of social knowledge. *The Closed Commercial State* is replaced by analyses of class and states (*Stände*), economy and law. Freedom is socialised and mechanised. Freedom is not connected only with the responsibility of individual consciousness. It is now related to the dialectics of the objective, subjective and absolute spirit. As a result, we can see how the unique status of human being becomes an accidental moment in the history of nations. I do not have in mind the critics of Hegel nor laud Fichte's humanity. The problems rests rather in deference between Hegel's subject of the state reproduction and Fichte's ideological subject of revolution, negation of feudalism and even—if we bear in mind the radicalism of *The Closed Commercial State*—negation of capitalism. Maybe in this point we can find the source of the Hegelian respect for Napoleon Bonaparte and hate for Fichte.

⁸ Hegel wrote about people in history: "most of them are entirely ignorant of what is at stake and merely take head blows as from an invisible hand" (Hegel's *Letter to Niethammer* 5.07.1816 (<https://www.marxists.org/reference/archive/hegel/works/letters/1816-07-05.htm>); 1958. *Briefe von und an Hegel*, vol. II, Hamburg, 87.

The new Hegelian rationality transcends forms bound with individual subject and points us toward the complicated relation between human/ things and complex machinery of society and state, artificial construction of social reproduction. For Hegel, it is necessary to emphasise human/ things character of social relations, their natural essence, not some fundamental extraordinary dimension of human existence (as Kant and Fichte did). In this sense, Hegel's reflection on freedom should be treated as crucial for any general theory of freedom.

FREEDOM ACCORDING TO LUIS ALTHUSSER

It should be clear by now that the author of this paper observes freedom in history via aspects and spirit of Althusser's philosophy, especially his theory of ideology, including the model of interpellation, "hailing," creation of subjectivity in act and conditions of ideological communication. The Althusserian influence also consists in some classical categories and interpretations of historical materialism. All this leads us to conclusion that we shall use some significant elements of the Althusserian tradition (or at least we intend to) in order to find fresh, interesting and intellectually useful approach to classical problem of freedom. Needless to say, it is possible to find a plenty of differences and contradictions between my attempts and the tradition of Althusser. But, as it occurs, the problem now seems to be formulated in such an insightful way that a serious discussion on freedom is possible.

In the end, I would like to present three final remarks. First, I will briefly point a single important difference between my own interpretation of interpellation and the one presented in the *Ideology and Ideological State Apparatuses*. The second remark concerns the possibility of short answer to question "What is freedom?" or "What exactly is freedom?" The third note concerns the shaping of consumer entity and consumer freedom.

If I accurately understood the category of interpellation presented in the *Ideology and Ideological State Apparatuses*, it seems to be used strictly to straighten the function of ideological interpellation as a form of the ideological state apparatuses activity. In this way "interpellation" occurs in strictly political categories, bound with state and its class functions (dictatorship of the bourgeoisie). In my view "interpellation" can be comprehended more universally as an instrument of recruitment used in different ideal systems of interpretation of the world views with social program at their core. Interpellation plays the same role in religious systems. It is not specific of one capitalistic social formation, but can be used in various forms of socialisation in different epochs. And so, the whole concept of "interpellation," becomes more useful, more universal and connected with all forms and kinds of socialisation.

We have called "interpellation" the main instrument of philosophy. While talking about feudalism we often like to emphasise specific status of philosophy

at that time. We tend to remind that in those days philosophy was treated as *ancilla theologie*. But if we approve that theology, ideology and philosophy are essential elements of the reproduction of social being and continuous process of socialisation, then we can conclude that all of them are *ancillae paedagogiae*!

Of course, at this moment we do not think only about schools and universities. The full process of socialisation, especially in our times, is written for different voices of contemporary mass society. The teacher with a piece of chalk, standing by the blackboard is rather archaic figure nowadays. In fact, the pedagogical process is hard to localise, since it permeates every part of our culture. The central moment of this stage is connected to an individual and its needs. The influence of private property of labour power on the importance of freedom is increased by consumer's rationality and use of his free during making choices on commodity markets. Consumer's freedom is an extension of worker's freedom; the confirmation of its good application and real power. But the general role of freedom is the same.

Freedom is a subtle medium of the ideological interpellation for an active participation in the realisation of an ideological social project.

Freedom as the described type of medium is specific of the capitalist society, grounded in the private property of labour power and consumers' rationality. By contrast, in feudalism this function is played by salvation. Like freedom in the capitalist society, salvation was at the heart of feudal culture. This is not limited only to the role of religion in the feudal past. The struggle between different religious fundamentalisms proves that confrontation between freedom and salvation is still a fact.

This definition of freedom emphasises the role of ideology and politics but, as we have said earlier, we can stress the general pedagogic function or the process of socialisation. I do not believe that this new understating of freedom could change ideology or politics; it only creates better conditions for asking about freedom, and helps us to realise that asking about "freedom" brings problems of how should we understand its meaning. We have only endured, reformulated and got over "freedom."

FREEDOM AND CONSUMPTION

Freedom as a medium of interpellation takes the form of a call to participate in the implementation of a social or political project, to implement certain ideology or worldview. Interpellation is a call to be free, that is, to make a choice. In fact, we attain freedom for a moment, to hold and immediately make a choice. The appellant can choose one universalism and treat the second as Other. In capitalism there are two alternative models of society: capitalism and socialism. All other interpellations are just elements of the subgroups belonging to these two fields; they can take the form of hybrid, conglomerate or amor-

phous bonding. Within these antagonistic and contradictory poles of polarisation, the call “be free” is immediately developed in the propagated political universalism. The exercise of freedom means to opt for one project, one interpellation. The positive response to another interpellation is called a “bad use of freedom,” “illusory freedom,” “bad infinity” and “falling into slavery.”

The interpellating subject is also the general subject socialising itself in the social process of teaching which goes far beyond the school. Here freedom is the foundation of choice—possible and within reach of every free will. The use and value of freedom, which is a positive response to the content of the interpellation, is a reward in form of “happiness” or “valuable life.”

But the political, ideological or pedagogical subject is not everything. In the consumer society turns up a very significant subject—the consumer, whose free will is subjected to the world of advertising and marketing. In this case referring to the subjectivity and freedom of choice is the foundation of the realisation circulation of capital, not just the reproduction of cultural hegemony of the ruling class.

The object of criticism is not just the consumer society as a whole. Its different parts and ongoing processes are analysed and criticised, namely: commercialisation, reification, homogenisation, McDonaldisation, etc. But the main significance seems to be related to the crisis of the rational subject and rationality as such. Essentially it means disintegration and total disaster for person of the enlightenment, disaster for the individual conscious subject, who (based on the scientific rational image of the world) has to be a genuine *homo sapiens*, outgrown from prior immaturity (Kant) able to become a citizen, society, state. The structure of the civil society, with all its institutional forms of rational communication, seems to be smashed by the consumer subject. The consumer subject logic of operation seems to be closest to the logic of Pavlov’s dog reaction or a jazz orchestra trumpeter salivating when seeing a boy eating a lemon. Accordingly, possibility of shopping and consumption, and a point of view defined by the desire of having a full trolley in a supermarket, all moral norms, labour and international laws, religious precepts and prohibitions crack and become devaluated.

It is not true that bombs and desperate men on the loose pose the biggest terrorist threat of our times; even presidents who break international law, violate the UN charter, disregard human rights and provoke wars in various parts of our globe, wars upon unreal pretexts are not the biggest terrorists. The super-terrorist in contemporary globalised world is consumption, an extended medium of global society that drives global capitalism processes of reproduction. Consumption penetrates and terrorises the macro-world—which can result in wars. It results with wars waged by the need to brim multi-cylinder tanks for the gasoline guzzlers. Consumption also penetrates our subjectivity, appoints hierarchies of values, creates our sensitivity and produces human being as a consumer.

It happens because consumption cannot be reduced to a simple physiological, economic or cultural phenomenon. The contemporary meaning of consumption is related to fundamental changes in relations between production and consumption. The symptoms of these changes can be seen when there are more employees in service rather than in production. That is why in the sphere of service we have to seek standards, models and examples that would define paradigms of functioning of all the spheres of social life. Because of the level of degradation of production and extension of consumption, examples, canons, matrixes and types of rationality from the sphere of consumption become widespread and obligatorily universal.

The whole social system and its fundamental ontology have to be strictly connected with consumer rationality. The world unmediated by consumption does not exist. Consumption becomes, in an imperial way, the principle of the whole social system including the function of the species reproduction in the biological meaning. Nowadays, even the decision about having children is often related to the assessment of the opportunities of the foreseen successors as consumers.

An individual is socialised to the world of consumption from the beginning of its life. This is why consumption is for it from the start a natural and objective world, rules of which are immediately universalised and made completely subjective. It may be even spoken on the colonisation of childhood, since childhood is utterly structured and qualified without any alternatives.

Researchers draw attention to the fact that in the consumer society even the dramatic traditional street disturbances take another form. Instead of street battles and attacks on offices or authority buildings, we witness store looting. In the consumer society freedom is identified with freedom to consumption (also to luxurious and prestigious). The discrimination of consumption is considered a limitation of freedom and general degradation of human being. Consumption, fashion, logos create new space of social communication; a sole blow can be treated as a whole message.

We can also relate these phenomena to scientific creating. As Jean Baudrillard had written many years ago, theory is not really theory, it is only an event. It does mean that theory can only exist when it becomes an event, commodity, mass media product. The *Index Librorum Prohibitorum* disappeared, just like any other form of censorship; contemporarily a barrier is ability to become a spectacle (event) on the consumer market.

It sounds dramatically, but a chance for success, free of personified violence and subjected to the democratic consumer will allows everybody to be glad to have a possibility, whose twin sister's name is hope. The compulsion of reproduction distributes itself on the democratic audience and individual will, subjectively seeking for pleasure. Of course, what is wanted and desirable, a possible source of pleasure is not neutral, but it is always an element of the terrorism of the world of consumption. But it is really hard to deny that we have to deal with

the fundamental dissimilarity of conflicts and social tensions. It is not really important that in the age of the Enlightenment arose a project showing an immature individual growing into a rational subject. This project had fallen down and its place was taken by a hypnotised purchaser of staged pleasures.

The freedom and authenticity of the individual, his/her unique character can realise itself in being an active consumer. It is not already submission to the power of another human being. It has to do more with an independent unit freely joining a spontaneous and creative availability. This is what Herbert Marcuse writes in the beginning of the *One-Dimensional Man*: “The people recognise themselves in their commodities; they find their soul in their automobile, hi-fi set, split-level home, kitchen equipment.”⁹

The depersonalisation of dependence and its impersonal nature provide us with an illusion of creativity of free will. This is exactly the character of the described relationships. The nature of these new realities arising in response to the interpellation is perfectly expressed in the slogan: “*Be yourself, drink Pepsi!*”

We are dealing with a spontaneous submission to consumption. The product of global corporations becomes a condition for the implementation of uniqueness and freedom. In this way “free will” becomes an epistemological obstacle for a real recognition of epistemological relations of exploitation and domination. The only thing we can do is enjoy the chance and worry about fate. We are dealing not only with the crisis of the Enlightenment model of human consciousness, but even the destruction of the rational subject without which there is no freedom as a recognised necessity.

There is no freedom, but there is no slavery either ...

ABOUT THE AUTHOR — PhD, associate professor, Instytut of Philosophy, Szczeciński University, Krakowska 71–79, 71–004 Szczecin, Poland (affiliation). Chief of the Department of Philosophy of Culture; Nowa Krytyka [New Critique] editor-in-chief. President of the Polish Marxists’ Association. He published among others: 2004. *Wolność i interpelacja*, Szczecin; 2007. *Życie codzienne w matriksie. Filozofia społeczna w ponowoczesności*; 2011. *Studia z teorii klas społecznych*. Warszawa; 2013. *Socjalizm*. Warszawa; 2015. Warszawa.

E-mail: jerzy_kochan@poczta.onet.pl

⁹ Marcuse, H. *One-Dimensional Man*:

<http://www.marcuse.org/herbert/quotes/QuotRedThread.html#Capitalism>

Michał Rożynek

GENEALOGY AS A METHOD AND A PROGRAMME

ABSTRACT

Genealogy is a well-known philosophical method, often used by a disciplines of Friedrich Nietzsche and Michel Foucault. It is seen as part of a broader programme—one that offers critical tools for examining the modes of production of the modern political subject. The aim of this article is to show the usefulness of the genealogical method as a mode of critique separate from the philosophical programme it often belongs to. In order to do this, the paper examines the transformations of genealogy from Nietzsche to Foucault as well as the common lines of critique.

Keywords: Michel Foucault; genealogy; Friedrich Nietzsche.

*Knowledge is not made for understanding;
it is made for cutting.*

Michel Foucault

Genealogy is central to the self-understanding of certain strands of critical and post-structural social and political thought. It is little known and little thought of in the Anglophone political philosophy, because of the commitment to ideal models of enquiry made by the latter on the one hand; and on the other hand, genealogy is often seen as inherently linked to a philosophical programme of deconstruction, rather than an autonomous method. The purpose of this short article is twofold. First, it is to familiarize ourselves with this mode of philosophizing and reflect on its role in contemporary political theory; as well as discuss the main lines of criticism of genealogy both as a programme and as a method. Second, I will argue that whilst genealogy can be understood as both a method and a philosophical programme, the former can be used without a strong theoretical commitment to the latter.

In order to do this I first attempt to reconstruct genealogy in its narrow, philosophical application as introduced by Nietzsche and adapted by Foucault. I will focus on the main objectives and structural features of genealogy that differentiate it from other modes of historical enquiry. Genealogy in this sense is not an attempt to reconstruct the past but a way of understanding contemporary identities and structures as contingent and historical. The subject of genealogy is not a study of any identity or concept but of *our* identity and the ideals and values that underlie it. This leads me to discuss the implications of genealogy as a method for the concept of identity, including the identity of the theorist (genealogist). My intention is to show how a set of methodological assumptions led to a program of systematic deconstruction of identity. The third section explores the ways in which genealogy can be understood as a critique I conclude by showing the link between genealogy and particular understanding of justice as emancipation. Given the limited nature of this article, it should be treated as nothing more, but an introduction to a number of interesting lines of enquiry.

THE CONCEPT

Although genealogy has been recognized and used as a method in social and political research by a number of authors, the term still remains ambiguous and unclear. To a certain extent, ambiguity of genealogy is inherent to the notion itself. Just like history, genealogy can be understood as a certain type of enquiry as well as the product of that enquiry. According to the *Oxford English Dictionary*, the word “genealogy” derives from ancient Greek and means “tracing of descent,” “race,” “generation,” as well as a “pedigree.” A genealogical enquiry can be thus understood most broadly as a kind of study that is concerned with descent or is based on a reconstruction of the line of development of a particular family of related identities. The term “genealogy” can be often found to be used to mean simply “history” or “origin.” However, it is also often used to refer to a very specific line of thinkers in the 20th century, such as Michel Foucault, Judith Butler, Louis Althusser, Gilles Deleuze and Giorgio Agamben. What all these thinkers have in common is a certain approach to the relationship between theory and praxis—knowledge¹ and its supposed binding power—that can be traced through a “genealogical” analysis. In its form, genealogical enquiry is similar, and hence very often confused with, other historical narratives that attempt to reconstruct the interplay of ideas and social forces—such as we can find in the works of Max Weber, Walter Benjamin, Max Horkheimer, Theodor Adorno or Georg Simmel. In all these cases, encounter with the historical is understood as only instrumental to a conceptual analysis, the purpose of which is to trace “concrete genetic sets of relations which are inevitably of a specifi-

¹ Geuss, R. 2002. “Genealogy as Critique.” *European Journal of Philosophy*, 10, 2, 209.

cally unique and individual character.”² Similarly, genealogical narratives formulate contrastive periodizations, construct paradigmatic moments and move between broad historical lines.³ As a result, they are very often criticized for being arbitrary, rhetorical and hyperbolic.⁴ Whether this criticism is at all sustainable should become clear to us when we look at the general features of genealogies. Despite the broad similarities amongst the above approaches to history, genealogy is a distinct and unique practice or method of interrogating abstract notions and practices through a historical deconstruction of the interplay of forces and ideas that underlie them. In its narrow sense—even in everyday language—genealogy does not refer to just any kind of historical enquiry. It is an investigation of the lines of kinship either in its literal sense or as a metaphor. Thus understood genealogy is a study of the origins of our moral and political identities characterised by its opposition to history, philosophy of history and identity. It is ahistorical because it does not attempt to reconstruct the exact meaning of events as building blocks of the past but examines historical happenings in terms of their difference from contemporary identities. Foucault calls this the “history of the present.” Secondly genealogy is hostile to philosophy of history as the genealogist opposes any claims to universality of the laws of historical development. It is suspicious of attempts to present history as logical or as having a direction. Lastly, the activity of practising genealogy is self-destructive, because the moment we unmask our world as contingent and constructed, we are unable to offer an alternative narrative about what “really is” or what “really happened.” To be consistent, a genealogist has to reject any strong commitments to this new narrative.

NIETZSCHE AND GENEALOGY

The term “genealogy” was first introduced to popular use in the 19th century, which saw the beginning not only of the study of heredity but also of genealogical psychology and evolutionary theory. In this context Nietzsche wrote his famous *On Genealogy of Morals*.⁵ In keeping with the fashion of the time, Nietzsche uses the word “genealogy” in several different meanings that seem to form what Martin Saar calls a “multi-layered conceptual practice.”⁶ If we were to reconstruct this practice, it would be very difficult to do so from what Nietzsche tells us directly. Because, from the beginning, genealogy is predominantly a practice rather than a well-defined theoretical method. As a result, any

² Weber, M. 2002. *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism and Other Writings*. London: Penguin Classics, 32.

³ Saar, M. 2002. “Genealogy and Subjectivity.” *European Journal of Philosophy*, 10, 2, 239.

⁴ Ibid., 238.

⁵ Nietzsche, F. 1996. *On the Genealogy of Morals*. Oxford University Press.

⁶ Saar, M. 2002, op. cit., 239.

attempt to conceptualise it, has to do so by abstracting its elements from the patterns and modes of Nietzsche's narrative.

First of all, genealogy is opposed by Nietzsche to a progressivist account of history. History is not a continuity of processes determined by abstract laws of development (either social or metaphysical). The author of *Thus spoke Zarathustra* portrays history as a product of will of power. This approach is meant to recognize the fundamental freedom of human beings and our desire to create, form and master the world which we inhabit. The study of the origins of morals becomes for Nietzsche a study of ourselves. The question he asks can be thus restated in the following way: Under what conditions did man invent the value-judgment good and evil? And it is the tracing of the history of this genesis⁷ that becomes interesting as it gradually becomes a revision of morality.⁸ The reason why genealogy matters even if history does not, is that history relies on a concept of identity and thus cannot reveal the discontinuity of our moral convictions. History is a "history of," which presupposes pre-existing identities that can be traced through time. Genealogy on the other hand is not limited by the notion of identity in the same way. Instead of tracing identities, it focuses on the ways of transmitting and transforming ideas.

Nietzsche famously argues that the notions of good and evil, which we believe to be abstract, immortal and universal, are in fact a product of the interplay of power reflected by language. To illustrate this he shows how in many Indo-European dialects the concepts of good and evil can be derived or linked to "high" and "low" respectfully. Taking this point further, he shows the relationship between "good," "virtuous" and "noble," and consequently also "aristocratic" and "powerful."⁹ Nietzsche traces these concepts to their Greek and Roman roots. The Greek ideal of good, according to him, had nothing to do with the present Christian morality of sacrifice. The notion of "good"; in Ancient Greece did not come before a "good man." On the contrary, it is the "good and noble man" being the master of his fate, who defines things which are good for him. This is why beauty, health and power are good, and ugliness, suffering and submission are considered evil or inhuman. We know this story very well.¹⁰ For Nietzsche, the reason why the notions of good and evil have taken their present form is that the spiritually weak but strong in number masses have rebelled against their masters. The revolution happened in Europe through Christianity in which the notion of the "poor servant" has been elevated to that of a universal value. Modern society is thus characterized by the "ethos" of the servant: submission, spiritual weakness, intellectual impotence and mediocrity. Greatness is

⁷ Nietzsche, F. 1996. *On the Genealogy of Morals* Oxford University Press, 11.

⁸ Saar, M. 2002, op. cit., 232.

⁹ Nietzsche, F. 1996, op. cit., 25–28.

¹⁰ The representation of Nietzsche's theory is here intentionally simplified. The aim of this paper is not to give a better account on Nietzsche that can be found elsewhere, but to critique the concept of genealogy as it presents itself to post-Nietzschean thinkers.

measured by the level of conformity to social norms which are a product of the interplay between middle-class values and Christian values. Nietzsche's description of the transformations of our moral concepts uses a language of pathology. It is almost as if some sort of sickness had been transmitted through the veins of history.

Genealogy in the sense in which Nietzsche employs it is a unique practice of interrogating abstract notions through a historical deconstruction of the interplay of forces that produced them. It does not constitute an attempt to reconstruct the past, but a way of understanding contemporary identities and structures as contingent reflections of relations between human beings. The purpose of this activity is always to reveal something that is not apparent in the contemporary usage of a concept but nevertheless can be traced as an essential part of its meaning or condition.

FOUCAULT: ORIGIN AND IDENTITY

Nietzsche's study of origin of morality has been a direct inspiration for Foucault's critique of identity. There is indeed a direct conceptual link between identity and origin. Origins are sources "of." They become an object of study precisely because we have differentiated "this" from "that" and have been able to assign to it a continuity in time. To be identical with oneself means to have limits, to have a unique place in space-time.¹¹ This *locus* is given to everything once. The finitude of the material world is the condition of plurality of things. The candle that we have burned will be replaced with another "one." In European thought there was a complementary metaphysical assumption that things are most essential in the moment of their birth. Historically this has been the offspring of the Aristotelian teleological view of the world. If the dynamics behind the transformation of *potentia* into *actus* is guided not by general laws but by *entelechia*, then the complete form of every being has to be already included in its beginning. The dialectics of the beginning and the end is linked to the idea of the substance as an autonomous unity. For mortal, limited creatures—such as ourselves—this unity has to be broken as we can never see things in their entirety. As a consequence, the philosopher sets himself on a way to what "is" and not merely "becomes" by means of withdrawing herself from the world of appearance (Plato) or attending to it exactly (Aristotle).

The modern narrative behind identity is told in the spirit of a "lost" or "forgotten" beginning. We are like Odes who cannot come back to Ithaca. The images of faraway home, lost childhood, or a pre-modern "natural" society are different expressions of contemporary social and political melancholy and have

¹¹ This particular understanding of identity was most clearly articulated in modern European thought by G.W. Leibniz. See: idem. 1992. *Discourse on Metaphysics and Other Essays*. London.

been reflected in many ideological as well as social movements. The moment we evoke the language of identity, we enter this spirit of melancholy, of something lost or broken.¹² This does not mean that all identities are necessarily negative or even strictly historical. But they all rely on an image of the past that ensures their stability. And this mythologization of the past takes place not only in countries whose identity is traditionally claimed to be “ethnic,” such as Germany or Poland. It also appears strong in countries such as the U.S.A. (the myth of the frontier¹³), whose identity is based on the Enlightenment’s idea of rational autonomy and social contract. While there is no longer any immediate metaphysical connection between origin and identity (ever since we left the religious worldview), philosophy, religion and indeed politics all offer different methods of recollecting this relationship. Genealogy is a way of exposing the way in which the narratives we construct create and support the specific social and economic practices which we exercise on ourselves.

The issue of the relationship between genealogy, history and critique has been the subject of Foucault’s influential essay *Nietzsche, Genealogy, History*. Foucault’s appropriation of Nietzsche’s concept is based on an even more radically constructivist vision of history in that he attempts to deconstruct the notion of the origin itself.¹⁴ In Foucault’s view, the focus on origins in the production of narratives rests on the metaphysical assumption that things are most essential in the moment of their birth. Then they can be seen in their perfect, paradigmatic form. An obvious example from politics is the concept of democracy. Political theorists, or politicians themselves often refer to the Athenian *polis* when talking about a model of democracy as well as basis of evaluating contemporary democracies which are “less participatory” or “less civic/virtuous.” In the case of concepts such as “nationhood,” this relationship is even more unclear, precisely because we use these notions as though they were natural and universal. There is a natural inclination to extend the history of moral and political notions retroactively into antiquity. This is why we can so easily talk about the Polish State in the 10th century, even if this means altering the sense of a product of a particular social and cultural context. We are seduced by the need to find the ultimate origin, a model that could serve as a source of comparison for judging or identifying all other forms of representations.

In the genealogical enterprise a historical study serves an ahistorical purpose. It reconstructs the conditions of contemporary moral subjects without showing them as building blocks of a universal history. On the contrary, by relating to difference rather than to identity, the causal explanation of the world has to be

¹² Kuczyńska, A. 1999. *Piękny stan melancholii*. Warsaw: WFiS.

¹³ Clifford, M. 2001. *Political Genealogy after Foucault. Savage Identities*. London: Routledge, X.

¹⁴ Foucault, M. 1980. “Nietzsche, Genealogy, History.” In: *Language, Counter-Memory, Practice. Selected Essays and Interviews by Michael Foucault*. New York: Cornell University Press, 146.

facilitated by a voluntary one. In this sense Foucault's genealogy is an attack on the teleological vision of history, as well as those who attempt to study concepts separately from human agency (as Hegel did) is even stronger than Nietzsche's:

" 'History' transposes the relationship ordinarily established between the eruption of an event and necessary continuity. An entire historical tradition (theological or rationalistic) aims at dissolving the singular event into an ideal continuity—as a teleological movement or a natural process. 'Effective' history,¹⁵ however, deals with events in terms of their most unique characteristics, their most acute manifestations. An event, consequently, is not a decision, a treaty, a reign, or a battle, but the reversal of a relationship of forces, the usurpation of power, the appropriation of a vocabulary turned against those who had once used it, a feeble domination that poisons itself as it grows lax."¹⁶

For Foucault it is the breaking of history that can explain the emergent nature of identity. In other words, genealogy perceives origins as entries of forces,¹⁷ which interplay of domination defines concepts otherwise considered abstract and universal. The origin is thus a stage, a theatre, a non-place of interaction. It is impossible to determine who is responsible for the final outcome. However, historicization is not an end in itself, "it can only develop its force when it turns to objects whose 'meaning' and validity is affected by revealing their historicity."¹⁸ By demystifying, denaturalizing and desubstantializing,¹⁹ the genealogist reveals the contingency of certain notions. This activity cannot be entirely neutral. Even though "historical" or "contingent" does not necessarily mean "untrue," historicization of general concepts can affect their binding or persuasive power. It can also tell us something about the hidden dangers or opportunities associated with these concepts.

"Similarly, he [the genealogist] must be able to diagnose the illnesses of the body, its conditions of weakness and strength, its breakdown and resistances, to be in position to judge philosophical discourse. History is the concrete body of a development, with its moments of intensity, its lapses, its extended periods of feverish agitation, its fainting spells; and only a metaphysician would seek its soul in the distant ideality of the origin."²⁰

This therapeutic dimension of genealogy is not just a by-product of the method. It is an essential part of the theory's self-understanding. Nietzsche's

¹⁵ i.e. genealogy.

¹⁶ Foucault, M. 1980, op. cit., 154.

¹⁷ Ibid., 149.

¹⁸ Saar, M. 2002, op. cit., 233.

¹⁹ Ibid., 233.

²⁰ Ibid., 145.

analysis of transformations in the moral vocabulary can be successful precisely because it aims to deconstruct something that we intuitively treat as natural—our language. But the task of standing outside our natural disposition is both well-known and risky, especially if done to construct an objective version of moral history. This is not the case with genealogy. Here, the theorists sees an opportunity to “set free” the contemporary individual by dissociating her roots through an exaggerated and almost “parodic” narrative. The “parodic effect” is accomplished by the choice of spectacular turning forms and transformations between identities, and the habit of turning minor, often historically doubtful, facts directly into representations of general ideas and principles. The fact that the story is likely, bears on our understanding of our own natural disposition as contingent.

“All genealogies have in common a structural reflexivity, a self-implication in the fact that whoever enacts a genealogical criticism does this by criticizing aspects and elements, maybe even ‘images’, metaphors, patterns of interpretation or ‘ideologies’ of his or her own culture or background. [...] Doing genealogy then is: telling the subject the story of the powers working on him, telling it the story of its own becoming.”²¹

There are three dimensions in which we are constituted as subjects: knowledge (archeology), power (genealogy) and morals (history of sexuality).²² None of these can be fully understood without the others. What for Nietzsche was just an instrumental way of showing the contingency of certain dispositions alleged to be natural, for Foucault became a fully articulated and autonomous programme to demonstrate systematically the emptiness and contingency of the notion of self.

Although it seems almost trivial to say today that the conception of self is a product of modernity—or historical processes that led to it—the power of Foucault’s programme is not based solely on the account of subjectivity, but on his ability to show why the way we understand ourselves is a product of the kind of the particular social and political structure we inhabit. As a result, genealogy becomes not only a therapeutic but a political programme of deconstructing oppressive norms. It is not enough to understand the forces and ideas that constructed contemporary identities. Knowledge does not give us any freedom precisely because we are left with no basis for the construction of our self. The only response to Foucault’s version of genealogy becomes resistance understood as an existential status. The fact that for a genealogist “historical” means also present²³ has dramatic consequences for the understanding of identity. By

²¹ Ibid. 236.

²² Clifford, M. 2001. *Political Genealogy after Foucault*. London: Routledge, 9.

²³ Geuss, R. 2002. “Genealogy as Critique.” *European Journal of Philosophy*, 10, 2, 211.

showing the development of everything considered immortal Foucault believes we can finally shatter the alleged unity of the self.

GENEALOGY AS A CRITICAL METHOD

It is without doubt that genealogy is primarily a type of critique. Although, as Raymond Geuss notices, it is not one that operates through negation or rejection.²⁴ The genealogist is not preoccupied with presenting reasons why something is or might be not true. She is involved in a critical activity, which combines elements of social critique (as specific social practices are examined) and an epistemological method. For some it could be seen as a way of attempting to keep the phenomenological reduction while rejecting the other side of Husserl's theory—the transcendental subject. Historical analysis is a way of disassociating it while maintaining the conceptual character of the enquiry. As Geuss suggests, “the principal targets of this problematising approach are the apparently self-evident assumptions of a given form of life and the (supposedly) natural or inevitable and unchangeable character of a given identities.”²⁵

By tracing the transformations of practices and ideas,²⁶ the genealogists reveals that the existing language games are not autonomous. For Nietzsche and Foucault, this is because that language is shaped by the interplay of power: “political concept of rank always transforms into the spiritual.”²⁷ And consequently our entire experience of the world and action is shaped by the epistemic frames of a historicized subject and conditions of power. For Nietzsche this means above all the victory of the weaker, or as he calls it “blood-poisoning and the victory of ideals.”²⁸ For him genealogy is associated with an idealization of the past, which seems to be a recurring motive in many other genealogies. However, even if we accept Foucault's claims about the general features of genealogical activity, it does not follow that we have to agree that these lead to deep value judgments. Genealogy is above all an efficient way of tracing the hidden conditions and meaning of historical concepts and practices. The primary concern of genealogy is the attempt to recollect the underlying structures to see “all (the) things whose history stretches out far behind are difficult to see in their entirety.”²⁹ Genealogy as a method in that sense does not have to be a destructive activity, but can reveal the historicity of such concepts as “man,” “freedom,” or “state,” and present them as non-autonomous elements of concrete language games.

²⁴ Geuss, R. 2002, op. cit.

²⁵ Ibid., 211.

²⁶ Nietzsche, F. 1996, op. cit., 14.

²⁷ Ibid., 17.

²⁸ Ibid., 21.

²⁹ Ibid., 20.

One of the most profound and well studied examples of genealogy in this sense is the genealogy of the state. Even in the late 1950s it did not seem odd to talk about the Greek *polis* or Roman *res publica* using the word “state.” The state was conceptualized as the final and model form of a political community. As a result, the only “proper” states were democracies, specifically liberal democracies. The conceptual analysis of the word “state” leads many thinkers to its sources in the European Renaissance. It was John Pocock and Reinhart Koselleck who first argued that the word that in western languages takes the form of “state,” “*der Staat*,” “*l’etat*,” originally came from Italian “*lo stato*.”³⁰ It has originated from the diversity of Italian political entities, constitutions, boundaries and loyalties. First brought to popular use by Machiavelli, the term “*lo stato*” was meant to denote a neutral political state that could refer to any form of government. The word itself means “a base,” “ground,” “foundation,” and because of this it overtime begun to mean something that once established, lasts although its forms might change.

However, the term “state” is characteristic only of western European countries and has not got an equivalent in the political vocabulary of Eastern Europe and Russia. Barabara Markiewicz, in her genealogical study of the word “state” shows that the Polish and Russian words “*państwo*” and “*hospodarstwo*” do not denote a neutral political state but both originated from the word “pan” or “*hospodar*” which derives from Latin “*dominus*.”³¹ As consequence, political community is not conceptualized as constituted by law or institutions but by personal authority and property. The word “*hospodarstwo*” explicitly means “household,” and in Polish “*pańszczyzna*” means the duty to work on the field of a noble. The difference between western and eastern meanings of the words “state” and “*państwo*” or “*hospodarstwo*” is highly illustrative to the differences in conceptualizing the role of the state and political authority, particularly the relation between power and property. This short genealogy of “state” is to show that the use of simple genealogical methods can bear heavily on our understandings of the present meaning of the word without negating it. To reveal these hidden meanings is to practice the “kind of reflection that will make our access to the object itself easier, which in politics is always a common object.”³²

Regardless of whether we agree with Foucault’s view on society or not, genealogy as an autonomous method promises to offer something that seems not to be achievable in any other mode of enquiry—empirical or hermeneutic. It claims to be able to show whether certain notions can be universally binding and furthermore whether they are autonomous.³³ Even though, the actual applicability of the method remains problematic, I believe it can be used further to

³⁰ Markiewicz, B. 1998. “Państwo albo stan, czyli o podstawie nowożytnej formy polityki.” In: *Państwo jako wyzwanie*. Kraków: Ośrodek Myśli Politycznej, 27.

³¹ Ibid., 29.

³² Ibid., 22, my translation.

³³ Geuss, R. 2002, op. cit., 212.

analyze contemporary language of nation-state and nationhood as it becomes challenged by other conceptualizations of political identity.

CRITICISM

There are at least three significant objections to genealogy, some of which are valid only or mainly in the case of its stronger version (genealogy as a programme). First of them is that genealogical narratives are not verifiable and as such do not have a commitment to truth. The second one claims that the practice itself presupposes a metaphysical notion of self and is as a result self-contradictory. The third objection comes mainly from the standpoint of normative political theory and claims to undermine the usefulness of the entire genealogical enterprise. It is argued that if we accept that there is nothing “in the subject” except power relations, and “power is everywhere,” we lose any possibility to judge political and moral action. Or, alternatively if we do construct a normative framework, it contradicts the assumptions of the theory which treats moral norms, and in fact moral agency as contingent.

The Problem of Truth: In many ways genealogical narratives often read like a bad crime fiction. The mystery is pretended and the plot too obvious. The sudden twist never comes and the culprits tend to be known from page one. Genealogy produces a coherent story, and usually a quite convincing one. However, it remains only a story. Although it might be theoretically probable, the philosopher lacks the instruments to make it true. It might be than questioned how this narrative can have any binding conclusions. Furthermore the reception of the theory does not depend on its logical coherence but on persuasive power.

These are all very fundamental objections, and an elaborate answer cannot be provided here. However, there are at least two trails that we can follow in answering these objections. The first has been expressed most accurately by Bernard Williams. A theory, he argues, does not have to make claims to truth in order to be truthful.³⁴ In other words, even fiction narratives can tell us something about the real world. And what is more, they very often play a vital role in political and moral theories. Genealogy can be envisioned as structurally similar to intellectual models such as utopia, the state of nature, or original position in rational choice theory. Williams successfully shows that the ability to imagine that the world could be different is a crucial element of theoretical understanding.

However, this follows an established view that probable stories are theoretically fruitful is not at all new. In fact, political theory was defined both by Plato

³⁴ Williams, B. A. O. 2002. *Truth and Truthfulness. An Essay in Genealogy*. Princeton: Princeton University Press, 6, 22.

and Aristotle as the search for what is only probable and not true.³⁵ Moreover, stories were one of the main theoretical instruments for Plato. For him these were accounts of things that brought us closer to the truth not by virtue of providing a theoretical model but because of their immanent conceptual qualities. In other words because of their coherence, and as Plato would say, their ability to persuade us to believe in good things. Perhaps more importantly, a probable story should be an account of the world that does justice to the complexity of man.

The Problem of Identity. One of the most challenging objections to genealogy comes from identity discourse and was formulated by Alasdair MacIntyre.³⁶ Since genealogy is a deconstructive activity, it aims to show our natural identities as historical, cultural, and contingent. On a metaphysical level, it usually involves negating the subject as a comprehensible continuity and unity. Self becomes punctual, or as Foucault attempts to describe it, it consists of masks that do not cover anything except other masks. The self is nothing. In his book *Three Rival Methods of Moral Enquiry* MacIntyre challenges this view by arguing that the activity of constructing a genealogical narrative presupposes a continuity of identity of the author. In order to construct a coherent narrative about anything, the genealogist has to resign from the punctual self. He has to make claims and take responsibility for them. Furthermore, as genealogy takes on a political dimension, it seeks to incline us to choose a particular action. But how can we talk about moral choice without a moral subject? Both Nietzsche and Foucault seem to assume that self is just a product of identity. That we are constituted as moral, political or epistemic subjects as a result of a set of historical practices. However, this notion of a practice seems to incorporate a lot of metaphysical assumptions about the nature of the subject.

The Problem of Power. By showing that contemporary identities are a product of a set of contingent, historical processes, the division between normal—abnormal or rational—irrational loses their normative force. The domination of one identity over another is seen as an act of oppression, a power struggle rather than an element of the order of things. In case of European though, which itself has dominated the globe, it is predominantly male, Christian and rational. Which means that all other forms of identity (women, atheists, homosexuals, children) were defined as aberrations from the dominant one. If we accept that our identities are products of power relations—then identity itself becomes a tool of impression and the deconstructive function of genealogy gains an emancipatory underlining.

³⁵ See for example: Plato. 2000. *The Republic*. Book Two. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

³⁶ MacIntyre, A. 1990. *Three Rival Versions of Moral Enquiry: Encyclopaedia, Genealogy, and Tradition Being*. Gifford Lectures Delivered in the University of Edinburgh in 1988. London: Duckworth.

Genealogy therefore reveals how identity can become a vehicle of injustice. By pursuing some, but not others narratives of identity, we also choose between justifications of the social order and the nature of our values and duties to each other (think of the justifications, in which women's work at home is not valued in the same way as paid employment). This function of genealogy is not limited to socio-economic inequalities, but could in fact be used to trace the different justifications of political identity, which can be found in national, religious and other types of group identities. Whilst the concept of authorship is contested through genealogical reconstruction, every narrative has those who claim the rights to being the narrator (either explicitly or implicitly).

There is then, it seems, a clear relationship between genealogy and some relational theories of justice, i.e. those, which see justice primarily as a question about asymmetry in relations between individuals, individuals and groups, and even between groups rather than questions of a fair distribution (or redistribution) of resources. The asymmetry which lies at the foundations of exclusion of some meanings from the genealogy of our political and social concepts reproduces order, which not only we are subject to—but one which also facilitates the economic structures in which goods are produced. The right to equal co-authorship (Rainer Forst³⁷) could therefore be understood, in the context of genealogy, as the right to question the sources and origins of our identities and practices. There is indeed a power to question which itself can change the nature of the relationship between the subjects and the rulers.

However, the moment we start talking about identities in terms of injustice, we seem to make *a priori* normative statements about the nature of power and identity. This question has been raised for example by Michael Clifford who refers to a similar argument by Seyla Benhabib.³⁸ A Foucaultian answer would be that in fact these are not normative statements as they do not tell us anything about the “wrongness” of power relations but only constitute a warning about their hidden dangers.³⁹ At the end of the day there is no “should” in Foucault's theory of the subject precisely as there are no methods of resistance that could bring us back to our “natural selves.” Power is dangerous, but so is resistance—the edge of the theory is directed not towards constructing a normative theory about justice but a narrative about the modern subject and its origins.

Even if we accept all this, Foucault's answer to Clifford's objection is an unsatisfactory one. Although it is clear why not every evaluative judgement has to be a normative one, it is less clear how the author can make this distinction. By constructing such a reductive narrative he has lost the basis on which to differentiate between non-normative and normative at all. And it is this inability to

³⁷ Forst, F. 2014. *The Right to Justification: Elements of a Constructivist Theory of Justice*. New York: Columbia University Press.

³⁸ Clifford, M. 2001. *Political Genealogy after Foucault*. London: Routledge, 154.

³⁹ Late Foucault has revised his understanding of power as oppression and has resisted many of the implications of his former theory.

make any sense of traditional philosophical distinctions, particularly between different kinds of power—that makes Foucault's theory revealing and muddying at the same time.

CONCLUSION

To summarise, genealogical analysis is primarily an explanatory enquiry which relies on a historical study of the multiple intersecting forces which produce the meaning of a given phenomenon or practice.⁴⁰ However, genealogy is also concerned with the asymmetry of social relations, and therefore with emancipation (although not in the way it is defined in modernity). Its mode of enquiry is anti-progressivist, anti-deterministic, and anti-naturalistic. Unlike traditional history, it

“must record the singularity of events outside of any monotonous finality; it must seek them in the most unpromising places, in what we tend to feel without history—in sentiments, love, conscience, instincts; it must be sensitive to their recurrence, not in order to trace the gradual curve of their evolution, but to isolate the different scenes where they engaged in different roles.”⁴¹

The focus on difference allows the genealogist to uncover the relations between ideas and practices which we no longer see, because continuity and unity have been enforced on us—much in the way in which political unity is achieved through destruction of local histories. Genealogy remains an ambiguous term, and this article highlighted some of the challenges of differentiation between genealogy understood as a method and a programme. The latter is intimately related to Foucault's critique of identity, which ultimately leaves us without the subject or ability to differentiate between power narratives on normative grounds. The former, retains the critical nature of the programme, but perhaps more akin to phenomenology—the reduction of historical identities is limited to its epistemic value. Finally, I tried to show that this ability to use genealogy as a critical tool allows us to uncover asymmetries, which can be framed in the language of relational justice—because they relate to inequalities of authorship of social practices we engage in.

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⁴⁰ Nietzsche, F. 1996, op. cit., XII.

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR —PhD, an Associate Professor of Political Theory at the University of Edinburgh; School of Social and Political Science, Crystal Macmillan Building, 15a George Square, Edinburgh, United Kingdom. His works at the intersection between political philosophy, history of ideas and social and political science. His main research interests include: cosmopolitanism, political identity, justice and citizenship, theories of the self, and moral and political aspects of debt. He has written a monograph entitled *The Philosophy of Nationhood and the Modern Self* (expected to be published by Palgrave Macmillan, winter 2016). He is also a co-author with Professor Barbara Markiewicz of a collected work entitled *Crisis of Political Identity and European Integration* (Scholar 2012), as well as author of a number of articles and book reviews in Polish and English. He is a member of the Polish Philosophical Society and the British Political Studies Association.

E-mail: Michael R <mrozynek@gmail.com>

Józef L. Krakowiak

NIETZSCHEAN TRAGIC OUTLOOK AS A CRITIQUE OF METAPHYSICS

ABSTRACT

In my taxonomy, the *tragic outlook* is one of four types of outlooks, beside organological, mechanistic and personalistic. Its essence is the idea of non-integrity of being, non-integrity of man, and a dissonance between the quality-riddled scene of the becoming being and the creative actor. The *tragic knowledge* is a vital component part of the tragic outlook; it is inherent in Carl Jaspers and Christianity's beliefs but as something transcended in the concept of *salvation* from the tragic. The Nietzschean challenge could be this "Be an affirming, creative way of life" upon seeing which the becoming "will not vomit."

Keywords: tragic knowledge vs tragic outlook, critique of substantialism; will to power as description and relation rather than substance; Heraclitean metaphors versus the Stoic heaven without guilt, self as a system of social drives, philosophical fear of the tragic.

GERMAN PHILOSOPHY ONTO THE TRAGIC OUTLOOK

Someone who [...] after calm reflection, could wish that his life as he has experienced it so far would be of endless duration, or of perpetually new recurrence, and whose thirst for life is so great that he would gladly and willingly take on all the pain and hardships that life is subject to in return for its pleasure.¹

I derive the essence of the tragic outlook directly from German dialectical philosophy, which from the late Kantian beginning with the uprooting of the already rooted evil, was gradually restoring philosophy the irrational wisdom of the Greek tragedy, which for two millennia were banished from philosophy by

¹ Schopenhauer, A. 2010. *The World as Will and Representation*, vol. I. Norman, J. A. Welchman, C. Janway, (Trans.). Cambridge: CUP, 310.

Plato. The true beginning of the tragic is owed to Friedrich W. Schelling, who, influenced by Jakob Böhme, accepted the murky principle, i.e. will as a proto-being: a blind and murky force, an irrational craving of the nascent nature. Will must, however, be read from the world of phenomena and then decoded by experiencing freedom on the basis of the activity of the human body.² In my taxonomy, the *tragic outlook* is one of four types of outlooks,³ beside organological, mechanistic and personalistic.

The problem engages not only the subject of pure thought but also the subject of affective activity understood as the being that is phenomenal, determined, and noumenal, that is the will to live. It is the will that gives unity and inner relationship as well as endurance to consciousness; this is accomplished along with the presupposed margin of the creative and spontaneous genius. The presenting I is constituted not by thinking but by the activity of the body: a body is a manifestation, an objectivisation of individual will. The body is not will itself, it is a will embodied, objectively seen in the brain.⁴ Likewise, Nietzsche in the *Thus Spoke Zarathustra* ("The Despisers of the Body") says that the I is a living, creative body, whose subject is no longer a quasi-atomistic soul or a Cartesian cogito beyond time and space; these are reduced to the role of ego's tools. The I is viewed as a social system of drives and affections. The Nietzschean category of will—as opposed to this Schopenhauer's category—is understood as a diverse thing, a complex structure of affects (sensations, feelings), (nascent) thought and affections (above all the affection of command), rather than a substance. This synthetic notion of "I" in the *Thus Spoke Zarathustra* can be reduced to thought or even to Dasein. This prefigures the Heideggerian Dasein.

The essence of craving love as a craving fullness was developed by Plato in the *Symposium* as a source of and path to an optimistic and ultimately satisfying metaphysics of ideas. Schopenhauer declared that "The basis of all willing is need, lack and thus pain [...] No achieved object of willing gives lasting unwavering satisfaction."⁵ This belief is the essence of the Faustian spirit, a characteristic feature of the greedy Western civilization, even the essence of its tragic.

² For Schelling, will lies on the path of the nascence of God, in a theological perspective, whereas for Schiller and Schopenhauer it is derived anthropologically.

³ This variety of outlooks, absent in Wilhelm Dilthey's writings, was implicit among ancient Greek poets and in the Greek tragedy; in Sophocles' *Oedipus at Colonus* it finds its generalizing classical expression that Calderón de la Barca draws upon in the *Life is a Dream*, with Arthur Schopenhauer bringing it back to philosophy.

⁴ Schopenhauer, A. 2010, op. cit., 286, 309. In my opinion, for that reason Greek philosophy did not attribute will to being because being—as an abstraction—was not expressed in bodily terms as living.

⁵ Schopenhauer, A. 2010. *The World as Will and Representation*. Norman, J., A. Welchman, C. Janway, vol. II. Cambridge: CUP. Plato in the *Symposium* says that there is only human poverty left and the divine Plenty is gone, and thus Schopenhauer annihilated the relational Eros, the demi-god, incarnated in Socrates. Plato only did that in the *Laws*, where he killed life at the altar of the law.

The idea is continued by Oswald Spengler. Only in man, especially by means of art and tragedy, life is recognized as a nightmare and constant spiritual suffering which has a metaphysical source. Hence, human life is presented as something that would have been better off not coming to be at all. A right diagnosis of the inexorable necessities, both external and internal, including the loss of illusory hope, that is, tragic knowledge, causes calm. Karl Jaspers introduced similar claims. It is a strand shared by philosophies of the voluntary Stoic wisdom strategy—foreign to theater and ritual religion—that protects from human anxieties by way of causing them by self-imagination and of healing them *a priori*. The most famous are the Epicurean healing triad, Stoic-Christian *memento mori* and the Heideggerian *Sein-zum-Tode* as well as Paul Tillich's "courage to be", the most general of these four.

Schopenhauer prefigures the late Freudian idea of culture as a never-drying source of Tantalus' sufferings. Things of this world, and of the human world, in particular, are not so much perfection, as is often claimed, but distortion in moral, intellectual, physical and all other terms. This valuation of existence, i.e. the renewed tragic worldview, is sin, absurdity and nothingness. It is the ontological primordially of evil. This is to put upside down Europe's most optimistic possible metaphysical assumptions (being is and it is good). At the top shines the idea of Good—Plato claims. "God is and is good"—Christianity proclaims. According to Schopenhauer, what exists in a positive sense is pain that originates from desire, inherently incapable of getting satisfaction, that is, from suffering: lack, shortage and suffering are positive things that make themselves directly known.⁶ The proposition is evidenced by the art of tragedy. Similarly, most hypotheses of the German voluntarism are evidenced.

The tragic outlook assumes the impossibility of reconciling the scene, that is, the nature of being which is not even neutral but hostile, with the desires of the human nature. Being is not integral, but a clash of incurably hostile forces.

LIFE AS A FORM OF THE NON-PANVITALIST AND RELATIONAL CONCEPTION OF THE WILL OF POWER

Life [...] strives after a maximal feeling of power; [...] the basic and innermost thing is still this will. (Mechanics is merely the semiotics of the results.)⁷

My conviction regarding the thought of Nietzsche's, seen from the perspective of the end of his work, is this: This is an immanent philosophy, not only a philosophy of life "for life is merely a special case of the will to power."⁸ It

⁶ Schopenhauer, A. 2010, op. cit., 309.

⁷ Nietzsche, F. 1968. *Will to Power*. Kaufmann, W. (Ed.). Kaufmann, W., R. J. Hollingdale (Trans.). New York: Vintage Books (Random House Division), 368, hereinafter as: WP.

⁸ Ibid., 369.

defends life which is beyond the good and evil. "Life" is a synonym of "being." How could something dead be a being?" Hence "the history of philosophy is a hidden folly against the assumptions of life, against the existential feelings of value, against aligning with their side of life."⁹ The main strand of Nietzsche's thought is a defense of the immanent value of life.

Philosophical, and not only religious theories of morality are also hostile to life: "My insight: all the forces and drives by virtue of which life and growth exist lie under the ban of morality: morality as the instinct to deny life. One must destroy morality if one is to liberate life."¹⁰ From this perspective—suitable for the weak manifestation of vital forces—what is full of life energy and creative is denigrated whereas failure is defended. This is how the forces of the spirit have been subordinated to the dream goodness. "He has made a means to life into a standard of life; instead of discovering the standard in the highest enhancement of life itself."¹¹ This was in the service of only one ascetic form of life, and not really the highest.

The theory of will to power can and should be interpreted as a philosophy of life "Regarding that which all life reveals as a *diminutive formula for the total tendency*; hence a new definition of the concept 'life' as will to power."¹² Life is becoming rather than being (God, ideas, laws of nature, formulas, etc.). Therefore, whatever exists is characterized by constant creativity. Reducing becoming to the formula of perpetual recurrence is a metaphoric rather than literal way of saying that the fact that all things recur is the greatest approximation of the world of becoming to the world of being. Nietzsche rejects both the idea that the world has a purpose and the view that the world deliberately avoids purpose and thus keeps forever fresh.¹³ Recurrences are forms of creativity, albeit limited: the world does not contain the means that protect it from reappearance but neither is it founded upon fatalism. The nature of the becoming renders impossible the literal of its notional image, that is, the truth. Hence the Heraclitean vagueness, obscurity, pictorial and metaphorical quality. It is a dynamic monism that precludes a two-value logic and all duality, suggesting a sense that is two-value, and hence idealistic.

Nonetheless, Nietzsche does not proclaim panvitalism, a position that Schopenhauer adopted in his substantive monism of will cognizable in man—present in all its manifestations in totality and indivisibly and expressing the world as *megaantroposa*. Nietzsche's "will to power" has a structural rather than substantive nature, with no trace of anthropomorphic character; it is impersonal. "Becoming as invention, willing, self-denial, overcoming of oneself: no subject but an action, a positing, creative, "no causes and effects."¹⁴ "Subject" is

⁹ Ibid., 286.

¹⁰ Ibid., 189.

¹¹ Ibid., 205.

¹² Ibid., 331.

¹⁴ Ibid.

a metaphysical concept, the forefather of any actuality, the first for of logical identity, says Nietzsche.

This is voluntarism, but according to Nietzsche, the substance of will, in an amorphous unstructured metaphysical sense, proposed by Schopenhauer, does not exist. Because there is no will, consequently there is neither a strong nor a weak will. The multitude of impulses and the lack of any systematic order among them result in a “weak will”; “their coordination under a single predominant impulse results in a ‘strong will’—in the first case it is the oscillation and; in the latter, the precision and clarity of the direction.”¹⁵ I will not go into the generalizing interpretation of the will to power. I accept its interpretation by Günter Abel,¹⁶ rather than Heidegger’s substantive one.

Another, even more adequate form of the acceptance of becoming, emphasizing its innocuousness, is the metaphor of the child Aion playing dice, which draws upon Heraclitus. The formula of Aion cannot be interpreted in the terms of subject. In Nietzsche’s approach, this is a model of a creative artist, the Dionysus-child. Life is like the casting of dice—it is one of Nietzsche’s favorite tragic figures. It denotes the affirmation of becoming and its innocence whereas, in Nietzsche’s opinion, Anaximander prefigured Schopenhauer’s thought: recognizing becoming as *adikia*, injustice, and thus a negative axiological value. Like for Stoics, for Nietzsche too, there is no guilt nor redemption other than a liberation from revenge, that is, from the reluctance of will towards time.

The Heraclitean-Stoic idea of “the heaven of chance, the heaven of innocence, the heaven of hazard, the heaven of wantonness”¹⁷ gives rise to the affirmation of random chance, relying on one cast of dice, at the same time being an affirmation of number and destiny, *amor fati*, but not the affirmation of fatalism at large; rather, it is the acceptance of ego as destiny. The universe, the monster; chaos rather than cosmos; neither a mechanism nor a living being—is an *exception among exceptions*,¹⁸ having no purpose in itself and thus leaving no place for random chance, either. Metaphysical qualities are just about people inscribing their wishful objectivations, motivated by weaknesses, into being. Nietzsche’s Anti-Christian proposition is man’s failures and waste of life instead of sin, supplemented by the idea of superman, who actively overcomes

¹⁵ Ibid., 28–29.

¹⁶ Markowski, M. P. 1997. *Nietzsche. Filozofia interpretacji* [Nietzsche. Philosophy of Interpretation]. Kraków: Universitas, 164–173, especially 168: “It is [...] the law that introduces into the structure of the world eternal *diversification and difference* that is called by Nietzsche the ‘will to power.’ The paradox of the law is that it only covers individualized cases, and exists in a concrete rather than general form, as the very event, momentarily and temporarily hijacked by individuals.”

¹⁷ Cf. the chapter of *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*, “Before Sunrise.” In referring to chance and hazard, Nietzsche rejects not only determinism but also teleologism proclaimed by Stoics.

¹⁸ The famous paragraph 109 from *The Gay Science*. This is the most flagrant denial, made from the standpoint of the philosophy of life—of the concept of the World Soul from Timaeus, which Plato compares to a happy animal.

this pathetic one-sided plight of herd-like value judgments, affirmed by the metaphysics of the democratic times. The doctrine of eternal recurrence, as a hammer in the hands of the most powerful men determines its creative function in the education of the future rulers because not only man but superman, too, forever returns.¹⁹ This temporary concept of winning the supreme power over is fatalism (ego—*fatum*; the most extreme case being “eternal recurrence”). To overcome this and in order not to be an optimist, good and evil must be removed. Supreme fatalism, equated with random chance and a creative factor is a forerunner of existentialism, which sought to make fate out of its own random existence and thus be the creator of sense of not just its own existence, and therefore had to have rejected all forms of determination and negate being to open space for human creative activity. *Thus the prophet spoke who defamed the despising of the body and the escape towards the underworld, banned imitation and ordered creativity that affirms the body and earth, that is, creating the future hierarchy of values in things where it is absent—he thus sets an example of an act, and “only a man of action learns,” to be followed by other aristocrats of the body that affirms itself through successful creativity.*²⁰

PILLARS OF THE NIETZSCHEAN PROGRAM OF RECOVERING THE EUROPEAN CULTURE’S QUALITY OF WILL

That great mistrust of the Titanic powers of nature, those ruthless Moira ruling over all knowledge, [...] was continually overcome anew, in any case veiled and removed from view by the Greeks through that artistic middle world of the Olympians. In order to be able to live, the Greeks were obliged to create these gods, out of the deepest necessity: a process which we should probably imagine in the following way—through the Apollonian drive towards beauty, the Olympians’ divine reign of joy developed in a slow series of transitions from the original Titans’ divine reign of terror: as roses burst forth from the thorn-bush.²¹

The very model of grasping man and his fate was derived by Nietzsche from the classical Greek tragedy, which referred to mythological imagery, within which he emphasized Apollo’s alliance, presiding over the Muses, with the essence of the Dionysian cult, which had not been unveiled theretofore. Thus an interweaving of the Dionysian element of nature with the Apollonian restraint, rather than the mere Dionysian element, appears to be the source of the Nietzschean tragic outlook, previously exorcised from the philosophical thought by Plato. The Apollonian moderation is an aesthetic post-Schillerian dimension of

¹⁹ N.

²⁰ N.

²¹ Nietzsche, F. 2000. *The Birth of Tragedy*. Smith, D. (Trans.). Oxford: Oxford University Press, 28.

Nietzsche's axiology, affirming human creative activity, which is contrasted with Kant's and Schopenhauer's ascetic moralizing.

The second, partly formal referential system is the Bible with its proverbial nature; it is very polemical in its contents but concurrently accepted in terms of literary form in the *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*. However, the dominant role of active creative life is here retained—Zarathustra, a prophet (Avesta) of an initially non-ascetic, dualistic metaphysics of an essentially monotheistic, messianic religion, reinforced by the principle of moral (conscience) and physical (water and earth) purity as well as worshiping the holy, purifying fire. The Nietzschean Zarathustra's disciple cannot emulate him as one cannot be reactive; only one who has found themselves and blesses others with themselves can be a true disciple—a creative person.

Nietzsche attacks "the peculiarly [...] abstraction of philosophers, with their negation of the world, their enmity to life, their disbelief in the senses [...] and has almost thereby come to be accepted as the ideal *philosophic attitude*."²² The whole post-Cartesian European culture, based on the moral interpretation of life, rather than merely the Christian religion is here the object of accusation. The future will belong to the tragic man—a superman who is capable of the undeluded affirmation of even such a tough, tragic life, without making a recourse to blaming everyone and everything around except themselves. Therefore "[t]his temporary European order of nations and states must be destroyed. The Christian-Democratic way of thinking favors a herd animal, the dwarfing of men, weakens the great driving forces (evil-), hates coercion, thought discipline, great responsibilities and great dangers."²³ Thus Nietzsche draws upon Schiller's aesthetics of the drive to play as spirituality derived from the Olympian gods, predating the ethical, Socratic-Platonic. *The Birth of Tragedy* presents the Greek Olympus, and thus mythology, too, as a cultural work of art, which, in its development complementation and obscuring the atrocities of life (the world of the Titans) allows the Greeks to steer clear from falling into Buddhism or pessimism. Its center being constituted not by Zeus but by the aesthetic Apollo, the guide of the Muses—the personification of the mythological drive. From this perspective, Schiller explicitly rejected the alternative "the beastly or the divine/angelic" as an irrelevant fiction, which, taken over from Epictetus, was expressed more explicit by Kant.

The category of the will to power reckons with interaction, positive cooperation of forces, that is, synergy, their coordination, with a domination of one; it means they are will that manifests itself focally and causes action. There is no object in itself; it is constructed from relations.²⁴ This is an unambiguous expression of *relational* ontology; there is no substance but there is a relation of

²² Nietzsche, F. 1887. *The Genealogy of Morals*. Samuel, H. B. (Trans.). New York: Boni & Liveright, 119. Hereinafter as GM.

²³ N, 335.

²⁴ N, 335.

forces. What is at stake is the health of the body, a Dionysian power restrained by the Apollonian restraint, proportion and harmony, which take on an aesthetic appearance in the symptoms of life. What is at stake is the artistic drive of nature among the Greeks.

The Dionysian orgies among the Greeks are something other than reducing man to a monkey and a tiger but a festival of the salvation of the world by the loss of individuality in the intoxicating world of dithyrambic music, with its quality of dance, rhythm but also dissonance, so as to attain mystical reconciliation with the proto-One. The Dionysian (Schiller's *sensual drive*), that is, the whole range of sensory system, including the sense of understanding and guessing as well as acting upon others, having come to a consensus with the Apollonian drive of form (Schiller), that is, intoxication with what can be seen, transformed into an image, a representation, with the whole power of fabulous vision, has since performed the function of abrogating alienation, attaining adherence to a *higher community* as it does away with poverty, license and other hostile barriers between people and between man and nature. Enchanted, one has since danced in the air, supernatural, elated, as though divinely free, one gives to things, forces them to take from him, makes them impose themselves so they can be uttered, clad in words, made sense of, felt as beauty or loftiness. "In this state we enrich everything out of our own plenitude: whatever we see, whatever we want, we see swollen, crammed, strong, supercharged with energy. Man in this state transforms things until they reflect his power—until they are reflections of his perfection. The need to transform into perfection is art."²⁵ This intoxication—an experience of perfection, excess, a synergic expansion of power—is super-manhood. None the less, it is not only in art that "man finds enjoyment in himself as perfection,"²⁶ and takes himself as the measure of all things. It is as though Kant methodically had abandoned natural theology, having before given up on the "critique of the teleological power of judgment," that is, the second part of the *Critique of the Power of Judgment* and its consequences. This means he would have been content with the affirmation of life without the hope for happiness and a conviction that one can deserve it. Sense is bequeathed on us by the fullness of life. What imparts sense is the very fullness of life, aesthetic intoxication, that is, a physiological sense of the intensity of the forces, a sense of fullness, which opens the process of ideation rather than the state of purposes, which can only begin to be contemplated or the phenomenological *epoche*. Notably, both the Dionysian and Apollonian kinds of intoxication from the *Birth of Tragedy* are upheld in the Twilight of the Idols—this is an unchanging pro-vitality pillar of the quality of the will of the European culture as seen by Nietzsche, which he constantly defends against the Neoplatonic devotion to which even rationalist philosophy, and not just ascetic religion, had

²⁵ Nietzsche, F. 1998. *The Twilight of the Idols*. Large, D. (Trans.). Oxford: OUP, 16. Hereafter as: TI.

²⁶ Ibid, 79.

succumbed. This was always far removed from Schopenhauer and Blaise Pascal, but was close to Plato and Raphael, who also glorified physical beauty. This means a significant proximity to Schiller and Maurice Merleau-Ponty. “Supra” does not mean “above,” but rather “a structural synergy of the immanent powers, perceived as intoxication”; this is the ethic of expression.

Man feels himself the most precious marble, subjected to form-making processing by powerful, divine forces of nature. This thinking is similar to the aesthetic, pantheistic romantic mysticism demonstrated e.g. by Friedrich Hölderlin (*Hyperion*). But the *prostration of millions* in the finale of Ludwig Beethoven’s *9th Symphony* is for Edmund Husserl the climax of the Enlightenment as it stresses the communal-Stoic aspect of the *tremendous reason* of nature in Nietzsche’s writings. The supreme man is an emanation of nature: a vast surplus, vast reason in detail, as a whole extravagant but also indifferent, that is, the Kantian loftiness of the creative genius (superman). Late Husserl stresses human inter-subjectivity as the pluralistic and subjective (neither God nor superman) basis of the constitution of the world’s unity, but he also speaks of the community of monads as another social layer of the constituted world. This is empirically rationalized, genetic transcendentalism.

The concept of eternal recurrences is the basis that makes likely a recurrence of pre-Socratic Greeks; it appeared again in the Italian Renaissance. In both cases the structures of small communities and no longer individual successful individuals found successful periods of the European culture. When superman himself becomes the subject of culture and fulfills the concept, that is, when fatalist thinking fails, the Europeans not only begin to consciously design the future but also reinforce and implement their will to power in a purposeful and creative manner. The lack of purpose has been in power so far. Mankind has not any purpose yet. This is what Nietzsche says within his concept of great politics, that is, the theory of intersubjectivity.

INTENTIONAL-DESCRIPTIVE SENSE OF THE *WILL TO POWER*

Thus man is able to shape himself and the first step is self-containment through daily self-denial in even small things in order to reach great self-restraint, self-harnessing, which goes against the human condition, as shown in the awesome motto with its spiritual sense that is sharper than the divine commandments from the tablets of Moses; these are commanded in purely moral terms. However, self-containment cannot change into a violation inflicted on oneself towards practicing a ruthless ascetic fight with evil, with the culture of transcendence; apparently. However, Nietzsche trespassed all boundaries on this path as he posed a nonhuman–superhuman mission. Ancient Greeks

“accepted the all-too-human as unavoidable and, instead of denouncing it, preferred to give it a sort of second-class justification by incorporating it

in the rites of society and the cult. It was usual to provide a moderate release for evil and questionable impulses instead of attempting to annihilate them completely. The Greeks were content to accept evil in moderate doses that were neither fatal nor thoroughly contaminating to everything affected.”²⁷

The measure of the greatness and quality of the human life are great affects, albeit restrained. In his late writings, Nietzsche speaks of the magnitude, configuration and inner dynamics of drives, each of which would seek dominance, our lived being an outcome of this strife.

It can now be clearly seen that the supreme values are not life and will in themselves; rather, these are the *quality* of life and the *quality* of will are values, objects of cognition and endeavors, but, above all, they are the driving forces: “life as a whole is not a state of crisis or hunger, but rather a richness, a luxuriance, even an absurd extravagance—where there is a struggle, there is a struggle for power ...”²⁸ Life as such is a powerful force, whereas the “moral lie in the mouth of the decadent says: “Everything is worthless—life is worthless.”²⁹ Therefore, man ought to be facing conditions where “you must need to be strong or else you will never become it.”³⁰ The tragic man is one who can face up to such conditions.

The concept of the will to power was also supposed to be an instrument of improving European sciences as they are characterized by the lack of a driving force “we observe only results and we consider them equivalent in content and force ...”³¹ and we cannot obtain change unless one prevails over the other. The two subsequent states result from a clash of two elements—events that are uneven in force but the original condition is not the cause of the consequent. “The will to power not a being, more than that!, not a becoming, but a pathos—the most elemental fact from which a becoming and effecting first emerge.”³² Nietzsche introduces something more primitive, more fundamental than becoming, than action and cause: pathos, suffering (passion) and the tragic rather than dialectical. Mechanics formulate consequent phenomena and semiotically at that, by means of sensory and psychological expressive means: it does not touch the causal force. However, the concept of the will to power transcends the horizon of the living—it is universal: the will of amalgamating force is a distinctive feature of the phenomenon of life, nourishment, reproduction, inheritance, of

²⁷ Jaspers, K. 1997. *Nietzsche: An Introduction to the Understanding of His Philosophical Activity*. Wallraff, C.F., F.J. Schmitz. Baltimore – London: The John Hopkins University Press, 134.

²⁸ TI 21.

²⁹ Ibid., 36.

³⁰ Ibid., 44.

³¹ WP, 366.

³² Ibid., 347–348.

the society, state, mores and authority. Cannot it also be considered a causal force operating in chemistry and in the solar system?

IF THE BECOMING ENJOYS AUTONOMY, THERE IS NO SUBJECT OF GUILT OR THE PUNISHING SUBJECT

The aforementioned positive explication through the will to power signifies the following in metaphysical terms:

- no subject (model of things), no God, no cause;
- no purpose, intention, and thus no free will, no guilt and no responsibility;
- hence no divine punishment too, and no resentful vengeance.

The will to power, thus understood—in association with such strong criticism of the concept of cause—has become the category that can no longer be charged with subjective interpretation, so in this perspective the question cannot be asked who is to blame for what is happening. There is no such a creature at all! It is also in the concept of cause that thing, subject, will and intention are inseparable. It is only such an a-personal and a-subjective perspective, negating “I” and God, which is also a-causal, that makes possible an effectual unmoralization of thought.

“We halcyonians especially are trying with all our might to withdraw, banish, and extinguish the concepts of guilt and punishment [...] We others, who desire to restore innocence to becoming, would like to be the missionaries of a cleaner idea: that no one has given man his qualities, neither God, nor society, nor his parents and ancestors, nor he himself—that no one is to blame. There is no being that could be held responsible for the fact that anyone exists at all, that anyone is thus and thus, that anyone was born in certain circumstances, in a certain environment. [...] It is a tremendous restorative that such a being is [...] There is no place, no purpose, no meaning on which we can shift the responsibility for our being, for our being thus and thus. Above all, no one could do it; one cannot judge, measure, compare the whole.”³³

This perspective raises the question: What was there to show? What was the goal of metaphysics? Prove that responsibility is an invention in the service of vengeance or that free will has been devised to serve guilt? The dominant emphasis in Nietzsche’s critique of metaphysics is placed on the idea of the liberation of the modern man and the post-Christian culture in general from the burning coals of vengeance: from the principle that holds that *every black sheep that suffers* seeks a “scapegoat” to take the punishment. So, the task was theoretically done also in a positive sense, that is, an understanding of reality was submitted that is freed from the spirit of vengeance, an affirmative kind of thinking.

³³ WP, 402.

The becoming need not be subject to philosophical fear or hatred if its complexity and innocence has a sound understanding; sure enough, for creative beings of a strong will to power. This is particularly true since all intentions, ends, meanings are just ways in which one will expresses itself and mutates; one will that is inseparable from all that happens, the will to power; that to have pursuits, ends, intentions, to will at all, is tantamount to will to be stronger, to grow towards that and will to have means to that end. All the more so

“that the apparent ‘*purposiveness*’ (‘that purposiveness which endlessly surpasses all the arts of man’) is merely the consequence of the *will to power* manifest in all events; that *becoming stronger* involves an ordering process which looks like a sketchy purposiveness; that apparent *ends* are not intentional but, as soon as dominion is established over a lesser power and the latter operates as a function of the greater power, an order of *rank*, of organization is bound to produce the appearance of an order”³⁴

based on means and ends. This lengthy quotation demonstrates that the philosophy of the will to power is anti-nihilism because the category has the property of rank-ordering the reality, that it renders itself to reading as quasi-purposiveness and thus in Kantian ways, as it were, as an aesthetic description of reality in the *Critique of the Power of Judgment*. The order thus described is not only free from axiology, both theological and anthropological as this by nature makes man the measure of all things. On top of that, temptation is rejected (which has one believe that no ends is an end) as leading to another form of theology: one in Lev Shestov’s spirit.

The punchline has the meaning that proves the Nietzschean idea of the critique of metaphysics is not only restricted to the critique of morality with a religious rationale—hence the “Death of God,” that is, the loss of legitimacy of a transcendent rationale for the sense of being. The criticism of morality rejects all “you must” including the killing of a dragon with gold scales, that is the transcendently justified Kantian morality of duty and moral rigor. However, it also rejects all of its three transcendental ideas: the unity of the object, that is, the world, the unity of the subject, that is the soul, and the unity of both these unities, that is, a god. It also refutes the essence of the synthesis of both Kantian critiques—the critique of the theoretical and practical reason, the latter being the critique of the power of judgment—the teleological unity of nature associated by the law of necessity with the teleological unity of its creator.

³⁴ WP, 299.

THE METAPHYSICAL STATUS OF THE NIETZSCHEAN PERSPECTIVIST AXIOLOGY

Whenever we speak of values, we speak under the inspiration—from the perspective-of life: life itself forces us to establish values; life itself evaluates through us when we posit values ...³⁵

My text presents an extreme anti-substantial interpretation of the late thought of Nietzsche—the relational metaphysics of the will to power. I reject both the organological outlook (panvitalism) as well as the mechanistic views (atomism and determinism).³⁶ My view also is far from the personalistic outlook (the world of persons). What, then, is the status of the formulations concerning the axiological dimension of his thought? If there is no quality in being, and it cannot be reduced to life, which is an exception, the values cannot be described as discovered but created. Therefore, the dispute about values is no longer a *pan-ontological dispute*: “Above all, no one could do it; one cannot judge, measure, compare the whole”³⁷ and neither one can negate: “Judgements, value judgements on life, whether for or against, can ultimately never be true: “the value of life cannot be assessed.”³⁸ This should be read as a direct polemic with Paul of Tarsus’s Corinthians 6:2–3: “Or do you not know that the Lord’s people will judge the world? And if you are to judge the world, are you not competent to judge trivial cases?” and “Do you not know that we will judge angels? How much more the things of this life!” Indeed, the scale of *ontological pride asserted* on all others.³⁹ This is the highest possible peak of demagoguery: man as the judge of not only the material but the spiritual, too! Demagoguery thus presented seen as an art of spiritual seduction, the art of flattery, the most conscious conceitedness of the elect, created on purpose, can never be surpassed, but has complemented with the contrasting idea of *sin*, concerning which Nietzsche often speaks as a form of a *par excellence self-degradation* of man. Knowledge is the first sin, the seed of all sins, the original sin (Antichrist). Nietzsche sets out the essence of the “original sin” here, and it is knowledge, which makes anyone who is *not meek in the spirit* guilty, and thus deserving of punishment: knowledge is a form of binding by the law.

The figure of the judge—in the immanent perspective—is not a promise of entering into the prerogatives of God at the Last Judgment, but a *non-human* form of life that affirms *plague*, that is, that which kills. Albert Camus repeats this belief after Nietzsche and Josef Kafka from *The Trial*. Its unconditional rejection indicates that the dispute is on life, perceived as only a part of being rather than in a panvitalist fashion. This is a dispute on the quality of some con-

³⁵ TI 22, 23.

³⁶ This has not been covered in much detail, particularly the critique of atomism.

³⁷ WP, 402.

³⁸ TI, 56.

³⁹ It might appear that it only concerns the saints, but in fact Paul’s goal was to seduce the lowliest and most excluded through demagogic flattery.

crete life, on *impressing the nature of being on the becoming*: suggesting the image of midday as a metaphor that is as much about the sun as it is about the time—fulfillment in the perspective of perpetual recurrences.

The object of making value judgments, as Nietzsche puts it, is the value of man's being, although he attributes concentration, the will to power as a tendency from plurality to unity, a pursuit of growth, a sense of growth—resembling the drive of love in Freud—to *all that lives, grows and multiplies*; so do philologists. At stake is the right to create, to be a genius who labors or inseminates, which cannot be said of a skeptic and neither can it be said of a scholar's impartial, selfless cognition or even such a great critic of reason as Kant. This is about philosophers, whose cognition is creative activity and their creative output is legislation. Such a noble soul is marked neither by actions nor works, which often only express the desire to be noble, but a belief, a unwavering conviction, self-worship, axiological self-centeredness, which is about one viewing oneself as the source of values, a place whence all value springs forth. A philosopher is always someone from tomorrow and the day after, ready to take on great responsibility, and thus not just accountability for oneself, which is the essence of freedom; their task is to create new values rather than just logically and artistically order the values past, that is, harness history, even though this is prerequisite for creating new values.

Nietzsche's philosophy is no contemplative perspective, something like an oxymoron, so is no "pure" theory but, rather, a creative activity, a bodily activity, and not a disembodied shadow. It is an endeavor to gather the diversity of our life into a whole. It is an inevitable attempt, forever resumed although futile, which Nietzsche depicts with the idea of superman, will to power, and thus a metaphor of a chance of a spiritual unification of what is inherently devoid of life. Only that which is alive has its center, and from this middle ground it tries to bequeath sense to the formless, with man—in the perspective of the living—appearing not only as any becoming but, rather, as the becoming that tries to impart a purpose to its becoming and order the world or, rather, the chaos that surrounds them. In so doing, man appears within its framework as a creative whole-making force.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR — PhD, retired Associate Professor at Warsaw University Institute of Philosophy. Affiliation: The Higher School of Health Education and Social Science, Kamińskiego 29, 90-229 Łódź, Poland. (affiliation). Deputy Editor-in-chief of "Dialogue and Universalism" 1997–2012. Author of: 2005. *Tragizm ludzkiej egzystencji jako problem filozoficzny* [Tragedy of Human Existence as a Philosophical Problem]. Warsaw: Scholar; 2010. *Absurd – pytanie o sens ludzkiej egzystencji* [Absurd—The Question of Meaning of Human Existence]. Warsaw: Scholar. Editor of 10 volumes of the Library of Dialogue, Warsaw 1997–2006. His main field of interest is philosophy of life, especially links between philosophy and literature. He organized numerous international meetings on universalism, among others for ISU(D).

E-mail: j.k.l@wp.pl

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